

FROM THE BEST SELLING AUTHOR OF 'GOLIBE' & 'IYA BEJI'

Adesuwa O'Man Nwokedi

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By **Adesuwa O'man Nwokedi**

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To Carmen, Claire, and Benedict! This is for you...with all my love!

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Chapter One

The Body

Sometimes, I sleepwalk.

Sometimes, I dream in motion and end up gliding around my house at night, usually with no memory afterwards. From the different bedrooms to the living rooms, the kitchen, and even the servants' quarters, I have been sighted in various parts of my house at odd hours of the night. Sometimes, when the person who finds me is kind-hearted, I am led back to my bedroom, and I'm none the wiser about it when I wake up the following morning. But if I am left unhindered, I usually awake in the same place; in my garden, sleeping on a bed of flowers. It's as if, even in my sub-consciousness, I crave the peace and tranquility I get from the place I consider my safest haven in this prison that is my home.

As the sun rays hit my face, I realise it has happened again, and my nocturnal stroll has led me back to my garden. The familiar fragrances envelope me, and I open my eyes to behold the symphony of colours in the 300 square feet of land I converted from dry grassland. Ruby reds, blush pinks, neon oranges, canary yellows, jewel greens, and snow whites are only a few of the hues of my prized collection of roses, tulips, lilies, orchids, daffodils, dahlias, daisies, marigolds, and chrysanthemums I have cultivated over the years. It truly never gets old. It is all my sweat and

blood, so if my spirit chooses this to be the first place I start my day most mornings, then so be it.

I close my eyes to savour my small piece of paradise, to forget about all my worries, and pretend that life is truly, and literally, the bed of roses on which I lie. But just as I am about to drift off to sleep again, my ears pick up noises uncharacteristic, not only for this time of morning but uncharacteristic period. I sit up and realize that I am not imagining things.

There really is screaming and wailing coming from the house.

I rise to my feet and start briskly walking towards it, not even conscious of my flimsy nightwear. My panic escalates as I notice the security guards, Abel and Ukawuike, rushing into the house, just as Nneoma, one of the junior maids, rushes out, her face alabaster white.

“O nwụ go,” she is muttering under her breath, again and again, her hand clamped so tight around the doorpost, I fear all her veins will burst through it.

“Onye nwu?” I demand as I get to her. “Who is dead?”

She just stares back at me with flat eyes, and I move past her into the house. I recognise the persistent screaming as Apunanwu’s, and I shove past more of the confused domestic staff in my desperation to get to the root of this bewildering matter. This has got to be some sort of tasteless joke.

“Ha egbuwo’m oooo!” Uzochi, the longtime housekeeper, is wailing as she sits - no, sprawls ungainly - on the stairway. “They have taken food out of my mouth, ooooo!”

I waste no time asking her questions and instead run up the stairs, taking them two at a time, almost stumbling over her hefty body in the process. My stomach drops when I see the room in front of which everyone is

clustered and from where Apunanwu's screams are coming from. From the looks on the faces of the people standing around, I no longer need to fear the worst. I can see it.

My pace slows as I approach the room, even though my heart is beating so fast, it is almost jumping right out of my chest.

"Nne, you shouldn't see this," Ukawuike says, as he tries to restrain me from entering the room.

I push past him, and I let out a gasp as my eyes behold the body of the elderly man lying on the floor. His head is bloodied, and there is a broken chair only a few feet away. His white t-shirt is stained with blood and vomit, and he is foaming at the mouth. There is no doubt about it. He is dead.

My eyes meet Apunanwu's as she lies wailing beside the body, and she lets out an even more guttural scream. "You killed him! Adanna, you finally killed him!"

I stare back at her, speechless and confused. I notice Anayo, her brother, making a phone call on the other side of the room. When he sees me, he shakes his head. I cannot even decipher the message in that. Is he trying to console me? Is he asking me not to pay his sister any mind? Or is he sending some other subliminal message I can't understand?

"Look at them, look at them!" Apunanuwu exclaims, rising to her feet and pointing an accusatory finger at Anayo and I. "Even here, you are exchanging secret messages. You and your lover killed him. You killed him!"

"Apunanwu, you better watch your tongue!" Anayo warns. "This is no time for this your childishness. We should all be putting heads together to find

out what happened here, instead of throwing baseless accusations around.”

My head starts to spin, and I walk over to the king-sized bed to sit, my eyes never leaving the body on the floor. How could a man so full of life only a few hours before be lying stone cold dead on the floor? Who could have done this? I notice three wine glasses and two empty bottles of the same on the coffee table, and I realise he had late company. But who?

“You people have killed him,” Apunanwu wails, her tears running freely down her face. Her hair is disheveled, and from the vomit also on her nightwear, I can see that she must have also held the body in her agony. I cast another look at the body and have no desire at all to do the same. “Where have you been all this while?” Apunanwu demands, glaring at me. “How come it took you so long to even get here? Didn’t you hear the noise?”

“Mba, ọ laru n’ilo,” Abel says in my defence. “She slept outside. We saw her as we were coming here.”

But this explanation goes right over Apunanwu’s head.

“I hope you’re happy now,” she continues, her blood-shot eyes continuing their indictment. “You and your lover killed him.”

“Which lover?” comes Akanna’s voice, as he walks into the room. “You know she has many.”

I feel the hairs on the back of my neck rise, as they typically do in his presence, and feel even more conscious of my scanty attire. I immediately want to be anywhere but there. I want to be far, far away from there. But I know I have no choice but to stay.

“Have you called the police?” Akanna asks his younger brother, Anayo. “They need to get here quickly, so we can move the body to the mortuary or

something. This visual is upsetting the women.”

Apunanwu’s wailing intensifies, and even my own stomach drops at the reference to the man lying on the floor as a ‘body’. Chief Arinze Nsofor now a body? It feels like I am in the middle of a very bad dream.

Anayo makes to cover the body with the bed sheet, but Apunanwu snatches it from him.

“Leave him like that!” she snaps. “Let the police find him just the way you people left him!”

Anayo throws his hands up and sits beside me on the bed, clearly frustrated. One part of me wants to move far from him, to prevent any more assumptions about our involvement in this mess. But another part of me is consoled by his proximity.

“Who was the last person with him last night?” I ask, finally finding my voice. “Those are used wine glasses, meaning he had company.”

Anayo and Akanna exchange a glance.

“We were here with him,” Anayo admits. “He was perfectly fine.”

“Obviously, he must have been,” Apunanwu snaps. “He clearly didn’t do this to himself.”

“And I left you two, remember?” Akanna says, sitting beside me on the bed.

“So technically, you were the last person to see him alive.”

“So, what are you implying?” Anayo demands, looking over me at his brother with his fists clenched, and I regret my position of sitting between the brothers. “You want me to tell everyone the reason you left me alone with him? You want me to tell them of the heated argument you had with him that would have degenerated into another fistfight if I hadn’t

intervened? Who's to say you didn't come back after I'd left, to finish what you almost started?"

Rather than get defensive, Akanna chuckles, and a chill runs through my body. I have been afraid of him for as long as I can remember, more so this fateful morning. I notice what looks like fresh cuts on his hands, and I look again at the smashed chair on the floor. I feel goose bumps all over my body as my brain starts to connect the dots, painting a clearer picture of what probably happened last night. A vivid picture that could very likely involve none other than the man's first son, Akanna.

We hear the sound of a car driving into the compound, and Anayo rises to peer out of the window. By this time, most of the domestic staff have left the room, and Apunanwu is still a whimpering mess on the floor, refusing to leave the body.

"It's the police," Anayo states.

Ukawuike joins him at the window, and Akanna takes advantage of their distraction, sitting closer to me on the bed.

"Nwanyi oma," he says, touching the back of my hand with his, his voice a seductive purr. "Ndo o. This must be very difficult for you. In fact, my handkerchief is wet from cleaning your tears."

His sarcasm is not lost on me. Despite the grief and anguish I feel, my eyes have remained bone dry. Try as I may, I cannot even will a single tear out of them. I know that, if for nothing but optics, I need to appear at least as devastated as Apunanwu because, even I know that, there will soon be several raised brows if I remain this calm.

I need to start acting like a woman whose husband has just died.

“My darling step-mother, you need to start shedding tears before ndi police get upstairs. I’m sure you know you’re the primary suspect,” Akanna whispers in my ear, followed by another chuckle. “The young, promiscuous wife of an old man like my father. You have a lot to gain with him out of the picture.”

I glare at him and, in return, he licks his lips and winks at me, before walking over to the door to welcome the three policemen who have walked into the room. I watch as the new additions to our party first of all express shock and dismay over the sight of the body, before they begin with their barrage of questions. I recognise one of them as Sergeant Ifedi, an active parishioner in our church. He walks over to the bed and stoops before me.

“Madam, I’m so sorry for your loss. This is a truly horrible thing that has happened. We will surely get to the bottom of it, I promise you. This is a peaceful town, and things like this don’t happen here. How can a man be murdered in his own house? In his own bedroom, kwanu? Mba, we will get to the bottom of this,” he says, and I can only nod in response.

He continues to talk, but I don’t hear a word of it. His voice trails off as my attention remains on Akanna, Anayo, and Apunanwu, my three step-children...all of whom older than I. They are speaking with the other policemen, and I find myself getting increasingly worried about what they are discussing. I ponder going to join their conversation, but an unseen force keeps me seated on the bed.

“Could it have been someone from outside? Are there any signs of forced entry?” Sergeant Ifedi asks, as he walks over to join the others. When he is answered in the negative, he asks again, “Maybe someone gained access when...when Madam left the door open at night?”

My cheeks flush in my embarrassment, and I cast my eyes down in shame. My sleepwalking reputation is no secret, even to people who live beyond the four walls of our compound.

“Or maybe she left the door open intentionally, to allow in one of her lovers from outside!” Apunanwu snaps, sending me daggers with her eyes.

“Now it’s her lover from outside,” Anayo retorts.

I say nothing in my own defense. The truth is, it really doesn’t look good for me. What Apunanwu said isn’t far-fetched. At some point in time, Anayo has been my lover. Akanna as well. Yes, one could debate what exactly the true definition of the word lover is, but regardless, I know I will need a stronger alibi than simply taking a nap in my garden.

How on earth did I get here?

Chapter Two

The Beauty

I always knew I was beautiful.

From as early as I can remember, the first thing anyone would remark, even before asking for my name, would be ‘I mara mma o!’ or some other variation of praise for my beauty. I was born golden-skinned, like my maternal grandmother, and blessed with the luxurious, lower-back length hair my paternal grandmother had been renowned for in her day. I started off being self-conscious of my large, saucer-like eyes but later realised they were what attracted and intrigued people the most. From a very young age, I grew accustomed to both men and women tripping over themselves at the sight of me or having all conversation stop the minute I walked into a room.

But my parents made sure none of it went to my head. Outside of the house, the praise and accolades were all fine and good, but the moment I stepped inside, it was drummed into my head that good grades, good behaviour, good home-keeping, and humility were much more important.

“The same man who wants to kill himself because of your face is the same one who will throw you away when your breasts fall down,” my mother would often quip. “A woman who knows how to take care of her home is what men really want.”

My father had a less traditional reason. “Beauty without brains is nothing, Ada,” he would often say. “This is the ‘90s. Soon, we will be in a new millennium. If you study hard and get good grades, even the sky will not be your limit.”

He encouraged me to dream, and dream I did. I dreamt of being an engineer one day, maybe even an aerospace engineer working at NASA, all the way in the United States of America. Not particularly a small dream for a young girl living in Onitsha with traders for parents.

Ours was a very modest life, but our parents had big dreams for my siblings and I; big dreams we were all determined to fulfill. My younger brother, Jidenna, wanted to be a cardiologist one day, and my younger sister, Ahunna, fancied herself one day joining her idols, Ruth Benamasia and Siene Allwell Brown, reading the news on TV.

For the most part, we did live up to their expectations academically. We were all known, and even teased, for being overly studious and efficient. We studied hard and got good grades to show for it. In between school, church, domestic chores, and helping out our parents in their shop, we had little or no time to socialise. Ours was a simple life; a simple and happy one.

It was the beginning of 1996, the year I turned 16, when one of my parents’ biggest customers, a big bakery in Asaba, placed what was their largest order yet. With plans to expand their bakery to Lagos and Benin, their typical orders for flour, sugar, and margarine had quadrupled. Understandably, my parents were very excited about this and the prospect of similar orders from this customer, especially as I was on the verge of writing my final exams, and going to university was no longer simply

something nice to talk about, but a stark reality. And with Jidenna only a year behind me, the additional income would no doubt be very welcome.

The day the customer was scheduled to pick up their order of 50 bags each of flour and sugar, as well as 100 cartons of butter and flavouring, I was at the store to assist our father with this large order. He had decided Jidenna would be better off learning a skill during the holidays, so he was working with a mechanic near our house. Ahunna had taken ill, and our mother was at home tending to her.

It was a tense wait, and the persistent shake of my father's leg and his short temper with his staff were evidence of his nerves. My parents had taken a loan from a local loan shark to be able to buy so much stock, and if the customer decided against the purchase, it would spell big trouble for them.

"Ha abiawo," Ebube, one of the shop assistants, announced when the familiar truck pulled up in front of the shop. "They are here."

That single announcement restored the store to life, and by the time Linus, the bakery's stock manager, hopped out of the truck, we were all primed and ready for them.

"Nwoke, you wanted to give me a heart attack!" my father exclaimed, giving his longtime customer a playful punch on the shoulder. "We've been waiting for you since. It's not like you to get here at this time."

"Biko, ewela iwe. Don't be angry. It couldn't be helped," Linus apologized, gesturing towards the vehicle with his head.

My father, never one to catch any hint subtle or overt, blurted, "Onye? Is someone in the car with you?"

Linus rolled his eyes in exasperation, just as a young man, who looked to still be in his teens, emerged from the truck. He smiled and bowed his head

in greeting, an obvious testament to his good upbringing, but the slight purse of his lips showed he had caught on to the unsuccessful non-verbal exchange between his companion and my father.

“Erm, small Oga, this is Mazi Okafor, and he is the owner of the shop,” Linus muttered. “Mazi, this is my small Oga. Chief’s last born.”

The way he stressed ‘last born’ sounded more like an insult than a description.

“Linus, I’m not any mazi, oh. Don’t give me any title I haven’t earned,” my father said with a nervous laugh. “It’s nice to meet you, young man. Aloysius is my name. It’s nice to see Chief already has a good succession plan in place.”

I stood in a corner as the guy was introduced as Anayo and noted how he looked very close to my own 16 years of age. As my father walked Linus into the inner store room, my eyes connected with Anayo’s, and I literally felt my heart stop beating. That was the moment, the very moment, that I finally understood my mother’s constant admonition for me never to ‘lose my head over any boy’. Because standing before the tall, lean, and honey-coloured teenager, I knew I had already lost my head.

“Do you work here?” he asked, making me jump.

“Only during the holidays,” I managed to answer, trying to keep my voice steady. He looked just like Ralph Tresvant, and the more I looked at him, the more I felt myself turn into butter. “It’s my dad’s shop.”

He nodded in acknowledgement but didn’t look particularly surprised by that piece of information. “You already know my name, but you haven’t told me yours,” he said, walking towards me with a smile on his face. I had to stifle a smile of my own, as I saw the same admiration in his eyes that

almost all members of the male species had around me, and I was never more pleased about the effect I had on men as I was that day.

“Adanna,” I answered, feeling a bit more brazen now, whilst also regretting my simple choice of attire; an old dress, so faded the floral patterns looked more like colour stains.

“Adanna,” he repeated, my name rolling off his tongue like very fine wine.

“That’s a beautiful name. How old are you? Do you school around here?”

I was tempted to lie but reluctantly decided telling the truth would be best, no matter what it cost me. “Sixteen,” I answered, deliberately leaving out the name of my local secondary school, which I was sure he wouldn’t know anyway.

“Sixteen? Wow! You don’t look sixteen,” he said, visibly surprised, something I wasn’t sure pleased or annoyed me. “I’m eighteen. I just finished from UDSS, University Demonstration Secondary School.” When I looked blank, he added, “In Benin.”

“Ngwanu o, ka anyi jee,” came Linus’ whiny voice, as he and my father emerged from the store, with our shop assistants bearing their goods. “Let us be going, Anayo. Before they think I’ve sold you in the market place.”

“Did you count every...” Anayo began to ask, squaring up before his father’s staff, his voice notably deeper.

Linus let out an irritated hiss. “Is it now that you will be asking me questions? If you wanted to know, you for come inside the store come count with me, na. Let us go, jor! If you want to cross-check, feel free! Biko Mazi, we have left. Greet your wife for me.”

And just like that, Anayo was whisked away.

I stood outside as their truck pulled out of the busy street, and I almost felt like running after it to have a few more minutes, just a few more minutes, talking with him. But instead, I stood there, rooted to the spot, watching until their car turned onto the major highway and disappeared. How could God have sent someone like that my way, only to take him away so quickly? I knew better than to ask my father any questions about when they would probably return to restock, so I kept my mouth shut and silently helped him balance his books.

In the coming days, the euphoria from the successful transaction was overshadowed by Ahunna's continued failing health. What was initially suspected to be malaria was proving to be much more, as her legs were swelling inexplicably. My parents decided traditional medicine would be better for her, so my mother travelled with her to her home town of Abatete, leaving me in charge of running our household. Between this and helping my father out at the shop, Anayo was truly the last thing on my mind. Which is why when he showed up again a week later, it took me completely by surprise.

It was a slow market day, and I'd been sitting on a stool, idly chewing gum and picking at my fingernails, when he suddenly appeared at the door. I was so shocked, I almost fell off my stool. Outwardly though, my face remained stoic and expressionless. I didn't want to give him the satisfaction of seeing the effect he was having on me.

"Hi, beautiful," he said, leaning over the counter, so close, I could feel his breath on my skin.

I felt my face flush. "Hi...hello," I stammered back. "I didn't think you guys would be back to restock so soon."

He smiled, and the sight of his immaculate, snow-white teeth made me feel lightheaded. Thank God I was sitting. He was truly the most handsome human being I had ever laid eyes on. “No. I’m here to see you.”

I looked at him, shocked. “Me? You came all the way from Asaba to see me?”

“It’s just a 30-minute drive. I didn’t have to take the night bus or anything,” he chuckled, prompting a smile from me. “You’ve been on my mind ever since the last time we were here, and I just had to see you again.”

Deep in my heart, I knew this line of conversation was wrong, very wrong. I knew this was the kind of thing I had been trained all my life to avoid. But the allure, the pull, was the strongest I had ever experienced.

“Are you busy? Is your father around? Can I take you out for a quick drink?” he asked, leaning even closer. “Don’t worry, I’ll bring you back in no time.”

That was when I noticed the shiny, black Toyota Celica parked outside and realised he had driven it there. This only made the temptation so much stronger.

“No, no, and...” I hesitated in answering the third question. My father had gone to his wholesaler in Aba, and I knew that I wouldn’t be missed too much if I just went out for a little while. “Fine, but I have to be back soon,” I finally said, with a quick glance at Ebube, who was fast asleep on a bench by the doorway. The other attendant, Ebenezer, had gone in search of lunch.

He smiled like he’d won the jackpot, and when he took my hand to lead me to his car, it sent shock waves through my whole body. Getting into the flashy sports car, I hated that I was again under-dressed. I wished I’d had the opportunity to prepare properly, to make an even bigger impression than

I already had. But alas, there I was in a frayed corduroy skirt, faded football jersey, and rubber bathroom slippers. I suddenly felt like running out of the car.

“Is there anywhere in particular you want to go? I don’t know Onitsha that well,” Anayo said.

I merely shrugged in response, trying to feign indifference, when in reality, my insecurity was eating me alive. For the first time, I noticed his expensive-looking leather loafers and even more expensive-looking watch, and knew I was nowhere near his level. What did a polished guy like him want from a bush girl like me?

Rather than be discouraged, he’d smiled and drove all the way to the GRA, to a bar nestled in a small boutique hotel. I didn’t utter a word of complaint as the drive took us to the other end of town, because even I wanted to be far away from the gossips in my neighbourhood. Dealing with them would be a whole lot harder to handle than getting back a bit late.

Walking into the highbrow bar, there were a few raised brows, and I knew it had less to do with my striking beauty and more to do with my unsuitable attire. But Anayo didn’t seem to care, so I’d walked in with him with my head held high, bathroom slippers and all. Taking a seat beside him, I made sure to sit with my legs crossed and my back rod straight. I wasn’t going to reflect on the outside how inadequate I was feeling on the inside.

“My God, you are so beautiful!” Anayo remarked as we waited for our drinks. “I was worried that I had exaggerated your beauty in my mind and that you wouldn’t be able to live up to it if I saw you again. But gosh! You are even more beautiful than I remember. I’m sure you hear this every day.”

A part of me wanted to tell him that, truly, I had been hearing it all my life, but another part of me wanted this to feel special and like something that

was new to us both. “No,” I answered, shaking my head. “Nobody has ever told me that.”

“I like you, Adanna. I really like you,” he said, taking my hand in his. “I want us to be special friends.”

“Special friends?” I echoed, not quite understanding his drift.

“I want you to be my girlfriend,” he answered. “Adanna, I want to marry you.”

I was caught up in the moment, but not enough not to hear the foolery in his words. “Marry me? Is that how they marry?” I laughed at him. “You’re just a teenager! Besides, we hardly even know each other.”

“I can court you,” was his emphatic answer. “We aren’t too young to court. My late mother was probably about a year or two older than you are now when she married my father.”

I placed my hand over his. “Anayo, there is no rush. Let’s get to know each other first. I also like you, but let’s take things slowly, okay?”

This didn’t quite satisfy him but, luckily, he didn’t say any more on the subject, and we were soon chatting about our lives in general. He told me about being the youngest of three children, even though the oldest was not from his mother. He told me about losing her at a young age and how that affected him growing up. I told him about my very strict upbringing and my NASA dreams, and before we knew it, we’d been sitting, chatting, and drinking there for almost four hours.

“I have to go, Anayo,” I said. “It’s getting late. My father will soon start looking for me.”

He nodded in understanding. “I’ll be back to see you in a few days. Then we can talk more.”

We walked back to the car, and just as I was about to get in, he pulled me into his arms and kissed me. It was completely unexpected but, I guess on a deeper level, my heart had been longing for it. As innocent as I was, I knew what a passionate kiss was meant to be like. Alongside my textbooks and NASA literature, I was also an avid reader of Mills & Boon and Harlequin romances, and I'd fantasised over the day I would meet someone whose kiss would make me levitate.

And levitate I did, as Anayo's kiss deepened. It felt like I was floating in air. I never wanted it to stop.

"I better take you back before we do something we shouldn't," he groaned in my ear. "I don't know how you've done it, but I'm completely crazy about you, Adanna. You're like a drug to me."

I wanted to tell him I felt the same, and that being in his arms was making me doubt, question, and re-calibrate my entire moral compass. I was ashamed to admit to myself that if he'd wanted to take things further with me, I might not have been strong enough to refuse. But I knew I would be better off not appearing so easy.

"One step after the other, Anayo," I said, disengaging from him and entering the car. "Let's get to know each other first."

The ride back to the shop felt shorter, and we made plans to see each other the following week. When we pulled up in front of the shop, he looked at me with longing. "Can I kiss you again?"

Much as I wanted to say yes, I knew that there was a high chance of being caught by one of the other traders in the vicinity, and the last thing my family needed was the scandal. So instead, I'd squeezed his knee. "Not right now, Anayo. When you come back."

“Can I have your phone number?” he asked, as I got out of the car.

Again, my feelings of inadequacy rose to the fore. “Our phone is not working,” I lied, not being able to tell him my family had never, for once, owned a telephone. “I’ll see you next week. Drive safely.”

And with that, I scampered away, just like Cinderella would have at the stroke of midnight. Because if I’d lingered for another second, the way Cinderella’s glamour vanished a minute past the hour, he might have realised that there really wasn’t much of a big deal about me anyway.

Getting back to the shop, I was surprised that my father, who by now had returned, didn’t even ask me about my whereabouts. He was, instead, preoccupied with taking stock of his consignment from Aba, which I saw was a whole lot. My mouth parted in shock, as I realised that he had probably taken delivery of over double, if not triple, the normal quantity he would have purchased.

“I decided to stock up for the next three or four times the Nsofor’s bakery comes to buy market,” my father announced proudly. “Apart from the fact that it saves us the stress of making several trips to Aba, I was able to get a big discount by buying a larger quantity.”

Looking at the floor to ceiling stack of sacks of flour and sugar, I knew my mother would never have agreed to this. I also knew that my father had taken another loan to fund this, as his wholesaler would never have released the items to him on credit. But considering we had consistent business with the bakery, if it made more economic sense and had a higher payoff, then I reckoned there was no harm in taking the gamble.

But that was the least of what occupied my thoughts. For the rest of that day and even that week, all I could think about was Anayo. When I closed my eyes, I felt the tenderness of his lips just as vividly as if he was still kissing

me. I made sure I went to the shop properly dressed up every day so that I wouldn't be caught unawares again. But as the days turned into a week, which became yet another week, and then another, my anxiety grew. Had he decided I wasn't worth the trouble after all?

Another person who was worried about the bakery's delayed return was my father. He made several attempts to reach Linus, none of which were successful. With hundreds of thousands of naira worth of inventory sitting in our store, any difficulty to offload them was not an option.

After almost a month, we finally sighted their van making its way down the street to our shop.

"Ha no ebe a!" our shop assistant yelled, running into the shop in excitement. "They're here!"

Upon hearing that, my father didn't have to ask whom he was referring to. There was only one party whose arrival was worthy of that kind of announcement. He smiled and straightened at the familiar sight of the truck, but to our collective surprise, it wasn't Linus who emerged, neither was it the dashing Anayo. Instead, approaching our shop was a well-dressed young man, too well dressed to be an employee.

"Good afternoon, Mr. Okafor," he said, his tall frame shadowing our doorway. "I'm from the Triple A Bakery in Asaba."

My father nodded. "Yes, I recognized the van. Linus didn't come with you?"

The man smiled, but there was no humour in that smile. "Linus no longer works for us. My name is Akanna, and I'm the new man in charge. My father owns the bakery."

There was something about his smile that sent an ominous chill down my spine, and from the way my father was fidgeting, I wasn't the only one with a premonition of doom.

"Mr. Okafor, my father and I agreed it would be best for us to give you the news in person," he continued. "We will not be purchasing any more items from you. We've been able to find a much cheaper source, and as a business man, I'm sure you can understand."

"Ehn?" my father exclaimed. "Ha, Oga, abeg! We have been selling to your father for years. In fact, we have restocked to meet your requirements for the next three months..."

"Mr. Okafor, I'm afraid this decision is final," Akanna cut in, his eyes widening to drive home his point. "We found out that Linus has been cheating us for years, and he was probably able to get away with it for so long, thanks to people like you."

"Alu!" my father exclaimed, his face red. "Abomination! Me, Aloysius Okafor, a cheat? Never! Young man, I might not have money, but one thing I don't joke with is my name!"

I glared at the spiteful man, standing there and insulting my father. He looked to be in his late 20s and was obviously the older half-brother Anayo had told me about. He was just as handsome, if not even more so, but there was nothing likeable about him. Nothing at all.

"Be that as it may, we have made alternative arrangements for our supplies," Akanna continued. "We are under no obligation to give you any advance notice. Me being here to tell you in person is out of courtesy and respect."

“Oga, biko! Please!” my father pleaded, chasing after the man as he walked towards his car. “I beg you. I will reduce the price. I will take off my margin. Anything you want.”

“I’m sorry, Mr. Okafor, but this is final. Your company has been blacklisted,” he answered, and it was then that he clapped eyes on me. “Are you Adanna?”

I equal parts wanted to punch him in the face for humiliating my father and also to recoil into a ball far away from his line of sight. “Yes,” was all I could manage to say in response.

“Anayo asked me to deliver this to you,” he said, an unmistakable smirk on his face as he held an envelope in his hand. As I walked up to him, he practically undressed me with his eyes, and I regretted the effort I’d made in trying to look attractive for Anayo’s visit. I hated the fact that the short dress I wore had my full thighs on display and wished I’d opted for any of my unflattering outfits instead.

“Where is he?” I asked, as I took the envelope from his hand.

“He’s gone to England, my dear,” Akanna answered, his eyes twinkling with amusement. “He left last week but asked me to deliver this to you myself. I hope he hasn’t broken your heart.”

England? I had so many questions I wanted to ask but knew it was not the time.

“Oga please, don’t blacklist us. Isn’t there something we can do?” I asked, not fully comprehending what that meant or the impact of this on our business, but knowing that it would be catastrophic for us.

He shook his head. “Little girl, don’t get involved in what you don’t understand.” Then turning to my father, he said. “Good day, Mr. Okafor. It’s

nice to have finally met you, even if under such unpleasant circumstances.”

We watched in silence as the truck pulled out of the small street, but by the time I turned back to look at my father, his face was ashen.

“I am finished, Adanna. I took a loan to buy all those things,” he said, confirming my fears. “Four hundred thousand naira! Your mother is going to kill me.”

I cringed internally but opted to be optimistic. “They aren’t the only customers in the world, daddy. We will find other people who can buy them, don’t worry. Ebube and I will draw some posters and paste them around. I’m sure we will find people who will buy.”

My father simply nodded, listlessly, before retreating to one of the back rooms. With him gone, and the shop assistants huddled in a corner gossiping about what had just transpired, I opened the letter to read.

Adanna,

My beautiful Adanna. If you’re reading this, it means I’m already in London. Everything happened so fast and I only just found out plans had been made for me to start school here.

I cannot write much, as I know the bearer of this letter will most likely read it. I just want to remind you of everything that we discussed, and to ask you to wait for me.

Because I will be waiting for you.

Yours forever,

Anayo

I felt hot tears spring from my eyes, as I realized any hopes I had of being with Anayo had been shattered like cheap china. There was no way he

would ever want to be with me, not after hobnobbing with beautiful and sophisticated women from all over the world. I had lost him forever.

My father did not emerge from his office for the rest of the day, and when he eventually did, it was like he had aged overnight. He didn't say a word to anyone, and I was the one who had to give the shop assistants instructions to close.

Making the short walk home, he just kept mumbling "Four hundred thousand naira! Ebee ka m ga-ahụ ụdị ego ahụ? Where am I going to find that kind of money?"

When we got to our house, he placed his hand on my shoulder. "I need to go to the business center to make a phone call. I will be home soon."

I wish I'd been able to understand the hollow feeling I had in my stomach, an obvious premonition of what lay ahead. But I hadn't.

"Okay, Daddy. Is there anything you want me to make for you?" I'd already made a pot of egusi soup before leaving the house but was ready to cook him any delicacy that would lift his mood.

He'd smiled at me. "Thank you, my daughter. Anything you make is fine."

Jidenna returned from his master's shop shortly after, and we both waited for over an hour, not wanting to eat dinner without our father.

"Ada, I'm hungry, o!" he eventually scowled when it was past 8pm, and I had no choice but to serve him. By this time, I was very worried. It wasn't like our father to stay out this late, let alone with his young kids alone at home.

After his meal, Jidenna was soon fast asleep, and I slid on my slippers to see if I would find our father at the business center. But the moment I

opened the door, I saw three men standing there, clearly about to knock. I recognised one of them as the operator of the business center.

“Ike, I was just coming to your place to look for my dad,” I said to him, anxiously looking at the faces of the other unfamiliar men. “Is there any problem?”

“Ada, please is your mother around?” he asked, his voice uncharacteristically subdued. Ike’s voice was one you could typically hear from streets away, especially when it was time to argue over how many minutes had been spent on the phone.

“She’s not. It’s just Jidenna and I,” I answered, before repeating, “Is there any problem, Ike? Where is my father?”

“When will she be back? Is there no adult we can talk to?” one of the unfamiliar men asked, prompting a glare from me.

“There is no other person around. My mother has travelled, and I’m the one in charge. You can speak to me.”

“Ada, he slumped as he was about to leave the business center,” the other unfamiliar man answered.

“What do you mean by ‘slumped’?” I demanded, my anxiety rising. “And how do you know my name?”

“Ada, biko,” Ike said, reaching for my hand, but I withdrew from him like he was a ball of fire. “Even me, as I’m standing here, amaghi m otu o si eme m. I don’t even know how it is doing me. One minute, he was harassing me for his change, the next minute, o dara n’ala. He just fell to the ground!”

“I was at the business center as well,” one of the men said. “He made several calls and appeared very upset...”

“Where is he now? Did you take him to the hospital?” I asked, my eyes welling with tears as, even though they hadn’t said the words, I already knew.

“Ada, he is dead,” Ike finally said, looking at me with sad eyes but making no attempt to hold me again. “By the time we rushed him to the clinic down our street, they told us he was already dead. Biko, gbasie ike. Please be strong, for the sake of your mother...”

I didn’t hear anymore, neither could I be strong any longer. All I remember from that evening is falling to my feet, being held up by the men, and being joined by some of our neighbours who heard the noise.

It wasn’t only my father that died that day. My childhood did as well.

Chapter Three

The Aftermath

What I remember is anger. So much anger.

The neighbours were angry with Ike and his companions for breaking the news to me, a child, instead of looking for an older member of the family. Pretty much everyone close to our family was angry with the ‘wicked’ and ‘evil’ people from Asaba, who had indirectly killed my father. But the worst of all these was the anger my mother had...for her husband.

She and Ahunna returned the very next day after the tragedy. From the harried way in which she entered the house, it was clear they had left Abatete in a hurry. Our house was full of neighbours and sympathisers who had volunteered to keep Jidenna and me company, and she brushed them all off as they made to console her.

She searched our living room for me, and when our eyes met, it was like that was the confirmation she needed that, indeed, her husband of almost 20 years was dead. She let out a loud wail as she collapsed to the floor, which also triggered more tears from me. We wept together, holding on to each other like our lives depended on it.

By evening, she’d heard all the versions of the story possible. I told her about how he had taken a loan to overstock the shop and what subsequently

transpired with the new Asaba bakery manager. Ike also talked about how agitated he had been when he came to the business center, and the several frantic phone calls he'd made, almost all of which ended in shouting matches. By then, her tears had dried up. Her desolation gave way to rage, which intensified even further when she went to the shop and saw, with her own two eyes, the ridiculous amount of inventory she was now burdened with.

“Chukwu taa gi ahụhụ n’ebe ọ bụla i nọ,” I heard her mutter under her breath, as we stood in the dusty room, surrounded by sacks of flour and sugar. “God punish you, Aloy! God punish you for leaving me with this mess!”

Standing there with her, I realised that I, too, shared her anger.

We were to find out that my father had died of a massive stroke, which had apparently been brewing for a while. It turned out that there was more to the headache he'd intermittently complained of for weeks. Whether or not the incident with Akanna Nsofor had been a trigger was anybody's guess. What was for certain was that Aloysius Okafor was dead...at the age of only 44.

In the days that followed, my paternal uncles arrived, my father's body was claimed from the mortuary, and in less than a week, we were whisked to his hometown of Ogidi for the funeral. There was to be no fuss, no drama. A young man had died, and there was nothing to celebrate.

I watched as my mother went through the rites of her new status of widow, all of which she endured with little or no emotion. After the funeral, she was shaved of every strand of hair on her body. I remember how inconsolably I'd wept the first time I saw her in that state, bare headed and donned in her shapeless, black mourning attire. It had absolutely broken my

heart. Seeing her looking like that was a clear reminder of what we had lost; a provider, a protector, and the engine that kept our home running.

We were in the village for a whole month. In that period, school resumed but there was no talk about any of us returning, at least not just yet. The burden of worrying about our fees after the expenses of the funeral would be too much for the young widow to bear, and none of my father's siblings were in the position to assist.

Another reason for the delay was Ahunna's health, which had not improved at all after their sojourn to Abatete. As a matter of fact, it had worsened. Even as traumatized as I had been in the days after our father's death, I had noticed how gaunt my sister had become. She was lighter by at least 10 kilograms, weight her already lean 12-year-old body could not afford to lose. But even with all that weight loss, her extremities remained swollen. Her legs especially had doubled in size. There was clearly something wrong.

"What did you say is wrong with her?" Auntie Uloma, my father's older sister, asked my mother one day, as Ahunna lay on her usual spot on the only sofa in the living room, looking exhausted even though it was only 7 AM .

"It's some kind of stubborn malaria," my mother answered, her voice frail. "I will take her back to Abatete when we leave here, so she can continue her treatment."

"Abatete? Kedu ihe na Abatete? What is happening there?" Auntie Uloma exclaimed, clearly surprised.

"There is one man who is very experienced with all these medicinal leaves. She was improving when we were there."

Aunty Uloma stared at my mother, mouth agape, for what might have been a good minute before she started clapping her hands in amazement. “Medicinal leaves kwa. I chọrọ lie nwa gị! It’s like you want to bury your child as well as your husband.”

“God forbid!”

“Ugochi! Ugochi! Ugochi! Ugboro ole ka m kpọrọ gị?” Aunty Uloma said, dragging her own ear dramatically.

“Three times,” my mother answered, her lips pursed in her irritation.

“If you know what is good for you, you better take that girl to see a doctor, ọsịsọ!” Aunty Uloma said, still dragging her ear. “That girl is like a living dead. Lee ya anya. Just look at her!”

All eyes in the living room turned to the sleeping form on the sofa, and we all knew Aunty Uloma was right. My mother’s eyes clouded with tears, and her sister-in-law put a comforting arm around her.

“If it’s money that is the issue, I will give you what I have. I will also raise money from my brothers before it’s time for you to go back to Onitsha. Let us do whatever we can, because if we leave this girl like this, hian! Ọ ga-abụ mbibi o! It will be a disaster!”

That remained on all our minds for the remainder of our stay in the village and as we journeyed back to Onitsha. True to her words, Aunty Uloma was able to not only raise ten thousand naira for us, she also came to Onitsha a few days after our return, to help take Ahunna to the hospital, considering the restrictions on my mother’s movements. But my stubborn mother wouldn’t hear any of it.

“So why then did I come all this way if you’ll insist on coming along?” Aunty Uloma exclaimed, throwing her hands up in frustration. “You are

meant to be resting at home! Have you forgotten you are in mourning?”

“I’ve had more than enough rest,” was my mother’s tart answer. “Let’s go.”

Reluctantly, Auntie Uloma conceded, and all three of them left for the hospital. They’d had no choice but to charter a taxi, as Ahunna was in no condition to make the long trip to the Teaching Hospital any other way. Funnily enough, I wasn’t worried about what the outcome of the hospital visit would be. On the contrary, I was relieved. In my childish mind, I equated going to the hospital with immediate healing. I expected my sister to bounce back, all strong and invigorated, the way my father would have if he had only paid better attention to his health.

They didn’t return until evening, and even then, they came back with no resolution. Apparently, after a long wait when they got there, more time was spent running tests on Ahunna, which was followed by another long wait to see the doctor, after which they had finally been asked to return in a few days when the test results would be ready. It was very disappointing, especially as Ahunna was even further weakened by the stress of the trip. Auntie Uloma insisted on remaining in Onitsha until the next hospital visit, much to my mother’s chagrin.

To be honest, I was happy to have her positive energy in our house, replacing the pervading gloom and doom. Our flow of visitors had become a mere trickle. With my mother either locked in her room or attending to the ailing Ahunna all day, and Jidenna sulking about not having returned to school, our home wasn’t the happiest place to be. But Auntie Uloma, just like her late brother, was full of fun stories and anecdotes and had a way of making you forget your worries.

Except the next day, not even her funniest tales could diffuse an even worse situation.

It was a little past noon, and everyone was napping, Auntie Uloma included. I found myself too nervous to sleep. There were 48 more hours before Ahunna's test results would be released, and I was getting increasingly anxious about the outcome. I was also getting antsy about the prolonged closure of our shop. Ebube and Ebenezer had come a few times to inquire about when, or if, it would reopen, but my mother had been in no mood to have the discussion. I guess it was still too painful for her. But it didn't stop me from worrying about our inventory, depreciating with every passing day. The sharp knock on the door snapped me out of my reverie. Standing outside were three men who, in their casual shirts and trousers, could have passed for your typical market traders. They looked like ordinary guys, except there was something about the set of their faces that told me otherwise.

"Is your mother at home?" the shortest of them asked. He was the smallest one but looked like he had the most authority.

"She's sleeping,"

"Wake her," he ordered. "Gwa ya Coach nọ ebe a. Tell her Coach is here."

"Coach?" I repeated, more to stall than to clarify.

He smiled patiently. "Yes, Coach."

I nodded and shut the door, not knowing how wise it would be to invite them in. Making my way to my mother's bedroom, I knocked tentatively on her door.

"She's sleeping. Leave her alone." Auntie Uloma whispered hoarsely, emerging from Ahunna's room, where she had been napping.

"There are some men outside," I told her. "One of them says his name is Coach. They want to see her."

“Onye bu Coach?” she demanded with an irritated grunt, before storming over to the door. “Good afternoon, o,” she greeted. “Biko, she’s sleeping. You know how it is. We shouldn’t disturb her.”

“Nne, this is very important,” Coach answered, politely but firmly. “We’ve given her plenty of time, but it’s now time to talk about...about serious business.”

“What is the serious business? Don’t worry, you can talk to me. My late brother was her husband.”

The men exchanged odd glances.

“Aloy was your brother?” the one who looked to be the youngest asked. “Ah, in that case, you’re the one we should be talking to.”

“Talking to about what?” Auntie Uloma asked, crossing her arms. But her voice had gone up an octave, an indication that she too was getting scared.

“Nsogbu adighi,” Coach interjected. “There is no need to panic. It’s just a small matter that needs resolving, that’s all. Aloy was a very good man, God rest his soul. Had death not snatched him so rudely, we wouldn’t even be here to make any demands. In fact, left to me, I would have preferred to just write the whole thing off. But unfortunately, we can’t. No be me get the money. As im take borrow am, na so me sef borrow am. I ghọtara?”

Auntie Uloma’s eyes widened. “Aloy was owing you? How much?”

“Four hundred thousand naira, plus interest.”

“Hei!” she exclaimed, before stepping aside and allowing the men into the house. “Sit down, please. I’ll go and get the wife. Ada, get them something to drink.”

Unfortunately, our last set of visitors had enjoyed the last bottles of soda we had, so water was all we could offer our ‘guests’. Having overheard everything, my hands shook as I set glass cups before them. The last thing my father and I discussed was this same loan, and short of a miracle, there was no way we would be able to raise that kind of money.

“Coach, how now?” came my mother’s voice, as she emerged from her room.

All three men rose to their feet, in respect and commiseration.

“Nwunye anyi, ndo o,” Coach greeted. “We are so sorry about what happened to Aloy. But kedu ihe mere? What happened? How could a young man just die like that?”

My mother smiled and took a seat, and I could immediately read her smile. It was one that could see through the false act of sympathy. After all, according to Ike, one of the last calls my father made that evening was to his creditor, and it hadn’t been a pleasant one. Who knows if it hadn’t been the pressure they’d mounted on him that had sent him to a premature grave.

“I guess it was his time,” my mother answered, looking Coach straight in the eye. “You shouldn’t have given him that kind of a loan. When he came asking for almost 10 times more than what we typically get from you, you should have refused him.”

Coach chuckled. “My sister, ọ bughị otú ahụ. That’s not how it works. That’s not how this business is. Aloy said he could pay it back, and we trusted him. After all, we have been helping him out for years.”

“Ngwanu, here we are now,” my mother said, shrugging. “I have no way of paying back your money, unless you want me to steal.”

Coach chuckled again, but the humour was fast dissipating from it. “Nwunye Aloy, you’re very funny. You know that is money I trade with. It belongs to my business. Aloy and I agreed on a repayment plan starting after a month. We are in the second month now, and no payment. I decided to give you time, out of respect, but unfortunately, we have to think of a way to raise that money.”

My mother shrugged again. “Unless you will collect the things we bought with the money. That’s the only solution. The customers we expected disappointed us, and we have nobody else who can take it off our hands. So, we might as well give the items to you.”

By now, all three men were chuckling.

“Madam, I no dey sell sugar, o! I just dey gentle because your late husband na my guy, but please, no allow me show my other side.” Coach finally said, all traces of laughter gone. He and his entourage rose to their feet. “I will give you one more month because I know it won’t be easy for you to raise the money. But, biko nwaa ike gi, o. Try your best, so that we can remain friends at the end of the day.”

After they left, the three of us sat in silence in the living room, until Auntie Uloma finally exclaimed. “What was Aloysius doing that he borrowed four hundred thousand naira? Four hundred thousand naira! Not kobo, oh, naira!”

I was saddened by the fact that my father was being vilified by everyone. If everything had worked out perfectly, the profit from the deal would have been worth celebrating. Alas, it hadn’t, and he had become the foolish man who had borrowed a ridiculously large sum of money, with no means of repayment.

My mother rose and wordlessly returned to her room, effectively ending the conversation. Later that night, I heard raised voices coming from her room, and I could tell she and Auntie Uloma were having an argument about the incident. I strained to hear their words, but couldn't.

My mother's voice was louder than Auntie Uloma's, so I figured she was angered about her judgmental attitude. It wasn't surprising that she was being protective of her husband in his death, despite the same resentment she herself had nursed earlier on. In all of this, all of us, his sister inclusive, knew he would never have put us in trouble deliberately.

But there was more trouble to come.

When Ahunna's test results came back, they weren't as bad as we'd thought they would be. No. They were much worse. In fact, they were downright dire. Her kidneys were failing, and she needed a kidney transplant to stay alive.

"They say we will have to go to Israel or India for a kidney transplant," my mother said, as she broke the news to me later that evening. Mom and Auntie Uloma had shielded Ahunna from the information and could only discuss it with me when she and Jidenna had gone to bed. "No hospital here can do it."

"Israel or India?" I cried, feeling like I was in the middle of either a very bad dream or an even worse Nollywood movie.

Auntie Uloma sighed deeply. "The doctor said it could cost anything from two to ten million naira."

Ten million naira? I just stared from my aunt to my mother, mouth agape. I didn't even know tears had gathered in my eyes until they started falling freely down my face. Was God playing some kind of joke? When we were

still in a bind about how to raise Coach's money, He had to throw this kind of curveball our way?

"Where are we going to get that kind of money?" I wailed.

My mother sighed deeply. "My daughter, I don't know. It will take a miracle. But whatever it takes, I will do. I will get that money even if it means selling everything I have."

"Ugochi, this will be hard to hear, but I just have to say it," Auntie Uloma said, leaning closer to my mother. "You can not take food out of your other children's mouths just to feed one. O nwurū anwū. She is already dead. Let us just accept it, instead of killing all of them because of one."

"What are you saying?" my mother demanded, glaring at her sister-in-law.

"I know you understand what I'm saying, but since you want me to spell it out," Auntie Uloma answered defiantly. "What they told us today is just the same as saying Ahunna has a terminal disease. No matter what we do, she will still die. What happens after you sell your property, sell yourself even, and she ends up dying in the end? That will be a disaster. Look at Adanna and the brother, who are yet to return to school over a month after they resumed. Think about them, instead of onye nwere ukwu n'ili. She has one foot in the grave already."

I glared at my aunt, too shocked to say a word. I stole a glance at my mother, who was staring at nothing in the space ahead of her, her face unreadable.

"I nūrū ihe m kwuru? Did you hear what I said?" Auntie Uloma prodded.

"Get out of my house," came my mother's voice, so quiet it was barely audible.

"I si?"

“I said get out!” my mother screamed, suddenly lunging at her, ready to tear her apart. If I hadn’t dived straight into the middle to restrain her, she very well would have. “You want me to leave my child to die? God punish you! God punish you over and over again. Why don’t you allow your own children to die? Why don’t you go home and stab your own children with a knife? Because that is what you are asking me to do to my daughter!”

“If you like, don’t listen to wisdom,” Auntie Uloma said from behind me. “Continue daydreaming. Maybe you have a money tree planted behind your house, because I don’t understand where a woman, who can barely put food on the table to feed her children, wants to get millions of naira from. Even if you want to do ashewo, how much can you even get? Who do you think will give you money? Is it my brothers that are struggling? Or me? Biko, open your head and have sense, instead of behaving like a child.”

The arguing degenerated until Auntie Uloma did indeed pack her things and leave our house at 10pm that night. With her leaving, I knew that was her effectively turning her back on us. After locking the door behind her, I looked at my mother, and for the very first time, I saw helplessness. Yes, she’d had the bravado to defy her sister-in-law and defend her daughter, but like everyone else, myself inclusive, she didn’t have a clue how she would raise the money.

“Maybe if you go and beg the bakery, they can still take the goods?” I asked hopefully. “If they hear Daddy is dead, maybe they’ll pity us and reverse their decision. I’m friends with Chief Nsofor’s youngest son, so he might be able to help.”

She looked at me, probably wanting to ask what I meant by ‘friends’, but she was clearly physically, mentally and emotionally spent. I was surprised when she eventually nodded.

“We will try the bakery,” was her flat answer.

We both knew that, even with the highest mark-up, we would not be able to raise even a million Naira. But it was still worth a try.

The very next day, armed with the address of the bakery, my mother and I journeyed to Asaba. The bus we’d boarded dropped us a few feet from the bakery, and as we approached the building, I found myself feeling overwhelmed. From the look on my mother’s face, I wasn’t the only one.

Sitting on about four hectares of land, this was more than a bakery. It was a full-on establishment. The place was brimming with activity, with uniformed workers milling in and around in their scores. As we approached the main entrance, we walked past several automation centers, where bread, biscuits, wafers, and other confectioneries were being packaged. I slowed down, taking it all in. It was so much more than the little neighbourhood bakery I had imagined. I guess this could explain Anayo’s flashy car and expensive wristwatch. This place was no small operation.

“Can I help you? Do you want to buy bread?” came a voice. It was a woman seated in the reception, and she was sizing us up, as my mother and I stood at the doorway, looking like refugees. “We only sell wholesale, o. So, if you’re here to buy ten naira bread, you won’t find it here.”

“We’re here to see...” my mother started, before turning to whisper in my ear. “Gini bu aha nwoke ahu? What’s that man’s name again?”

“Akanna,” I answered, feeling even more self-conscious.

The woman looked at us from over her glasses. “You want to see Akanna? Chief’s first son, or another Akanna?”

“We’re from the shop in Onitsha, where they buy their stock,” I said, stepping forward.

The woman looked unimpressed. “I’m sorry, but Akanna isn’t here. He is in Lagos now. If you want to see him, you can go there.”

“What about Anayo?” I asked, pushing my luck further. “He is my boyfriend.”

Both my mother and the woman looked at me incredulously, but this only emboldened me.

“Your boyfriend?” the woman repeated, still peering at me from over her glasses. “Someone that is in Great Britain?”

“He is my boyfriend, and I have an urgent message for his father,” I said, my shoulders squared, determined to get audience with the almighty Chief Nsofor, whatever the benefit. “I’ll be very grateful if we could either see Chief, or if you could give me Anayo’s phone number in England, so I can call him...”

“The anya m hụrụ! The things my eyes see in this place,” the woman said, shaking her head. “Are you pregnant?”

I gasped and shook my head, scandalised by the mere insinuation.

The woman hissed and shook her head again. “Little girl, my advice is that you go home. If you want bread, pass by the small building outside and tell them I sent you. They will give you some free loaves. Just don’t stay here telling stories.”

“Telling what stories?” came a deep voice from behind us.

The woman almost tripped over her stool in her mad scramble to stand on her feet. “Good mor...good afternoon, Sir.”

Before we turned around to look at him, we were already overwhelmed by his presence. His rich perfume was like the emissary he had sent before him

to announce his entrance. Standing behind us was a tall, lean man who looked to be in his mid-fifties. Dressed impeccably in a tan French suit and decked in gold jewellery around his neck, wrists, and fingers, he stood majestic, regal and handsome. Anayo was his carbon copy.

He looked at my mother and I. “Have you been well attended to?”

“They say they’re here to see you,” the woman said, a mischievous glint in her eye.

He looked at us, and I found myself literally trembling in fear. There was a cursory glance at my mother, but when he got to me, he scanned me from my hair to bathroom slippers.

“Should I get security to throw them out, Sir?”

“No. No, don’t bother with that,” he answered his over-zealous member of staff. “I’ll see them.” Then, smiling at us, added, “Follow me.”

As my mother and I obeyed, first upstairs and then through a labyrinth of offices, we finally got to one which was even bigger than our entire flat back in Onitsha.

“Nọdụ. Sit down,” he said, gesturing at two chairs in the office. “So, how can I help you?”

“I am a widow,” my mother started. “You used to buy your supplies from the shop my late husband and I run in Onitsha...”

“Oh, Aloy’s wife?” the man proclaimed. “I’m so sorry for your loss. We heard about the unfortunate incident.”

“The thing is, we have come to plead with you about the goods you rejected and to see if there is any way at all you can...”

“Ah yes, after the Linus saga,” Chief Nsofor said.

“Please, Sir, we took a loan to be able to buy the goods,” my mother pleaded. “Have mercy on us, in the name of God. The loan sharks are on my neck, and we have been advised to take my younger daughter abroad for treatment. Her kidneys are failing, and we’ve been told she needs millions for a transplant.”

Chief Nsofor exhaled deeply and shook his head, his brows furrowed. “I’m so sorry to hear all of this. You have truly gone through a lot. Ordinarily, I would have asked Akanna to sort it out, but I just transferred him to Lagos to oversee our business there.” He was pensive for a few moments before finally smiling. “But I will help you. I will have my people take the items off you.”

My mother grabbed my hand in her relief. After thanking him profusely, we scampered out of his presence. Even though it would not cover Ahunna’s medical bill, it would go a long way in solving some of our other pressing problems...like getting Coach off our backs.

As our bus pulled into Onitsha, my mother leaned closer. “Let’s go to the shop,” she said, and I was genuinely surprised she finally wanted to go there. “We can send a message to Ebube and his partner to come over at once. Let’s send the goods to the bakery before they change their minds.”

Getting back to the shop, it took a few minutes to open the padlocked gates, as the old lock was now rusty. Upon entering, the dust inside was enough to build sand castles. The place was a mess.

“So you mean Ebube and Ebenezer did not think it wise to come and clean this place all this while?” my mother grunted, as she struggled to open the inner store. “Look how it is looking like wasteland.”

I was going to add some quip of my own, reminding her how she had discouraged everyone from even talking about the place, when the door to

the store finally opened. But the sight that befell our eyes dried up every word in my mouth.

The room was empty, cleared out. Every last sack of merchandise, down to the last sack of sugar, was gone.

We had been completely robbed. Four hundred thousand naira worth of goods had disappeared into thin air.

Chapter Four

The Decision

Our longtime shop assistants, Ebube and Ebenezer, had robbed us.

They had been spotted loading the items to a van over a week before. When they were questioned by neighbours, they told them the goods were being delivered to a new customer in Awka. This hadn't sounded odd to the other traders, neither had the fact that the shop remained locked in the days following. They'd thought my mother had decided to give up the shop following her husband's death. If only they knew how far, how very far, this would set us back, maybe they wouldn't have let the dreadful ingrates my father had taken care of like they were his own children, run away with the goods that had cost him his life.

We tried tracing them to the small apartment where they lived with Ebube's older brother, only to find the place completely empty.

“Ha apụọla,” an old man, who lived nearby, volunteered.

Truly, they had indeed moved out of the house. We combed their entire neighbourhood, but nobody seemed to know their new location. Either that or they just chose to protect them.

“They have finished me!” my mother, who had tried to control her emotions in the days following our discovery of the theft, lamented as we sat alone in our living room one evening. “Ebee ka m ga esi malite? Where on earth can I start from? What am I supposed to do?”

As her tears finally came forth, I held her in my arms, rocking her back and forth. I had no words of comfort for her, because there were none. We were truly finished.

My mother woke up very early the next morning. As I lay in bed, I saw her apply her makeup for the first time since my father's death, and she took extra care in tying her head tie. This was the first time in a long while that I would see her bother about her appearance.

"I'll be back. Take care of your younger ones," she said, before dashing out of the house. It wasn't even 6am.

As we were yet to return to school, Jidenna had since resumed his apprenticeship, so the only person I had to worry about was Ahunna. Taking care of her was getting more and more difficult, as she was fast degenerating. The swelling was worsening, she was constantly out of breath, and she was now always in excruciating pain. There was hardly anything that could alleviate her persistent abdominal pain, and anytime I looked at her, swollen and writhing in agony, all I could see was death.

My mother didn't return till well past 9pm. She didn't acknowledge my greeting and brushed past me to her room, but not fast enough for me not to notice her bloodshot eyes.

I was later to hear from the grapevine how Coach had lured her to his bed, under the promise of cancelling our indebtedness, only to renege on it the very moment the act was over. To make matters worse, he chose to boast about this, making my mother lose, for us, the little amount of goodwill and respect we still had.

For a woman whose husband had been dead only a couple of months, her action was deemed despicable and disgraceful. Nobody wanted to think of what kind of hardship could have pushed an otherwise upstanding woman

to do such a thing. Nobody wanted to remember that the same Coach was constantly harassing us to pay money we could never have dreamt of in a whole lifetime, or the fact that the life of one of her daughters was hanging by a thread. She was now considered a good-for-nothing harlot.

In the weeks following, we were finally able to agree on a payment plan with Coach, one which would see us paying him for the longest foreseeable future. My mother took on several menial jobs, just to be able to raise enough to meet this obligation and send Jidenna and I back to school at the same time. Even though we had missed most of the term, we were able to catch up.

Jidenna continued his apprenticeship after school, and his kind boss chose to pay him a small stipend, to help him support his widowed mother. But despite the fact that we were in a slightly better financial position, Ahunna continued to fade away a little more each day. My mother had resumed giving her local herbal concoctions, which, rather than improve her situation, only served to worsen it. She was dying before our very eyes.

And then one day, a Saturday afternoon, everything changed.

I was hanging clothes on the washing line when I saw a sparkling white Mercedes 200 pull up in front of the house. As it happened when flashy cars like that came to our neighbourhood, children were soon openly gawking and adults peeping from their windows. I glanced in its direction briefly, but wasn't curious enough to continue looking.

I guess I should have been.

“Adanna,” came a deep, familiar voice. “Ọ bụ aha gị, isn't it?”

I looked up and almost had a heart attack when I saw who stood before me; Chief Arinze Nsofor himself. I stepped back unconsciously, knocking down

my bucket of clothes in the process. “Yes...yes, Sir. It’s my name. Good afternoon.”

He smiled, revealing crystal white teeth. “Don’t be afraid, Princess. I’m not here to hurt you.”

I looked around and realised we had become the neighbourhood spectacle. Everyone around was watching us keenly. I suddenly wished I were anywhere but there. I also feared the dripping wet clothes he stood amongst would soon ruin his immaculate white kaftan.

Everything about him seemed to be white.

Noticing my discomfort, he decided to put me out of my misery. “Is your mother at home?”

Thankfully, she was. She had made it a point of duty to work herself to the bone from Monday to Friday, but left her weekends free to spend time with her kids. I nodded and led him upstairs to our apartment. I’d never before realised how shabby our flat was until that very moment. Having Chief Nsofor standing there, as ethereal as he looked, the place looked like a pigpen. Yes, it was spotlessly clean, but with our torn chairs and faded curtains, it looked like the place would contaminate him if he as much as spent more than a minute there. But instead, the man sat down without giving it a second thought.

“Chief!” my mother exclaimed when she walked into the living room from Ahunna’s room. She threw me a questioning look, to which I simply shrugged. I, too, had no idea why the Asaba millionaire was in our house.

“Nwunye Aloy, ana m ekele,” he said to her. “I greet you. How have you been? After the last time we saw, my staff and I have been waiting for you. When we didn’t hear from you after a while, I sent them to the shop to take

delivery of the items and was surprised when they came back to say the place was locked. I thought you said you were desperate to sell.”

“Chief, I...we didn’t...I...” my mother stuttered.

“Nne, please sit down,” he said, patting the spot on the sofa beside him.

“How can I be talking to a lady, and she’ll be standing. Biko, nọdu.”

My mother sat reluctantly, casting an imploring look at me. I didn’t even understand if she wanted me to rescue her or leave them alone. But my curiosity wouldn’t allow me to leave the spot where I stood rooted.

“We were robbed, Chief,” she said, finally regaining her composure. “When we got back from Asaba, we found out our staff had robbed us. They took everything and ran away.”

Chief Nsofor sat quietly for a short while, before nodding. “Yes. I heard about that. When my people went to your shop, your neighbours told them. Actually, that is why I came. I was very worried about you, especially after all the things you told me you’re dealing with. How are you handling your late husband’s creditors? And your daughter’s health?”

My mother sighed deeply. “We’ve been struggling, I won’t lie to you, Chief,” she answered. “We had to agree to a repayment plan for the loan, and almost everything I make from the small, small jobs I’m able to get here and there, go into paying it. As for my daughter...” At this point, her eyes welled up with tears, and she dabbed at them with her wrapper. “My daughter is dying, Chief. My daughter is dying.”

Chief Nsofor patted her shoulder as she cried, and I still struggled to understand his motive for being in our house. Even as he consoled my mother, he appeared neither a kind nor an empathetic man. Deep in my heart, I knew there was an ulterior motive.

And I wasn't wrong.

"Well, I am here with a solution for you," Chief said. "Ugochi, I can make all your problems go away."

I stared at the man, wondering how he knew our names, as we'd told him neither the one time we'd met him in Asaba. I couldn't help but wonder just how much digging he'd done on our family.

My mother stared at him imploringly, and I knew that she was ready to do just about anything. "Adanna, please go into the room so Chief and I can talk."

"No, let her stay," he cut in, looking at me. "The solution involves her."

My mother and I exchanged a puzzled look. "What do you mean?" she finally asked.

"I will pay off your loan with Coach. I will also take care of your daughter's medical costs to the country of your choice," he said, his eyes still on me. "But in exchange, I want to marry Adanna."

"Marry Adanna?" my mother repeated, her eyes wide with shock. "Marry my daughter?"

A slow smile formed on the older man's face. "Does that seem like such a shocking thing to you? Isn't she of marriageable age? She is 16, I'm told. From what I hear, you weren't too far from that age when you married Aloy."

"Heiiiiii!" my mother exclaimed, throwing her hands in the air. "It has finally happened! O mechaala mee, ooooo! Aloy, ì nwere ike ihu ihe i meworo ayi. Can you see what you have done to us, Aloy? Can you see?"

I looked on as my mother wept, my own heart breaking for her pain. Chief Nsofor, on the other hand, just sat there unbothered.

“Adanna, banye n’ime,” she whimpered. “Go inside and stay with your sister.”

“But mommy...”

“I said go inside!” she yelled, throwing her slipper at me, making me scamper into Ahunna’s bedroom. But I left the door slightly ajar to enable me hear their conversation.

“Please, Chief. Not my daughter. Take me instead. Let me marry you instead. Please.”

Chief laughed, and I could tell he was genuinely amused by her proposition. “Marry you? No offence, Nne. But I didn’t say I’m bringing you tubers of yam. I’m here offering to spend millions of naira, and I expect a decent exchange. Not a haggard mother of three, who has been sleeping around not even up to a year after her husband’s death.”

I flinched, feeling the impact of the insult. Her response was so quiet, I had to strain extra hard to hear her words.

“I made a mistake with Coach. He said he would write off our loan, and I believed him.”

“Nobody is here to judge you, my dear. You did what you had to do, I suppose,” was Chief’s patronising response. “All I’m saying is, you are not the one I’m here for. I have had my eye on your daughter since the time you both came to Asaba. She has been my sleeping and waking thought. For her, I would spend my entire fortune if it means having her to call my own.”

“If that’s the case, the answer is no,” was my mother’s curt answer. “My daughter is not for sale.”

Chief chuckled as he rose to his feet. “Don’t allow your pride prevent you from doing the wise thing for you and your family, Ugochi.”

“You are old enough to be even my father,” my mother retorted. “How can you want to marry my daughter, a mere child? I can never give Adanna to you, no matter what you’re promising.”

“Ngwanu, Ugochi. As you like it. I thought you had your other daughter’s health in mind,” he taunted. “Coach, I know you can handle. Between the five, five kobo you pay him, and the sex you throw in here and there, I’m sure you can take care of that situation. It’s just a shame you’ll have to watch your other daughter die because of your pride.”

My mother rose to her feet. “Ehn, let it be like that! You are not God! We will find a solution for Ahunna, with or without you.”

There was another chuckle from Chief, and I was tempted to peep to catch a glimpse of his face, to see if he was truly amused or angered by my mother’s rejection.

“I will spend the night here in Onitsha. I have some business to take care of,” I finally heard him say. “I will be back here tomorrow before I leave for Asaba. That should give you enough time to think through this properly.”

“I’m not thinking of anything. Biko puo. Leave, and don’t bother coming back.”

I listened until Chief’s footsteps and the sound of the door closing indicated his departure, before returning to the living room.

“Mommy,” I called out to her, but she just stood there, her face set, save for the tears rolling down her face. “Mommy.”

Without a word, she brushed past me and went to her bedroom, locking the door firmly behind her. For some reason, she seemed angry with me, and I

couldn't understand why. With slouched shoulders, I returned outside to continue hanging the clothes to dry.

I could feel the curious and even judgmental stares from our neighbours, but I made sure not to make eye contact with any of them. All they could do was gossip. None of them could make any real impact on our lives, positive or negative.

The rest of the day dragged along, with my mother refusing to say anything to me. Tired of being the one making the effort, I too resigned myself to the fact that there would be no conversation that night. Jidenna had travelled with his boss to Enugu, and Ahunna's pain was now so intense that the only sounds that came out of her mouth were moaning and crying, no more words. After eating alone, the meal of rice and stew I'd cooked, I retired to bed, hopeful that the atmosphere would be less tense the following day.

But later that night, I was awakened by Ahunna's agonising cry. Rushing to her room, I saw our mother sitting by her bedside, also in tears, as she tried unsuccessfully to give her daughter relief by massaging her distended abdomen. I stood by helplessly, not knowing what to do.

"Has she taken her medicine?" I asked, referring to the concoction the herbal doctor had given us.

"That thing is not working," my mother answered, wiping her tears with the back of her hand. "Ike gwurū m. Ada, I'm tired. I'm just tired."

And then standing there, watching my mother cry and my sister writhe in pain, I knew exactly what needed to be done.

"Mommy, I will marry him."

My mother's head snapped up like a taut spring. "You will marry who? Chief Nsofor? Are you out of your mind?"

“We have no other choice. Look at her,” I said, pointing at Ahunna, who stared back at me with dilated eyes. “If we don’t do something about it, she’s going to die, right here on this bed and in this room.”

My mother was silent for what seemed like eternity. “I can’t allow you make that sacrifice, Adanna. I can’t allow you marry a man old enough to be your grandfather.”

“It is my choice, mommy. Nobody is forcing me. I want to do it.”

“Over my dead body will I allow...” She was cut short as Ahunna heaved and vomited violently all over the bed and our mother’s clothes. As it had been in the last few days, her vomit was tinged with blood. When she was done, she just lay back in bed and shut her eyes, the release having given her some relief. Our mother and I remained immobile, neither of us moving to even clean the mess. It was evident to both of us that this could not continue. “How can I ask something so big of my own daughter?” she asked, her voice breaking.

I realised then that the decision had been made.

Wordlessly, I proceeded to peel off the stained bed sheets and took them to the bathroom to wash. My mother came in shortly after and dropped her stained wrapper in the bucket, leaving without saying another word to me. But the truth was no more words needed to be said.

Lying in bed that night, I thought about Anayo, the one who had my heart. For the first time since I made my decision, I was tempted to change my mind, as the implication of what I was signing up for hit me in the face. Marrying Chief Nsofor would put paid to any dreams I had of reuniting with his son in the future.

But who was I kidding? What was the guarantee that he hadn't already forgotten me? Why would I mortgage my family's welfare for some childish daydream of being reunited with a guy who very likely had only been toying with me? Yes, I knew it would be awkward the next time I did see him, but at least my family would be well sorted. And for that, I could take anything.

When Chief returned the following afternoon, it was to a more mellow audience.

"You will have to give us the money first," my mother stated, unable to meet his gaze. "Give us the money for both Coach's repayment and Ahunna's treatment, before you can marry her."

"You must take me for a fool, Ugochi," the older man chuckled. He seemed to find everything funny. "I will marry her first, and then we can resolve all these issues."

But, on this one, my mother refused to budge. "Mba. No way! That's how you will change your mind afterwards, and my daughter will forever be marked as the girl who married an old man."

A knowing smile formed on Chief's face, and he decided to concede. "Fair enough. How about we do it this way? I will give you Coach's money now, and this week, I will have my medical team evaluate Ahunna. But only after I marry Adanna will we fly her out of the country for her procedure."

And just like that, a deal was struck.

"How many other wives do you have?" I asked suddenly, surprising the older people. I at least deserved to know how many angry women I would encounter as his new bride.

“None, my dear girl,” he answered, with a cheeky grin. “You will be my only one.”

“What about the Calabar woman?” my mother asked, making me wonder just how much about Chief Nsofor she knew.

“Nkoyo was my brief mistake, and she has gone back where she belongs. Before marrying her, I was a widower for almost 10 years,” he answered. “I’m a man of God, Nne. I’m not a polygamist. Adanna will be my only queen. She will be well taken care of, you have my word.”

My mother and I exchanged a look, and my heart melted at the raw pain I could see in her eyes. But we both knew that neither of us had a choice.

What had to be done just had to be done.

Chapter Five

The Wedding

It was a decision that changed all our lives.

In a matter of days, Coach's loan was fully paid off, and Ahunna was taken, first of all to the Teaching Hospital in Enugu, and then to a specialist hospital in Port Harcourt, where she would be managed before flying out to India. Even though the decision to marry me off to Chief Nsofor had been a weighty one, seeing the improvement in Ahunna's health was enough to lift our mother's spirits. And with Coach no longer looming above us like a stormy cloud, she was soon back to looking more like her old self.

But Jidenna had been furious when he heard about the price that would have to be paid for all of it. At 15, he fancied himself more of a man, and indeed the head of our household, so when we'd told him of my impending marriage to the Asaba millionaire, he had exploded like a volcano.

"How can you marry an old man? What about school, NASA, and all the other plans Dad had for you?"

"NASA? Your family is burning and you're still talking about NASA? What about your sister?" I snapped back. "What about the fact that your mother was prostituting herself to that animal called Coach? Maybe you want to

wait till you have to drop out of school and face Maduekwesi's mechanic work full time, before your eyes will clear!"

He had no comeback, and this was expected. There was no possible comeback. The truth was plain to see. Without Chief Nsofor, we were on the fast track to implosion. Coach would inevitably have gotten impatient with the repayment coming in trickles, our very kind landlord would have tired of harbouring us for free since my father's death, and Ahunna would have died. It was that simple.

But even though I had agreed to it, and had even suggested it, I found myself praying for some kind of miracle to avert it. I wished Chief would change his mind about wanting anything in exchange for his 'kindness' or, if he was insistent on an exchange, would marry my mother instead. When my father's older brother, Mathias, came to the house to discuss the matter with my mother, I was hopeful that he would be so scandalised by the idea, he would call the whole thing off. But there was no such luck. Yes, he had worn a sullen face, but when I overheard him discussing the details of the small ceremony, I knew my fate was sealed.

A little under a month after his proposition, Chief Nsofor and I were married in my parents' living room. Not wanting to put our family disgrace on display for our neighbours to see, the ceremony took place right there in our family living room, underneath a picture of my late father.

Only two of my father's brothers, Uncle Mathias and Uncle Cyprian, were in attendance, and there were none of my mother's family members there at all. Aunty Uloma had reluctantly come, although she was anything but her usual boisterous self and had taken her seat next to my mother, intermittently sighing deeply and shaking her head the whole time. Chief Nsofor himself had come with a handful of witnesses, who appeared to be

more of acquaintances than family. I'd even expected to see his rude first son, Akanna, but he had been conspicuously absent. But this didn't seem to bother Chief, as he was in extremely good spirits, cracking jokes and laughing almost from the very moment he and his entourage arrived.

He was in such high spirits that even my uncles were soon laughing and making merry with the visitors from Asaba. They even managed to squeeze out a few smiles from my mother. But Auntie Uloma and Jidenna remained stone-faced the whole time.

Jidenna's face could not mask his own rage, and he stood cross-armed in a corner of the room. My poor brother. I knew he was angry, more with himself than anyone else. I knew he thought he had failed us, had failed me. I wish I'd been able to give him the assurance that this was so far from the truth. But I couldn't. How could I give something I didn't have?

Kneeling there, dressed in my mother's most expensive lace material, I shut my eyes as Uncle Mathias prayed over us, my new husband and I. I shut my eyes, not only because I didn't want to see the smug grin on Chief's face, but also because I could not bear to meet my father's gaze. Never had his picture seemed more lifelike than it did that day.

It was a picture of him taken at a family wedding a few years before, and from the uncomfortable smile on his face, he had obviously been stampeded into taking it. When he died, it was the only decent picture of him we had, the only one that we could frame to mount on a stool outside our apartment, where an old notebook had been converted to a condolence register. And when we returned to Onitsha after his funeral, it was hung in the most prominent part of our living room, right above our television that had seen better days.

In the months gone by, I'd even forgotten it was there, but kneeling hand in hand with a man almost four times my age, I was all too aware of his sad, probing eyes. I knew he would be turning in his grave over what was happening. I knew he would have never even have allowed me to marry the man of my choice at the expense of getting a good education, talk less of marrying for money. I knew he would weep bitterly, seeing me give up my bright future to be the teenage bride of a much older man.

So I kept my eyes closed.

After the ceremony, my mother avoided making eye contact with me and busied herself with putting finishing touches to packing my box. Chief and his entourage were waiting to leave with their bride, and so I sat on her bed, wordlessly, watching as she rushed around packing things that we both knew would be trash the next day.

Ahunna was in hospital in Port Harcourt, and we were both happy that she hadn't been at home to witness the charade. Having started kidney dialysis, she was in much better health and was much more lucid than she'd been in the last few months. At the age of 12, she too would have understood the weight of the sacrifice her sister was making for the family, and would surely have been saddened by it. So, it had been the silent decision to shield her from this information for as long as we could.

The door opened, and Auntie Uloma walked in. She stood in the middle of the room, looking from me, sitting on the bed and looking on listlessly, to my mother, squashing the umpteenth wrapper into the box that could hardly close as it was.

"Ugochi, i gwala ya okwu?" she asked, but when my mother did not even as much as acknowledge her question, she turned to me. "Has your mother spoken to you?"

I looked at my mother, unsure of what this ‘speaking’ was about, but not wanting to say anything that would indict her. But my wide and confused eyes were more of an answer than any words I could have said.

“You haven’t spoken to your daughter? They are about to take her away to a strange place, and her own mother has not given her any advice? Any guidance?”

“She doesn’t need any guidance,” my mother muttered in response. “Ọ bụ nwanyị. She’s also a woman. There is nothing new that she is going to face.”

“Ewo!” Auntie Uloma exclaimed, clasping both arms over her chest. “Chukwu gbaghara anyi ooooo! God forgive us for what we are doing to this girl.”

Tears sprang from my eyes before I could stop them, and before I knew it, I was weeping in Auntie Uloma’s arms. The dam was finally broken, and I sobbed loudly, weeping for the loss of my innocence and the incarceration that awaited me.

“Adanna, what is all this?” my mother exclaimed, her own eyes shiny with unshed tears. “Do you want them to hear you crying? Do you want Chief to think you have changed your mind?”

But, try as I may, I couldn’t stop the tears. It was finally dawning on me that Chief Nsofor would be my husband. The 55-year-old father of the boy I truly did love would be my husband.

Exasperated, my mother left the room.

“Leave her. Ọ nọ kwa n’ihe mgbu. She is also hurting,” Auntie Uloma said, before tilting my chin up. “That’s enough now. No more crying. Time for

crying has stopped. You need to be strong now. You need to be brave. Do you hear me?”

Still crying, I nodded, even though I felt anything but.

“You need to be as wise as an owl, but also as gentle as a lamb, *inugo*?” she continued. “Whether 19 or 90, men are all the same. They want a woman who can spoil and pamper them. If you treat him right, there is nothing you will not get from him. If you can wrap him around your finger, he will protect you with his life. And in a strange place, that is the most important thing you need.”

I nodded again, my tears beginning to ebb, the realisation that I would have to bed this old man, sitting like a pile of rocks in my stomach.

“But open your eyes, my daughter. Observe everything around you. You must always be one step ahead. Always!” she continued, her own voice breaking at this point. “I will be praying for you. And if you ever need any help, you know how to find me.”

We sat in the bedroom for a few more minutes before she pulled me to my feet.

“Ngwanu, change and look presentable,” she said, a determined look on her face. “No matter what you do, you must always look your best. It was your looks that attracted the man, and it is your looks that will make him your slave. So, remove that oversize lace wrapper and wear something more flattering.”

Even though I’d been just as happy to leave for Chief’s house in my mother’s wrapper and my makeup already faded, Auntie Uloma fished out the ankara dress I’d made the Christmas before; a low necklined, slim-fitting dress in the ‘Shabba’ style that was all the rage at the time. It had a

slit that ran higher up my thighs than my father had liked. But my father wasn't there.

She took her time to brush my hair so hard, it shone. She held it in a tight bun, making a bow around it with the dress's accompanying head tie. After a dusting of face powder and a slick of Vaseline across my lips, she stepped back and smiled. I didn't even have to look at a mirror. I knew I looked much better than I had during the earlier ceremony.

And the look on Chief's face when I re-emerged from my bedroom confirmed this. The man was dumbfounded, and seeing this gave me the courage I was so desperate for.

"You go market true true, Chief. Nwa agboghọ a mara mma!" I heard some of his companions exclaim.

From the corner of my eyes, I saw my uncles beam with pride at their beautiful niece, but for some reason, my mother looked annoyed.

"Why did you change?" she asked in a gruff whisper, moving close to me.

"Chief married a young girl, a fresh young girl, not one who has gone past her shelf date," Aunty Uloma whispered back, glaring at her sister-in-law.

I looked around for Jidenna so that I could at least say goodbye to him but was disappointed to see he had left the house. It was obviously too hard for him to watch.

As I was led out of the house to the even more imposing white Land Rover Chief had been chauffeured in, almost my entire neighbourhood had clamoured outside, waiting to catch a glimpse of the spectacle. The car stood, loud and majestic, like the white elephant it was, an oddity in my lower-middle-class locality. To make matters worse, in its company were two glossy black Volkswagen Santana cars, which had ferried his guests.

I guess word had already filtered out about my unfortunate marriage, and everyone wanted to see with their own eyes if what they were hearing was true. I made eye contact with Ogbonna, the man who lived in the flat opposite ours and who had been very friendly with my late father, and the pain I saw in his eyes almost brought forth my tears again. Almost.

Rather than cry, I maintained eye contact with him for a little longer than I should have, before finally looking away. Where had he, and in fact all the others, been when Ahunna was wasting away to death, or when Coach was bullying my family? Rather than help us, he had been part of the gossip machinery that had crucified my mother for the decisions she had been forced to make. Walking out, ordinarily, I would have kept my head bowed, not wanting to meet any of their eyes, but this time I walked with my head held high and my back ramrod straight, putting on an illusion of confidence I certainly didn't feel.

"Can't we follow her?" Auntie Uloma demanded. "She is a small girl and can't just go with you like that. One of us needs to accompany her."

"Mba, not today," Uncle Mathias interjected. "Anyị ga-amara ebe ahụ, but not today. But you know this, Uloma. They will host the mother, brother and myself next week. Abi, Chief?"

"Ogọ'm, of course," was Chief's boisterous answer. "You can even bring the Auntie along so her body can come down. Ọ na-achaghari iwe ụbọchi niile. The woman's face has been like spoilt eba since we got here!"

As everyone, my mother included, burst in loud laughter, Auntie Uloma and I exchanged a look, and even though no words were said, in her eyes was a reminder to be strong, to be brave.

Minutes later, we were on the highway, headed to Asaba. Chief and I were the only two in the car, save for the driver. The other cars in the convoy

were riding behind us, and I found myself wishing for their loud banter, or anything that would diffuse the silence in the car. But no. It was just us two; me...and my new husband.

“Nwanyi o ma,” he said to me after a while, running his knuckle across my face. “How lucky a man am I!”

Rather than wallow in his adulation, I turned my face away. I wasn’t quite ready to put on a show, playing the role of a yielding and attentive wife. Right now, all I wanted was my space. And thankfully, he respected it and didn’t make any more advances.

I stole a few glances at him. The honest truth is that I could have been dealt a far worse hand. Chief looked better than many men half his age. And it wasn’t just because of his expensively maintained skin or impeccable grooming. His body was still toned, and he had the same boyishly handsome look his younger son had. The truth is, it wouldn’t be too much of a stretch for me to learn to love him. At least, that way, it would make for a more tolerable life with him.

When we got to Asaba, my nerves rose to the fore, and I kept thinking we would turn off the major road any minute. But we didn’t, and drove straight through the town, instead. Looking back, I realised that the other cars accompanying us had already branched off.

“I thought we were going to Asaba,” I remarked.

“Ah, she finally speaks!” Chief teased, smiling at me. “I was beginning to wonder if we left your beautiful voice back in Onitsha.”

This time, I refused to look away but instead held his gaze, straight-faced.

“The bakery is in Asaba, my dear,” he finally answered. “My ranch is in Ojiji. That’s where I’m from. Your mother has investigated me so much,

I'm surprised she didn't tell you."

Ojiji was another 20-minute drive from Asaba, and I wondered how a detail as important as that could have been omitted.

"Have you been there before?" he asked.

I shook my head and turned my face away, dismissing him. If there was anything that would make my situation worse, this was it, living away from the major town. When we finally turned off the road and onto the narrower streets leading to Ojiji, I was completely rankled. I hadn't prepared my mind for village life.

The moment we turned into the street, I could immediately identify his house. Standing regal at the end of the street, on at least 1,000 acres of land, the 3-storey building looked like a cross between a church and a hotel, with its large pillars and cathedral-like windows, juxtaposed with modern lines and elaborate lighting. It stood out like a sore thumb, not only on its quiet street but the entire sleepy town. It was everything I'd imagined it would be, and so much more. From the gate to the house was a full five-minute drive, and I marveled at the sheer expanse of the compound, complete with a small pond and peacocks running around the lush greenery. He hadn't exaggerated when he called the place a ranch.

"Home, sweet home!" he proclaimed when the car pulled to a stop in front of the main house.

"Nnọọ," chimed a middle-aged woman, standing at the door. "Welcome, Chief," she beamed at me. "Welcome, o. Welcome."

I said nothing in response. Instead, I hovered around the booth of the car, waiting to get my suitcase. But Chief gently took my hand and pulled me

away, just as two uniformed men ran to the car to offload the vehicles. And I got the message. Over here, there were servants for that kind of thing.

“Uzochi, how are you?” Chief greeted the woman before turning to look at me. “This is Adanna. My wife.”

I bristled at the word, but the same word elicited a broad grin from the woman.

“Eeooh! O mara mma!” she exclaimed. “Nne, welcome. Welcome.”

“Uzochi will take care of you,” Chief said to me, just as we were about to walk inside. “I have to make a quick dash to the bakery. I will be back soon.”

“But it’s already evening,” I exclaimed, suddenly feeling anxious about being left alone with strangers.

He smiled, pleased to hear the concern in my voice. “I won’t be long, my princess. Trust me when I say, if it was within my control, nobody would be able to tear me away from you. But alas, there are people waiting there for me. I’ll be back soon. I promise.”

I stood there and watched as he got back into the car, blew me a kiss, and was driven away. I hated the fact that, in only a few short hours, I had already gotten accustomed to his company. In resignation, I followed Uzochi into the house.

Walking inside, I let out an involuntary gasp, the white and gold accented décor taking my breath away. In all my years, I had never seen such luxury and grandeur up close. It reminded me of the Von Trapp family mansion in The Sound of Music movie.

I caught a glimpse of the living room as I was led upstairs, and I almost felt like running there and doing a Julie Andrews twirl. From this display of

opulence, I saw that Chief's wealth was so much more phenomenal than any of us had imagined. But it couldn't be just from baking bread and biscuits. Not even if he was baking for the entire country on a daily basis.

We walked to the 2nd level, and Uzochi led me into a large room, with a queen-sized canopy bed and a cream, gold and white colour theme. With the mahogany wood furniture and cotton and lace sheets, it looked like it had been cut straight out of a magazine.

"Do you have any more suitcases?" Uzochi asked, and I realised the uniformed gentlemen from earlier had beaten us to the room, as my box was already perched at the foot of the bed. "There is more than enough space for all your things," she continued, pulling open the floor to ceiling closet and pointing out a similar one across the room. Both of them were empty. I was suddenly confused.

"Where are Chief's things?"

Uzochi looked at me, perplexed, before she realised what I was asking and burst into laughter. "Chief has his own room, Nne. Upstairs. This one is for you."

That piece of information made me look at the room with totally different eyes, and my separation anxiety slowly started to morph into elation. Not only was this beautiful room mine and mine alone, I didn't have to share a bed with him. I wasn't naïve enough to think he wouldn't want to share mine, but at least, it wouldn't have to be a daily occurrence.

"Let me leave you, my daughter. You have had a long day," Uzochi said, walking to the door. "If you want to eat, just send for me, and I'll organise something for you."

“Aunty Uzochi, please, can I ask you a question?” I called out, not wanting to lose the opportunity to get valuable information from the older woman. “Chief’s wife... the Calabar woman. Is she still around?”

Uzochi let out a long hiss. “Nkoyo? O laala, thank God. She has gone back to wherever it was Chief picked her from.”

“And her children?”

Uzochi shook her head. “She had none.”

“How many kids does Chief have?”

Uzochi stared at me, confused. “O gwaghị gi? He hasn’t told you?” when I said nothing, she shrugged. “There are three of them. One from his first wife, and the last two from the late one, God rest her soul.”

“Where are they?”

“Akanna is running the business in Lagos. Apunanwu is rounding up her degree program in Benin and should be home any day now. And Anayo, the youngest, is abroad in school.”

Anayo. Hearing his name again broke my heart anew.

“I’m sure you’ll meet them soon,” she said as she walked to the door, but when she got to it, she turned around again. “I know this must be hard for you. I have a young daughter, so I can imagine how you must be feeling, being here by yourself. But you have nothing to worry about. Chief is a very kind man. He has taken care of my family for decades. If not for him, I don’t know what would have become of us. Forget about the age. Trust me, you couldn’t have found a better man than Chief to marry.”

No, I didn’t agree with her. I could have found a better man to marry. I’d already found him, in fact. One with whom he shared the same DNA.

I was tempted to ask why none of his children had come for the wedding, or why there had been no pomp and pageantry to welcome the new bride home, but I remembered how low key my own family had also kept the wedding, and then I understood why. This wasn't the kind of thing to shout about from the rooftops. Besides, with the number of wives the man had already had, his friends, family, and even house servants had clearly tired of wedding festivities. But it suited me just fine.

After a shower and a change, I took Uzochi up on her offer and went downstairs for a meal. I noticed other members of staff giving me curious looks, and I realised that, just like back home in Onitsha, I was also a spectacle here; a beautiful young girl married to an older man.

Dinner was a meal of steaming hot rice and native fish stew, and I almost scraped off the enamel of my plate eating it. I couldn't remember when last I'd eaten a meal so wholesome and delicious, considering that not only had my mother switched off elaborate cooking after my father died, we hadn't even had the money to buy anything outside of the very basics. The size of fish I'd been served was more than what Jidenna, mom and I would have eaten combined.

Once dinner was over, I walked over to the living room, looking at the portraits hanging on the wall. There was one of a much younger Chief, and I smiled at the image of the stunningly handsome man, not at all surprised by how good looking he'd been as a younger man. In fact, age and money had only served to further refine those looks, making him even more attractive now. Then there was a picture of a pretty, thin woman with a thick afro, and I realised that was likely Anayo's mother.

From what he'd told me, his father and Akanna's mother had parted acrimoniously, so I knew her picture would not be there. This was

obviously Chief's dearly departed wife. Next to hers was a portrait of Akanna, and for the first time I saw the resemblance he too had with his father. There was a smirk on his face as he stared back at the camera, and just like the last time I'd seen him, a chill ran down my spine. There was just something about him that rubbed me the wrong way. Then there was a portrait of a girl who was the spitting image of the woman with the afro, and I deduced that was Apunanwu. She had the same sad eyes and unsmiling face, and I started to worry about what meeting her for the first time would be like.

And then there was Anayo.

Standing below his portrait, I looked up at him, this boy who had stolen my heart, and I was taken back to the only two times I'd seen him; the time he had accompanied their bakery manager to my parents' store and when we'd spent that beautiful day together in town. With smiling eyes, he looked back at the camera as if he had a secret that was too much for him to contain.

Looking at him, I fell in love all over again, and as my hand reached up to touch the painting, hoping to somehow be able to touch some part of him, the finality of what had occurred hit me again. I would never again be his. We would never be a couple. Never ever. Never.

And it broke my heart.

Later that night, I was already back in my room and asleep when there was a knock on the door. Opening it, I was equal parts relieved, surprised and frightened to see that it was Chief Nsofor.

"Welcome, Sir," I said, with a small curtesy.

Chief bellowed as he sat on my bed. "Onye bu Sir? Who is your Sir? I'm your sweetie pie, o! Just like you are my honey."

I had to stop myself from rolling my eyes.

“Come, sit next to me,” Chief said, his voice soft.

My heart dropped, wondering if this was the moment I’d been dreading. I reluctantly took my seat next to him and stared ahead, not knowing what to expect.

“You are the most beautiful being I have ever laid eyes on,” he said, stroking my arm. “Look at how beautiful and soft your skin is, just like a baby’s. You are beautiful and pure like an angel. You’re a virgin, aren’t you?”

I nodded, happy that at least that fact was true.

“From that first day I saw you at the bakery, you just exploded my brain,” Chief said, stroking my face now. “I mewo ka m buru onye nzuzu! You’ve turned me into a fool for you. All I can think about is you.”

I sighed deeply, waiting for the speeches to end and the inevitable to commence.

“You are beautiful, pure and spotless,” Chief said, taking my hand in his and kissing it. “There is no need to rush. I know you are not quite ready for me tonight, and I’m patient enough to wait for you to be ready, truly ready for me. In the meantime, I want to keep you pure and spotless, just like a beautiful flower.”

I looked at him, shocked. Had he said the words I thought he had?

“Sleep well, Ezigbo nwunye’m!” he said, walking to the door. “I’m in the room right on top of yours, if you need me.”

I stared at the closed door after he’d left, wondering if he had truly decided to spare me the agony of sex with him that night. Upon realising that he

had, I felt a warmth in my heart for him. Maybe this wasn't going to be so bad after all. Maybe I would be able to love him after all. Maybe I would be able to forget Anayo after all. Maybe.

Chapter Six

The Wives

That night, I slept better than I had since before my father died.

Waking up the following morning, wrapped in the luxurious sheets in the fully air conditioned room, it felt like I was in heaven. Maybe this wasn't going to be that much of a sacrifice after all. In fact, it seemed very win-win to me.

By the time I finally made it downstairs for breakfast, I was told Chief had long since left for Asaba.

"He wakes up as early as 4am," Uzochi declared with a knowing smile, as she dished my meal of boiled yam and fried eggs. "In fact, it is the smell of his pipe that wakes me up most mornings."

I nodded, remembering what Auntie Uloma told me about gathering information and noting every pertinent piece of it.

"He asked me to give you this," she said, handing me an envelope. "Let me know when you finish eating, so we can leave the house on time."

I looked on in confusion as she walked away, wondering where we could possibly be going together. But looking into the bulky envelope, I got my answer, as there were several large N50 bundles. My eyes doubled in size when I saw that it was Ten Thousand Naira. 'Get yourself something nice'

was what the note inside said. Hmmm! If this was a sacrifice I was making, then it was going to be the easiest in the history of mankind.

After breakfast, Uzochi and I were driven to Asaba, where I bought some nice dresses, a pair of sandals, and some ankara fabric bundles from a boutique in town.

When my money was exhausted, Uzochi proceeded to buy me toiletries from the money she had on her.

“Chief said to make sure you don’t pay for your creams and sprays,” she teased. “That is your husband’s responsibility.”

As we drove around the town, I found myself warming up to my older companion. She looked to be about my mother’s age, but that was where any similarity ended. In a lot of ways, she reminded me of my Auntie Uloma. They were both loud and chatty, but even beyond their gregariousness, they were deeply kind. Uzochi laughed, and her eyes twinkled. She smiled, and you could see that it came from deep in her heart. I suddenly no longer felt so alone.

I was relieved when we didn’t stop at the bakery but drove straight home to Ojiji after our shopping expedition was over. By this time, I felt not only more comfortable around her but even Okeke, the driver with whom Uzochi laughed and bantered with. And upon getting home, I noticed there was a much friendlier air around. The domestic staff no longer gawked at me like a unicorn on display. The security guards, Nathaniel and Ukawuike, waved enthusiastically as the car drove into the compound, and Isichie, the butler, spared me the slightest of smiles as he let us into the house. This place I’d thought would be my prison, was fast feeling more like home.

“Auntie Uzochi, please sit with me,” I pleaded, as the housekeeper made to leave me alone in the dining room, after a hearty meal of jollof rice and

plantains was dished for me.

She stared at me, clearly surprised. “Ị chọrọ ka m nọrọ ebe a? You want me to sit here with you?”

“Either that, or I’ll follow you to the kitchen,” I teased, feeling bolder.

She laughed heartily as she took a seat at the dining table. “You this girl! You’re nothing like what I expected, o. I thought you would be one of these useless ashewo girls, only after money. But you’re not like that. I was watching you in Asaba. It was difficult for you to even spend a kobo. Mba, your parents brought you up well.”

The smile on my face faded, and I lowered my eyes, unable to meet her gaze, lest she saw that I was that kind of girl who married for money. After all, that’s what this arrangement was all about.

She noticed the change in my countenance, and she covered my hand with hers. “I’m not going to ask what led you to marry Chief. I can see that whatever it was, was out of your control.”

My eyes clouded with tears, and before I knew it, I was telling her the whole story, starting from my father’s debt, to his untimely death, to Ahunna’s sickness, to Coach’s bullying. I confided completely in my new friend, and when I was done talking, she had tears in her eyes.

“Nwa’m, you have really gone through a lot,” she said, wiping her eyes. “Your poor mother. I can’t imagine how she must feel. I would be rolling in the streets if anyone were to take my own daughter away from me.”

I thought back to my mother’s behavior and had to bite my tongue from telling Uzochi that rolling in the streets hadn’t exactly been her own reaction. But that wasn’t fair on my mother. The truth was, even though she might have shown it differently, she was hurting just as deeply.

“But you are lucky,” Uzochi continued. “Like I said the other day, Chief is a wonderful man. Yes, he is getting on in age, but be rest assured that he will treat you well. Lee ihe mere taa. Look what happened today. See how he has already started spoiling you from day one. And this is just the beginning.”

“You’ve lived here for a long time?”

Uzochi smiled and nodded. “Over 20 years. When I came here, Ifeyinwa, Chief’s late wife, had just given birth to Apunanwu.”

“You were hired to take care of her?”

“No. It was Ibekwe that brought me here when we got married,” was her surprising answer. “He used to be the gardener here. In fact, his father was the first person Chief’s father hired to take care of this land, even before they built the house. Luckily, they were in need of a cook when I came, so I got the job. After a while, I was promoted to House Manager.”

“Is your husband late? You said he used to be the gardener?” I couldn’t help but ask.

She smiled, but this time her eyes didn’t have their usual twinkle. “No, my dear. He is alive. He had an accident some years ago that left him incapacitated. He was trimming the palm trees in the courtyard and had a nasty fall that injured his spinal chord. He is unable to walk now.”

I suddenly felt selfish for filling her ears with my own problems, when she had big ones of her own. “I’m so sorry to hear it,” was my lame offering.

“So, where is he now?”

“In our quarters, down in the basement,” she answered, her eyes tearing again. “You see why I don’t take Chief to play? This God-sent man took care of all my husband’s medical bills and has been paying for his

rehabilitation ever since. He gave us a bigger apartment downstairs and pays for a nurse to take care of Ibe, while I'm up here working. Not only that, he is even helping us train our daughter, Daluchi, as there is no way I would have been able to cope on my salary alone."

This softened my heart towards my new husband even more. As we talked, I got to know more about Uzochi's family. She too had been a young bride to Ibekwe, but they hadn't been able to conceive their only child till over a decade later. Later that evening, she introduced me to the young Daluchi, a pretty nine-year-old girl. She reminded me so much of Ahunna, as they were both so shy, making eye contact was a problem. It endeared her to me all the more.

Later that evening, it was with much reluctance that I peeled myself away from Uzochi's side, and it was even at her behest.

"Go and get yourself ready for your husband. He will soon be home," she'd prompted. "Take care of him, and he will take care of you."

These were the words in my head as I reapplied my makeup in anticipation of Chief's return. It was past dinner time, so I knew that, like the day before, he would come to my bedroom to see me.

And see me, he did.

"How lucky a man am I?" he exclaimed, the moment I opened my door. "You look like a beauty queen. In fact, a goddess!"

My smile wasn't as forced as the previous day, and I realised I'd actually started enjoying the flattery. "Welcome, d'im," I greeted, and his grin in response to my reference to him as my husband was from ear to ear. "I hope you had a good day."

“It was the usual craziness, but thinking of you was all I needed to see me through the day,” he answered, sitting on my bed.

I took off his shoes as I used to for my father and proceeded to massage his feet the same way. Unlike my father’s feet, which always had the pungent smell of something trapped without air for longer than it should have, Chief’s feet smelt of lavender and Old Spice. I wasn’t brave enough to take off his socks, but from the satisfied moans coming from my husband’s lips, he didn’t seem to mind. After massaging his feet for about thirty minutes, during which he talked me through his activities that day, he gave me a hug and left my room. I had again lived to die another day.

And that was how it played out for the rest of the week. I would spend my days following Uzochi like a shadow, and my nights were in the company of my new husband, if not massaging his feet or shoulders, having dinner with him, all of which ended with him giving me a hug or a light kiss on the cheek. I was still as virginal as the day I set foot in his house.

And it suited me just fine.

The following weekend, we hosted my mother, Jidenna and Uncle Mathias. I was disappointed not to see Auntie Uloma, but excited to see my family nonetheless.

“Adanna, kedu ihe ị na-eri? What are they feeding you here?” Uncle Mathias had exclaimed. “One week here, and see how plump and fresh you are already looking.”

“She is being well taken care of,” was Chief’s smug answer.

As the men walked into the living room to chat, my mother gave me a small hug. “You look very well, my daughter. I am happy to see you this way.”

“Chief is taking good care of me,” I said, my smile genuine. “I lack for nothing.”

“I can see that. Look at your beautiful dress. Even see how your skin is shining.”

“But am I really looking fat?” I asked her, concerned.

“Of course not,” she’d laughed. “Your cheeks are a bit rosier, and there is more of a roll around your hips when you walk, but nothing uncommon for a new bride.”

I smiled, relieved. But she suddenly held my arm tight, her fingers digging into my skin. “How have you...? I hope it wasn’t too...”

I knew what she was trying to ask, and I suddenly felt resentful. Before I left Onitsha, she hadn’t thought it wise to educate me about what lay ahead of me in my marital bed, so she had no right to know about what had, or hadn’t, transpired there.

“Everything is fine,” had been my curt answer.

She let go of my arm, clearly getting the message that there would be no further discussions on the topic.

Outside of that, it was a generally pleasant visit, with lots of lively chatter and laughter from the back and forth joking from the two older men. Jidenna had been very quiet and had answered me in monosyllables when I tried to ask about school or his after-school vocation. In the end, I just let him be as I realised he was still angry about my marriage to Chief Nsofor. The one thing that made me the happiest was hearing that Ahunna and my mother would be leaving for Lagos in the coming week, to process their travel documents for India. Just like that, our lives had turned around.

Before they left, I made sure I introduced my mother to Uzochi, telling her how she had taken me under her wing, and I could see the relief on my mother's face.

"Please take her as your daughter," my mother implored Uzochi. "Knowing someone here is watching over her will make me sleep better at night."

"Nne, don't worry about a thing," Uzochi assured her. "Adanna is in good hands, I promise you."

It was when my family was leaving, and I realised I didn't even feel sad about it, that I knew I had truly made Ojiji my home.

The following week was similar to the week preceding it, and the one after it similar to the one before, and so it went. I soon fully settled into my status quo, and all was well in my world.

Until the morning I awoke to find a strange woman in the house.

I'd been descending the staircase when I noticed someone sitting in the living room, the same living room that was more of a museum for pictures and artifacts, and not somewhere any of us frequented, except we had visitors. From the wag of her foot, she didn't look very happy. I tried to peer in without her seeing me, but I guess I wasn't discreet enough.

"Oh, you must be the new wife," was her sly remark.

I immediately backed away and headed to the dining room, which had been my original destination anyway. I was surprised to find Chief's table setting intact, meaning he hadn't had his breakfast and probably was still in the house.

"He's still upstairs. He hasn't come down yet," Uzochi said, her voice missing its usual chirpiness. "That one," she said, using her nose to point in

the direction of the living room, “descended here like a demon from hell, at the very crack of dawn, and has refused to leave till she sees him.”

“Who is she?” I whispered.

“Nkoyo.”

Oh. My predecessor. Interesting.

I was mid-way through battling with my curiosity, which desperately wanted to go to the living room to get a better look at the woman Chief had briefly married, when her voice jolted me from the door.

“So, you won’t come to welcome a guest? Is that the kind of home training you have?” she said, walking into the dining room.

I turned to look at her, and she was nothing like what I’d expected. If anyone had asked me if Chief had a type, I would have answered in the affirmative, considering his late wife and I shared a lot of similar features. But the woman standing before me was the complete opposite. Standing at over six feet tall, this woman was an Amazon.

Everything about her just seemed big; big eyes, big nose, big chest, big arms, big legs. She looked like she belonged in some medieval boxing ring. And neither the wrapper and blouse she wore, nor the wild hair and garish makeup she adorned, did anything to feminize her. I struggled with the thought of Chief finding her attractive enough to marry in the first place.

“You no dey talk?” she prodded further, obviously wanting some form of reaction from me. When she got nothing, except me looking back with fear oozing out of every orifice, she shook her head and hissed. “Dem tell me say na small pikin he marry, but this one don pass small pikin. Aren’t his children even older than you?” she glanced at Uzochi. “Abi I lie?”

Uzochi's mouth was set in a firm, grim line, and she said nothing in response.

"This one dey do im face like person wey drink poison!" Nkoyo giggled, clearly enjoying herself. "If you like die, I'm not leaving this place till I see that yeye man!"

"O bu ndi mmadu no n'onu uzọ m na-ata uta," Uzochi mumbled under her breath, loading Chief's breakfast onto a tray.

"You think say I no hear that one?" Nkoyo laughed. "You blame the people at the gate, abi? I no blame you. Na myself I blame. If I had fired you and thrown you and that your useless husband out of the house when I had the chance, would you be there mumbling nonsense? And if Chief likes, let him eat his breakfast, lunch and dinner in his room, I no dey go anywhere! Na here im go meet me. He will soon come down. I know him too well. He can't stay away from that useless bakery for long."

"Useless bakery that has been paying your bills," Uzochi snapped uncharacteristically. "If the man is so yeye and his business so useless, why do you keep coming back here then, begging for money?"

"Money that is mine? Money that I am entitled to?"

"Entitled to nonsense. What did you do for the man? Did you even have any children for him?" Uzochi retorted. "You're there talking of entitled. Entitled indeed!"

I was expecting the mother of all comebacks from this giant of a woman but was shocked to see her visibly recoil. Her face reddened and looked to almost double in size, and I found myself suddenly feeling sorry for her.

"Nkoyo, will you not just leave me in peace?" came Chief's voice, as he walked into the dining room. "It has been five months since you left this

place. Why do you keep coming back to make trouble?”

It was in that very moment I understood the war strategy of striking your opponent at their weakest, as Nkoyo, still reeling from Uzochi’s insult, was now left flustered and unable to properly respond to her former husband.

“Uzochi, is that my food on the tray?” he asked his housekeeper. “Please set it back down. I will run away from nobody.” Then looking again at Nkoyo, “You suddenly have turned mute. You that were calling me yeye and my business useless. You think I didn’t hear?”

“I’m here for my money, Chief,” she said, finally finding her voice, but still subdued. “You promised to settle me, and you are yet to redeem it.”

“By the way, have you met my new wife?” Chief said, smiling in my direction. “Just look at how beautiful she is.”

I instinctively stepped back, not wanting to be roped into this conversation at all, but at the same time wanting to hear every word of it.

“If you want to marry a girl still in her diapers, that is your problem,” Nkoyo retorted, her confidence returning. “All I want is my money.”

“You used your own two hands to pack your things, and you left my house,” Chief chuckled, pouring cream on his oats. “But now, I suddenly owe you money. In fact, you and your people are the ones who need to repay me for the bride price I wasted on you.”

“We both know why I left. Why are you suddenly acting like I left for no reason?” Nkoyo countered, her voice cracking. “It was a mutual agreement, and you promised to compensate me for all the years I spent here with you.”

“My wife, are you not hungry? Sit down and eat with me,” Chief said to me, ignoring Nkoyo.

I sat down obediently, looking from him to her like they were playing a game of chess, wondering what the next person's move would be.

“Chief, this time, you're not going to get rid of me that easily. This time, I'm not going to leave here with your empty promises. For the last five months, it has been failed promise after failed...”

She was cut short by Chief suddenly reaching into his pocket and flinging several crisp notes at her. Some drizzled around her, some hit her in the face, but all of them were soon on the floor at her feet. She made no move to pick them up, but instead just stood there, looking from Chief to the notes on the floor. I had to look away so as not to add to her embarrassment. I had never witnessed such humiliation in my life.

“That should take care of your transport back home and give you some change to do one or two things for yourself,” Chief retorted. “Just leave, and never come back here again.”

Nkoyo remained immobile for several minutes, before finally bending to pick the notes, one by one. The poor woman had been forced to swallow her pride to take this money she was clearly in dire need of. As she picked the money, I saw tears roll down her face and my heart bled for her. How could a woman who was once married to a man as wealthy as Chief Nsofor be reduced to this?

Having gathered all the notes, she started counting them, but Chief clearly had no time for that. “My dear, don't waste my time. That is Twenty Thousand Naira. I believe I have been more than generous. Take it, leave, and never return.”

But she remained standing there. We made eye contact, she and I, the old and new. I could see in her eyes her shame, her sorrow...and her sympathy. It almost looked like she was sorry for me, and I couldn't understand why.

“Isichie! Isichie!” Uzochi called out to the butler. “Bia kpochapu nwanyi a n’ebe a. Escort this woman out of here!”

Nkoyo shook her head, a sardonic smile on her face. “No need, oh. I’m going,” she said, before pointing a finger at the housekeeper. “As for you, mark my words, you will leave this house in disgrace. I promise you that.”

Uzochi chuckled and let out a long hiss, as Nkoyo walked past her. I knew that if it wasn’t for Chief’s presence, she would have given the former mistress of the house some choice words of her own.

“Tell those imbeciles at the gate that the next time she finds her way in, they will pay with their jobs,” Chief said to her after Nkoyo left, sending a chill down my spine. I was seeing a completely different side of the man I had married, and I didn’t like it at all.

The incident kept replaying in my head long after Chief left for the bakery and the rest of the household had returned to their normal activities. On the one hand, I wanted to ask Uzochi what could have possibly led to the woman’s unceremonious exit from the mansion, but on the other hand, I didn’t even want to know.

I lay in my bedroom the whole day, not even bothering to go down for lunch nor to the family lounge to watch the new digital satellite TV, as I ordinarily would have. I just wanted to be by myself.

I was roused from a mid-afternoon nap by a knock on my door. I shut my eyes, wishing it away, but the knock came again, this time more persistent. I wanted to shout to the knocker, whom I thought was Uzochi, to tell her I wasn’t interested in having lunch and just wanted to sleep, but my home training eventually made me rise reluctantly to open the door.

Standing outside wasn't Uzochi, but a familiar young woman, with very sad eyes. It was Chief's only daughter, Apunanwu.

Even though I'd long prepared for this moment, the moment I would finally meet her, standing before her, face to face, I felt fear. Real fear.

Chapter Seven

The Fear

She was intimidating. Looking at her, all I felt was fear.

Standing there before me in an orange satin dress with an embellished neckline, precious stone bedecked chandelier earrings, and clear jelly sandals that were all the rage at the time, her flowery perfume enveloping her like a second outfit, never had I felt so inadequate, even in my own new clothing. She wasn't quite as pretty as her portrait depicted, but she was one of the most sophisticated women I had ever seen face-to-face.

"Are you Adanna?" she asked.

I nodded, not quite sure whether it would have been wiser to deny it.

"Oh, you poor thing!" she exclaimed, suddenly embracing me.

I stood in her embrace, arms straight and eyes wide with shock, not understanding if this was some kind of trap. Why on earth would she be hugging me for marrying her father?

"I heard you were young, but you're even younger than I thought," she remarked, holding me before her like she was scrutinizing a piece of meat.

"Can I come in?"

She was asking for permission to enter a room in her own father's house? Was this the twilight zone or something?

I nodded and stepped aside.

“Thank God they changed the décor here after that Nkoyo woman left,” she said, sitting on the bed and looking around. “Would you believe that she actually had sheets and curtains in red satin? This place looked more like a shrine than a bedroom.”

I nodded again, assimilating the very pertinent piece of information nobody had deemed it fit to share with me; that Nkoyo had occupied this room before me.

“I’ve been speaking with Uzochi, and she’s told me everything,” Apunanwu said, looking at me, her sad eyes looking even sadder. “You poor girl. You’ve given up your own life just to help your family.”

I shrugged, not trusting myself to say anything, not trusting the entire conversation.

“I’m not sure I could be that brave,” she went on. “To give up on love and happiness forever? I just couldn’t do it.”

“I’m happy here,” I said defensively, wanting to convince her, but more so myself, that things weren’t as bad as they seemed.

She sighed and smiled, the same smile you would give a five-year-old girl from the village with dreams of one day becoming the President of the United States of America. “How old are you, Adanna?”

“Sixteen.”

“Have you finished secondary school?”

I looked away, not sure how to tell her I'd dropped out only a few short months before my GCSEs, nor how I hadn't even had the nerve to discuss it with my new husband, to ask him if it would be possible for me to finish secondary school at the very least.

She sighed again. "I thought so. And my father is such a possessive and controlling man, I'm not sure he will allow you enroll in any of the schools nearby."

Possessive and controlling? I stared at her, eyes wide with panic. Even though there was something deep in my gut telling me Chief wasn't the saint everyone was making him out to be, hearing his own daughter voice my fears was downright scary.

"Don't look so scared," Apunanwu laughed, a loud and infectious sound that goaded a smile out of me. For someone who had such a melancholy face, she was surprisingly effervescent. "I love my father to pieces, and he is a wonderful and loving man. But, like all of us, he does have his flaws."

"Aren't you even angry that he has taken a new wife?" I couldn't help but ask.

She shrugged. "It's been years since my mother died, and even then, they didn't exactly have the best marriage," she said. "After she died, he had several women in and out, and when he finally married Nkoyo, I was hopeful that there would at least be stability. I was in my early teens and really hopeful of having a mother figure in the house."

"But she wasn't one?"

Apunanwu hissed. "Far, far, far from it! That woman doesn't have a maternal bone in that her giant body. Never have I seen someone more self-

centered and mean. She was something else. I was very relieved when Dad told me she had left.”

“Did your Dad like her? Did he...erm...did he like her like that?” I stumbled through the question my curiosity was killing me to ask.

Apunanwu smiled, genuinely amused. “You mean, because she’s not pretty like you?”

“Or your mother even,” I answered, not wanting to sound full of myself. “She just doesn’t seem like the kind of woman that would attract a man like your father.”

Apunanwu chuckled. “My dear, leave that one. Men are men,” she looked at me from the corner of her eye. “Anyway, you’re too young to know. In time, you will realize that men are dogs and are ruled by that thing they have hanging down there. They don’t have a ‘type’. All women are their type.”

I suddenly felt affronted. She wasn’t much older than me, so why did she think she knew more about men than I did? But who was I kidding? Having spent a minimum of five years in the almighty University of Benin, she was undoubtedly more schooled in the ways of the world than I could have even dreamt.

I stole a glimpse at her, noting her perky breasts pushing through the satin material of her dress and her thighs on full display, and decided there was no way she was a virgin. She’d probably even slept with more than one man. Maybe even three.

“Adanna?”

I was jolted out of my reverie and realised I’d missed the last thing she said to me.

“Is that how your mind travels?” she giggled, punching me playfully. “I was asking if you’re hungry so we can go down for dinner.”

Dinner? That was when I realised the day was fast spent, and it was already evening. So we, my new friend, slash step-daughter, and I, made our way downstairs and enjoyed a meal of stewed beans and plantain. The longer I spent in her company, the more relaxed I became, and by the time Chief returned from Asaba later that evening, Apunanwu and I were talking and laughing like old pals.

“This is such a wonderful thing to behold! My two favourite women enjoying each other’s company!” he remarked, beaming from ear to ear.

Uzochi was also pleased that we’d hit it off, and I was able to enjoy the company of a young person in the two weeks that followed. Alas, it all had to come to an end with her impending departure for London, where she was enrolled for a Masters degree program in Biochemistry.

“Don’t you want to do your Youth Service first?” I asked her one evening, as we sat in the family lounge watching *The Real World* on MTV, trying to delay our separation for as long as I could.

“Youth Service indeed!” she scoffed. “I told Dad I’ll do it after my Masters, but between you and me, I have no intention of coming back to Nigeria.”

My heart broke at this statement. Her leaving for school was one thing, but never returning was an entirely different ball game.

“Don’t worry, we’ll be home in a few months for Christmas, Anayo and I,” she said, giving me one of her characteristic hugs.

The mention of his name, as it always did, made me lightheaded. I’d had several opportunities to tell her I’d met him before, but I was afraid of what her reaction would be to hear that not only had we met, but we’d even

kissed. There was no way she would be liberal enough not to be scandalised about that. Her brother and her father's wife? No, that would rankle even the best of people. So, I'd kept quiet.

My only hope was that he wouldn't spill the beans to her when she got there. I wondered if he even knew I was the young bride his father had taken, and I could only hope he wouldn't have put the pieces together, at least not just yet. By the time he and Apunanwu came home for Christmas, we would find a way to cross that bridge.

"Uzochi, take care of my queen," Chief said, as he and Apunanwu prepared to leave for Lagos to catch their flight to London. "Anything she wants, make sure she gets."

"Consider it done," had been Uzochi's cheery answer, flashing her sparkling white teeth in her characteristic smile.

I smiled as he embraced me, and I was genuinely saddened by the thought of being separated from him. He had left me enough money to keep me happy, but I knew it would be a lonely month without him nor my dear friend, Apunanwu.

"Take care of yourself, Ada," she whispered as she hugged me. "And always guard your heart. Don't allow yourself fall to pieces when the old man's attention starts to wander. You need to be prepared for that."

They were such ominous last words that I was left speechless as the car disappeared down the long driveway. So, Chief's attention was expected to wander? I wouldn't be the only object of his fancy for much longer? I was surprised to realize the thought scared me. Was it because I wasn't sleeping with him yet? I decided that, if I was going to stay in the marriage for the long haul, upon his return I would have to do something about that.

That evening, as I ate dinner alone, the house had never seemed emptier. I was already missing Apunanwu's high-pitched voice, talking endlessly about her university adventures. And when I retired for bed that night, I missed the evening chats I would have with Chief. I'd grown fond of the man and missed him a lot more than I thought I would.

"Eiya, sorry o!" Uzochi said, patting my shoulder sympathetically, as I toyed with my breakfast the following morning. "I know you're already missing your friend."

Her words brought tears to my eyes, which I quickly wiped away. I decided, then and there, to snap out of my sadness and adjust to life alone, just the way I had before Apunanwu arrived. I decided to get more involved in the running of the household. I was the lady of the house, after all. Yes, it had been nice having a friend for a little while, but now she was gone, life just had to go on.

So I fell right back into my routine and started accompanying Uzochi to the market and on her other errands in the town. Not only was this cathartic for me, it helped me feel more involved and make more friends. Life wasn't bad at all.

Until the day it all changed.

We were driving into the compound when we sighted a black Toyota Celica parked in front of the house. I recognized it as the car Anayo drove when he came to see me in Onitsha, and my heart skipped a beat. Was he home?

"Gịnị kpataara na ọ nọ ebe a?" Uzochi mumbled under her breath, a deep frown on her face.

This confused me, as I knew she had a soft spot for Anayo, from the way she fondly spoke of him. If he were the one, she wouldn't be wondering

what he was doing in the house.

“Who is it?” I asked.

She said nothing in response, but I was to get my answer very soon. As we disembarked from the car, a tall figure emerged from the doorway. I felt my blood run cold as I recognised who it was. Akanna.

“Where have you two been? I’ve been here for at least an hour,” he demanded, his nostrils flared and his jaw set.

“Ewela iwe. Don’t be angry. We had to go and buy a few things,” Uzochi answered, her voice quivering. I looked at her, shocked to realize she too was scared of him.

His eyes focused on me, and a slow smile formed on his face. “My father’s wife. Adanna, isn’t it?”

I nodded, unable to look him in the eye. I increased my pace, so I could quickly get into the house and out of his presence, but he held me by the wrist.

“Where are you rushing off to? Don’t you want us to at least chat?” he asked, his smile now a full-on grin. “You’re my new step-mother. Surely, we should get to know each other better.”

Uzochi quickly scampered into the house, leaving me standing there with the imposing heir to the Nsofor dynasty. By this time, I was shaking like a leaf, no longer able to mask my fear. From the smile on his face, he was taking a lot of pleasure in seeing the effect he was having on me. Seeing the look of satisfaction on his face was all it needed to snap out of my irrational trepidation.

Why on earth was I afraid anyway? Why was everyone afraid? Why had Uzochi behaved like a confused mouse in the presence of the house cat?

Even Okeke, the driver, had appeared nervous. What was it about Chief's first son that had everyone all tied up in knots? I could see he enjoyed it, and I was suddenly determined not to give him any further satisfaction.

So, I took a deep breath and looked him straight in the eye. "You don't have to hold me to make your point."

His brows rose in his surprise. "A spunky one. Interesting. You didn't appear quite so brave the last time I saw you in your father's kiosk."

"Shop. My father had a shop, not a kiosk," I answered, my fear progressing to anger. "And I'm sure you're aware that he died only hours after your ill-fated visit."

"No fault of mine that Aloy bit off more than he could chew," he said, the grin still on his face. "But we can talk about it more inside. Why don't we go and have some tea on the patio and chat a little?"

I pulled my hand out of his grip, glaring at him. The brief exchange had only served to reopen old wounds and remind me of the unfortunate exchange that occurred the day my father died.

"I think we know more than enough about each other," I retorted. "If you'll excuse me, I'm going to my room."

"Does my father know about you and Anayo?" he called out as I started to ascend the stairs. "Does he know how his new wife spent a whole afternoon with his son in a seedy Onitsha hotel?"

I froze mid-ascent and turned around, my mouth agape. How did he know about my afternoon with Anayo? And why did he make it sound like it was anything but an innocent date?

"I'll take it he doesn't," he laughed. "No problem. You can go to your room, Adanna. I'll definitely see you soon."

I walked like someone in a trance to my bedroom. I could immediately see why everyone had been eager to flee from his presence. There was something sinister about the man, which was in contrast to his smooth, good looks. He was clearly bad news, and I was determined to stay far away from him.

Not ready to see him again, I decided to skip dinner. I'd had quite a bit to eat at the fish market anyway, so missing a meal wasn't too much of a sacrifice in exchange for my sanity.

I was lying on my bed, reading a book, when my door opened. I sat up with a jolt, as nobody, not even Chief, ever let themselves into my room without knocking first.

"No need to look so scared. I don't bite," Akanna said, walking in.

I pulled up my sheets, feeling self conscious of the chemise nightwear I wore. "How can you just walk into a woman's bedroom without knocking?"

"What you are trying to hide, I have seen thousands of times," he retorted, before cocking his head to one side. "Even though I have to admit, yours seems to be much more attractive than most. You've really blossomed since the last time I saw you. Filled out in all the right places."

"Get out of my room!" I yelled.

"Not so loud, Adanna," he said, shaking his head. "You don't want me to tell my dad that he is actually eating from Anayo's leftovers."

My face reddened in my embarrassment. "Nothing happened between Anayo and I. He...he was just my friend."

"A friend you went to a motel with?"

“It wasn’t a motel. It was a nice restaurant, and all we did was have a few drinks...” I stuttered.

“Does that even sound believable to you?” Akanna chuckled. “And the love note he made me give you? Just from a friend, right?”

I looked away, no longer having any comeback for this awful man. There was silence for so long, I thought he’d finally left my room. But I looked up only to see him still looking at me, his eyes narrow and all traces of laughter gone. I knew that look. I’d seen it before on several men.

It was desire.

“You need to leave now,” I said, standing up, no longer worried about my flimsy chemise.

He turned around and walked to the door, but rather than exit, locked it.

“What are you doing?” I cried. “Why did you lock the door?”

“I think it’s only fair that I also have a taste of what my brother and father have eaten, don’t you think?”

Realisation of what he was saying hit me, and I let out a loud cry, but he was on me before the sound could travel far, covering my mouth with his large hands.

“Any noise from you, and I am going to telephone my father tonight to let him know what kind of slut he has married,” he sneered.

“He knows I’m a virgin,” I sneered back, trying to act brave even though tears were rolling down my cheeks.

“You’re a virgin?” he exclaimed with a glint in his eye, and I immediately knew giving him that information was a costly mistake.

Mustering all the energy I could, I pushed him and tried to run to the door, but he caught me before I'd even taken two strides. Before I could scream again, he silenced me with his lips, kissing me with so much force, I tasted blood. As he held me against him, I felt his growing erection, making me fight even harder. But the more I struggled, the more rabid he became.

He pushed me on the bed and was on top of me immediately, his large frame dwarfing mine. With one hand, he pinned my hands above my head, and with the other hand, he pulled off my underwear. I let out a guttural scream when I felt his hand in my womanhood, my most intimate area that had never before received any attention. I struggled and thrashed under him like a wounded animal, but it made no difference. When he let go of my hands to undo his zip, I tried to push him off, and got a deafening slap in return. But I wasn't going to go down without a fight, and so I bit deep into his chest.

Big mistake.

He punched me in the face; once, twice, ten, fifteen times. Blood was soon oozing out of every orifice of my face, and I felt my strength start to fade. But the most searing pain came from when he finally penetrated me. I wanted to scream out loud over this agonizing, unfamiliar pain, but no sound could come out of my swollen lips.

As he thrust, he moaned in ecstasy, and I knew he was stealing my most valuable treasure. My virginity. Tears stung my bruised eyes as his thrusting intensified. When he finally reached his climax, rolled off me, and lay on the bed, panting with satisfaction, I had never felt dirtier or more worthless.

I wished for death.

"I've had thousands of women, but that was, without a doubt, the best ever," he exclaimed. "I've even had virgins before, but none of them felt as

good as that!”

I lay on the bed, immobile, staring at the ceiling, wishing my life away.

He stood and pulled up his jeans. “I don’t have to tell you this stays between the two of us, right? The consequences will be dire if you tell anyone about this.”

I shut my eyes, not saying a word, not even caring about what he did or didn’t tell his father. My life was over. A monster had just stolen my virginity. Nothing worse could happen.

Except it could.

“I’m not sure you know this, but I’m the one who handled your mother and sister’s logistics to India,” he continued talking. “I’m the one who’s been liaising with the doctors at the Specialist Hospital over there in Jalandher. I’m the one who controls the payments. So far, we’ve paid for the preliminary investigations still being carried out. When that’s over, I’m the one who will approve the payment to the donor, as well as for the procedure itself. And then there’s the all important after-care.”

I sat up, the import of what he was saying hitting home.

“I’m glad I finally have your attention,” he laughed. “The bottom line is, if you tell anyone about this, I’m going to pull the plug on your sister’s treatment. Do you understand?”

“How do I explain my face?” I asked, my voice almost inaudible. I couldn’t see the extent of my injuries, but with my eyes so swollen I could barely see through them, I knew I looked almost as horrible as I felt.

“You fell in the bath. Be creative,” he answered, with a sly wink.

“What about when Chief finds out I’m no longer a virgin? What do I tell him?”

“That you lied, of course,” he chuckled again. “That one of those Onitsha traders had already sampled you. He’ll be angry but I’m sure he’ll live with it.”

I looked away, feeling dead inside. He was empowered because of how high the stakes were. If I talked, Ahunna’s treatment would be jeopardized. It was that simple.

“Looking at you is getting me excited again,” he said. Panicked, I looked to see him staring at me with renewed desire. “Take off your nightie.”

My eyes widened in terror, not believing, not accepting that he planned to repeat the assault on me again.

“Take it off!” he bellowed.

With shaky hands, I pulled of the chemise, leaving me fully naked.

“Lie down with your legs apart,” he said, his voice thickened by his rising desire.

I did as I was told, his threat to stop my sister’s treatment hanging over me like a noose, like a gun being pointed at my head. I watched as he took off his jeans and mounted the bed again. I shut my eyes as he straddled me again, the experience no less painful than the first time.

He didn’t leave my room until it was almost dawn, before which he had raped me at least six more times. After he left, I just lay on the bed, motionless, unable to move. Life, as I knew it, had changed forever.

Chapter Eight

The Attack

As the warm rays of the sun hit my face, I lay on the bed, immobile. The wounds on my face stung from its intensity, and my swollen eyes ached from the heat impact, but still I lay there, receiving it like some sort of punishment. I was good for nothing, damaged goods, deserving punishment, deserving nothing but pain.

Not even the rumbling in my stomach nor the stickiness between my thighs were enough to rouse me. I shut my eyes several times, wishing the angel – no – demon of death would come and take me away. Hell could not be worse than the perdition I was already in.

There were times when I would drift off into spells of shallow sleep, but anytime my consciousness returned, the ache deep in my soul was the painful reminder I needed that what happened had been no nightmare. It had truly happened. Akanna had raped me.

The sun had begun to set when there was a gentle knock on my door.

“Adanna? I dịkwa mma? Are you okay?” came Uzochi’s voice. “You haven’t been down today.”

I tried to answer that I was fine, I tried to tell her I wasn’t hungry, but the sound of my voice couldn’t even carry beyond the pillow on which I lay. I

couldn't even raise my body enough to lock the door nor clothe my bruised, naked body.

Not hearing a response, she opened the door.

“Jesus! Jesus!” she exclaimed, running to me. I tried to wrestle as she grabbed me, but instead she held me, tears pouring down her face as she looked at me.

But she said nothing.

Not even when she went to the adjoining bathroom and returned with a small towel and a bowl of warm water, nor as she cleaned my bruises did she say a word. Her only communication was in the tears that flowed down her face.

After cleaning up my face, she helped me to my feet and led me to the bathroom where she proceeded to bathe me. I winced as the water introduced me to new injuries I hadn't even realised were there. I tried to prevent her from washing my nether regions, but I hadn't been strong enough to struggle, so I'd let her wash away all the blood and semen from my thighs, crying in renewed memory of my assault. She dried me and dressed me in a fresh pair of cotton pajamas and sat me on the sofa while she made the bed. When the bed was ready, she led me to it and covered me with the duvet.

But still she said nothing.

Even though Akanna had admonished me not to say a word to anyone, I desperately wanted to talk to someone. My heart wanted to tell her about what he had done to me, but my lips were heavy. If only she'd at least asked me what happened, maybe I could have been brave enough to talk...but she didn't, so I wasn't.

“What do you want to eat?” she asked when I was well settled. “Yam? Rice? Plantain? Tell me anything you want, and I’ll bring it for you.”

The part of me that wanted to sulk wanted to rebuff this offer, but the part of me that had been starved for nearly 24 hours finally found a voice. “Anything is fine,” I managed to croak.

She nodded and walked out of the room, but not before I saw new tears pool in her eyes.

That was when I realised there was nothing neither her nor anybody could do for me. There was a fear for Akanna that defied all explanation. I had seen it in all their eyes the very moment he arrived. He was untouchable and could do anything he liked.

Uzochi returned with a large tray that had almost everything her hands could put together; fried plantain and eggs, roast chicken, custard and scones, corn and ube, and a bowl of pineapples, watermelon and paw paw. She was trying to console and heal me with food.

On a good day, I would have asked her to take away most of what was on the tray, but I simply looked on at the overloaded platter. It was probably just as well, considering I had no intention of going downstairs ever again.

“Biko, akpochi ụzọ!” Uzochi said, looking deep into my eyes. “Lock your door!”

And that was the only exchange we needed for me to know she knew what had happened, and it broke her heart not to be able to do anything about it.

I nodded, wiping away fresh tears. She hugged me tight, before pulling away and scurrying out of the room. After she left, I picked a little at the plantains, had a spoon of custard, a bite of the scone, and nibbled at the fruits, but it all tasted like sawdust.

Struggling to my feet, I carried the tray to the other side of the room and placed it on the small coffee table, with plans to eat its contents the following morning. I caught a glimpse of my face in the mirror and gasped. I knew I looked awful, but seeing the swollen-eyed, puffy-faced girl looking back at me was too much to bear. My light skin was bruised purple in several places, and it would have been a tough sell to convince any logical thinking person that the injuries had come from a domestic accident.

I was still staring at my face when I heard footsteps approaching. Remembering I hadn't yet locked it, I ran to the door...only to realize there was no key there. My heart started racing in my panic, and I leaned on the door in some desperate attempt to keep anyone from gaining entry.

But it was too little too late.

The door almost opened, and I pressed my weight on it more.

"What are you trying to do?" came the voice I had grown to detest. "Is this a joke, or are you actually trying to keep me out?"

"Go away!" I cried, pressing even harder on the door.

In one swift movement, the door was kicked open, sending me sprawling to the floor.

"You're really funny," Akanna chuckled, strolling into the room like he owned it. "Trying to stop the door with your weight. How comical! You probably weigh just as much as my little finger."

I remained on the floor, sobbing. My nightmare was about to continue.

"Wow, so much food!" he said, stopping at the tray and taking a bite of the scone. "Someone has no plans of leaving this room any time soon." Then he winked at me. "That's okay. I'll just come to you." He sat on the bed, the tray on his laps. "Come eat with me."

I glared at him, still crying.

“I don’t want to have to force you, Adanna. Don’t let me have to hurt you again. I don’t like seeing what I’ve done to your face. It would be so much easier if you’d just cooperate.”

I didn’t move, but instead lowered my head, trying to wish him away.

“You seem to think this is optional. You’ve forgotten what I told you about Ahunna,” he said, humour having left his voice. “I spoke with your mother this afternoon. They now have a date for the surgery. It’s in another month. What a shame it would be to have to terminate everything!”

That was all it needed to make me do his bidding. I rose to my feet and sat beside him on the bed, watching as he ate.

“Uzochi is undefeated. These eggs are delicious!” he remarked. “Are you sure you don’t want any of it?”

I shook my head.

“I hope you didn’t tell her anything,” he said. “It would be a disaster if you did.”

“I didn’t tell her anything,” was my answer, which was the truth.

When he was done eating, he set the tray on the floor and brought my key out of his pocket. I felt bile rise to my mouth as he locked the door, and I knew it was going to be yet another agonising night.

I put up no fight when he returned to the bed. Instead I lay there and allowed him do what he wanted. I thought it would be easier not to fight, but I was wrong. It was just as horrible. It was just as soul wrenching and demeaning as it had been when I’d fought him.

Like the night before, he had his way with me multiple times, but unlike the last time, he didn't bother leaving my room when morning broke. Instead, he slept soundly, and when finally he awoke, the first thing he did was reach for me, continuing the cycle. By the time he finally left my room, it was well past 10am. As he walked out, I caught sight of one of the junior maids walking along the hallway, and I could only imagine what she was thinking of me.

At noon, Uzochi returned with an early lunch for me, but unlike the previous day when she had been emotional, she was stoic, her face expressionless. She didn't even ask how I'd managed to clear the huge tray of food from the previous evening, but instead set the new tray there, as if nothing had happened.

“Kedu ihe ì ga-eri n’abali? What will you eat this night?”

I looked at her, trying to decode any hidden message, but reading nothing at all in her deadpan eyes. So I simply shrugged, not saying anything.

“Ngwanu, jisie ike,” she said, with almost an air of indifference as she walked out of the room. “Take care of yourself.”

I was stunned beyond belief. What on earth could have changed between yesterday and today? Where had all the empathy from the previous day gone? How could she have gone from weeping even more profusely than I, to acting like nothing had even happened?

I was well and truly alone.

Akanna strolled back to my bedroom at about 3pm and proceeded to stay there all night. When he ordered his meal to be delivered there, I couldn't understand it. If he was so insistent on my not telling anyone of what had been transpiring between us, he sure wasn't doing anything to hide it.

Dumebi, the young maid, did everything she could not to make eye contact with me, as she arranged his tray on my small coffee table. I was too ashamed to look at her as well. By now, I knew that the entire household would be gossiping about what they thought was going on between Akanna and I. What I didn't know was how all this would be happening without word of it filtering to Chief's ears. Yes, Akanna might have been controlling Ahunna's logistics, but Chief controlled the purse strings...and that was much more important.

But I wasn't brave enough to do anything about it, and so I yielded to becoming Akanna's sex slave.

He moved into my bedroom, departing only for a couple of hours for quick visits to the bakery. I had no way of knowing if him being in Ojiji was only to hold the forte while Chief was away, or if he had relocated from Lagos for good. With everything in my heart, I prayed it was the former. Whatever the case, he only spent at the bakery a fraction of the time his father would ordinarily have spent there and chose to spend the better part of his day in my bedroom...in my bed.

It didn't get any easier. He ravaged my body like an animal devouring raw meat. If this was what sex was all about, then everyone had lied. It was the most horrible thing I could have ever fathomed, and every incident left me bruised and battered, physically and emotionally.

Thankfully, my facial injuries from our first encounter healed, and I was soon able to journey out of my room. There was no point hiding there. The whole household knew of my shame. By this time, my relationship with Uzochi had become completely frosty, and one wouldn't have believed we had once shared a close friendship. She gave me curt smiles as she announced my meals or informed me when she was leaving the house to

run errands, but that was it. Uzochi, my adopted mother here in a strange land, had herself become a stranger.

Finally, after five long weeks, Chief returned home.

I'd taken special care with my makeup that day, trying to hide any telltale signs of having been tampered with. Thankfully, Akanna had the good sense to move out all his things which had accumulated in my room; clothing, footwear, wristwatches and even toiletries. My only wish, my only prayer was that he was gone for good.

"Ah, look at my princess!" Chief exclaimed, as I ran to embrace him in the lobby. "You look like you've lost a lot of weight. Uzochi, haven't you been taking care of my angel?"

Uzochi looked away, and I could only wonder what she was thinking.

"I got you a lot of beautiful things you'll love," Chief said, taking my hand as we walked together into the living room. "And Apunanwu sent you some things she says you ladies like."

I smiled, trying to appear excited, but not even the thought of beautiful things from London could rejuvenate my weakened spirit.

"I also spoke with your mother several times," Chief went on. "From what I hear from their doctors, everything is going excellently well. Both Ahunna and her donor are ready, and surgery should be in the next couple of weeks."

"That's wonderful," I said, giving him a small hug. "Thank you, my husband."

"I'm the one that should be thanking you every day," Chief said, planting a huge kiss on my cheek. "My beautiful wife!"

Akanna walked into the living room at that point, and there was a sardonic smile on his face. “Ah, the lovebirds.”

“Akanna, you’re here,” Chief remarked, his tone flattening. “I thought you would be in the bakery. Isn’t it a little early for you to be home?”

“I came home to welcome you,” Akanna answered. “Or did I commit a crime by doing so?”

“How have things been?”

“Don’t act like you haven’t been getting information from all your spies,” Akanna retorted. “I’m sure they’ve all told you I’ve been doing a great job. I’ve made quite a few changes.”

“Nke ahụ abụghị ihe m gwara gị mee. I didn’t ask you to make any changes, just to manage the place in my absence!” Chief snapped. “I didn’t bring you here so you would destroy the business like you’ve done Lagos!”

Akanna rolled his eyes. “Ah, here we go again.”

“Anyway, we can talk more of that later. For now, I just want to rest. It has been a long journey, and I just want to enjoy the company of my beautiful wife.”

A sly smile formed on Akanna’s face. “Very good company indeed.”

I stiffened in Chief’s arms and looked at him to see if he had picked up on anything. But it didn’t look like he had.

“Di’m, food is ready. It has already been set in the dining room. Fufu and vegetable soup, just as you like it,” I said, trying to deflect the situation.

“Music to my very weary ears!” he laughed. “Let me use the rest room, I will join you shortly.”

I walked to the dining room, trying not to allow my nerves show on my face. Hearing Akanna's stay in town wouldn't be short term was devastating, but I was consoled by the fact he wouldn't dare touch me now that Chief was back home. I made a mental note to make sure to accompany Chief on any of his trips going forward. At no point ever again would I be left alone with his beast of a son.

As I was dishing soup to Chief's bowl, I felt Akanna's all too familiar breath on my neck. "I hope you are dishing some for me."

I tried to shrug out of his hold. "Please stop this. My husband is back."

He chuckled. "Your husband. You don't know how ridiculous it is hearing you call him that."

I heard Chief's footsteps approaching and proceeded to summon all my strength to wrestle myself away just in time.

Or was it?

There was a look on Chief's face I couldn't quite decipher. His brows were furrowed, and he wasn't quite as bubbly as he'd been only moments before.

"You will love the soup, di'm. I finally convinced Uzochi to allow me cook for you," I declared proudly, taking my seat next to him.

He simply nodded in response. I looked at him, puzzled by his indifference. Maybe he was just tired?

"I'll allow you lovebirds enjoy dinner," Akanna declared. "I have a date in town. See you. Don't wait up!" He winked at me as he left the room, and I quickly looked away.

When I looked up, I saw Chief looking at me.

"Is everything okay, my husband?" I asked.

He continued looking at me, before finally chuckling. “Adanna, my beautiful wife. I think I have waited for long enough. I want you to warm my bed tonight. Why don’t you meet me in my room by about 9pm, after I have taken a small nap.”

My heart crashed into the pit of my stomach, and I felt a cold sweat break on my forehead. “To..tonight?” I stuttered. “Don’t you want to rest tonight?”

“I have been resting for too long, my queen,” he said, kissing my hand. “I think it’s high time we consummate our marriage, or don’t you think?”

Those were the words that haunted me for the rest of the evening; consummate our marriage. Whilst it had been a scary thought when I’d first arrived, after a while, I’d grown to expect and even anticipate it. But after Akanna’s violation, after he had taken what it was Chief was expecting to receive, it was now an even more frightening thought than before.

I spent an hour in the bath, trying to luxuriate in scented soaps and oils. Maybe if my skin looked and smelt so good, Chief wouldn’t notice anything else. I took extra care to apply my makeup, and wore the silk night robe Apunanwu had given me before she left. When I walked out of my room at a few minutes before 9, I knew there was no way he would be able to resist me.

“Come in,” he bellowed when I knocked on his door. I had only been to his room a few times, and those had been on the occasions he had been too tired to stop by mine upon his return from work.

“Di’m, it’s me,” I said, unnecessarily announcing my arrival.

I had never made so much of an effort in my appearance for him, so standing there before him, looking so beautiful, even I couldn’t deny it, I

was expecting his typical showers of praise. I was expecting him to lose his mind over how stunning I looked.

But his face was set like stone.

“Get in the bed,” he ordered.

I was taken aback. This wasn’t like him.

“Chief, is everything okay? Did the food upset you?”

“You really want me to say it twice?” he retorted. “Undress and get in the bed.”

He sounded so much like his nasty son, I was tempted to turn around and run far, far away. But instead, I braced myself, slipped first out of the silk night robe and then out of my sheer negligée, standing before him completely naked. For someone who was supposedly crazy about me, he was surprisingly indifferent seeing me in my naked state.

Without another word, I got on to his large bed, the luxurious bed sheet feeling like I was lying on flowers. But the vibe in the room was so tense and hostile, I might have as well been on thorns.

Wordlessly and without any of his usual endearments or acts of affection, he took off his only item of clothing, a loose pair of jogging pants, mounted me and began to thrust aggressively. I winced, to try to simulate a woman doing it for the first time. Luckily, it didn’t last as long as it did with Akanna, and I felt like I’d somehow gotten away with it.

When he was done, he rolled off me and got off the bed. I watched as he put his jogging pants back on, walked across the room and lit his pipe.

“I thought you said you were a virgin,” he said, looking at me with what I could finally see was revulsion. “There was nothing virginal about the

woman I just lay with.”

I sat up, not knowing whether to lie or admit that he was correct.

“Answer me!” he shouted, making me jump. In one single stride, he walked back to the bed and dragged me off it. “Tell me why I shouldn’t throw you out of my house this very minute! I married you thinking I was getting an angel, only to get a woman with an expressway for a vagina!”

“Chief, please! Please!” I screamed, shielding my face lest he attack me. “I swear, I came here a virgin. It was...it was Akanna. He raped me. When you went to London, he raped me. He’s been raping me...” I dissolved into tears, not able to say any more. I knew that by telling Chief, I was jeopardising my sister’s welfare, but at that point, I was willing to take the risk to protect my own life.

“Akanna raped you,” he repeated sardonically, pulling me to my feet, his fingers digging deep into my skin. “Akanna raped you, or you threw yourself at him the minute I turned my back?”

I stared back, flabbergasted. “No, Sir. He’s the one who came to me. He came to me.”

He struck me on the face with the back of his hand, the large ring on his finger cutting my cheek. “You’re nothing but a harlot! I heard all about how you’ve been seducing him, keeping him locked up in your room from morning to night. If he ‘raped’ you, why were you accommodating him every day?”

I just stared back, clutching my bleeding cheek, my mouth agape.

“As if that wasn’t bad enough, they tell me you also slept with my younger son, Anayo,” he shouted, his fists balled in his rage.

“I didn’t sleep with Anayo,” I whimpered. “I only met him two times. And all we did was have drinks...”

Another slap hit me across the face before I could even finish talking.

“Asusu! This is a scandal!” he yelled, kicking me on my chest before grabbing his belt that lay on his sofa. “You sleep with a father and his sons? This is an outrage! An abomination!”

No matter how I tried, I couldn’t dodge the whips of the belt, as it landed indiscriminately on every part of my body; my face, head, chest, stomach, arms, legs...no part of my body was spared. I screamed, but it was like the more I screamed, the more incensed he became. He was a bull seeing only red, and he attacked me just like one. It wasn’t until I lay motionless on the floor, that the flogging stopped.

“I have a good mind to send you away,” he panted, also spent from his attack. “You’re nothing but a very bad investment. You are not worth a single kobo of the millions I have wasted on your unfortunate family.”

I wept as I lay on the floor, realizing this was very likely the end, not only for me, but for Ahunna as well.

“The logical thing to do would be to call the hospital and tell them not to proceed with the procedure,” he said, still standing over me. “You harlot, I should return you to your mother. I should send you back to her and watch her bury other child. That is what you and your rotten family deserve.”

I looked up at him imploringly, pleading with my eyes for mercy. If for nothing, to make all the suffering I’d endured in both his and Akanna’s hands worth it...for my sister’s sake.

“But I won’t do that,” he said, after a lengthy pause. “I am going to keep you here for the purpose I brought you in the first place. Now, get out of my

room before I kill you tonight!”

I scrambled to my feet, quickly throwing on my negligée but not even bothering with my robe. As I scampered out of his room and ran downstairs to mine, his words kept ringing in my head. He was going to keep me for the purpose he got me? What purpose could that possibly be?

Sitting on my bed, the adrenalin began to ebb, and I started feeling the pain and stinging from all the welts on my body. I thought back to only a few months before, when my life had been so much simpler, and I had been the apple of my late father’s eye. Now, he was gone, and here I was, sexually, physically, emotionally, and mentally abused, and for what? Was it really worth it? Would Ahunna ever appreciate the huge sacrifice I was making for her?

“Nna, ooooo,” I wailed, my body, spirit, and soul completely broken. I wasn’t calling out for my dad because I missed him. I was calling out for him so that he could take me away. To end all my misery.

Chapter Nine

The Father, The Son

Sleep eluded me.

For hours after my return to my bedroom, I just lay there, staring into the night, watching as darkness slowly gave way to light. By the time dawn broke, I'd come to a decision. I'd married Chief to help my family, and I was determined to see the whole thing through. I was going to fight for it if I had to, but by God, I wasn't going to return to Onitsha with nothing to show for it. Not after Chief and his son had already had their way with me. I came there to be a wife to Chief, and a wife I was going to be.

Armed with my renewed determination, I rose to my feet, had a shower, and dressed up in my finest ankara. I took the time to tie my head tie to give me a regal, more mature look, one that gave me an air of authority, one that could help me better pass for Lady of the House. Satisfied with my appearance, I set off for the dining room early enough to meet Chief having his breakfast. I was determined to undo whatever havoc my dalliance with Akanna had caused.

"D'im, good morning," I said, a smile on my face as I took a seat next to my husband. "Did you sleep well?"

Chief continued eating his toast, not taking his eyes off the newspaper in front of him. I inhaled deeply, trying to muster more courage. This was going to be harder than I thought.

Uzochi walked in at that moment, a kettle in her hand to refill Chief's coffee cup. "Ah, Nne. I teta? You've woken up?" she remarked. "Do you want me to bring your breakfast here?"

I glared at her, still furious over her abandonment. How dare she speak to me like she hadn't left me when I'd needed her the most?

"My husband," I said, placing my hand over his, still trying to make small talk.

He pulled his hand away as if he'd been in contact with a leper. "Will you get out of here! Get out of my sight, and don't let me see you anywhere around me!"

I recoiled as if he'd struck me in the face. His reaction shouldn't have surprised me, considering what had transpired the night before, but it did. And from her wide eyes and parted mouth, it had surprised Uzochi as well.

Not wanting to cause a scene, I stood up, curtsied, and left the room, determined to find another opportunity to continue making amends, preferably without an audience next time. I ignored Uzochi's sad eyes as I walked out, and kept my head held high as I made the walk of shame to my bedroom. Chief's voice had been loud enough to carry far, and I knew most of the domestic staff would have heard his admonishment. But I was ready to swallow all the insults, if it meant getting back into Chief's good books eventually.

I was so deep in thought that I didn't hear Akanna walk up behind me as I entered my bedroom.

“What’s the matter? Trouble in paradise?” he chuckled.

I turned around and had to restrain myself from landing a slap across his face.

“What do you want? Why did you follow me?” I demanded.

“If you have fallen out with the old man, that will be terrible for you and your family. You know that already, right?” he teased.

Suddenly emboldened, I glowered at him. “Well, whose fault is that? Everything that has happened is all because of you.”

“You’re so naïve, little Adanna,” Akanna said, leaning on the doorframe, his arms crossed. “Did you really think my father brought you here to play happy families? Did you really think he brought you here to be any more than a doll he can put on display? My dear girl, do you really think the old man works in the bakery till 9, 10pm every day? Do you really believe he has been celibate since he brought you here?” Then making air quotes with his fingers, ““Waiting for you’?”

I tried to maintain a steady gaze, even though his questions were hitting me like arrows, each one of them sounding less plausible than the one preceding it.

“How soon will it take you to realize you are not his cup of tea?” Akanna asked, his eyes boring into mine. “And how soon before you realize on what side your bread is truly buttered?”

Having heard enough, I rose to my feet. “I’d like to lock my door, so kindly step back.”

Interpretation. Get the hell out of my room!

Akanna smiled. “Someone seems to have grown a pair of wings. It looks like it’s those same wings that will fly you right back to your Onitsha slum,” he straightened and stepped back. “I’m leaving for Lagos anyway. I have to finalise the sale of the bakery there. Unfortunately, that didn’t quite work out.”

I looked away, uninterested in whatever was his reason for leaving town, but very relieved nonetheless.

“I’ll be back soon. Don’t miss me too much.”

When he left, I locked my door with so much force, I almost pulled the door knob off. But his words remained with me.

I spent the rest of the day in my room, not even venturing out for my meals. After the morning’s humiliation, I didn’t want to have to face Uzochi and the other staff. It was the classic fall from grace. I had gone from being the cherished bride who, despite what Akanna said, had been the object of Chief’s affection...to being someone whose sight he couldn’t stand.

As I made do with leftover boiled groundnuts for my meals, I was all the more determined to find out where I stood with Chief. If he wanted to send me away, then he might as well just go ahead with it.

It wasn’t until 11 PM that I heard Chief’s car drive up to the house. Deep in my heart, I knew there was some truth in what Akanna said. Could he really have been at the bakery till such a time of night? Brushing the thoughts aside, I adjusted my clothing, rubbed a slick of Vaseline across my lips, and then dashed downstairs, to receive him at the door.

“Welcome, my husband,” I greeted, making to carry his briefcase. “How was work today?”

“I bu onye ntị chiri? Are you hard of hearing?” he bellowed, his eyes spitting fire. “What part of ‘I don’t want to see you around me’ don’t you understand?”

“If you don’t want to see me around you, then send me back home,” I snapped, finally sick and tired of the whole thing. “If the sight of me irritates you so much, then send me away.”

Chief glowered at me. “Who are you talking to like that? Dirty prostitute. Do I look like your age mate? If I didn’t stoop into the gutter to fraternize with your ilk, where would you see me to run your mouth? Asking me to send you back home. My dear, don’t tempt me!”

“I’m sorry, Chief,” I said, my head lowered. I didn’t have to be a soothsayer to know things had irrevocably changed between us.

“From this day forward, I don’t want to even see your face. Have your meals in your quarters and remain there until you are needed. Only when I have guests or I need you to accompany me out do I want to set my eyes on you. Is that understood?” he bellowed.

I nodded and curtsied again, my head still lowered. “Yes, Sir.”

He muttered under his breath as he ascended the stairs. I stood there until he disappeared from my line of sight, and I felt both angry and frustrated. I couldn’t understand why I was the only one bearing the brunt of his anger, while Akanna was still being allowed to live his life as normal. I also couldn’t understand why I hadn’t gotten a stronger punishment for my perceived affair with his son. Why was Chief still keeping me around, when he was clearly furious about Akanna beating him to my virginity? Was he simply bidding his time, delaying the inevitable?

I managed to sleep this time, but it was a fitful one, with me tossing and turning constantly, wondering what lay ahead for me, wondering if my days in the house were numbered, wondering how soon it would be before the plug would be pulled on Ahunna's treatment.

I didn't bother going down the next morning to greet him, neither did I have the courage to leave my room. My stomach rumbled with my hunger, as my boiled groundnuts were long gone. At that point, all I could do was plan my apology speech to my mother, explaining to her why our benefactor had turned his back on us.

"Kon kon kon," Uzochi said, mimicking a knocking sound as she peered inside my room. "I made you some lunch," she said, setting the tray on the table. From the aroma, I could tell it was fufu and vegetable soup.

I let out a long hiss, even as the smell of the food seduced me. I wished I was in a position to refuse the meal, but I was too hungry to.

"Nne, emejowo m gi? Have I offended you?" she asked. "This one that you're hissing."

"You've dropped the food, you can leave now," I retorted. "I'm sure all of you heard Chief insult me not only yesterday morning, but in the night as well. I'm sure I'm the talk of the kitchen, so don't come up here pretending."

Uzochi shook her head. "Adanna, you became the talk of the kitchen when you allowed Akanna just useless you like that."

"Useless me? Is that what you think? You who saw what he did to me that first time?" I exclaimed, stunned and confused by what I was hearing.

"I asked you to lock the door!" she retorted, walking closer to me in a fit of rage. "Akanna is an animal...a wild animal. Do you know how many little

girls he has attacked? How many young girls we have hired that he has driven away? I warned you because I knew something like this would happen. But when I saw that he had become a permanent fixture in your bedroom, I decided not to get involved.”

“So, if he has a reputation for this, why doesn’t Chief believe me? Why doesn’t anyone believe me?”

“Chief knows it’s true. He is very aware that Akanna attacked you against your will. That’s the reason he didn’t send you back to Onitsha first thing the following day,” she answered, before her face clouded. “But that doesn’t mean he can’t send you away tomorrow. By falling out of favour with him, your position here can not be justified for much longer.”

I was suddenly overcome with rage. Why was I the one being punished when I wasn’t even the perpetrator of the crime? “And nothing happens to Akanna? He just gets to continue with his life as normal, while I’m the one branded a prostitute?”

Uzochi smiled sardonically and shook her head. “*I na-ekwu okwu di ka nwatakiri*. You’re talking like the child that you are. Since when did women get treated the same as men? A man will steal all the fruits from a tree, cut it down and even burn it afterwards, but a woman will be stoned to death for just stopping to watch. You better wake up. That’s life for you,” she mused. “Adanna, maybe nobody has told you this, but Chief doesn’t take Akanna to play. Of all his children, he has the softest spot for him, and the way he loves him is the same way he fears him.”

She went on to tell me the story of Akanna’s mother, Chioma, who had apparently been Chief Arinze Nsofor’s first love, but who had been rejected by his family. “Ibe told me that Chief’s parents refused to pay her bride price. Even when she got pregnant with Akanna, they didn’t budge. Chief

decided to move her into the house in defiance, hoping they would one day change their minds, but that never happened. But from what I hear, Chioma herself was no pushover and gave it back to Oriaku, Chief's mother, hot hot. Neither of the women agreed to back down. Ibe says the house was always on fire, from sun up to sun down."

"But she left eventually?" I asked, echoing what I'd heard.

"She just disappeared. According to the story, Chief and his father had to travel for an extended period of time, to Lagos or somewhere like that," she shrugged. "By the time they returned, Chioma was gone. Oriaku said she left her child and ran away, but everyone knew that was a big lie. They said the woman loved the boy too much to have abandoned him."

I felt a chill envelope me. "Did Chief's mother harm her?"

"Nobody knows for sure. The last they saw of her, she was leaving for the market, on foot, early one morning, with just her purse, not even a handbag. She never made it to the market. The woman just disappeared into thin air. I wouldn't put anything past Oriaku. The woman was a terrible human being. Shortly after Chioma's disappearance, they arranged for Chief's marriage to Ifeyinwa."

"Apunanwu and Anayo's mother?"

Uzochi nodded. "Very beautiful girl, as I'm sure you've seen from the pictures. She was young, just like you, and everyone thought she was such a perfect match for Chief. Everybody except Chief."

"He didn't love her?"

"He didn't even like her. He merely tolerated her. It didn't matter that she was so beautiful, she wasn't the kind of woman he would go for. I hụrụ

Nkoyo? As big, fat and ugly as she is, that's the kind of woman he likes. Ifeyinwa, in all of her beauty, did nothing for the man."

All of a sudden, Akanna's words rang so audibly in my ears, he could have been back in my room, repeating them.

How soon will it take you to realize you are not his cup of tea?

Uzochi saw the question in my eyes and nodded. "Yes, Adanna. Including you."

It felt like all the blood had drained from my body, the realization that Chief had probably never been attracted to me, hitting me like a splash of cold water.

"So, why did he come for me? Why did he pay such a heavy price to marry me?" I asked, bewildered.

"Don't quote me, but I think he did that hoping to get the same kind of favour he had when he was with Ifeyinwa," was Uzochi's answer. "It was when he was married to her that his business started booming and his wealth multiplied. Yes, his father had been successful and already built him an empire, but being with a woman as beautiful and graceful as Ifeyinwa opened so many doors for him. She was the perfect companion to have at his side at all times, the one who courted for him favour from everyone they met. And now that the business isn't doing as well as before, my guess is that he was hoping you would do the same for him."

I just stared ahead, mouth agape, as all the pieces fell into place, Akanna and even Apunanwu's words making so much sense to me now. Nkoyo he had married for love, but she had obviously not fit the role he'd wanted her to.

“Akanna said Chief’s late nights are not from working till late, but that he has several concubines in the village,” I finally said. “Is that true?”

Uzochi looked away. “I’ve already said too much. Just use what I’ve told you to figure out the rest.” She rose to her feet but thought against it and sat down again. “Can I talk freely, Adanna? Can I give you the same advice I would give my younger sister?”

I nodded, desperately wanting to make some sense of this convoluted situation I’d been thrown into.

“If Chief throws you out today, your reputation is already destroyed. Word of your affair will precede you, and you will forever be known as the woman who slept with her husband’s son. No decent man will come for you again, and your life will be destroyed.”

I bowed my head, subdued by the weight of her words. She wasn’t lying. Leaving Chief’s house in disgrace would be catastrophic, not just for my reputation but for my family’s.

“Chief didn’t love Ifeyinwa, but she had a strong footing in the house. She had Oriaku’s full support, and by the time that one died, she’d already had children for the man. When she finally had Anayo, a boy, nothing and nobody could uproot her from this house, until death finally did. But you, on the other hand, you have nothing. Not yet.”

I looked at her, catching the undertone in her statement, and she looked away momentarily.

“You married Chief for a reason, Adanna. You came here to help your family. The worst is already done, and you can’t turn back the hands of time. But you can be wise and use some things to your advantage.”

“What exactly are you saying?” I demanded, my panic interweaving with impatience in a very bad combination.

“Akanna, Ada. Akanna is the only way your standing in this house can be secure,” she answered, looking me straight in the eye. “If he is still coming for you, don’t turn him away. Use your feminine wiles to hold him down. Once you secure him, nobody can throw you out, not even his father!”

I stared back at her, speechless, not trusting that I had heard her correctly. Surely, she couldn’t be suggesting I submit to Akanna? The same Akanna who had raped me mercilessly? That Akanna?

“Let me spell it out for you, nwa’m. That man is the real decision maker in this house,” Uzochi continued. “When Akanna was in university, there was a time he locked Chief in his bedroom and flogged him mercilessly all night. His own father. As the old man was shouting in his bedroom, the rest of us were crying downstairs, helpless. There was nothing anyone of us could do. And will you believe that the next day, it was Chief himself who swore everyone to silence. That story has not left the four corners of this big compound. It is too heavy for any of our lips. Akanna is dangerous. Apart from the fondness Chief has for him, he also fears him more than death. Akanna’s word is law. Even with him knowing nothing about the business and destroying anything he is placed in charge of, his father doesn’t do anything without his consent. I won’t be surprised if he was the one who even suggested your marriage. I can guarantee you that Chief will happily look the other way and carry on with his concubines, just as long as you can keep up appearances. It might even be better for you in the long run. Akanna only just turned 30. He is still a young man, and might even decide to marry you properly after his father dies.”

“You’re asking me to...to continue letting Akanna dehumanize me?”

“You can call it what you like, Adanna. I call it survival,” Uzochi retorted.
“I have said my own.”

By this time, I had heard enough.

“Please, leave,” I said, my voice quiet.

She hesitated for a moment, before rising to her feet. “Don’t discard my advice because you don’t like the sound of my voice. Think about what I have said, Adanna. Think about your mother, your sister. Think about how the disgrace will destroy your family if you’re to leave here in shame. Think about all that.”

“Leave!” I shouted, my body trembling.

She sighed deeply before finally shrugging, rising to her feet, and leaving the room.

I sat on the bed long after she had gone, reeling in shock, not believing what kind of sordid direction our discussion had taken. I had gone from being married off to a man forty years my senior, to being raped and battered by his son, to now being advised to allow the same son warm my bed while still being married to his father.

It was simply too much for my young brain to grasp.

That night, I had several nightmares, one after the other, almost all of which ended with Akanna violently raping me, while his father watched and laughed. By the time I awoke, I decided there was no way I would be a party to something so perverse. Uzochi was wrong, Chief was attracted to me. I knew what it was like to be admired by a man, and I definitely had seen in Chief that same admiration. What I needed to do was harness my relationship with him, instead of destroying it by continuing to bed his son.

I spent the next day planning all the things I would say to Chief that night. I planned to start by apologising yet again, and then giving him the foot and shoulder massages he loved. I would pamper him the way I had heard men liked to be pampered, and soon the unfortunate incident with Akanna would be long forgotten and a thing of the past. That was how I was going to regain my standing in his household, and not by taking Uzochi's absurd advice.

That evening, Chief's car pulled up much earlier than was normal for him; 8pm. I quickly rearranged my clothing and sprayed the vanilla body mist Apunanwu had sent from London. I half sprinted, half walked down the hallway, trying to reach him before he disappeared into his bedroom, but also trying not to over-exert myself. There was no point getting to him and spending the next few minutes trying to catch my breath.

But I was in for a nasty surprise.

I was midway down the stairs, when I heard a woman's laughter. I stopped, heard Chief's voice this time, but it was followed again by that same female laughter. And then I saw them; Chief and another woman.

He had started ascending the stairs, with the woman on his arm. Though not as tall as Nkoyo, they could have passed for sisters. She was broad, thick, and athletic. Her eyes were too large for her face, and her low cut hairstyle made her already full face look even fuller. They both stopped talking when they saw me, and for a moment, we all stood there looking at each other, only two rungs of stairs separating us.

As if controlled by an unseen being, I stepped aside, and they swept past as they continued their ascent of the stairs. The woman cast a curious glance my way, but Chief, my husband, did not even spare me another glance. Either I had been truly replaced as the object of his affection or he found no

more need to hide his extra-marital dalliances, neither of which was a good sign for me.

My time was almost up.

By the time Akanna returned that weekend, I had prepared my mind for the possibility of being sent away any minute. I had prepared to hear that funding for my sister's treatment had been terminated and that she and my mother would soon be dispatched back home. I had prepared to face the disgrace I would meet back home after news of my unfortunate marriage filtered back.

I was ready for anything.

But that evening, when I heard the familiar knock on my door, and I opened it to see that it was, indeed, Akanna standing there, I decided to choose survival. I let him in.

Chapter Ten

The New Normal

And so began my new normal.

Willingly submitting to Akanna didn't make the ordeal any easier. I'd thought that willfully giving him what he wanted would make him a little less aggressive with me, but that was not the case. Not at all. Instead, from the minute he walked into my bedroom every night, he was my predator...and I was his prey.

But as the days turned into weeks, I grew accustomed to it.

It became normal for me to have him saunter into my room anytime he liked. It became normal for me to be grabbed the minute he walked in, many a time without even bothering with conversation. It became normal for me to be kissed so forcefully, his mouth pressing so deeply into mine and sucking so rabidly, I was often left with painful sores.

I got used to being pinned down on the bed, sometimes even by my hair or throat, as he thrust away with reckless abandon. I got used to the agonising soreness between my legs, after accommodating his roughness multiple times every night. By the time he fell asleep each time, it felt like I'd been attacked by a wild beast. Which I guess was correct, as he was indeed a beast in the very true sense of the word.

I also learnt the hard way to keep my mouth shut.

On one of the earlier nights, as he pinned both my hands up above my head, I wondered why he still had to act like I was someone who needed to be subdued.

“You don’t have to hold my hands, Akanna,” I’d said to him. “I’m not struggling with you.”

The response I’d gotten was a blinding slap, which was followed by several more in quick succession, all of them so resounding I’d actually seen stars. Not releasing my hands, his thrusts had been more intense and frenzied, and I realised that seeing me in pain actually excited him more.

After that day, I never said anything unless I was directly addressed.

The good part of our arrangement was that he didn’t tarry in my room too long into the morning, and was usually gone before 7 am, leaving me in peace until his return later in the evening. Once he was gone, I would sleep soundly until about 10 am, go down for breakfast, and watch TV till about 5 pm when I would have an early dinner and disappear into my room.

I kept well out of Chief’s way and didn’t even set my eyes on him for the first couple of weeks. Considering the turn in his behaviour and the fact that he was no longer the loving man whose homecoming I used to look forward to, it suited me just fine. I would often hear the voices of his lady friends from my window, but I soon learned how to block out the noise. His affairs no longer bothered me.

Life soon assumed some semblance of normalcy. I slowly regained my sanity and resumed my friendship with Uzochi and the rest of the staff I’d befriended before. If this was to be my permanent arrangement, then it was something I had to learn to live with.

But I soon realised things wouldn't be so easy when one Saturday morning, after Akanna had left my room, Uzochi knocked on the door with a message from Chief.

“Ada, kulie,” she said. “Wake up. Di gi kwuru na i ga-adị njikere. Chief said you should get ready. You’re accompanying him to Ubulu-Uku for a wedding.”

I sat up, surprised by this instruction, especially considering his warning for me to make myself scarce.

“He said to ask you to wear that lace he bought you,” she continued, before giving me a knowing look. “I trust you to look your best.”

I understood her message loud and clear. If Chief wanted me to be his showpiece doll, then I had better look the part. And look the part I did. By the time I made my way downstairs, dressed in the rich Swiss lace attire his tailor had made for me in the early days of my arrival, bedecked in the heavy white and yellow gold jewellery set he had also gifted me, and with my face painstakingly made up in hues of gold and red, I knew that whatever role he wanted me to play, I would pass with flying colours.

But the old man didn't even give me a second look.

“Di'm, m na-ekele gi,” I greeted, with a slight curtsy.

He grunted in response, before walking ahead into the waiting car. Okeke smiled at me as he helped me into the passenger's side, and I smiled back. I could tell that, like the other domestic workers, he felt a lot of sympathy for me. My situation was a secret to nobody.

Not even Chief.

We rode in silence, with him reading his newspaper the whole time. Looking at him, I was certain he knew of my ongoing affair with his son.

The same way he knew I was all too aware of his own numerous trysts. But apparently, putting up a show with a beautiful wife at his side was more important to him. I knew better than to try to make any conversation, so I just kept my mouth shut.

It was only a 30-minute drive, but on getting to the venue, I immediately regretted wasting my beautiful outfit on such a local affair. Apparently, one of Chief's bakery workers was marrying off his daughter, and had made him the chairman of the occasion. We stood out like a sore thumb, with the villagers captivated by the glamorous Mercedes Benz, but even more so by the beautiful wife.

“Lee mmadu! Is that a human being or a spirit?”

“Chief, ị jisiri ike ooo! You are a very lucky man!”

I watched as my husband reveled in the praise and adulation and saw that, even more than his affluence and finery, he was taking much pride in their admiration of his beautiful wife. And I suddenly realised the power I wielded.

“I’m going to leave some money with Uzochi on Monday morning,” he said, as we headed back to Ojiji. “So you can get some more clothes. I will also give you some lace fabric you’ll sew for some other important occasions we have to attend soon.”

I had to stifle a smile from forming on my face. The worst was over. “Okay,” I answered casually. If this was our arrangement, then it suited me just fine.

Except it wasn’t that simple.

As we walked into the house, and I headed towards the stairs, Chief called out to me. “Come to my room in thirty minutes.”

I froze in my steps, shocked and not entirely pleased by what he had said. He didn't even bother repeating himself and swept past me upstairs. Getting to my room, I didn't bother with any elaborate preparation. After a basic shower, I wore one of my casual dresses and went to his room as instructed.

Upon getting there, I found him sitting on his armchair wearing only a towel, pipe in hand.

"Get in the bed," he ordered.

I did as I was told and had to look away as he disrobed himself. Even though it was nowhere near as rough and forceful as it was with Akanna, there was nothing tender nor gentle about the act either. When he was spent, he rolled off, got on his feet, tied the discarded towel round his waist, and walked into his bathroom. Nobody had to tell me it was time to make myself scarce.

Walking back to my bedroom, it was with a hollowness in my stomach that I realised I would also have to warm Chief's bed on occasion. The thought of subjecting myself to both father and son wasn't one that filled me with glee.

The silver lining came a few weeks after when a smug Akanna informed me that my sister's transplant surgery had not only happened but had been a success.

"So, because of our generosity, your peasant family won't have to bury another member," he smirked.

But not even his insult could taint my joy. I was beside myself with happiness. It made the sacrifice of my body, my dignity, my innocence worth it. I longed to be able to speak with my mother, to hear her tell me

how much better Ahunna was doing, but I knew I would be immediately shut down if I asked. So I didn't even bother asking.

The day after hearing the news, after Akanna left my room, I was unable to get out of bed. It felt like the whole room was spinning, and I thought maybe I was hung-over from the joy of the previous day. It had been so long I'd felt anything other than melancholy that the feeling of relief and hope had been alien to me. I managed to drag myself out of bed, have a shower, and make my way downstairs for breakfast. But the moment I lifted the lid of the bowl of fried yam and eggs, I felt all the food I'd eaten the previous day rise to my mouth.

"Are you not hungry?" Uzochi asked me.

I spat into my napkin and shook my head. "I think I ate something that upset me yesterday."

Uzochi looked at me keenly. "When last did you see your period?"

I stared back, surprised at the direction of her question until I realised that, truly, it was over a week since my period should have arrived.

Seeing my confused look, Uzochi shook her head and inhaled deeply. "O meela. It has happened. You are pregnant. What do you want to do, and who do you want to tell?"

I looked at her, confused. In addition to still having Akanna in my bedroom almost every night, Chief had summoned me to his room a few more times, meaning anyone could be responsible. But I knew that a baby was a definite means to get some legs in the house, and so I decided to take the chance and ascribe responsibility to my husband.

So that night, unsummoned, I went to Chief's bedroom.

“D’im, God has blessed us,” I said, the moment he let me in. “I am pregnant.”

He looked at me for a few moments, before bursting into laughter. “What do you take me for, little girl? A fool?” he said, as his laughter ebbed.

“Sir?” was my bewildered response.

“You open your legs nightly for my son, and you dare come before me to tell me you are pregnant?” he barked, all humour gone. “Pregnant for who?”

I stared back, my mouth unable to form a suitable response.

“I’m going to leave some money for Uzochi. You better do the sensible thing!” he retorted. “Now, get out of my room, and never come back without invitation.”

It wasn’t until I was back in my bedroom that it dawned on me what he was demanding of me; an abortion. In a fit of panic, I decided there was no way I was going to kill any unborn child God had deemed it fit to bless such an unworthy person as me. No way at all!

When Akanna came to my room later that evening, he was in a foul mood. “Where were you earlier? I came and you weren’t here.”

“I was upstairs. I went to see your father,” I answered, noting the same rigid set on his face anytime I had cause to sleep with Chief.

“I’ve told you I don’t want you going to his bedroom,” he sneered.

I shrugged. “How can I refuse when he sends for me? He’s my husband,” I patted on the space beside me on the bed. “Can you please sit down? There’s something I want to tell you.”

A wry smile slowly formed on his face. “Let me guess. You’re pregnant. And you’re thinking of pinning it on me.”

“Pinning it?” I exclaimed. “Who else would be responsible? Except for the days when I have my flow, you’re the only one who touches me.”

His slap sent me falling off the bed. “Will you keep quiet! Keep quiet, you prostitute! You open your legs for my father and I, and who knows, maybe even some of the servants, and you think you can accuse me of being the father of your bastard?”

I lay on the floor, not daring to move lest I provoke him into beating me some more. I could see the same rage I’d seen in weeks past, when he beat me to a pulp right there on the same bed. But my immobility wasn’t enough to prevent him from kicking me twice as he walked out of the room, for the first time losing his desire for sex. Lying on that floor, I made a decision. I was going to have the abortion.

The next day, Uzochi took me to a small clinic in Asaba, where it was confirmed that I was indeed pregnant. But a few short hours later, my abortion was complete. As we were driven back home, I felt an even bigger sense of shame, of despair, of emptiness. I had lost a part of me I didn’t even know I wanted. And it hurt like hell.

That night, I locked my door, ready to damn the consequences and face whatever would happen when Akanna came and couldn’t gain entry to my room. Thankfully, he didn’t come that night, and I was able to have a quiet night, meditating on what I had lost that afternoon.

But the next night, he did return, and he wasn’t as patient.

“Adanna, you better open this door!” he shouted.

But I was determined to stand my ground. “I’m still recovering,” had been my sardonic answer. “I can’t see you tonight.”

I don’t know what I thought would happen, but if I thought he would go back to his own bedroom, I was deeply mistaken. The door was suddenly kicked open, and a furious Akanna walked in. The first thing he did was to punch me in the face.

“You must be very foolish for that stunt you just tried to pull!” he shouted. “Telling me ‘you’re recovering’? Are you crazy?”

I couldn’t even get another word in, as in came another punch, followed by slaps and kicks. When he was spent beating me, he dragged me and threw me on the bed.

“I can’t do anything for at least six weeks,” I pleaded. “I’m still bleeding. You know I had an abortion...”

His slap silenced me, before he mounted me. I screamed as he penetrated my very sensitive area, and after he’d rolled over and fell asleep, I wept at the sight of my blood-stained thighs and bed...and the thought of my lost child.

I think that was the night I started to die slowly. That was the night I realised that there would never be anything ‘normal’ of my existence in that house. It was the night that the little ember of light I still had inside me was extinguished.

After that day, I moved around like a zombie, like a soul-less robot. I extinguished all my feelings, obediently submitting myself whenever Akanna came to my bedroom or when Chief decided on my company over his typical village women. I was past the point of caring.

Or so I thought.

Chief had been away for a few days, having travelled to Lagos for business. That particular morning, Akanna hadn't left my bed at his usual time but had just lain there, whistling away. He was in an uncharacteristically good mood, and I couldn't quite figure out why. But I kept my mouth shut and didn't ask.

"Aren't you going to ask why I'm still here?" he asked, a broad smile on his face. "You're not curious why I haven't left for Asaba yet?"

A glance at the clock revealed that, at 9 am, it was well past time for him to have left, but I simply shrugged in response. The only thing I was upset about was missing out on my morning sleep, but even that was something I could still make up for when he eventually left.

When I made to get out of the bed, he held me by the arm.

"Where are you going?" he demanded.

"I want to wear my nightgown," I answered, using the sheets to conceal my nakedness. Even though he had ravaged me so many times, I was still uncomfortable allowing him see me in the nude.

"I'm not done with you yet," he answered with a wink.

I lay back in bed, angry; angry with him for the humiliation I felt, angry with myself for being so helpless, angry with God for allowing all this happen. For how long was I going to continue this way?

"I'm expecting someone," Akanna continued, when he got no reaction from me. "I wonder what's taking so long?"

I sat up in bed, panicked. "You're expecting someone? Here?"

Just then, there was a knock on the door. I stared from the door to Akanna and back to the door, my anxiety rising. How could he have summoned

anyone to my room of all places? And he hadn't even had the decency to allow me cover my nakedness. Even though our affair was no secret, putting it on full display for whomever was at the door was the highest disgrace for me.

He rose to his feet and slowly started pulling on his trousers. "Come in," he bellowed, a wide smile on his face.

In hindsight, his behaviour should have tipped me off.

The door opened, just as Akanna was threading his belt, and as I lay staring ahead, looking like a deer caught in the headlights...a naked deer caught in the headlights.

"Welcome, baby brother," Akanna declared, beaming proudly. "I would introduce you to your father's wife, but I think you've already met."

I gasped in recognition. Standing at the door, his face also a mask of shock, was Anayo...the love of my life.

Chapter Eleven

The Other Son

“Adanna!”

It was a noun, a verb, and an exclamation all at once.

I looked away, unable to face him, unable to look at the pained expression on Anayo’s face.

“And there you were planning to drive all the way to Onitsha to see her,” Akanna chuckled. “Looks like you’ve been saved a trip!”

“You’re my dad’s wife?” Anayo’s voice conveyed every emotion he must have been feeling; shock, pain, disappointment, and confusion. “You’re the one who married my father?” He glared at Akanna before turning back to look at me. “And you’re sleeping with him?”

“Let me leave you two lovebirds to catch up,” Akanna sniggered, putting on his shirt. “I’m sure you have a lot to ‘talk’ about. And apologies, dear brother. I couldn’t deliver all those letters you sent to her, for obvious reasons.”

“Was this why you had me come to Ojiji before dad and Apunanwu? So I would see you with her?”

“Like I said, baby brother, I only wanted to save you an unnecessary trip to Onitsha,” Akanna answered, barely able to contain his satisfaction. “And I

wouldn't nurse any ideas of getting a share of the pie, if I were you. Dad and I have a difficult enough timeshare as it is."

Akanna's evil laughter rang in the hallway long after he'd left. If I had a knife, I just might have stabbed him in the chest, with a special focus on his vile heart.

"This has got to be a nightmare!" Anayo said, still transfixed to the spot. "This can't be real. Since I left home at the beginning of the year, all I've been dreaming about is returning to you. All I have thought about is you. All I have longed for is coming back home for you."

"Anayo..."

"And then I come home to see that you are the teenage bride my father has taken," he continued. "How could I have read you so wrong?"

"I swear, it's not what you think," I said, getting out of bed, using the bed sheet to cover my nakedness. "I had no choice. My father died, and my family was in debt, and my sister was dying. We were sinking when your father came with the proposition to help us but only on the condition that I married him. We truly had no choice."

"Is that right?" he remarked sardonically, his eyes hardening. "And what about my brother? What reason do you have for having him in your bed?"

I stared back, not able to tell him about the circumstances that had indeed led Akanna to my bed, unable to tell him how he had not only raped me but stolen my virginity, unable to say how I'd been forced to continue sleeping with him because of my fear of being thrown out of the house or, worse, my sister's treatment being stopped. How could I articulate all that into anything that was sensible to say?

But my silence proved detrimental.

“I thought you were an angel from heaven, a spotless jewel,” he finally said. “Do you know how many letters I wrote you while I was away? Forty-two. I literally wrote you a new one every week. I had them sent to Akanna, as he was the only one I trusted to give them to you,” his eyes hardened. “He’s been ‘giving it to you’ alright.”

My nostrils flared, and I found myself suddenly angered. I straightened and looked him in the eye. “Don’t talk to me like that!”

“I’ll talk to you any way I want, Adanna!” he retorted. “You’re nothing but a dirty prostitute. A dirty animal. A dirty rag.”

My fingernails dug into my palms in my fast escalating anger. How dare he just stand there and throw nasty words at me? He didn’t know even half of what I’d had to go through.

“Welcome home. I hope you enjoy your holiday,” I managed to say, before stepping back and shutting the door firmly in his face, locking it securely.

“Adanna! Adanna! Adanna, I’m not done talking to you!” he shouted, pounding on the door.

I ignored him and returned to my bed, pulling the sheets well above my head to drown the noise. I already had more than enough gloom to wallow in. I didn’t need to add another layer to it.

Eventually, the knocking stopped, but sleep could not find me, no matter how hard I tried. It was the cruel end to one of the fantasies I’d been secretly nursing; of Anayo, my love, rescuing me like a knight in shining armour. I used to dream of him coming home and being so angered by what his father and brother had done to me, that he would engage them in a duel, before whisking me away, far away from Ojiji, where we would live happily ever after.

Not in one of those fantasies had he caught me in bed with Akanna.

I knew his anger was valid, especially if he had been thinking of, and longing for, me for as long as I'd been longing for him. But the situation was what it was, and I was sick and tired of being branded the harlot responsible for it all.

Eventually, I drifted off into a deep, dreamless sleep, not rising until it was well past noon. I had a shower, dressed up, and went downstairs to see what I could find to eat. As much as I dreaded the thought of seeing Anayo again, I was not going to remain cooped up in my room because of him. I was ready to allow whatever that was going to happen with him being home for the holidays, happen.

"You're finally awake," Uzochi remarked, walking into the dining room. "Ahụ gị? How are you feeling?"

I shrugged, knowing full well what she was referring to but never again wanting to acknowledge it. The abortion was something I never wanted to remember, let alone speak of ever again.

"Do you want to eat something?" she asked. "We still have some akara from breakfast, but I could also dish you some rice I just boiled for lunch."

"When did Anayo get home?" I asked, wanting to know how I'd missed it.

She smiled. "You've met him? What do you think? Much better than that nasty Akanna, abi? Anayo is a darling of a boy. A real gentleman!"

"When did he get home?" I repeated my question, firmer this time.

She picked up on my tone and gave me a quizzical look accompanied by a shrug. "Late yesterday. He said something about Akanna asking him to get here so they could go somewhere important today. Chief and Apunanwu will return later today."

My mouth formed a grim line, the realisation that Akanna had set the whole thing up. He set it up for Anayo to catch us in bed red-handed and got exactly what he wanted.

Thankfully, Uzochi didn't persist, and when she left to get my food, I couldn't help but be angry with myself. Apunanwu herself had told me they would be home for Christmas, so I too should have been on my guard, expecting their arrival any minute. But I'd let my despondency not only let me lose track of time, but also make me sloppy. It would have been much easier justifying my marriage to his father, but explaining why Akanna and I were in bed together would be a very hard sell. But there was no more point in that.

After eating the very delicious meal of boiled rice and fish stew, I decided to return to my bedroom to read a book or something. But as I walked past the living room, a pair of strong hands pulled me inside.

"Anayo!" I exclaimed, glaring at him. "What's the meaning of this?"

"And you're here sauntering around the house like you own it," he sneered, his grip on my arm tightening. "Look how your skin is shining. You really are enjoying my father's money. Who would have ever thought you were such a viper? A money-hungry viper!"

I tugged at my arm, desperate to break free, but he held on tighter.

"You didn't struggle with my brother, but instead gave him a free pass to the honeypot between your legs."

I tried to wrestle my hand away, but he only just held on tighter.

"To think I had you right there before me but chose to be the perfect gentleman," he said, pulling me closer to him. "I could have slept with you

in that hotel, but I was there thinking you were this virginal prize I had won. A prize to be saved for later. What a fool I was!”

“If you don’t let go of me, I’ll scream,” I said sharply, glaring at him.

“Since you’ve been giving freely to every man in this house, I don’t see why I should be left out,” he grunted, pulling me closer. “That should be my compensation for waiting for you like a fool. I didn’t even look at another woman while I was gone.”

His lips tried to claim mine, but my reflexes were way too sharp for that. There was no way I was going to allow myself be taken advantage of by another Nsofor man. With my free hand, I slapped him hard across the face. Just as he held his face in stunned surprise, I heard a gasp come from the door.

It was Apunanwu.

“What on earth is going on here?” she demanded, looking from Anayo to me in surprise. “Why did you slap him?”

“She’s trying to act like the two of us don’t go way back!” he said, pushing me away and making me stumble.

“You two know each other?” Apunanwu exclaimed, looking, not at her brother, but at me. “Ada, is that true? You know Anayo?”

“I’m the last person you should be worried about,” Anayo retorted. “Guess where I found her this morning. In bed with Akanna, that’s where! The two of them stark naked,” he looked at me with so much contempt, it was difficult to remember him as the young man who had been so enamoured with me only a short while before. “I wouldn’t waste my time on her, if I were you. She’s nothing but an opportunist.”

He walked away, but Apunanwu kept her eyes on me.

“Tell me this isn’t true. Tell me all what he said are lies!” she demanded.

The thought of losing the only true friend I had in the Nsofor household filled me with dread. “Biko, Apunanwu. Hear me out.”

“Don’t touch me!” she yelled, as I made to hold her. “Jesus Christ! You were in bed with Akanna? You are sleeping with Akanna? Under my father’s roof? And Anayo – you knew him before? You and I were together for over two weeks, and you never even cared to mention that very important detail? I talked about Anayo all the time, but you just kept quiet as if you didn’t know who he was, yet you were sleeping with him before you married my father?”

“No, Apu. I swear it,” I pleaded. “You need to let me explain.”

“What do you want to explain? Jesus Christ!” Apunanwu exclaimed, looking at me like I was the eighth wonder of the world. “I was so wrong about you. I thought you were an innocent girl who life had happened to. I had no idea you’re just a common prostitute. Sleeping with a man and his two sons? You are sick!”

In that very moment, I knew I’d had enough. I stepped back, straightened my shoulders and looked her straight in the face, determined not to be disrespected, neither by her nor anyone else. Not anymore.

“Don’t insult me, Apunanwu!” I said, my voice firm. “You have no idea what I have had to endure. You have no right to call me names.”

“Lee nke a! You still have mouth to talk?” Apunanwu exclaimed. “You gutter girl! And to think I thought we were friends!”

“I thought so too,” was my unshaken answer.

She glared at me, the hatred she now felt oozing out of every pore of her body, before storming off towards the other wing of the house. Watching her go, I felt absolutely nothing. I had gone beyond the point of feeling distraught or devastated. Yes, it was unfortunate to have lost a friend in Apunanwu, but I hadn't come to Chief's house to make friends.

I noticed Uzochi standing at the door leading to the kitchen, and from the muffled sounds I could hear, the other domestic staff were also lurking around. They had all obviously witnessed the whole thing. But I didn't care.

"Please have the rest of my meals served to me in my bedroom," I instructed Uzochi, ready to eat in isolation for as long as it took for Anayo and Apunanwu to leave.

Uzochi nodded, her face downcast. With my head held high, I glided up the stairs. Upon getting to my bedroom, I locked the door firmly and looked around for possible weapons I would use in self-defense if Anayo tried to attack me there. Noting my bedside lamp, ottoman, transistor radio, and even the encyclopaedia on my coffee table, I decided they would have to do. Yes, circumstances beyond my control had made me submit my body to his father and brother, but I'd be damned if I would add him to my body count, no matter whatever love I'd felt for him in the past.

Thankfully, Akanna didn't come to my room that night either. I overheard Chief's voice and deduced he had returned to Ojiji with Apunanwu. I couldn't help but wonder if she would tell him what she had seen or what Anayo had told her about Akanna. Or maybe Anayo would even tell him himself. Yes, the old man knew about it, but who knew if hearing about Akanna and I from his other children would rub him the wrong way? To my relief, nothing happened that evening. I wasn't summoned to Chief's bedroom and, instead, slept like a baby that night.

The next day was the same. Besides Uzochi, nobody else came to my bedroom. But when this repeated again the day after, which was Christmas Eve, I started wondering what was going on.

“The house has been very quiet,” I remarked to Uzochi, as she placed my dinner tray on the table.

“They decided not to spend Christmas here,” she answered. “They all left for Lagos yesterday.”

“Even Akanna?”

Uzochi nodded, her face grim. She was clearly not pleased about this turn of events. “Yes, even him.”

Honestly, that was the best thing I had heard since my arrival in Ojiji. The next morning, I dressed up in my best and accompanied Uzochi and her young daughter, Daluchi, to the church in the village, where we worshipped and sang Christmas carols. It made me so happy and reminded me of happier times with my beloved father.

Upon our return, I accompanied them for Christmas lunch at her older sister’s house, which was an elaborate affair with almost all the women in their family gathered in the backyard, making pots and pots of delicacies. It felt just like home. For the first time since being in the mansion, there was no fear looming over my head like a dark cloud.

The wonderful feeling lasted for well over a week, but alas, on the fifth day of the New Year, Chief and Akanna returned. Watching them from my window as they disembarked from the car made my stomach drop, and hearing that all-too-familiar knock on my door that night even more so. Regardless, I was just grateful I’d been able to have a much-needed break from their tyranny, but unfortunately, it was now back to status quo.

The weeks turned into months, and Uzochi had cause to take me back to the clinic in Asaba a few more times. By the fourth time, the doctor insisted on fitting me with a contraceptive device. From the framed photographs he had on his desk, he had two daughters who looked to be around my age, which explained the firm set of his mouth each time I returned. Even though it was initially commerce for him, I guess seeing me return again and again must have been too much for even him to bear.

But everything proved to be worth it, as my mother and Ahunna returned a week before Easter. Chief got them a flat in Port Harcourt, to be closer to the clinic where she was to continue her post-operative care.

Words will never be enough to articulate how I felt when I saw her, after almost a year. Walking into her bedroom, she had actually risen to her feet and embraced me. Gone was the gaunt girl who had been knocking on death's door only a few months before. In her place was a vibrant girl with rosy cheeks and a bright smile.

“Adanna, you look so beautiful! Mommy told me you married a millionaire, and it shows. How does it feel to have a rich husband? Are you going to finish school? You know daddy wouldn't want you to drop out of school. What is your house like? Do you have plenty servants? Do they cook for you? Do they bathe you and pick out your clothes? Do they fan you when you're eating? No, I'm sure you have air conditioners. How many do you have? Is there one in every room of your house? Is there any in your kitchen?”

I had happy tears in my eyes, listening to her rattle on, back to her talkative self. My mother too looked so much better; well rested and peaceful. Even Jidenna looked happy. We'd been given the biggest gift ever. We had

Ahunna back, and anything that had happened to make it possible was definitely worth it.

“My daughter, you look radiant!” my mother remarked, when we were alone. “I’m so glad Chief is taking care of you well. God bless him for all he has done for our family.”

I nodded and smiled, but it didn’t go beyond my lips. Thank God I didn’t look like what I was enduring.

Chief hadn’t accompanied me to Port Harcourt, and as I was chauffeur-driven back, it crossed my mind to run away, to just push open the door of the car and run for dear life. The worst was over and my sister was in good health now. I had nothing more to lose.

But I found myself frightened at the prospect, wondering where on earth I would run to. To Onitsha, where I would never be able to hold up my head? To Asaba? Enugu? Benin? Apart from the fact that I knew nobody in any of these places, what if what lay ahead there was worse than what I was running away from?

And that was when it hit me, the sad reality that, whether I liked it or not, Ojiji was now the only home I had. I couldn’t survive anywhere else. Not anymore.

Chapter Twelve

The Sleepwalker

The sleepwalking started eighteen months into my stay in the Nsofor mansion.

The first time it happened, I'd fallen asleep in Chief's bedroom and awoken on the staircase landing, between his floor and mine. It wasn't yet dawn when I awoke, so I'd quickly made my way to my bedroom, to make it look like I'd decided to leave him early. The next time I wasn't as lucky, and I'd been awoken by Chief's kick. I'd fallen asleep on the staircase landing again, and he'd found me on his way downstairs.

"I bụ mmụọ ojọọ? Are you possessed or something?" he'd barked. "My friend, get off from the floor before the servants think I'm using you for money rituals?"

I immediately scurried back to my room, where I spent the better part of the morning thinking of what could have led me to venture out of his room, not once but twice. I immediately deduced that, since it only happened in Chief's bedroom, it was my spirit's way of rebelling against his company. The next time he summoned me, I did everything I could not to close my eyes, for fear of embarking on another unconscious, nocturnal stroll. But alas, sleep won in the end. This time, I was found on the kitchen floor by one of the junior cooks, who had let out a shrill scream upon seeing me,

thinking I was dead. The noise awoke me, and I guess the entire household, as they all rushed there before I had a chance to run away.

“You are what they call bad market!” had been Chief’s derisive taunt. “Why I have not sent you back to Onitsha is a mystery to me. Now your spirit people have started calling you at night. Biko achoghi m nsogbu o bula. I don’t want any trouble at all, at all. Just carry your wahala and stay in your room!”

After that incident, he never summoned me to his room again.

It was a huge relief to no longer subject myself to sleeping with him. It was an act neither of us enjoyed anyway, and I often wondered why he even bothered with me. Over time, I realised it was usually when none of his lady friends from town could make it to the house, or after I had accompanied him out and his head was over swollen with pride from all the compliments I’d received. Yes, he took a lot of pride in that. That was why I knew he never would send me back home, not even with what I was still doing with Akanna.

The admiration, lust, and desire he saw in the eyes of his peers whenever he was with me more than made up for it. It was no wonder why he’d eventually discarded Nkoyo. There was no way she could have elicited a fraction of the reactions I did. So, I knew that, until Chief found a more beautiful woman to flaunt, he was sending me nowhere.

Three weeks after the kitchen incident, and on one of the rare nights I didn’t have Akanna for company, I awoke and found myself on the corridor, right outside my door, wearing only my flimsy night slip. I scampered back into my bedroom and made sure to keep the door locked on subsequent nights. But it didn’t stop, not even in the confines of my room, as I would awake in my bathroom, the sofa or even the floor.

After a while, even in my unconscious state, I was able to circumvent my locked door and soon started venturing to different parts of the house. Soon, it was no longer novel for any member of the household to find me in any nook or cranny of the house. Not even on the nights when Akanna came to my bed did this stop.

“Ada, this thing can’t go on,” Uzochi said with deep concern, after I’d been found this time in the store. “You can’t continue like this. People have started gossiping, saying maybe you are possessed.”

As I too was desperate for a solution, I was happy to follow her to see not one, not even two, but three ‘spiritualists’ in town. All three came up with far-fetched reasons to explain my behavior; from me being at war with the other members of my coven, to me having a water spirit that was yearning to return back to its aquatic base, to me being summoned by a spirit husband. There was hardly anything we weren’t told. When I refused to participate in any of the ‘cleansing’ exercises being suggested, Uzochi decided I was too stubborn to be helped and let me be.

In time, even Akanna’s visits to my bedroom reduced, as he too tired of having to wrestle with me when I arose unconsciously at night. So, even though I had no cure for my sudden disorder, it at least rid me of my two predators, if only for a little while.

At the end of my second year, Akanna took a wife. Nobody was more ecstatic than I was, especially as he would now be based in Asaba, where he and his new bride, Tonia, were making their home. On their wedding day, I looked at the lady with pity, wondering if she had any inkling of the kind of beast she was giving her forever to.

A lady in her mid-twenties, her father, a retired police commissioner, was a well-respected man in the area. Though not wealthy, their family was very

well regarded. Light-skinned and painfully thin, she wasn't particularly pretty, and I couldn't help but wonder what the attraction to her had been. She had no personality at all and spoke in the most irksome monotone, unable to hold conversation for longer than a few minutes, not even with her new husband.

From the even way in which she addressed me, I couldn't tell if she'd heard any rumours about Akanna and I. To be honest, I really didn't care. I was just too happy to be finally rid of him. Thankfully, neither Anayo nor Apunanwu came for the wedding. I had seen neither of them since that unfortunate Christmas, and I wanted it to remain that way for as long as possible.

With Akanna out of the house and Chief having lost interest in me, I was finally able to relax. I took to gardening, transforming a small patch of land in the compound that, legend had it, Oriaku had used as a yam farm, into a lush garden full of beautiful, colourful flowers. As the years rolled by, it became my sanctuary, my happy place. On days when the weather was good, I would go there with a book, where I would spend my time reading and daydreaming. And on bad weather days, I would look at it from my window, admiring the scenic view of the flowers in the rain.

As for Chief, his rotation of women soon narrowed down to just one, a widow called Chiasoka. She wasn't like the others that he would sneak into the house at night. This time, she would even spend several days at a stretch. They were getting serious, and everyone could tell. But I wasn't worried. Not at all.

Chiasoka was a mountain of a woman and even more unattractive than Nkoyo. She looked like a wrestler, the kind of woman who would snuff life out of you with just one buttock. Her face was so big, it looked like it went

all the way down to her chest, and there was a lingering smell of fish and sour corn that followed her anytime she came to the house.

At the age of 22, I could now understand what Apunanwu had told me when I'd just arrived at the mansion as a young, innocent girl. But even though I understood it, I didn't quite agree. Chief had a type. He liked them masculine, unattractive and unrefined. If I was a betting woman, I would put a wager on Chioma, his first love, being the very same way.

"Nwunye anyi ekele m gi. I'm greeting you, o, our wife!" Chiasoka would often jeer, anytime she walked past me in the house.

I would often simply smile in response, uninterested in giving her any attention. I could tell that she was spoiling to engage me in a verbal, or possibly even physical, spar, but I couldn't be bothered. A sixty year old man? She was free to him.

She obviously knew I was nothing but a figurehead, a puppet of a wife. But I didn't care. Chief was free to do with anyone as he pleased. As long as it didn't disrupt my peaceful existence, I was fine.

As for my family, life could have been better. Thankfully, from what I was able to scrape from Chief, I was able to help my mother fund Jidenna's tuition to one of the state polytechnics. Ahunna's health, though not quite hundred percent, was a whole lot better than it had been before her kidney transplant. She was in her final year of secondary school, trying to write the necessary examinations to get into university. Chief had long stopped sending my mother any money, so it was only what I could put together that they were surviving on, that and the pittance she made from domestic jobs she was able to get on occasion.

Alas, anytime I visited them at home, I felt more and more like a stranger, so distanced from their poverty. It no longer felt like a place I had called

home for 16 years of my life, but somewhere I was eager to quickly vacate the moment I arrived. In the expensive cars that ferried me there, and my equally expensive clothing, I no longer belonged there. And after a while, even conversation became difficult as we barely had anything to say to each other.

“My beautiful daughter, *ogo m na-elekota gi anya*. My in-law is taking good care of you!” was my mother’s favourite phrase, which often made me even more resentful. Surely, after six years, she would have heard enough rumours to know I was anything but happily married.

In response, I would nod and offer a stiff smile.

With Jidenna, it was hardly any better. So close in age, we’d once been like twins, but now all we did was offer each other a perfunctory greeting. I could see in his eyes resentment, but I wasn’t sure if it was resentment over my perceived wealth or resentment for marrying Chief in the first place. After a while, I no longer even cared.

As for Ahunna, she never tired of grilling me with questions about my ‘castle’, as she called it. She had accompanied our mother only once to visit me in Ojiji and had remained obsessed with the place ever since. Unfortunately, talking about my ‘castle’ soon got tiresome, even if it was with my beloved baby sister.

My biggest regret was never returning to finish school. After all the drama of the first few years, I’d been too frightened to bring it up with Chief, and he’d never suggested it either. And with each passing year, I felt less and less inclined. The thought of peering with people growing progressively younger than me had no appeal whatsoever.

Generally, I had grown accustomed to my life. It wasn’t the best, but I had become comfortable with it. I wasn’t losing out on anything.

Or so I thought.

It was Christmas of 2003, the year I turned 23. As was our habit, I accompanied Chief for a society wedding in Owerri. The son of Dr. Nwabuwa, the owner of the only hospital in Ojiji, was marrying a girl from another esteemed medical family in Imo State. It had been just like any other high society Igbo wedding, but the moment I clapped eyes on the bride and groom, I knew I was missing something.

They were both extremely good looking, and I spent more than a few moments staring at the groom, Naeto. I could remember seeing him in church a few times in years past, mainly during festive periods. Lean, tall, and bespectacled, he looked like Ojiji's very own version of Clark Kent, nerdy but insanely attractive. His bride, Fuchi, was also tall and equally stunning. With her glossy dark skin, she looked like a supermodel. But that wasn't what enraptured me.

As the couple danced their first dance to a Stevie Wonder song, I watched as they looked deep into each other's eyes, mouthing along the words of the song. At a point, both their noses touched, and I felt an ache in my heart, longing for what they had. It was at that moment, that very moment, that I realised just what I had given up, what I had sacrificed. I found myself longing for that same kind of love.

On the drive back home, I hummed the tune of the song, still lost in the fantasy of what it would be like to love and be loved like that.

"Please stop that irritating sound!" Chief retorted, snapping me out of my reverie.

I smiled, so lost in my daydream that I couldn't even be angered. "It was such a lovely wedding, don't you think? Naeto and his wife make a lovely couple."

Chief gave me a sideways glance before chuckling. “Are you having any ideas? Hoping to one day find your own Prince Charming?”

I sat up, hating myself for being so transparent. “Of course not,” I lied. “Just stating the obvious, that’s all.”

“They are both medical doctors, did you know? From what I hear, the girl is razor sharp. She finished first in her class at UNN,” he said, a taunting smile on his face. “That’s how young men these days like their women; intelligent and well-schooled. Being beautiful is no longer enough.”

And he left it there. The devil of a man just left it there. He didn’t need to say any more words. He had clearly made his point.

The tune out of my head, I turned away and remained quiet for the remainder of the trip, hating him but hating myself even more, wishing I could be brave enough to just leave. He at least had Chiasoka waiting for him back home. I had nobody, and probably never would.

But those thoughts were soon to take a very secondary seat.

Driving into the compound, as we approached the house, there was a cluster of people gathered in front. I thought nothing of this, as it wasn’t unusual for Chief to have people waiting for him at any time of the day. But when I recognised, first my Uncle Mathias, and then my Uncle Cyprian, I had a sinking feeling in my stomach.

“What are you all doing here? Why have you chartered everyone from your village and brought them to my house? This isn’t a market square!” Chief barked, as he disembarked from the car. He had done away with niceties with my relatives a long time ago, and now regarded them the same way he did me, as scum of the earth.

“Ogọ’m, ana m ekele gi,” Uncle Mathias answered. “I hope your journey back home was fine.”

As I got out of the car, looking at my relatives, I recognized the look they had in their eyes. It was the same look Ike had when he and his companions came to see me the day my father died.

“Who is it?” I asked, my eyes already tearing. “Is it Aunty Uloma?”

My favorite aunt had been down with a strange ailment for over two years. The disease had ravaged her, making her a mere shadow of her former self.

Uncle Mathias shook his head. “Uloma is in a very bad state, but she is still alive,” he cast an imploring look at Chief. “My in-law, can we speak with you alone?”

“Look, I don’t have time for this nonsense. If you have anything to tell her, tell her yourself,” he retorted.

I was expecting him to storm into the house if he was as uninterested as he wanted it to appear, but instead, he remained there.

Uncle Mathias nodded in acceptance before turning to me. “My daughter, let us go inside. It’s not right for us to talk outside.”

“Biko gwa ya,” one of my other uncles chimed, clearly unimpressed with the reception they’d been accorded. “Tell her, so we can leave this place.”

“Uncle, who is it?” I repeated to Uncle Mathias, grabbing his hand.

He sighed deeply. “It is your sister. Ahunna passed away yesterday morning.”

I stepped back, as if he’d physically struck me. No, it couldn’t be so. Not my sister. Not the one for whom I’d sacrificed my whole life for in the first place. Not her.

It had to be a joke.

Chapter Thirteen

The Mourners

As the reality of what I had just been told sank in, I found myself feeling...nothing. Absolutely nothing.

In what must have been a sudden wave of conscience and sympathy, Chief led me into the house, closely followed behind by my visiting relatives, and I allowed him. I looked on as he asked them what happened and as they told him Ahunna had just slumped as she prepared to go to church for Block Rosary prayers. I just stared into space as my husband asked questions and my uncles responded. I couldn't say a word. I had no words; not on my lips nor in my head. Ahunna was dead. It seemed like a bad joke...a very distasteful one.

When my uncles left, it was Chief who saw them out. I couldn't even bring myself to rise to my feet.

"It's very unfortunate about your sister," he said, when he returned to meet me still sitting in the same position as when he left. "We will go to Onitsha tomorrow to see your family."

I looked up at him, my eyes flat. This had been the bait with which he'd caught me, and now it was gone. Or better still, wasted. Seven years, all for nothing.

“I suppose you’ll want to go with some of your things,” he continued, his eyes keenly searching my face for some kind of reaction, “to spend a few days?”

I shrugged and rose to my feet, walking away without another word. Once in my room, I locked the door and just stared into nothingness, Auntie Uloma’s words ringing in my ears. If we had listened, by now, yes Ahunna would have been long dead, but at least we would have definitely paid Coach off somehow. I would have finished school and maybe even made it to the university. Worst case, I would have learnt a trade and probably gotten married.

No, I definitely would have gotten married by now, with probably a couple of children running around my feet. But instead, I’d given it all up just so that my sister could live, only for her to still die in the end.

It was so pathetic, it was almost laughable.

One thing was perfectly clear. My time in the Nsofor household had come to an end. It was time for me to return to whatever semblance of life I’d had before this whole fiasco. By the next morning when Uzochi knocked on my door, I had packed all my bags.

“Nwa’m, I’m so sorry about your sister,” she said, holding me in a tearful embrace. “Your mother must be devastated.”

I nodded and shrugged. “She’ll be fine. We’ll all be fine.”

She tipped my chin up. “I know it is painful, but you have to be strong. Be strong for her,” she looked at my boxes. “Do you think leaving is a good idea?”

“I have no more reason to be here,” was my tart answer.

“Your sister had her surgery years ago, so if that was the case, then you should have left since,” she retorted. “Emela ihe ọsọ ọsọ. Don’t cut off your nose to spite your face. You need to make the years you have spent count. Don’t leave here empty-handed!”

I stepped back and carried the lightest of my bags. I would have been better off leaving empty-handed, instead of with my innocence and hopes for a future shattered to pieces. “I’ll ask Somto to come get the rest of my bags,” I said, referring to one of the junior house stewards.

I had my first wave of emotion as I swept past her, saddened by the abruptness of our parting. Even though we’d had our moments, Uzochi had been a mother figure to me over the years. But I couldn’t linger any longer. While, indeed, Ojiji had become home for me, could I really stay now that my sister had finally passed away?

Walking past the domestic staff, I nodded and smiled in response to their greetings of sympathy. I knew they all genuinely cared for me, and I was going to miss them, no doubt, but my time in the mansion was up.

Chief was waiting for me in the car, and there was a flicker on his face when I emerged with all my boxes. But he said nothing, and instead flipped open a newspaper to read. As my boxes were loaded in the boot, I took my seat beside him, somewhat reminiscent of the way we had sat when he brought me from Onitsha, seven years before. As we made our way down the long driveway, I felt saddened that it was my last time seeing the place. Even though it was not quite as pristine as it had been when I came, as a result of Chief’s declining wealth, it still stood regal and majestic, and I knew I would miss it very much. I felt a pang of sadness as we passed my garden, its flowers in full bloom. Somehow, it didn’t feel like I was going home...but leaving it.

The drive to Onitsha was a totally different one from the drive from it seven years before. It was an entirely different mood this time. Back then, Chief had been loving and attentive, but this time, we were both in our respective worlds; he lost in the pages of his newspaper, and me staring out the window the whole time, looking at everything...but seeing nothing.

Upon arriving at Onitsha, I was thankful that my mother had moved a few streets away from our former house a few years before, so the same people who had seen me leave weren't the ones to see me return; in mourning... and in disgrace. Being an even poorer neighbourhood than our last, Chief's ostentatious car was even more of a spectacle than it was in 1996. The white Mercedes had given way to a shiny, metallic silver Range Rover. Even though he wasn't as wealthy as he'd once been, he was still determined to always put up a show. His cars and his trophy wife always had to look the part, and look the part we did.

We made our way past the throng of mourners and well-wishers in the compound and up the crooked stairs that led to my mother's apartment. With Jidenna mostly in school, she and Ahunna had downsized to a small one-bedroom flat, which could barely even fit our immediate family, talk less of dozens of people coming to commiserate with her on the loss of a child. Thankfully, Okeke had the good sense not to lug my several boxes out of the boot, as that would have definitely distracted everyone, and not in a good way.

The moment my mother saw me, she let out a loud wail. "O laala ooooo! Adanna, your sister has left me, oooo!"

I thought I would break down upon seeing my mother. I thought the grief that had been eluding me would engulf me the moment I stepped into the house, but it didn't. Instead, I felt angry. Very angry.

But I knew I couldn't present myself as anything but a bereaved older sister of the deceased, so I walked across the room to hug her, holding her as she cried.

"Ogo'm, daalu," she tearfully said to Chief, after I led her back to her chair. "Thank you for everything you did for us. Nobody can say that we didn't do everything we could to keep her alive."

Chief gave her a small embrace. "Nne, gbasie ike," he said, patting her on the back. "Be strong. I can only imagine what it must be like to lose a child, and I'm sure you must be truly devastated. Try to be strong."

I looked away and saw Jidenna across the room, and in his eyes, I saw the same apathy that was in mine. He gave me the barest of nods to acknowledge my presence and continued attending to more well-wishers as they crammed into the tiny space. I didn't even know my mother still knew so many people. I spotted Ahunna's picture on a small table, and for the first time, tears, real tears, pooled in my eyes. Not only did it take me back seven years to when my father's picture had been mounted on the same table, it was the dose of reality I needed to let me know that my baby sister was truly dead.

Chief spent the next few hours playing the doting in-law, talking with guests and entertaining them with the drinks he had brought from Ojiji; several cartons of malt drinks and juice. He waited until the sun started to set, before having Okeke remove my boxes from the car.

"Take care of yourself," Chief said, pressing a fat envelope in my hand.

I watched him leave, and I didn't feel the sense of relief I thought I would. Checking the envelope, I saw that he had left me thirty thousand naira, which was generous on the one hand, and a mockery of all the years I had spent with him on the other.

“What’s all this?” Jidenna asked, as I dragged my boxes upstairs. “So many bags for only a short visit. Or has your millionaire husband had his fill of you?”

I ignored him, not trusting the words that would come out of my mouth. I tried to discreetly drag the boxes to the only bedroom in the house without rousing my mother’s attention, but failed woefully. Even though she said nothing, I saw the unspoken question in her eyes, which, the minute the guests had reduced significantly, was unspoken no more.

“Why did you bring so many suitcases home?” she asked, walking into the room where I had sequestered myself. “How long are you here for?”

“I’m not going back,” was my curt answer. “Ahunna is dead. Is there any real reason for me to return to Ojiji?”

“Chief is your husband, Adanna,” she said imploringly. “And he has been good to us.”

“Really? Even though he hasn’t sent you anything in years, and all the money you’ve gotten recently has been from me?” I retorted, not even caring about her feelings. “Do you truly think I have been happily married all this while? Do you really?”

Our eyes held for almost a full minute, before she finally looked away and exited the room. Sitting on the bed, I saw Ahunna’s multi-coloured bed wrapper and was saddened anew by the reminder that she would never again cover herself, head to toe, in the garish material. From a family of five, we had become three – and unfortunately, it was only the three jaded and beaten ones that remained.

The very next day, we headed to Ogidi to bury her. Apart from a few sentences, none of us – Jidenna, my mother nor myself – said much to each

other. We were locked in our individual worlds of guilt and blame. When we got there, we had to deal with a new set of mourners and were all grateful that her funeral was a lot quicker than our father's had been. But as simple as it was, even I was surprised by how quickly after it my mother wanted to return to Onitsha.

"Sitting in the village and crying won't pay the bills," she'd muttered. "And this one that Adanna has chosen to leave Chief to join us in our poverty, we can't afford to sit down doing nothing."

Neither Jidenna nor I could argue with that, so we'd all returned home. I hadn't even had the chance to see Auntie Uloma, who we were told was so sick, she probably only had days to live.

"O bu ara ya," one of my distant aunts had offered. "They say her breasts have gone so rotten, the decay has even eaten deep into her bones."

My heart crashed when I realised it was probably breast cancer that had metastasized. For someone as medically savvy as my aunt, I was surprised she'd let her condition degenerate that way. But who was I kidding? Where would she have raised the money for any expensive cancer treatment? I was almost certain that the way she had advised us to let Ahunna die might have been the same way she'd decided to opt for death, instead of giving her family the headache of raising money for treatment.

Our first night back in Onitsha, as I unpacked in the bedroom, Jidenna walked in. "I'm going back to school tomorrow."

I looked at him, surprised. We were only a few days to Christmas, and I knew school wouldn't be in session.

"I just can't stay here, Ada. It will eat me alive," he admitted. "Let me go back to Oko and hustle small. I still have one more session to go, and now

that you've left that man's house, I know money will be tight, not only for my fees but even for putting food in our stomachs."

I shrugged and continued packing, not wanting to be dragged into any guilt trip. Everything Chief had given me, I had spent in the few days we spent in the village, on one funeral expense after the other.

"Is it true?" Jidenna asked, and I was surprised to see him genuinely uncomfortable. "Some people around here have been saying some really awful things...about you also sleeping with his first son."

My head snapped up so quickly, I almost gave myself whiplash. "Who? Who's been saying that?"

"Everyone," he answered, unable to look me in the eye. "It started with Paulinus, Ejike and a few others in the market, before spreading to the old neighbourhood. They've been spreading rumours, saying you're caught in some kind of spiritual web between Chief and his son. Something about how the two of them sleeping with you is some kind of money ritual."

My mother walked into the room at that point, and I could see the same question in her eyes, which only enraged me all the more.

"So, you also heard?" I shouted at her. "You knew Chief and Akanna were abusing me, and you kept quiet about it?"

"I thought they were all rumours," was her nonchalant answer. "Besides, how can your own husband 'abuse' you?"

"You thought they were rumours?" I retorted. "Did you also hear that it was Akanna, and not his father, that took my virginity? Did you hear about how he raped me every night, beating me up black and blue? Did you hear how, for a long while, he and his father were exchanging me, like an overused toy? Were those also part of the rumours you heard?"

We were startled by the sound of Jidenna suddenly punching the door in his anger. “You mean they really did that to you? You mean all the ugly stories are true?”

“I was their sex slave for years, and no, it had nothing to do with any money rituals or anything as ridiculous. It was just father and son feeding their lust. It wasn’t until Akanna finally got married, and Chief met Chiasoka, that they both left me alone,” I answered, feeling suddenly mentally, emotionally and physically drained.

“Who is Chiasoka?” my mother asked, her eyes narrowed.

I laughed sardonically. “That’s Chief’s latest babe. There have been a steady stream of them almost right from the beginning.”

For some reason, this seemed to upset my mother more than my abuse.

“Heiiiiii! You mean that man came and took my daughter, just to make her an object of ridicule?” she exclaimed. “He has been flaunting women in your face? And he allowed his son sleep with you? Heiii, emechaala’m! I’m finished! And Uloma dọrọ m aka ná ntị! Uloma warned me, but I didn’t listen. If I had known Ahunna would still die in the end, I would never have given you to him. Now, look! Look how he has spoilt your life! If the story of you and his son is really all over the place, nobody will ever come for you. You will just die here, a spinster.”

I stood and watched as my mother cried, and as even Jidenna dabbed his eyes. My experience had saddened them both, and I was finally able to see that was what my brother had been hiding beneath his tough and angry façade all these years, his helplessness over my situation. But what was done was done, and nothing could change the past.

Jidenna decided against leaving the next day, and instead stayed until the New Year. We spent so much time together talking, it was almost like we were trying to make up for lost time. I told him all about the abuse I'd endured, and I could see him get more and more enraged with each sordid story. In a funny way, I derived pleasure seeing him angered by my experience and got the satisfaction of knowing that there was still someone very protective of me.

"Ada, don't worry. I'm going to take care of you," he always assured me. "I'm going to make sure I get a good job after school, to make sure you and Mom never suffer again."

For the first time since our father died, I actually felt safe. I was no longer worried about the future. I was confident everything was going to be okay.

Jidenna soon left for Oko, leaving just our mother and I in the small flat. It didn't take too long for us to start getting on each other's nerves. The space was just too small, and after the novelty of having me home wore off, she took over the bed, leaving me to sleep on either the floor or the worn sofa in the living room. Regardless of which option I had, sleep was a luxury in the house as, no matter how hard I tried to fumigate with our local sprays, it remained infested with mosquitoes and roaches.

During the day, my mother would go her own way, and I would go mine in search of work. Being that I was qualified for nothing and had no real skills, my options were limited. I would comb the streets and markets, in search of any kind of work, and before long, between walking under the hot sun and the nightly mosquito attacks, my once glossy skin soon became burnt and bruised. I even swallowed my pride and went to the district my parents' shop had once been, pleading with their former neighbours to employ me, even as just a shop assistant, but it was one story after the other.

“Ewo! Nwa Aloy! You’ve grown, o! I wish I had work for you, but market nor dey too sell!” was one person’s excuse. “Mbanu! You’re like a child to me. Your father was my good friend. How can I employ you? Ngwanu, were ego a. Take this money and buy something for yourself, o. Fine girl.”

All of them patronising, none of them yielding.

On my third attempt in the shopping district, as I was walking down the road, depressed after another failed day of job searching, someone called out to me from a passing car.

“Hello. I’m so sorry to bother you,” came a nice sounding voice from inside it. “I was wondering if I could give you a ride home. You shouldn’t be walking under this hot sun with skin as lovely as yours.”

I looked to see a good-looking man smiling at me. He looked to be in his late twenties, and from his crisp white shirt and pants, gainfully employed.

I looked at my skin that he was calling lovely, the same skin that been destroyed by the sun and insects, and wondered if he had gone blind. The neat Toyota Camry he drove, though an old model, looked air conditioned, and I decided I deserved to give myself a bit of a rest. So I agreed to his offer.

As we journeyed to my house, he introduced himself as David and told me he had relocated to Onitsha from Abuja, to help his father set up a hotel. Our conversation flowed, and from the keen look I saw in his eyes, I knew he was interested in me. By the time he dropped me at home, I was more than interested in him as well.

“Goodbye, beautiful Adanna,” he said, holding my hand. “I really enjoyed chatting with you. Can we have lunch tomorrow? I would love to take you out, so we could talk some more.”

I smiled at him, hopeful and keen. "I'd like that."

"Who was that?" my mother asked, when I walked inside the house.

I was so excited, I couldn't contain my smile. "His name is David. I met him in the market. He was buying supplies for his father's hotel."

My mother smiled, also hopeful. "He's very handsome, o! Biko jide nke a! Hold this one tight, o!"

I giggled like a schoolgirl and proceeded to daydream about him the rest of the day and almost all night. The next day, I selected one of the nicer dresses Chief had bought me, and expertly applied my makeup to make me look my best. By 2 pm, I was more than ready for our date. But 2 pm soon became 3 pm, and then 4 pm. By the time it was 5 pm, I knew he wasn't going to come.

"Maybe he had an emergency," my mother postulated.

I nodded in agreement but, deep in my heart, I knew. And my hunch was confirmed when I saw him again a few days later, walking along the shop corridor close to where we'd met. I called out his name and waved, and when he turned to wave at me, his was less than enthusiastic.

"Hey, David," I said, walking up to him, still beaming. "What happened the other day? I waited for you."

Without even cracking a smile, he shrugged. "I was very busy."

"Oh. I'm sorry about that." Why I was apologising, I had no idea. "I'm free now, in case you want to grab a drink or something." I said, still holding to faith.

"I'm afraid I have to go now," he said, giving me a curt nod. "Take care, Ada. It was nice meeting you."

I watched in shock as he rushed off, and when I looked in the direction of where he'd been coming from, I saw two familiar traders looking at us and whispering.

That was when I knew. I knew that my inability to get a job had nothing to do with the men unwilling to hire my father's daughter. I knew that David's sudden loss of interest had nothing to do with him being too busy. I knew then that news of my dalliance with Akanna had truly found its way to my hometown. I knew that my reputation was truly in shambles.

Dejected, I walked the long distance back home, my heart and spirit broken. Getting back to the house, I struggled to open the door and soon realised in frustration that it was locked from inside. I pounded on it, wondering what my mother was doing to make her lock the door, and why she was even home in the first place.

I was soon to find out.

After several minutes of hard pounding, the door opened to reveal her looking dishevelled. "Do you want to break the door? And why are you back so soon?"

"Mommy, please let me just come inside," I said, trying to push past her. "I've had a very hard day, I just want to lie down."

To my surprise, she blocked me from gaining entry. "You have to come back later. I'm busy now."

My eyes widened as I realised what was really happening. "Do you have a man inside?"

"Ugochi, onye nọ n'ọnu ụzọ?" came a deep voice from inside.

"It's nobody. Give me a minute," she answered, closing the door behind her as she pushed me into the dark corridor. "I said come back after a while. Do

I have to spell it out for you?”

“Who is that man?” I demanded. “I thought you said you were going to town to work.” And then realisation hit me. “Don’t tell me this is your work!”

I had never truly known exactly what kind of domestic work my mother engaged in, and seeing her in an unkempt state, a wrapper hastily tied around her body and her hair bedraggled, helped me put together the missing pieces of the puzzle.

“Don’t you dare look at me with judgemental eyes! You’ve seen how hard it is to get any work in this town. How do you think I’ve been able to take care of the family, with the pittance you used to send me when you were still with Chief?”

My mouth dropped open as I looked at the stranger standing in front of me, a stranger I had called mother.

“Please close your mouth there! You’re a woman like me. You did the same when you were in Ojiji! Or wasn’t it for money you slept with both Chief and his son? Please just leave and come back later, and try not to come home unannounced next time.”

I stood motionless in the hallway, long after the door was shut. She was right. For whatever reason I consented to throw open my legs for father and son, whether or not it was to save my sister’s life, it had been a form of prostitution. I really wasn’t better than the woman I was judging. I was just like her, if not worse.

Standing there, I made the decision to return home...to Ojiji. There was nothing left for me in Onitsha. My reputation was in shreds. I would never

be able to find a husband or any means of livelihood. It was better for me to go where I still had a place.

I waited in the hallway until my mother's guest left the house, and I recognised him as one of the mourners in the house when Ahunna died. I could only wonder how many of such 'friends' the woman had. Upon getting to my room, I started packing my bags.

"You're going back?" my mother asked.

I nodded, and she said nothing in response. It was almost like she'd been expecting it, maybe even hoping for it. At the crack of dawn the next day, I was on the first bus to Asaba, from where I got a taxi to Ojiji.

The excited way the guards at the gate greeted me when the taxi got to the ranch made me know I hadn't made a mistake coming back, after four long months away. My heart jumped at the sight of my garden and the peacocks strutting around. This was definitely home for me.

I was surprised to see Chief standing outside the main door, hand in hand with Chiasoka. Not only because it was unlike him to be home so late in the morning on a weekday, but because he was still with her. He hadn't been exclusive with any of his concubines, and it looked like this was different from all the other dalliances. In turn, they both stared in equal surprise as I alighted from the car, all my luggage in tow.

"Adanna!" Chiasoka exclaimed.

"You're back," Chief half-stated, half-asked.

That was when I realised I might have also lost my place in the ranch after all. What if Chiasoka, ugly as she was, had taken my place? Moved into my bedroom? Assumed my responsibilities as Chief's wife?

“Yes, I am,” I answered, looking the man in the face, daring him to ask me to leave.

But he didn’t. “Very well. Your room is waiting for you,” he said with a nonchalant shrug. “You should have given us notice, so the maids would have cleaned it up for you.”

Ignoring him, and with my head held high, I dragged my boxes in as they both watched me. I had gone past the stage of caring.

“Let me get someone to help you with those,” Chief finally said, walking past me into the house.

“Nwunye anyi, nnọọ o! Welcome home, our wife!” Chiasoka said, her words dripping with sarcasm.

I didn’t even spare her another glance, her mockery having no effect on me. I was back home, and that was what mattered.

Chapter Fourteen

The Return Home

It felt so good to be back home. How ironic that the place I'd considered my prison only recently, was now my sanctuary. My first night back in Ojiji, I slept like a baby, luxuriating under the cosy sheets in the air-conditioned room. I was so comfortable it almost brought tears to my eyes. Ojiji was now my home, and I no longer felt bad about that.

Reuniting with Uzochi had been another highlight. She'd leapt on me like we'd been separated for years, and not just a few short months. Thankfully, there was no 'I told you so' from her, and I appreciated that. I didn't need to be reminded of the fact that, despite my fierce determination to leave, I'd returned to the mansion, tail between my legs.

The rest of the domestic staff were also happy to have me back, and it didn't take me long to settle back into my normal routine of sleeping, eating, watching TV, reading, and basking in the beauty of my garden. How could I have ever thought life would be better for me in Onitsha?

The only downer was that my sleepwalking soon returned. Strangely, I didn't have any incident in Onitsha. Not even one. On no occasion at all did I wander away from my sleeping position at night. I always awoke exactly where I'd fallen asleep. My theory was that sleeping uncomfortably had

kept it at bay, and now that I was back to sleeping like a queen, my body was relaxed enough to continue playing its silly games.

But it was a small price I was happy to pay to be back home.

So comfortable was I that I even stopped hiding when Akanna visited the house. After he married, I was so relieved that I wouldn't have to endure his abuse that I'd ensured I made myself scarce anytime he came to Ojiji. I figured the less interaction we had, the better.

As for his poor wife, the few occasions she accompanied her husband to visit with their growing family, I saw the light in her eyes extinguish a little more each time. Even though she hadn't had much of a personality to begin with, Akanna's domineering nature soon completely overshadowed hers. Just like he'd done with me, he'd succeeded in breaking her. Before she did anything or even spoke, I would see her look at him, almost like for permission or validation. He had gotten the very type of wife he wanted. It didn't help that she was almost always pregnant. Their four years of marriage had already produced three sons, and I had a hunch they weren't done yet.

But it was not my problem. And with my return to the mansion, I no longer felt any need to fear him. There was no more reason to. With Ahunna dead, I didn't have much to lose either way.

"Ada, Ada," he chimed as he walked into the dining room one morning, while I was having breakfast. "I didn't believe it when they told me you were back from Onitsha. Apologies about your sister."

I shrugged, not wanting to engage him in any conversation. Even though I no longer feared him, it didn't mean I wanted to chat with him either.

He took the seat beside mine. “It’s been so long that we’ve had any privacy to talk. Anytime I come here, you’re always suddenly busy. One would think you were deliberately avoiding me.”

I looked at him, my former predator, and had such a sense of pride at the realisation that he no longer had any power over me.

He leaned closer to me. “I’ve missed you,” he whispered, his breath hot on my neck. “Sometimes I lay down at night, dreaming of your body. You know, if I want you, you’ll have no excuse not to give in. With my dad getting closer to that village woman every day, your days here might be numbered. If that happens, you’ll need my help, and you know that.”

I sniggered and shook my head, very amused. “I don’t need your help for anything, Akanna. The worst that could happen is that Chief will throw me out, and I’ll be back on the streets. I might not have liked it, but if I have to return to Onitsha, it won’t kill me,” I looked him in the eye, brazen for the first time. “Try again.”

He looked at me, tongue-tied, and I suddenly wished I’d been this brave when he was bullying me in the past, blackmailing me with my sister’s treatment.

“I can still have you if I want to, Adanna. Make no mistake about that,” he sneered, recovering himself.

Looking at him, I realised that I could use his desire for me to my own advantage. I clearly had what he still desired and could use that to help myself.

“Yes, you can. But it will cost you,” I answered, maintaining eye contact with him.

“Cost me what?”

“Nothing goes for nothing, Akanna. For every time you want to be... entertained by my company, you’ll have to pay.”

He looked at me, shell-shocked for a few moments, before bursting into incredulous laughter “So, you’ve become a prostitute? You want to exchange sexual favours for money. I can see that the few months you spent in Onitsha have opened your eyes to the ways of the world. I guess like mother, like daughter after all.”

Now that was a shot that hit its mark, and I glared at him, angered by the correlation drawn between my mother and I. Pushing my plate forward, I rose to my feet and walked out of the dining room, thinking how I’d made a mistake remaining in his company in the first place.

I hadn’t been back in my room for thirty minutes, when there was a knock on my door. Opening it, I was taken aback to see him there.

“This new feisty behavior of yours is a real turn on,” he said, grabbing me.

I lingered for a few seconds, just to give him a feel of my body, to remind him of what he’d once had unfettered access to, before pulling away from him. “You need to leave.”

He grabbed me by the shoulders and pushed me to the wall. “I don’t need your permission, Adanna. And I don’t need to threaten you with anything either. If I want you, I’ll have you, and there’s nothing you can do about it.”

His aggression took me back to the early days, and I realised the fear I thought I’d banished was actually still lurking in the background. But I was determined not to cower before him.

“You are very funny,” I chuckled, when inside I was quivering like a leaf. “Lay a hand on me, and I will go straight to your father-in-law and tell him everything. I will show him my wounds. After that, I will go straight to the

police. They might fear you in this house, but by the time law enforcers see what you can do to a woman, let's see if you don't spend some nights in jail!"

He released me and stepped back. Frankly, I hadn't thought it would be that easy to scare him.

"What do you want?" he asked, his eyes clouded by desire...and I knew I had him exactly where I wanted.

I let him sleep with me that morning, and again the next time he came to the house, which, no surprise, increased in frequency. In exchange, he gave me money. Sometimes, like that first time, it was a lot, and other times it wasn't. But it was enough to put something in my wallet, without being overly dependent on Chief. Yes, sex with him was still more aggressive than was desirable, but at least this time, there was a pay off for me.

A few months into our renewed dalliance, I knew most, if not everyone, in the house knew what was going on. But thankfully, there were no confrontations about it; not from Chief, not from Uzochi, and obviously not from Tonia, Akanna's wife. Maybe because it had gone on for so long in the past, it was almost accepted as normal. And I guess it was. Normal.

What wasn't normal though was Chief's new lady love. Over time, he had relegated Chiasoka to being his companion only during the day, when she would saunter around the house like she owned it, dishing instructions to the staff. Chief had cleaned her up, so she no longer looked quite as dirty and unrefined as she used to. But that wasn't even the bizarre part of the situation.

One evening, I noticed him with another woman, a much younger woman this time. On the one hand, I was happy that Chiasoka's monopoly on the

old man had come to an end, but on the other hand, I couldn't help but feel threatened by the fact that his new woman looked almost as young as I did.

She was very tall, over six feet, and even though she also wasn't particularly pretty, she had more refinement than was the norm for his courtesans. As she walked into the lobby with him, she strutted like a beauty queen...a super model. She had a whole lot more confidence than was commensurate with her looks, so much so that one could even be deceived into thinking she was better looking than she really was.

She came home with him most evenings, spent the night, and left first thing in the morning. Then later in the morning, at about 9am, Chiasoka would arrive, and she and Chief would spend time in his bedroom, before leaving together for the bakery in Asaba. He no longer went there as early as he used to, and sometimes didn't even go at all. But as threatened as I was by his nighttime girlfriend, I couldn't help but admire the effective timeshare he had with his two mistresses.

Until I found out the shocking news that the younger woman was Chiasoka's daughter, who was barely out of her teens.

"Eziokwu?" I exclaimed when Uzochi gave me the scandalous piece of information, as we watched the young girl catwalk out of the house in the early hours of the morning. "You don't mean it!"

Uzochi let out a long hiss, barely able to contain herself. "These men are beasts! It almost makes me believe the rumour that they are doing it for spiritual reasons. If it's not father and son sleeping with the same woman, it is mother and daughter sleeping with the same man!"

She went on to tell me how she knew Chiasoka from the village, and even knew when she had Isioma, her only child. "I know them very well. That's why when that useless Chiasoka comes here, raising her shoulders, I just

look at her, wondering whom she's trying to exercise authority over, because it's clearly not me. I knew when she married her late husband and how she struggled to have Isioma. I know them very well," she shook her head, her upturned nose an indicator of her disgust. "Isioma just got into the College of Education in Asaba. I hear that is one of the reasons Chiasoka has been following Chief, to be able to pay for her daughter's education. I'm sure she doesn't know the man is getting his repayment from the two of them."

"Heiiii!" I exclaimed, unable to believe what I was hearing, and when Chiasoka showed up shortly after, I couldn't help but stare at her, wondering if she really didn't know what was happening between her lover and her daughter. But she was as oblivious as ever, her loud voice reverberating around the house as it typically did. And when she walked out of the house later that morning, arms interlinked with Chief's, I couldn't help but cross my own arms over my chest in amazement, as old women would typically do. If what Uzochi had said was true, then it was the most bizarre thing ever.

That evening, when Isioma returned, looking at her, I saw that, indeed, this was Chiasoka's daughter. They both had the same large face, wide eyes, and overbite, but Isioma was clearly the younger and slightly better looking version. I watched her disappear upstairs with Chief, my mouth agape as I beheld the spectacle that it was. In fact, it wasn't just a spectacle, it was a downright circus.

By the second month, I was convinced that both women had to know about each other. There was no way they could be in the dark about their dalliance with the same man. There was just no way Chief could have been juggling

them so efficiently for so long. The longer it went on for, the more convinced I was that both mother and daughter knew what they were doing.

I was in my garden one afternoon, just as Chief and Chiasoka drove out. As I did every time I saw them together, I remained rooted to the spot, gaping at the car as it made its way to the gate, still floored by the soap opera playing out before me.

“It’s disgraceful, isn’t it,” came a voice from behind me.

I turned around to see the young gardener who’d been recently hired. I had never given him a second glance before, and was suddenly struck by how good-looking he was up close. But he wasn’t good looking enough not to have any respect for my husband. Uzochi, I could gossip with, but not him, some random, domestic staff who might not even be there the next day.

“Excuse you,” I retorted.

He immediately realised his mistake and gave me a curt nod. “Apologies, Ma.”

As he walked away, I couldn’t help but check him out. Tall and very well built, he looked like he belonged in a body building competition. I was suddenly regretful of silencing him, wishing instead that I’d listened to him. He might have even had some juicy information about Chiasoka and Isioma that I would have loved to hear, and now I would never know.

When I returned to my bedroom, I watched him from my window, his sweat glistening on his glossy ebony skin as he worked under the sun. At a point, he looked up and our eyes held. He waved, and I briefly contemplated shutting my window blinds and ducking so he wouldn’t see me. But instead, I waved back, eliciting a smile from him, a perfect smile revealing deep dimples running down both sides of his face.

“Who is that new boy I saw mowing the grass?” I asked Uzochi casually, as she dished my dinner that evening.

Her brows furrowed before she finally realised who I was referring to.

“Oh, you mean Chizutere?” she laughed. “We hired him about a month ago. The grass was looking too unkempt, and the boy needed the money. I know his family; very decent and hardworking. He said he’s trying to save money for university.”

Saving for university. Interesting. This gave him several points in my book. A good-looking, sexy man with ambition...there was everything to like about that. Everything.

Chapter Fifteen

The Gardener

After a long bath, I applied my makeup very meticulously and wore a long, floral summer dress that flattered my body without making it look like I was trying too hard. Getting downstairs, I had my breakfast packed into a small basket and went to my garden with a book, under the guise of having a solo early morning picnic. But the truth was that I was eager to see Chizutere again.

I sat out there for over an hour before I considered that he probably wouldn't be at the ranch that day, and proceeded to eat my meal. The next day, I was also on the lookout for him, but just like the day before, and in the days that followed, he was nowhere to be found. With a sinking heart, I realised he might have been let go, or maybe he'd decided he wasn't cut out for that kind of menial work.

I was surprised by how upset both possibilities made me, for a man I barely even knew. Absolutely nothing could come out of any 'friendship' with the gardener, of all people. He was also probably just a teenager. What was I even thinking?

A few weeks passed, and I'd already forgotten about him when he finally resurfaced. I'd been uprooting weeds from my garden, when I felt a shadow loom over me.

“Let me help you with that,” came the velvety voice I’d replayed in my head over and over in weeks past.

I looked up at him from the brim of my straw hat. “Nobody touches this place but me. I hope you haven’t been doing anything here.”

Why that was the first thing I thought to say to him beats me to this day.

“No, not at all,” he said, throwing his hands up. “I was told the moment I started working here that this place is off limits. I only offered to help when I saw you struggling with those weeds.”

“I’m fine, thank you,” I muttered, looking away but not before catching sight of his beautiful dark body, barely contained by the worn singlet he wore. “Did you travel?” I found myself asking, my curiosity getting the better of me.

He smiled, revealing perfect white teeth. “Yes, I did. I went to Jos to see an uncle of mine.”

“I hear you are saving to go to university. Was it anything about that?” I asked, looking up at him, trying to prolong our conversation.

He smiled again, obviously pleased by my interest. “Yes. The factory where he works was looking for casual workers, and he thought I could make some good money.”

“And did you?”

“I did. Even more than I thought would be possible in three weeks,” he answered. “I made more than what I could make here in six months.”

“So, why did you come back then? Why didn’t you just stay there?”

“They only needed temporary relief workers,” he answered, with a sad shrug. “But my uncle says there will be permanent positions opening soon,

and he'll let me know when they do.”

“Good,” I said, looking away in what I hoped was a dismissal. I had spent too much time chatting with him and didn’t want him getting any ideas.

Or did I?

“I’ve been saving for the past three years since I left school,” he continued, obviously not wanting our conversation to end either. “Every time I save enough, something happens, and I have to use the money to support my family. Money is not always easy to come by for my parents, and I have younger ones still in school.”

I immediately felt empathy for him; empathy and kinship. I knew too well what it was like to sacrifice for family. I was also aware that if he left school as recently as three years before, that put his age at anywhere between 19 and 21. Too young for me.

“You still need to keep something for yourself,” I said to him, meaning it. “There will always be family issues, and you can easily spend every dime you make supporting them. You need to think of yourself. The money you made in Jos, I hope you haven’t done anything with it.”

He shook his head.

“Good. Keep that. Add that to whatever little you have already. Before long, you would have saved enough.”

“Thank you. I’ll be sure to do that,” he answered, beaming happily.

The next day, I went to the garden with hopes of seeing him there, and this time, I wasn’t disappointed.

“Thanks for yesterday’s advice,” he said when he saw me. “I went to deposit the money in my savings account after we spoke yesterday. From

now on, there is a minimum percentage of the money I make that will be deposited there.”

“You have a bank account?” I asked, surprised that a local boy like him would have one, while I was still storing my own money in an old cookie tin container in my closet. Nobody had ever deemed it fit to open one for me, and I’d never asked either.

“Yes, I opened it a few years ago, the year before I finished school. It hasn’t really been active as I hardly have enough to make any deposits, but all that will stop now.”

On another occasion, I asked him, “What school are you saving towards, and what do you want to study there?”

“Before I travelled, I would have told you DELSU, UNIBEN, or even Auchi Poly,” he answered. “But I’ve fallen in love with Jos, and I wouldn’t mind going to the university there. There are also several factories apart from the one where my uncle works, so I’m sure I could get part-time work while also running my program. As for what I want to study,” he continued, smiling wistfully. “Electrical Engineering.”

This prompted a smile from me. “When I was younger, I thought I was also going to study engineering too. Aeronautical Engineering, mind you. I dreamt of one day working in NASA.”

“NASA, really?” he exclaimed, and I was impressed that I didn’t even have to explain to him what NASA was. “Are there any universities in the country that offer that as a course?”

“The plan was to get a scholarship to study in an American Ivy-League university,” I answered with a wistful smile of my own. “MIT, to be precise.

If anyone had told me I wouldn't be a space engineer, but would instead end up in Ojiji, planting flowers, I wouldn't have believed it."

His smile dimmed. "Forgive me for being forward, but what led to you coming here? What led to you marrying a man old enough to be your grandfather?"

I knew I should have been offended, but instead, I found myself wanting to talk about it. "I guess the same thing that has prevented you from saving for school. Family obligations," I answered, before telling him all about my father's death, the loan shark that had been after us, and my sister's illness.

"I'm so sorry. You've really been through a lot," he said, the sorrow he felt for me in his eyes. "But if your sister eventually died, why didn't you just leave?"

I chuckled and shook my head. "How old are you, Chizutere?"

His eyes flickered, and I could see him wanting to tell a lie, before finally deciding against it. "Twenty," he reluctantly admitted, before quickly adding, "but everyone tells me I'm mature for my age."

"When you're older and wiser, you'll be able to answer for yourself that question you just asked me," was my patronising response.

But back in my bedroom, I couldn't help but ponder over that very question. Yes, I could answer that my inability to find work and my destroyed reputation had been what led me back to Ojiji and that I no longer felt at home in Onitsha, but were they really and truly enough reasons for me to have come back here to this life...this life of nothingness?

Here was a young man like Chizutere, working towards getting an education and living a more meaningful life one day, and I was content to spend my days eating, reading novels, and being a glorified prop. The truth

was I was wasting away my life. A woman without so much as a bank account, or even a mobile phone which everyone, Uzochi and the other domestic staff included, had... I was nothing but a waste of space.

I didn't go to my garden the next day, and from my window, I saw Chizutere milling around it, probably hoping to see me. I just couldn't face him nor deal with my growing envy of him and his accomplishments. I kept away from the garden for a few more days, but the urge for the comfort my flowers gave me was soon too much of a pull.

Almost a week after staying away, very early on a Saturday morning before most of the household awoke, I went down there to meditate. I knew I had to come up with a plan for my life, no matter how painful for me such a plan would be.

"I thought I'd said something to offend you," came Chizutere's voice, making me jump. I hadn't expected him to be there so early, and also on a Saturday. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean to startle you."

"Why are you here at the crack of dawn?"

"I stayed over last night to help clean out the ponds and aviary," he answered. "I take on any additional work I can, which is important if I'm going to raise that money." He gave me a quizzical look. "You look a bit dull. You're not usually here this early. I hope nothing is wrong."

Before I could even answer, I heard loud screams from the house. We both turned in its direction, just as the front door was flung open, and a naked Isioma was pushed out of the house, followed by a screaming Chiasoka.

The shit had finally hit the fan.

"You are a shameless child! You are nothing but a prostitute! Enweghi nkita! You are a dog! A shameless dog!" Chiasoka was screaming so hard,

her voice was now raspy. From her bloodshot eyes, I could see that finding her daughter in bed with her lover had actually been a surprise to her, unlike what I had grown to believe.

“Chichi, leave the girl alone,” Chief appeared from the house, chuckling. “See how you have stripped her naked for the whole world to see.”

I felt suddenly enraged for these two women, angered by the fact that the lover they had in common was clearly enjoying the whole show. He didn’t even have the decency to attempt to cover Isioma’s nakedness.

“You! Chineke ga-ata ahụhụ! God will punish you!” Chiasoka screamed, turning to him. “My daughter? My child? A girl that has been like a child to you?”

“She is not my child, oh, biko,” Chief chuckled. “When did I ever tell you she was my child?”

“You know how important she is to me! You know she is all I have! You know taking care of her was the reason I even started following you in the first place!” Chiasoka screamed. “Wasn’t I enough for you? Did you also have to steal my daughter’s innocence as well?”

“There is nothing innocent about Isioma, don’t deceive yourself,” he answered, his eyes twinkling. “Uzochi, come and cover this girl up.”

I looked at the whimpering Isioma, crouched on the ground, trying to cover her body but failing woefully.

I stole a glance at Chizutere and, from his clenched fists, saw he was just as enraged as I was. I put my hand on his arm, to prevent him from doing something stupid like rushing to the young girl’s aid. That would have been equal to suicide.

“I am finished! What will I tell the world?” Chiasoka said, throwing herself to the ground. “Otu nwoke ahụ dina mụ na nwa m nwanyị? I am finished, ooooo!”

Uzochi ran out of the house and threw a wrapper around Isioma, before pulling her to her feet.

“It’s the people that let you in that I blame!” Chief said, all traces of humour gone. “You know the time you are allowed to come here. I thought I made that perfectly clear.”

“So, it was because you were sleeping with my daughter that you stopped me from staying here overnight? It’s because you wanted to eat both the banana and the peel, okwiya? You don’t know who you have messed with! I will deal with you in this town! I will tell the whole world what you have done to us.”

“Get her out of here,” Chief said to Uzochi, before taking Isioma by the hand. “Mmụọ ozi’m, my angel, please come inside.”

“Hapụ’m aka! Leave me alone!” Chiasoka jerked her hand out of Uzochi’s grip. “Isioma! Isioma! You are still following him inside? Isioma!”

The Isioma glared at her mother with intense hatred, before allowing Chief lead her back to the house. My heart broke for Chiasoka. I knew her daughter’s betrayal hurt much worse than her lover’s.

“Please, my sister, let us go,” Uzochi pleaded, taking the weeping woman’s hand. “There is no point crying here. Let me take you home.”

“You knew! You knew, and you didn’t tell me?” Chiasoka spat at her. “If I hadn’t decided to confirm the rumours I’ve been hearing in town, and sneak in here, that’s how all of you would have continued looking at me like a big

fool? How long has this been going on? How long has she been coming here?”

Uzochi sighed and looked away, and I didn't blame her. As if she could open her mouth to spill such sensitive information!

“God punish you! God punish all of you! God punish that devil of a man! And God punish that foolish excuse of a daughter!” Chiasoka cried, her entire body vibrating in her rage. “Why should I be surprised when the demonic man has been sharing his own wife with his son?”

I flinched at the obvious reference to me and stole a glance at Chizutere to see if he'd understood what she said, but I couldn't read the look on his face.

Chiasoka was soon bundled out of the compound, and before long, there was little to no indication that there had been any altercation only a short while before. Except in my heart, where I was suddenly overwhelmed with shame for becoming a byline for the kind of incestuous relationships that Chief Arinze was known for.

“How can a man involve himself with women like that,” Chizutere asked, cutting into the silence, “when he has a beautiful angel for a wife?”

I looked up at him, and in his eyes was the love and adulation I was so desperate for. I don't know who moved forward first, whether it was he or I, but the gap between us soon closed and our lips melted together in the most tender of kisses. I closed my eyes as his lips teased mine, and I held on to him as if my life depended on it, needing more, wanting more of him.

As our kiss deepened, I pulled him to the ground, loving the feel of his taut, muscular body, the smell of his sweat, and his raw sexuality. I wanted him there, and I wanted him then.

But he had other plans.

“Not here,” he whispered against my ears. “Not out here in the open.”

I tried to pull him back as he rose to his feet, not ready to stop, not wanting to stop. But as he pulled away, I had no choice but to stand as well, suddenly feeling ashamed of myself for my wanton behaviour. I was angered by his rejection and desperately wanted to get as far away from him as I could. As I made to shove past him into the house, he held my hand... and I melted into butter all over again.

“My queen, you are everything I have ever dreamt of,” he said, planting small kisses from my hand all the way up my arm and right up to my shoulder blade. “Everything.”

I closed my eyes and groaned softly as his lips now wandered along my neck. Never before had I felt this kind of sexual desire. With the two men I had ever bedded, it had always been nothing more than a chore to be endured, but this time, I desperately wanted to be taken, to be consumed by this man.

I wanted him.

“Meet me at the back gate tonight,” he whispered in my ear. “I’ll be waiting for you.”

For the rest of the day, I floated through the house with a sheepish smile on my face, his words ringing in my ears, and his scent pervading my senses. I was desperate to push the arms of the clock forward, desperate for the long day to quickly turn to night. So eager was I to see Chizutere again, to be taken in his arms again, to kiss his soft lips again...and to experience so much more. I was desperate for it.

Chapter Sixteen

The Affair

I sat on my bed anxiously watching and waiting for dusk to give way to night. I watched as the sun made its slow journey to exchange places with the moon, and the very moment I decided I had enough darkness to act as a cloak, I left my bedroom.

It was only a little past 8pm, but there was reduced activity in the house. The dinner service was over, and only Uzochi and a few other kitchen assistants, who would attend to Chief when he returned, remained in the house. As far as I knew, Isioma was still in his bedroom, recovering from the earlier altercation with her mother. I couldn't help but wonder if Chief would decide to take her on as another wife, now that their secret had been exposed.

But that was actually the least of my problems.

I made my way quietly to the back door, careful not to arouse any suspicion. Once outside, I walked nimbly but noiselessly to the other side of the compound, doing everything I could not to rouse any of the domestic animals nor their keepers. With the gate hardly used, it was secured by an old, rusty padlock, I was grateful to see that someone, very likely Chizutere, had left the padlock open.

I gasped at the loud creaking sound the gate made when I opened it and looked around frantically, to be sure nobody had been alerted by the sound. Satisfied that my tracks were still covered, I proceeded to squeeze myself through the small gap that had already been created, not ready to risk opening it any wider.

“I’ll have to oil that gate tomorrow,” came a voice beside me.

I looked, and my heart burst into a chorus when I saw that it was the man whose kiss I had been dreaming of since we parted only hours ago.

“Hi,” I said, breathless, not because I was tired from the journey from the house, but because of the excitement and nervousness I felt from being in his presence. My heart was racing a mile a minute just standing there next to him. Everything about him was electrifying.

He bent and took my lips in a sensual kiss, one that I happily and willfully gave in to. The back gate of the ranch opened into a large expanse of unoccupied grassland that was being contested by some families, so we had no audience. I wrapped my arms around him, kissing him with an eagerness that surprised even me, ready to succumb to him right there and then, with the moon and star-lit sky forming the perfect tapestry for our love.

“I want to take you somewhere,” he said, holding my hand and leading me down a hastily cut path on the grassy road.

My body tingled in my excitement. “Where are we going?”

He turned around and smiled, the smile that turned me into mush. “You’ll see.”

We walked for about twenty minutes, and I made sure to keep my head bowed. It hadn’t occurred to me that we would come so far out into town, otherwise I would have brought along a scarf to cover my face. I was even

too scared to speak, to ask where on earth he was taking me to, lest my voice gave me away. It was not like there were that many pedestrians on the road, but the handful of people walking to and from their places of commerce, or just enjoying a quiet evening stroll, were enough to cause me considerable panic.

Thankfully, we soon branched off into some kind of woodland. It was a part of the town I had never seen in all my years living there. Before I could raise any alarm over this strange place he was taking me to, we got to a small creek. All my grumbles and complaints died right there on my lips as I beheld the beauty of the body of water, ornamented with rocks and boulders, the sound of its flow almost melodic. Under the moonlight, it twinkled as if scattered with a million, tiny diamonds. I had never beheld such a picturesque sight in my whole life.

“It’s beautiful, isn’t it,” Chizutere beamed with pride, as if he had created it himself. He held out his hand to me. “Come.”

I looked around. As scenic as the place was, it didn’t seem conducive enough for the fulfillment of my passionate fantasies. With rocks and stones everywhere, where would we lie?

“Is this where you bring all your women?” I asked coyly. “Do you seduce them here, under the moonlight?”

He shook his head, his gaze never leaving me. “I’ve never brought anyone else here. I discovered it a few years ago, and I come here when I want to think...to meditate.”

Thinking and meditating was the last thing I wanted to do. Deciding we would have to make do with the stony ground, I reached for him and pulled him into a kiss. His was tender, but mine was much more demanding. He

kissed me like we had all night, but I was more mindful of the limited time we did have.

Eager to move things along, I pulled away from him and started unbuttoning my dress.

“No, my love,” he said, putting his hand over mine. “Let’s not rush. I didn’t bring you here for that.”

I looked at him, surprised, not understanding what he meant, not understanding how it was possible for him to want anything but sex from me.

“Being here with you, having you here with me like this is a dream come true for me,” he said, planting a tender kiss on my nose. “You don’t know how long I’ve wanted you.”

“So, you don’t want to sleep with me?” It was more of an accusation than a question.

He looked at me, and there was raw desire in his eyes. “You don’t know how much. But not here...and not like this.”

“Then let’s go somewhere then. Let’s go to your house, or I could even sneak you into my room – “

“Or we could simply enjoy each other’s company, like this,” he said, kissing my hand. “We could just sit here, under this beautiful night sky, and enjoy each other’s company. We could get to know each other first.”

“So, why did you bring me all the way here?” I retorted. “We could have just done the same back at the ranch!”

“That’s where you’re wrong, my beautiful Ada,” he said, leaning in to kiss me. “Back in the ranch, I couldn’t kiss you like this.”

I closed my eyes and savoured his kiss; slow, unrushed and beautiful. As he wrapped his arms around me, I allowed myself enjoy the comfort of his strong body. As I dialed down my sexual desire, my heart took over, and as I kissed him, I felt something I had never felt before.

I felt love.

“I’ll never forget the first day I saw you,” he said later on, as we sat leaning on a boulder, his arm draped around my neck, and my head on his chest. “It was in the market, and you were there with the older housekeeper. I didn’t think you were a real human being. In fact, I thought you were a spirit. You didn’t look like you were from this world.”

I smiled. “I’m sure you were still in your diapers then, so you hadn’t seen much of the world yourself.”

He chuckled. “You’re not that much older than I am, Ada. Three years is nothing in today’s world.”

“It’s four actually, and that’s plenty where I come from,” I answered, the smile on my lips fading. “You’re too young for me, Chizu. This can’t lead anywhere.”

He titled up my chin. “Says who? Make no mistake about it, Adanna. I’m going to marry you one day.”

I couldn’t help but laugh. “Marry indeed! Have you even finished saving money to send yourself to school?”

But he wasn’t amused. “This isn’t a joke to me. I’m in love with you, and I swear to God that I will not rest until I can take you away from your excuse of a husband.”

“You want to marry me, even with all my baggage?” I asked, when I realised he was serious. “I don’t need to ask if you’ve heard about Akanna

and I. The whole village has heard. I'm not the pure and spotless angel you think I am. I'm dirty and –"

He put his finger over my lips. "Adanna, you are perfect to me."

With that statement, I was signed, sealed and delivered. With that statement, I knew immediately he was the one my heart had been waiting for.

And so became our nightly ritual. I would leave earlier, usually at about 7pm, and meet him at the creek, where we would talk, daydream, and talk some more, with the burble from the bayou and nocturnal animal sounds as a soundtrack. During the day, we were, at best, civil to each other. If I saw him whilst in my garden, I would acknowledge his greeting with the curtest of nods. Nobody who saw us would have believed that we were lovers after sunset.

There were times he tried to sneak in a smile with his greeting, but those were the times I was even more offhand. The last thing I wanted was for anyone to suspect us and, thankfully, nobody did. Another wonderful outcome of our love was that my sleepwalking completely stopped. I no longer awoke to find myself in strange parts of the house. Instead, I awoke on my bed, in the same state of content bliss in which I fell asleep after returning from our rendezvous each night.

"I'm going to make sure you go back to school," Chizutere said on one occasion. "You're a very smart girl, and I know you'll excel. Who knows, your NASA dream might still become a reality one day."

I'd laughed at the mere idea. "Don't talk nonsense, Chizu. NASA indeed. From Ojiji to NASA?! Ọ bụ otú o si eme? Is that how they do it? Let's get you into school first. Then you can get a fancy job in Lagos and take care of me properly."

“I won’t insist. All I know is that I’m definitely going to give you the best in life,” he laughed. “Starting with a mobile phone. As soon as I can save enough money, I’m going to buy you a mobile phone. You’re probably the only one I know who doesn’t own one.”

This, like most of our conversations, prompted a giggle from me, which, just like the other times, would always lead to more kissing. We hadn’t gone beyond that, and even though there was a particular occasion when I could tell he was very excited, he’d somehow been able to control himself. And I loved him all the more for it. I never knew love and sex were not mutually exclusive, that I could be loved and feel so passionately for someone I desired, and who desired me sexually, without giving my body away.

Leaving him was always the problem, and it took a lot for us to tear apart from each other after every rendezvous. I made sure I didn’t get back to the ranch anytime after 10 PM , and nobody seemed to be the wiser about my whereabouts. I was sure to be casually dressed, enough for people to think I’d just been wandering around the compound, or maybe even in my garden. Nobody seemed suspicious of my movement.

At first.

There was a night I got home, and as I was making my way up the stairs, Isioma brushed past me with tears in her eyes.

I stared at her as she rushed out of the house and wondered what could have happened to upset her so. Since the incident with Chiasoka, she had been almost a permanent fixture in the house, barely even leaving to go to school. Her mother, on the other hand, was now a thing of the past. Before Chizutere, I would have been worried about Isioma soon replacing me as Chief’s wife, but now, I no longer cared if the man married ten of her.

“Ebe i si bia? Where are you coming from?” Chief’s voice boomed over me.

“I went to look for something to eat in the kitchen,” I answered, trying to keep my voice calm and steady. “But I didn’t find anything.”

“When you’re too lazy to cook, how will you find anything?” he mumbled, as he descended the stairs past me.

“Are you looking for Isioma? Ọ pụowo. She has gone,” I said, deriving pleasure in giving him that titbit of information.

He glared at me, obviously detecting my sarcasm, and continued his march to the front door. I chuckled as I walked upstairs. Good luck to them.

The next morning, as I ate breakfast, I was in the mood for some gossip.

“What happened to Isioma?” I asked Uzochi. “I saw her crying and running out of the house last night.”

“Really?” Uzochi asked. “Where did you see her?”

“I was going upstairs as she was running down. She even almost pushed me off the stairs,” I added with a snigger.

“Hmmm. And where were you coming from yourself?” Uzochi asked.

There was something in her voice that made me look up at her, and I saw genuine concern in her eyes. “Ada, kpachara anya. Be careful.”

With that, she carried her tray and exited the room, leaving me staring at her in panic. Did she know? Could anyone know? No, it wasn’t possible. Chizutere and I were careful. There was no way anyone could know. I convinced myself that it had been a warning from her to stay out of Chief and Isioma’s matter. Yes, that had to be it.

I didn't even have too much time to ponder over it as, just like a long forgotten nightmare, Akanna resurfaced later that afternoon. He had been away in Europe, working on one business deal or the other. I had since realised that the Nsofor wealth had not come from baked goods, but from smuggling firearms. When their government contacts had been sacked a few years before, there had been a downturn in their business, but from the way Chief had resumed spending money like it was going out of fashion, it was apparent that business was booming once again.

"Adanna! My beautiful Adanna!" Akanna exclaimed the moment he saw me in the hallway, not caring who around him could hear. "You look more beautiful every time I see you."

"Welcome," was all I could mutter.

"I brought you some lovely things I believe you'll like," he said, reaching for my hand. "Let's go upstairs, and I'll show you."

I stepped away from his reach. "I'm not feeling too well. Some other time."

He looked at me, a frown forming on his face. "You're not feeling well, how? You look pretty fine to me. If it's that time of the month, you know I don't mind."

My stomach churned at the awful memories his statement evoked, and it took everything in me not to slap him hard across the face. But instead, I took a deep breath and shook my head. "I don't feel well. I am not up to anything. Sorry for the inconvenience."

I looked him in the eye, daring him to react. We both knew I was no longer that girl he could bully into submission. Our recent dalliances had been strictly for monetary gain, and as I had found a treasure more valuable than

money, I no longer needed him. The beauty of it all was that he couldn't make me do anything I didn't want to. Not anymore.

"You're not up to anything? I see. No problem," he said with a stiff smile. "I guess that means you will forfeit what I brought for you then."

I shrugged, totally indifferent. "That's fine." Nothing he could possibly have brought could be of any interest to me.

As I walked away, I felt like I had won the lottery. Akanna would never again have access to my body. I couldn't help feeling regretful that I wouldn't present myself a virgin when Chizutere and I finally did make love. But I knew he didn't mind. I knew he had accepted me just the way I was, and it made me love him all the more.

But then things took a morbid turn.

One morning, as I descended the stairs for breakfast, I heard Uzochi wailing from the kitchen. Rushing there, I saw her sitting on a stool, crying. Huddled around her were some of the other domestic staff, looking equally distressed.

"What's the matter?" I asked, panicked. "Is your husband okay? Or Daluchi?"

"O bu Isioma," answered Fidelia, the junior cook that had just been hired. "It's Isioma, Chief's..." her voice trailed off in her confusion about how to explain the identity of my husband's mistress.

"Isioma anwuola, oooo! Isioma is dead!" Uzochi wailed. "Eeeeeo! She is all her mother has! That girl is all the woman has! Kedu ka o ga-esi jikwaa?"

I almost hissed in my relief that it wasn't someone dear to me that had died, but I was soon overcome by sympathy for Chiasoka, and also curiosity. It

had been only weeks since I'd seen Isioma in the house, though tearful she had been. What could have killed such a young girl, so full of life?

We were soon to find out that, in a bid to terminate a pregnancy, she had taken some kind of concoction that had led to her bleeding uncontrollably for days. Her friends had tried to manage her privately, doing everything they could to stop the bleeding, and when they became overwhelmed, had rushed her to the Teaching Hospital, where she died less than twenty-four hours later.

As I listened to Uzochi relay the information she herself had heard from the grapevine, I found myself feeling nauseous. Had that been what Isioma had come to tell Chief the night I'd found her tearful on the stairway? That she was pregnant? And had he denied responsibility for the baby? After years suppressed, I found myself overwhelmed by vivid flashbacks of my own abortions, and I was overcome with sorrow for the poor girl, who had probably been too inexperienced to know the steps to take to safely end her pregnancy.

"Did you hear about Isioma?" I asked Chizutere, as he walked past my garden. I was in no mood for our snubbing games that day.

He sighed and shook his head. "It's all everyone in town is talking about," he answered. "They say Chief was responsible for the pregnancy."

"Who else? The girl practically lived here!" I exclaimed. "That man is evil personified. In fact, he even —"

I was interrupted by loud, sorrowful crying. I looked in the direction of the sound, and my heart broke when I saw that it was Chiasoka, crying outside the gate. She was sitting on the ground, wailing in her grief. From her stained clothes, it was evident she had been rolling on the floor. Her pain was so palpable, it brought tears to my eyes as I remembered my own pain

when my dear father had died. But unlike me, Chiasoka had nobody to grieve with. Isioma had been her everything.

“Leave her alone!” I shouted, running towards the gate as the guards made to push her out of the way. “Get your hands off her! Can’t you see she is bereaved?”

“Ọ na-egbochi ụzọ,” Ukawuike, the senior guard answered. “The woman is blocking the road. What happens if Chief wants to drive into the compound?”

“Let him park outside and see what his actions have caused her!” I yelled, not caring about the impact of my words. “Let him look at his handiwork face to face!”

Chizutere tugged at my hand, and I knew I had said too much. Sad as I was for the bereaved woman, it wasn’t my battle to fight. Not wanting attention to divert from Chiasoka to us, I pulled my hand away from Chizutere’s and walked away, keeping a good distance between us.

Later that evening, as we sat at the creek, the mood was a somber one.

“You have to get out of that house. I have to take you away from there,” Chizutere said, his eyes distant. “Come with me to Jos. Let’s leave this place.”

I looked at him, shocked by his suggestion, but when I saw the determination in his eyes, I realised that was the only logical thing to do. For how much longer could I live in that kind of toxic environment? It was Isioma today, who knew if the next corpse wouldn’t be mine?

And so we began to make plans. He spoke to his uncle, who confirmed that new vacancies had opened in the factory. When Chizutere told him he was

bringing me along, he had assured him I would be able to find work, as long as I was willing and able, and willing and able I most definitely was.

We decided to leave in a month, almost eight years to the day that I first arrived Ojiji. As the days drew closer, I could barely contain my excitement. Chizutere and I were finally going to be together properly. We would get married and start a family, and I would finally have my happy ending. I couldn't wait.

We had it all planned. I was to leave a small bag, with the few belongings I was taking along, at the back gate the night before our departure, and early the next morning, I would just casually stroll out of the front gate, under the guise of making a quick dash to the market. Chizutere would be waiting for me by the junction, and we would be on the bus, first to Benin, from where we would board the night bus to Jos.

"I got this for you," he said to me, handing me a small box, two days to our departure.

I took the box and gasped when I opened it. Inside it was a small, used Nokia phone. "Chizutere!"

He smiled and shrugged. "I just thought it would be nice for you to start your new life at least owning one. It's absurd that you still don't even have a mobile phone."

"But your savings!" I protested.

"All will be replenished as soon as we get to Jos, don't worry," he said, kissing me. "I did it for selfish reasons too. I want to be able to talk to you anytime I want."

As we embraced, I was so happy, it felt like I was floating. Finally, after having it rough for so many years, life was finally being good to me. I

thought about my mother and brother and decided to call them only after getting to Jos, lest they discourage me from eloping with the much younger Chizutere.

Even though I slept happy, when I woke up the following morning, I had a strange sense of foreboding I couldn't explain. I sat up, wondering why I felt such a weight on my chest, but then decided it was apprehension over leaving the familiar and starting life anew in a strange place. I reminded myself of feeling a similar way when I left Onitsha as a young bride. Thankfully, this time, I was starting my new life with a man I did love.

As I ate breakfast, I noticed everywhere was unusually quiet and wondered where everyone was. Not even Uzochi was anywhere to be seen. But I didn't care. I had just about twenty-four hours to still be in their company, after which it would be farewell forever.

Walking out to my garden, I noticed Ukawuike talking with the other guards in a cluster, his hands on his head. Then I saw some of the other domestic staff walking in a group from the gate, talking and shaking their heads. It was then I noticed that none of them were in their uniforms. As a matter of fact, they all looked like they had just rolled out of bed. In the eight years I'd been there, I'd never seen anything like it and wondered if this was some kind of strike.

But from the tongue clicking and head shaking, I had a sinking feeling it wasn't.

Uzochi emerged from the door and walked up to them. Whatever they told her was distressing enough for her to place both hands on her chest and look upwards. Rising to my feet, I managed to walk to her, even though my feet were already as heavy as lead.

Even before I heard the words, I already knew.

“What is it? What happened?” was all I asked.

She looked at me, and I immediately saw, not just grief over what she had just heard, but sympathy for me. “The gardener, Chizutere. They say his family house caught fire overnight. By the time people noticed the fire, it was too late. They tried and tried, but were unable to bring any of them out. By the time they could finally enter the house, they were all dead.”

I stumbled back, not believing what I had heard. No, she had to be lying. She had to be joking. Chizutere and I were leaving for Jos the next day. Saying he was dead had to be a cruel joke.

So, I started running. I started running towards the gate, so I could see this for myself, so I could prove to myself that there was no way my love was dead. No way.

“Adanna! Adanna!” Uzochi called out as I ran. “Mechie ụzọ! Lock that gate!”

The nearest person to the gate complied, and it shut just as I reached it. I held on to it, crying and shaking it, the reality of the situation dawning on me, the reality that I would never see the love of my life again.

“Are you crazy? Have you lost your mind?” Uzochi whispered hoarsely as she grabbed me. “You better get a hold of yourself. How will you explain going to the boy’s house? What will you tell people is the reason you are crying? You better get yourself together, if you don’t want to get into trouble!”

The concern in her voice made me look at her, and I saw in her eyes knowing...and fear. I realised that she knew. She knew about the affair. But it was the fear in her eyes that sent a cold wave through me, a chilling reality dawning on me. Chizutere had been killed.

Chapter Seventeen

The Tragedy

I looked from Uzochi to the others standing around. It was then that I noticed their averted gazes, none of them able to make eye contact with me. They knew. They all knew.

I shrugged out of Uzochi's grip and turned around to walk back to the house. All the chatter had ceased, and the only sound was from the birds chirping obliviously in the trees. It was only then that I realised that I was barefoot, my slippers having come off my feet in my mad dash to the gate.

The hot ground burned me in my trek of shame, and once again in my life, I wished for death. I cursed God for delighting in taking away those I loved, those I held dearest. Why was He still keeping me alive if all He ever gave me was suffering and pain?

"Kedu ihe i na-ele? What are you looking at? Will you all get to work!" I heard Uzochi admonish the rest of the domestic staff, but it was too little, too late for me. I had already created enough of a spectacle. I could only wonder how long they had known about Chizutere and I, how long I had been regarded as the philandering wife of their employer, frolicking with the gardener.

"Just wash your face and lie down," Uzochi said, walking into my bedroom behind me. I hadn't even realised she'd followed me upstairs. "This news is

too distressing. Imagine waking up to hear something so awful. There has been too much bad news in the last few weeks. First Isioma, now this fine young boy...”

“How did you know about us?” I cut in. “How did everyone know?”

“Ada! But I warned you. I told you to be careful. I told you,” she sighed deeply. “I heard a few whispers in the village. One or two people had seen the two of you headed to the Okwute Stream. At first, I didn’t think much of it. You’ve already had to endure so much, and I thought it wouldn’t be such a bad thing for you to just have some small relief, no matter how brief. It was when the whispers started getting louder and louder, and I started hearing the gossip even here in the house that I knew I couldn’t keep quiet anymore. Remember that morning you were having breakfast, and I warned you to be careful?”

“How was I to know that was what you were talking about? I thought you were talking about Chief and Isioma!”

Uzochi gave me a knowing glance. “Did you really think so, Adanna? Or is that what you made yourself believe?”

My eyes pooled with more tears, and she took me in her arms, rocking me as I cried. “You have to be strong. It is sad, but you can’t afford to mourn him publicly. I know what it feels like to lose someone you love. The boy I was supposed to marry was wrongly accused of theft and sent to jail, only for them to kill him there. And now, my own husband is no better than a vegetable, alive but dead. I understand loss.”

I sobbed even more as she spoke. No, she didn’t understand. There was no way she could understand my pain. Nobody could. Nobody ever could understand how it felt to be lifted so high into the heavens, only to be dropped not even down to earth, but straight to hell.

“I have to see the place,” I said, when my tears finally subsided. “I have to see where he died.”

Uzochi twisted her lips as she pondered over my request. “It isn’t the best idea, but you might truly need that to get some closure. I will ask Daluchi to take you there. But you have to be careful. She will just point the house out to you from afar, and then you’ll come back home immediately. Don’t even linger for an extra minute. There are spies everywhere, as I’m sure you can see.”

Her verbal confirmation of my inner thoughts incensed me. The temperature in the room seemed to rise, as red hot fury raged through my veins. “It was Akanna, wasn’t it? Akanna did this!”

Uzochi looked away, and I could see that she also nursed the same suspicion. “All I can tell you is you need to be careful. You are surrounded by dangerous people. You need to be mindful of your every move. Please, I’m begging you. I promised your mother I would take care of you. I don’t want to have to start telling her stories if anything bad happens to you.”

Her words stayed with me, even after she left to get her teenage daughter, Daluchi, to accompany me to town to see Chizutere’s burnt family house for myself. I knew Akanna was a beast, I knew he was dangerous, but this by far exceeded anything I could have thought he was capable of.

Daluchi arrived and, draping a scarf around my head like a veil, we walked to the village. I was sure to keep my face fully concealed, as the last thing I wanted was to be identified again.

“That’s the house over there,” she said, as we turned into a small street. “My God! So, Uzoma is gone just like that!”

Uzoma was Daluchi's classmate in school and one of Chizutere's four sisters. They had all perished with their mother. From what we'd heard, their father had been working overnight at Ibuzor when the tragedy occurred.

I stood there, looking from afar at the ashes that had apparently once been my lover's home. There were still visible embers, and from the smoke that was still emanating, it was obvious that the fire hadn't been completely extinguished. The bodies of the deceased had already been taken away, and there were clusters of people still hanging around, trying to see what could be salvaged from the place.

"That's their father over there," Daluchi said in a hoarse whisper, pointing at a man sitting helplessly on a makeshift stool, staring into nothingness as a group of people talked loudly around him.

He was just exactly what Chizutere would have looked like thirty years older. The resemblance was uncanny. I wanted so badly to go to him, to ask that he enter the ruins of his house to look for his family. I wanted to shake him out of his defenselessness, demand for him not to accept this lie without a fight. I wanted him to fight for us to get back the people we loved.

As I looked at him, I didn't realise when my hand fell from my veil, and it dropped, revealing my face. Maybe feeling the intensity of my gaze, he looked in my direction...and our eyes held. From the sorrow and anger in his, I could tell that he knew. He knew who I was and what I had been to his son. The talking around him stopped, as his companions looked in my direction, all of them recognising me, and none of them looking particularly pleased by my presence.

“Let’s go,” Daluchi said, dragging me by the hand, obviously sensing the tension, and I willfully followed her. Any longer, and they would have lynched me.

Upon getting back to the ranch, I went straight to my bedroom, locked my door, and shut my blinds, leaving the room pitch-dark. I lay on the bed as day turned to night and as night to day, not even bothering to change nor shower, not caring to see any ray of sunlight. I wanted the place to be as dark as I felt inside.

Now and then, I drifted into fitful bouts of sleep where I had nightmares of Chizutere running to me at the creek, aflame. His agonized cries sounded so real, so vivid, it was almost as if I was hearing him burn as he and his family died in the fire. By the end of the third day in my room, my visions of Chizutere had progressed from dreams to vivid hallucinations, with his face haunting me in the pitch-dark room.

It wasn’t until I finally turned on my lights that I stopped seeing him lurking over me everywhere I turned. I was gradually losing my mind. He was haunting me, and for good reason. If it weren’t for me, he would still be alive.

By the fifth day, I decided that enough was enough. I had to be strong to face life again, even if it had been cruel to me. Having only nibbled on old crackers and groundnuts stored in my wardrobe, I was ravenously hungry. I had a shower, wore a bright orange and pink boubou, applied light makeup, and left my bedroom for the first time.

I nodded in response to the polite greeting from the staff. I knew that underneath all the “Good morning”, “Ụtụtu ọma”, and “Nne, kedu” I was getting were really greetings of sympathy and commiseration. As Fidelia poured my tea, she patted my hand before she left the dining room, and I

saw that, rather than judge me, they all pitied me. And that made me feel a bit better.

My breakfast that ordinarily would have taken less than 30 minutes to finish dragged to over an hour. I struggled with the toast and tossed the eggs around on the plate idly. Food held no appeal for me. Nothing interested me anymore. Life had simply lost its colour. Not even the thought of going to my cherished garden and seeing my beloved flowers was any consolation. None of it would bring Chizutere back.

I was eating my last piece of toast when I heard his voice...the voice of the devil.

Akanna.

I looked out and saw him strolling into the house, talking on his mobile phone. How dare he show his face after the horrible thing he had done? I walked to the door and watched him as he talked and laughed so casually, not acting like he had the blood of six innocent people on his hands.

“Adanna, you look so beautiful this morning,” he remarked as he got off the phone, a coy smile on his face. “I asked after you yesterday but was told you were...indisposed.”

I glared at him, hating him with every fibre of my being, wanting to claw out his eyeballs. He knew exactly what had confined me there.

“Such a shame about that gardener boy...Chizutere. Was that his name?” he asked, his smile mocking.

And I saw red.

I rushed at him, grabbing him by the shirt. “You are a killer! You are a cold-blooded killer! You’re going to rot in jail for what you did! You won’t go scot-free –”

In one swift movement, he pushed me, sending flying across the room. Before I could even regain my composure, he stormed over and grabbed me by the hair.

“Who do you think you’re talking to? Have you lost your mind?” he shouted, his temple throbbing in his rage. “Is it because I’ve been indulging your sauciness, you think you have the nerve to talk to me like that?”

“Let go of me!” I screamed, struggling in vain to get out of his lethal grip. “Leave me alone, you monster! Mmụọ ojọọ! Demon!”

His fist landed on my face with such force, it felt like his hand had passed through my brain. This was swiftly followed by another punch, and then another, and then another. I heard the sickening crack of bone and knew he had broken my nose...or cheekbone...or both. I struggled, hands flailing as I tried to escape his attack, so reminiscent of old times...but yet so much worse.

When he let go of me, I tried to scramble to my feet so that I could escape his incensed presence...but my legs failed me.

“Look at this prostitute thinking she can talk to me anyhow!” Akanna said, whipping off his belt and lashing me across the face. “You filthy dog, sleeping with my father’s gardener, you have the nerve to insult me? When you should be covering your face in shame?”

He kept on flogging me with his belt, lashing indiscriminately, not caring where his large buckle hit. “But what should we expect from the daughter of a prostitute? You would be turning tricks on the streets of Onitsha if my father and I hadn’t rescued you from that life!”

As I screamed, I tasted blood, which was flowing freely from my nose and mouth. There were angry red lines all over my arms, and from the stinging

on my neck and back, I knew those places hadn't been spared either.

“Biko hapu ya! Please, leave her!” Fidelia cried, rushing out of the kitchen. She was the only one brave enough to confront him, as the others were cowering in the kitchen.

Incensed, he sent the belt flying her away, hitting her on the chest. With an anguished yelp, she ran back into the kitchen, shutting the door securely behind her.

Using this distraction, I tried to crawl to the staircase, but he grabbed me by my shoulders and dragged me up. With his hands digging deep into the back of my head, he rammed my face into the wall repeatedly. I could feel my strength dissipating. I could feel life seeping out of my body. I knew I would die if I didn't fight him. But I couldn't. I had nothing left in me.

“O ga-egbu ya o! He will kill her, o!” came Uzochi's wail, as she ran in from the back door. She dropped her bag of groceries and pushed him off me. “It's enough! Biko o zuru. Leave this poor child alone!”

My relief was short lived as he released his hold of me and grabbed Uzochi by her neck, throwing her with such force, she crashed onto a nearby console, sending the ceramic table and its glass flower vase crashing to the ground. She lay on the ground, face down, and I was scared that he had inflicted on her irreparable harm.

I turned around to try to run away, but he grabbed my dress from behind, ripping it open from top to bottom. I gasped in horror as the destroyed piece of fabric fell off my body, leaving me clad in only my underwear.

“You are a public toilet! There is no part of you that is worth any form of decency. No part of you that the whole world has not eaten and spat out!” he snarled, tearing apart my bra from the bridge.

I stood there sobbing as the bra fell off me and did nothing to stop him as he did the same to my panties, tugging at them until the flimsy lace fabric dropped to my knees, leaving me stark naked in the hallway.

“Whore!” he spat at me, before storming out of the house.

I just remained there, crying, not even having it in me to run away to cover my shame, to hide my nakedness. The kitchen door opened, and the domestic staff filed out, some of them to Uzochi’s aid and some to mine. It felt like I was watching them from a faraway place, as a wrapper was flung across my body. I was whisked to the dining room, where my wounds were cleaned and tended to. I didn’t even have it in me to be ashamed of the fact that my nakedness had been exposed for the entire household to see. Akanna had succeeded in killing my already broken spirit.

Okeke carried me to my bedroom, closely followed by Nnedinma, one of the younger maids. As we ascended the stairs, I saw that there were tears in the older man’s eyes. Having been there when I was brought as a young bride from Onitsha, he was very protective of me, and I knew he felt helpless over not being able to save me from all the mess I’d had to endure over the years, culminating in Akanna’s brutal attack on me that morning. But he wasn’t the only helpless one. We all were.

“Rest your body,” Nnedinma said, pulling my cover sheet over me after helping me into a nightgown. “I will check on you in a few hours. Rest, so your body can heal.”

“What about Uzochi?” I asked, my voice raspy. “Is she okay? And Fidelia?”

“They are both fine,” Okeke answered. “Don’t worry about them. Focus on taking care of yourself.”

They left shortly after, leaving me lying on my bed, battered and broken. I shut my eyes, but sleep would not come. And when my eyes were open, the pain I felt was overwhelming. As silent tears streamed from my eyes, stinging as they made their journey down my face, I wondered why I had returned to this hell on earth. Yes, Onitsha had been bad...but it couldn't have been this bad. This wasn't life. It was perdition.

I knew I had to leave...for good.

Later that night, when I was sure Chief would have returned, I decided it was time to inform him of my decision to return to Onitsha. I was also determined to let him know about all Akanna's atrocities. Yes, he might have been aware of some of them, but he needed to know his son was also a cold-blooded murderer.

Even though my body was throbbing with pain, I slipped into my sandals and slowly made my way up the flight of stairs that separated his room from mine. Getting to the door, I tapped as hard as my wounded hand could manage.

"Come in!" he bellowed.

When I walked in, I was relieved to find that he had no female company that night. He gave me a cursory look, his only acknowledgment of my battered appearance a slight arch of an eyebrow. Other than that, he said nothing.

"I would like to return to Onitsha," I said, going straight to the point. "I made a mistake coming back after Ahunna died. I would like to go back home now."

Chief smiled and took a puff of his pipe. "May I ask why?"

“It’s Akanna,” I answered brazenly. “Look at what he has done to me. Look at my face. This morning, he attacked me. He beat me up like an animal. He stripped me naked and humiliated me in front of everyone.”

Chief’s face was unreadable. “So, I heard.”

“And that’s not all,” I said, after a brief silence. “He...he killed Chizutere and his family. He had their family house burnt, killing everyone inside.”

Chief chuckled. “Is that so? Akanna set the house on fire himself? And onye bu Chizutere anyway?”

“The...the gardener.”

He nodded. “Ah yes, the gardener. Handsome young man, wasn’t he?”

I hesitated, not quite knowing if it was a trick question.

“Ada, Ada. Ada, my wife,” Chief continued to chuckle. “You are so naïve. You actually think Akanna has the kind of intelligence required to take care of important business? Beating women and shouting all over the place are how far he can go. He doesn’t possess the intellectual capacity to get things done.”

A slow chill started to creep up my spine, the realization of what Chief was saying dawning on me.

“You think you can mess around with local village boys without any consequence?” he snarled, suddenly rising to his feet. “You think I would just sit back, fold my hands, and watch you make a fool of me?”

“But we don’t even have a real marriage! You have other women. I don’t even share your bed. Why would it matter to you if I found love with another man?” I cried.

“Adanna, you are my wife until I say otherwise!” he answered. “I came for your hand, and I paid a hefty price for it. Don’t you ever forget that!” He shook his head and laughed. “You said you made a mistake coming back after your sister died. What a joke! My dear, you were there in Onitsha only because I let you. Trust me when I say I would have brought you back here eventually, whether you liked it or not. I brought you here to be my wife, and be my wife you will!”

“Well, I’m going!” I said, my voice raised by a few octaves. “I’m done being your slave. I’m done wasting my life away. First thing tomorrow, I’ll be on a bus to Onitsha and nothing you can do can stop me.”

Chief smiled coyly. “No problem, Ada. You can be on the first bus to Onitsha. There’s no problem.”

Slightly taken aback by his concession, I turned around to leave his room.

“But be rest assured that what happened to your gardener lover and his family will be child’s play compared to what will happen to your mother and brother,” came his chilling words.

I stopped dead in my tracks, his words like a sharp arrow piercing my back. I turned around to look at him, and there was a satisfied smile on his face, seeing that his words had made the desired impact.

“And when I’m done with them, I will hunt you down in whatever hole you have crawled to, and I will have dogs tear you apart, limb from limb,” he continued. “So, think wisely about any grand plans you might be nursing.”

By now, I was quivering like a leaf. Without another word, I stumbled out of the room and half-limped, half-ran down the stairs to my bedroom. Chief had not only blatantly accepted responsibility for Chizutere’s death, he had

made it implicitly clear that he wouldn't hesitate to do even worse to my own family.

I knew then and there that I couldn't take that risk. I couldn't do that to my mother and Jidenna, not after all they'd already been through.

I sat awake in bed all night, not trusting what would happen if I closed my eyes to sleep. The honest truth was that I was trapped in that house. Chizutere had been a nice dream, but it was time to return to earth and face my reality.

At exactly 9am that morning, there was a knock on my door. I rose to my feet and shuffled to it, not even caring who could be on the other side of it.

"See what you made me do to your beautiful face," Akanna said, a smug smile on his face.

So frightened was I that I put up no fight when he shoved past me into the room, pulling me to the bed without even locking the door. As I succumbed to him, it wasn't as the woman who did so because of what she stood to gain, but as one who knew that was the only choice she had. I was back to my sad reality.

Chapter Eighteen

The Mature Woman

A robot.

A robot is what I became after the Chizutere incident. After realising that my family's safety, and even mine, would be in jeopardy if I left the ranch, I resigned myself to my fate. I switched to auto-pilot mode, focusing on my living and breathing moments, never on my tragic past, and most definitely not on any lofty hopes for the future. I had no future outside of Ojiji.

So, I stayed. I stayed on as Chief's ornamental wife, good for a show but nothing else. I ignored the stream of concubines he continued to take, and put on a bright smile when I had to be on his arm at public functions. I allowed myself enjoy the caprices of his renewed desire to ensure I looked the part of a multi-millionaire's wife. I allowed myself indulge in the expensive clothing and even more expensive skincare, ensuring that, as the years went by, I didn't shrivel and wilt like my mother had but, instead, blossomed.

With this renewed understanding came something of a friendship between Chief and I. He was pleased that I had finally become the kind of wife he desired, beautiful to look at and, at the same time, blind to his vices. This led to longer and more congenial conversations, with him sometimes even

seeking my company to chat. Ours was not a sexual relationship, neither was it a familial one, it was just a friendship between two people who had learned to tolerate and accept each other.

As for Akanna, in the first few years after Chizutere's death, he frequented my bedroom so much that I often wondered how he explained his many nights away to his hapless wife. Just like in the past, he was back to being violent and aggressive, sometimes beating me for no reason at all. He was clearly trying to punish me for my perceived betrayal.

I put up no fights and took all the beatings without even as much as a yelp, accepting it as the hand fate had dealt me. In time, he eventually tired of trying to prove whatever point he'd wanted to and resorted to only dropping by my quarters only on occasion. Sometimes as frequently as several times a week, and other times months would go by without him seeking me, even if he was in the ranch. But I soon trained myself not to care either way. If he came, I tolerated it, and if he didn't, then it was all the better.

As for the domestic staff, my bond with them strengthened after Akanna's humiliating assault. Maybe it was guilt over their inability to help me or maybe they just pitied me for all I'd endured, whatever the case, after that day, they took me on as family. They loved and protected me fiercely, especially from the vicious gossip coming from town, about me being responsible for the death of a promising young man like Chizutere. Uzochi and Daluchi, especially, were extremely protective of me, and ever so often, would invite me to their private quarters in the basement for a meal. I finally got to meet her paraplegic husband, Ibe, and she soon became to me more of a mother than my biological one was.

Time hadn't been good to my mother. Even though only in her fifties, she looked at least a decade older. It was like all the men she allowed ravage

her body over the years took a piece of her each time they'd had their fill. Eventually, and I suspect as a result of her inability to attract men to sustain her lifestyle, she'd taken to petty trading, which earned her a whole lot less money, leaving her even more frustrated than she'd been before. I still tried to support her as best as I could but, contrary to her belief, there was a limit to how much of Chief's money I had access to. Thus, her resentment of me escalated over the years.

Jidenna had also not been very successful. Even though he finished his program at the Polytechnic with decent grades, he struggled for years to get a good job. He spent a few fruitless years in Lagos, roaming from one menial factory job to the other. Frustrated, he returned to Onitsha and to his former master, whose auto repair workshop he took over when the old man finally decided to retire. Alas, it hadn't been a full relinquishment on the man's part, as he still expected to share a decent chunk of Jidenna's earnings. As my brother had not been able to come up with the money required to buy out his former master, he'd had no choice but to continue sharing his income, leaving him with very little to call his own at the end of the day.

Chief's other children, Anayo and Apunanwu, made it a point of duty not to return to Ojiji. In the early years, when they came to the country, Chief would meet them in Lagos. But after a while, even that stopped. After that awful Christmas, I didn't set my eyes on Anayo, the one whom I'd once thought myself in love with. As for Apunanwu, she finally returned in 2011, when Chief turned 70. The moment we clapped eyes on each other, I could see an even more intense hatred than what had been there the last time we'd seen each other that unfortunate Christmas of 1996, fifteen years before. But this time, I was not going to allow myself be bullied.

She had arrived at the ranch, shouting orders at everyone like she was the queen of the manor. She did everything she could to undermine me and my authority, but I was prepared to make her see that I would not be her pushover.

“Mba, Apunanwu. That’s not how we are going to do it,” I’d countered her, when she tried to steer her father’s birthday party in a completely different direction from what had already been planned. “Nobody is renting any hall in Asaba. This compound is good and big enough. We will decorate it accordingly, and it will more than meet our need for the day.”

“Will you keep quiet there?” she had snapped, finally able to confront me. “People are talking, and this one is talking. Is it because Akanna is not warming your bed today that you have the nerve to open that your gutter mouth to talk?”

Adanna of years before might have cowered into a corner, but not this one. Instead I smiled at her. “Apunanwu, I know you are frustrated so I will ignore all the nonsense coming out of your mouth. It’s not easy still living off your daddy at almost 40 years of age. Echegbula o. Don’t worry, keep praying to God for your own husband, and I’m sure He will soon send you one. In the meantime, allow me take care of my own, inugo?”

There was a snigger from one of the maids, and if looks could kill, Apunanwu would have murdered me a million times over. Her face was so red and swollen, I knew I’d touched a sore spot...but I didn’t care. I too could play dirty. I’d learnt how to. They’d taught me how.

She had withdrawn from the birthday planning and, on the day of the party itself, had been very subdued. It hadn’t helped seeing Akanna and his own grown children, nor her peers whose kids were in their teens as well, not to

talk of the distant relatives who kept badgering her about when she would get married.

On the one hand, I did sympathise with her. I also couldn't boast of being reasonably married, neither did I have kids of my own. We were far more alike than I wanted to accept. However, I knew that, given the chance to humiliate me, she would jump at it, so this made me savour and enjoy her own humiliation. She left Ojiji the very next day.

As for my sleepwalking, not only did it resume after Chizutere died, it got worse...so much worse. So dead was I to the world that I was now wandering further and further from where I would normally go. Even though the domestic staff were very protective of me and always were sure to see me back to my bedroom without anyone else being privy to what had happened when any of them found me, it soon got to the extent that even they couldn't hide my worsening condition. It was when the security men guarding the ranch at night mistook me for a thief and shot at me, the bullet missing me by mere inches, that Chief decided enough was enough. He took me to see Dr. Nwabuwa, the Medical Director of the only hospital in Ojiji.

“Oria nwata nwanyi a na-aka! This girl's issue is getting out of hand,” Chief lamented, the first time we went to the hospital. “Please, you have to help treat it before she disgraces me outside.”

The old doctor had looked perplexed, and even I could tell that my issue was way beyond him. He had gone ahead to prescribe several drugs, most of them anti-depressants, which only succeeded in making me dizzy and drowsy during the day, but nothing else. My sleepwalking only stopped for a day or two, after which it continued with a vengeance. But Chief insisted on my continued attendance at the hospital, and I was pumped with the

awful medication for about five years, which only succeeded in dampening my personality but not much else.

It wasn't until the old doctor died that I finally was free. At that point, Chief also resigned himself to the fact that nothing could cure my condition and instead put additional security measures in place, to ensure that I was at least contained within the compound.

And so in 2016, after twenty years as his bride, this was life as I knew it.

Until it all changed.

"I need to stop attending some of these useless functions," Chief complained, as we made our way from yet another occasion he had been invited to in town. "Not only do I gain nothing, I only end up spending money!"

I smiled and patted the old man's hand. At 75, he was no spring chicken. Even though he was still much stronger and more agile than many men his age, he had started slowing down in recent years. He now spent most of his time at home, and no longer had the same steady stream of women flocking to the house, but just the odd one or two.

"Don't worry, next time we get an invitation, if it isn't important, I will represent you," I offered, knowing fully well what his reaction to that would be.

As a more mature woman, I knew now that what I'd thought was possessiveness was actually an intense insecurity on his part. He preferred to keep me caged at home not only so as not to risk a repeat of the incident with his gardener, but to prevent another man of means from stealing me. It hadn't even been months after Chizutere died that my mobile phone had

mysteriously disappeared, and when I'd made an attempt to get another one a few years later, he had vehemently refused.

But I hadn't even put up much resistance. What did I need a phone for anyway? Who did I want to talk to, and who wanted to talk to me? Nobody, was the answer to both questions. Uzochi was on hand to relay and receive messages from my mother and brother, so that was enough for me.

"If I can't go, neither can you," had been his rigid response, prompting a knowing smile from me. I could now read him like a book.

We rode in congenial silence till we got to the ranch. I smiled and waved at Ukawuiké, the longtime guard, and his new companion, Abel, as the car drove past them. I knew it irked Chief that I was so close to the staff, but it was something I would not compromise on, not ever again.

"Who is that?" Chief remarked, as we noticed a car parked in front of the house. "What is the point of having security guards if they will allow any and everything into the compound. That was how they allowed that useless Chiasoka in years ago!"

After Chiasoka's unauthorised entry into the ranch many years before, the day she caught her late daughter with her lover, Chief always cited that as his perfect example of a security breach. As it did anytime her name was mentioned, my heart dropped.

She never did recover from Isioma's death. The loss of her daughter had led to the loss of her own sanity. Since that time, she'd roamed the streets of the village, looking unkempt and bedraggled, crying and shouting incoherent words. Anytime I happened to see her, my heart broke. She didn't recognise me, nor anyone else for that matter. She was completely lost to this world and lamenting to be a part of the one where her daughter now lived.

I looked at the Honda Accord parked in the driveway, trying to see if I could recognise it, but I couldn't. It was obviously not somebody from the village.

As we approached, a tall man got out of the car. He was so familiar to me but I couldn't quite remember where.

"Good evening, Sir. Good evening, Ma'am," he said, with a polite nod first at Chief then myself. "I was just about to leave you a message."

I smiled as I recognised who he was. "Naeto?" I exclaimed. "Dr. Nwabuwa's son?"

A broad smile broke on Chief's face. "Oh! Nwa Doctor! I wouldn't have recognised you walking on the street. How are you? And how is that your beautiful wife?"

Ah yes, his beautiful wife. My mind journeyed back to their beautiful wedding in Owerri so many years before, and how in love they had looked.

"She's fine. She's in the States," he answered.

"Oh yes, now I remember your late dad telling me you relocated there," Chief went on. "That's very good. It's much better for doctors over there. So sorry about your father, o! When he died, he left a big hole here. We really miss him."

Naeto cleared his throat. "Thank you, Sir. It's actually the reason I'm here. I've returned home to take over the hospital, so I just thought to pay you a courtesy visit to let you know."

"You don't mean it!" Chief exclaimed, his eyes almost popping from their sockets in his glee. "Nwunye'm, i nula? Did you hear that? This is fantastic news!"

I stared at the strange man incredulously, wondering why on earth he would do such a stupid thing, leave the U.S. to run a local village hospital.

“It was his wish, but I couldn’t return immediately as I was...taking care of a few things,” Naeto continued, not making any eye contact with me. “There’s a lot of work to be done, so it might be a few months before we resume the practice proper...”

“Nonsense! You will continue from where your father stopped with this my wife. She is very sick, and he was treating her before he died!” Chief said, rambling on and on about my sleepwalking.

Naeto cast a curious look at me, and I could see in his eyes that I didn’t look sick to him. I also straightened as I recognised the faintest hint of admiration and was pleased that, as usual, I had taken my time to look my best. But he looked away quicker than I liked, and I couldn’t help but wonder if I hadn’t just imagined it...his admiration.

As he and Chief chatted, I looked him over, head to toe. He no longer had the Clark Kent glasses and was not as lean as he’d been fourteen years before. I noticed his toned chest and arms beneath the Ralph Lauren polo shirt he wore, as well as the small dimple on his left cheek as he spoke.

“So, that settles it then!” Chief said, startling me out of my reverie. “Anyị ga-abịa echi. We’ll be there tomorrow.”

Naeto opened his mouth as if to protest, before thinking against it and nodding. “Okay, Sir. I look forward to seeing you,” then turning to me, he bowed again. “Enjoy the rest of your day, Ma’am.”

“Are you sure you don’t want to come in for dinner or something?” I asked, suddenly remembering my manners.

“Didn’t you hear when he said he had to rush to Asaba to meet someone?” Chief chided. “You see what I mean, nwa Doctor. Her mind is forever wandering!”

Naeto smiled, revealing again that dimple. “Thanks, Ma’am. I appreciate the invitation. Maybe some other time. I look forward to seeing you tomorrow.”

Chief walked ahead of me inside the house, and I couldn’t help but look back as Naeto got into his car. Our eyes held momentarily before he started his car and drove off. A small smile formed on my face.

This was going to be interesting.

Chapter Nineteen

The Doctor

I dreamt that I was floating on water.

I was floating on the waves of the most beautiful turquoise blue ocean, underneath the warm rays of the sun. The sky was a clear powder blue, and the sun a golden yellow ball, so large, it felt like I could reach out to touch it. As I glided on the water, I felt weightless...free. It almost felt like I was soaring in the clouds. I felt one with it all, like it was my natural habitat.

But then I felt the force of gravity pull me, and I was suddenly no longer floating. The friendly waves were now hostile, working against me as I struggled to remain afloat, my arms flailing. But I soon lost the battle and found myself sinking, free-falling to the ocean floor. Even though I could no longer breathe, it no longer felt like a struggle. Instead, I submitted myself to the pull of the water, in what was now a slow-motion tumble, and it felt like the most natural thing in the world...falling...sinking...dying.

The sound of loud voices around me, alongside the sudden inhalation of air, jolted me. I opened my eyes to find myself being dragged out, not from the beautiful blue ocean, but the stream that ran through the ranch. My sleepwalking had finally led me to the edge of the cliff. To death's door

itself. If it hadn't been for one of the night guards who had noticed an unusual form in the water, I would have drowned long before sun up.

By the time I was led back to my bedroom, wrapped in a warm blanket, I was shaken, and not just from the cold. It felt like I was truly possessed by a demon I had no control over.

"Ada, let me take you to see my pastor," Uzochi said, looking at me with her worry etched all over her face. Over the years, she had substituted her 'spiritualists' for a series of Pentecostal churches, each one more high-strung than the last. "This is a spiritual attack. We have been lax about it for way too long. You can see that the demons are now hungry for your life. We have to fight them back, fire for fire."

I nodded listlessly. At that point, I was ready to try just about anything. It frightened me how vivid this experience had been, but, even more so, how unwilling I had been to fight for my life. I knew then that I couldn't allow my sleepwalking continue for much longer.

Later that morning, Chief and I made our way to downtown Ojiji, where Dr. Nwabuwa's hospital was located. A modest one-storey building, it had been the town's only means of health care, with the amiable doctor happy to attend to patients from 7 am to midnight. The old man lived for his practice and was beloved by the entire community, in and outside of Ojiji. When he died, his young protégé took over the place, but he'd had neither the temperament nor patience to continue.

With the old doctor barely charging his patients a kobo, there wasn't much money to be made from the place, a truth the new doctor found too bitter to accept. And so, less than a year after taking it over, the hospital was shut down and had remained desolate in the three years since.

But from the look of things, Dr. Naeto Nwabuwa had grand plans for the place. The building wore a fresh coat of paint, and more modern fittings had replaced the forlorn windows and rusty doors that had been there before. Inside, even the old furniture had given way to contemporary and functional seating.

I looked around, on one hand impressed by the calming hues of cream, mint and lavender, and the tasteful pieces of artwork, paintings, and sculptures that adorned the place. But on the other hand, I couldn't help but scoff at the pretentiousness of it all. Why do all this for a small village clinic, where he could only charge patients so much? It didn't make sense.

"Good morning, Sir. Good morning, Ma'am," he greeted, walking out of his father's old office. "I saw you arrive from my window."

"Where are your nurses? Are you the only one here?" Chief asked.

Naeto smiled. "I'm still in the process of hiring suitable hands. Remember, I did tell you it would be at least a few weeks before we can attend to patients."

"I like what you've done with the place though," Chief remarked, looking around. "But isn't it a bit much for the local people here? It looks like you have spent a lot of money."

"I've had a good deal of support," Naeto answered. "A few of my colleagues back in the U.S. have partnered with me on this project, more as a way for us to give back. Some of them will even be flying in occasionally, to treat the patients here pro bono."

"Pro gini?" Chief repeated, confused.

"He means free of charge," I explained, keeping a cautious eye on the doctor turned philanthropist. I had grown very distrusting of people who

acted like they didn't want anything in exchange for favours they gave.

"Is your wife one of these doctors? When is she coming to join you?" Chief asked.

"Very soon, Sir."

"With your family? Your children?"

"All of them," he answered, a bit too hastily, before turning around to lead us to his office.

I smiled at the large portrait of his father hanging on the wall. He had been one of the kindest human beings I'd ever met in my life, and even though I'd been relieved I would no longer be pumped with drugs in his failed attempt to contain my illness, I'd been genuinely upset when he passed away.

"I'm sorry for the mess," Naeto said, shifting aside a huge pile of folders. "In between conducting interviews, I've been trying to convert old records to a digital and easier accessible format. It's easier to track and monitor a patient's history that way."

"Hmmm," Chief couldn't have sounded less interested in what he was saying. "Doctor, you have to do something about my wife. Ọ pụtawo n'aka. Her issue is getting out of hand. Can you believe this sickness almost drowned her this morning? It was in the stream they found her."

Naeto looked at me in concern. "How long were you underwater? Do you have any chest pain? How is your breathing? I'm going to have to examine you to make sure you don't have water in your lungs."

"Doctor, hapụ nke ahụ! Let's focus on the real issue here. She is very fine, as you can see," Chief retorted, getting impatient.

“We need to rule out any case of delayed drowning, Sir. This happens in a lot of cases,” Naeto answered firmly.

“I’ve heard you. But let’s pay more attention to the trigger, if not, maybe it’s every day we will be treating this ‘delayed drowning’!” Chief insisted.

Naeto looked through a worn paper folder on his table and shook his head. “Sir, after our discussion yesterday, I went looking for your wife’s file. Frankly, I can’t understand why my father had her on such a high dose of anti-depressants and tranquillizers. It makes no sense to me. Did they even work at all?”

I shook my head. “Only the first night he prescribed them. After that, they had no effect. Nothing changed.”

“And you were on them for five years?” he shook his head, shutting the file. “Chief, I don’t think I have the expertise to treat your wife’s condition and, God rest his soul, neither did my father, from all indication. Maybe she could see a clinical psychologist or an occupational therapist...”

“My wife is not a lunatic. She has a problem, yes, but it hasn’t gotten to that stage yet,” Chief retorted. “Frankly, I think her brain is just idle. She does nothing from morning to night and just roams around the compound all day, playing with flowers. I think that’s what is wasting away her brain.”

Naeto glanced at me again before shrugging. “I’m no expert, and I am yet to come across any empirical correlation between idleness and mental health. But I guess it wouldn’t be a bad idea to get her engaged in something. Maybe if she is busy during the day, she might be too tired at night to sleepwalk.”

“Exactly!”

Naeto started to write. “So, Madam...are there any things you like to do? Any activities you’d want to sign up for? Swimming? Tennis? Or maybe you could become active in one of your church societies?” He shrugged again. “Or you could come help out here as well. That way, I’ll be able to keep a closer eye on you.”

I almost burst into laughter at the ridiculousness of the suggestion. As if Chief, a man who wouldn’t even let me have a mobile phone, would allow me leave the ranch to get an actual job.

“I like that. I like that suggestion,” Chief said, to my surprise. “You don’t even have to pay her. Let her just be able to leave the house and make herself useful. In fact, thinking about it, I’m very sure that’s what she needs.”

“Madam will most definitely be paid, Sir,” Naeto answered, smiling. “I just hope what the hospital can afford won’t be an insult to her.”

Chief hissed. “If that’s the only problem, then we have no problem!” he declared, rising to his feet. “She can even start now.”

I looked up at my husband in a state of panic. “I don’t think Doctor is ready for me...”

“Nonsense. Didn’t you see how he was struggling with all those files?” Chief answered, before turning to Naeto. “Unfortunately, she is not very educated, so you just have to make do with her limited capacity.”

Naeto looked my way, clearly embarrassed for me. “From what I have observed, I think she is more than smart enough.”

“Great,” Chief beamed. “Ada, my lovely wife, ana’m ahapụ. I’m sure you can find your way back home. And please, don’t argue with the doctor about salary, biko. Whatever he says he will pay you, collect. God knows I

would even gladly pay him if this will mean all that your abali ije will stop.”

I looked on, mouth agape, as Naeto saw Chief out and was still like that when he returned to the room. For someone who had kept me caged like an animal for two decades, this sudden push into the wild was something I had difficulty wrapping my head around.

“So, Madam...” Naeto began, taking his seat.

“My name is Adanna,” was my own curt answer.

He nodded and smiled. “Apologies. So, Adanna, I find it hard to believe you’re as uneducated as your husband said. There aren’t many illiterate people who know the meaning of pro bono.”

I shrugged. “Well, he said the truth. I’m not educated.”

“You didn’t go beyond primary school?”

I scowled at the insult. “I left school a few weeks shy of starting my GCSEs.”

“That’s not at all illiterate,” he said. “Why didn’t you finish?”

“I got married,” was my matter-of-fact answer.

He nodded even though I could see several questions still on his face. “Do you know how to use a computer?”

“No,” I answered, suddenly angry with myself for not teaching myself with the one in Chief’s study. “But I know how to type. I can use a typewriter very well.”

Well, as well as anyone who hadn’t touched the machine in twenty years could.

Naeto pondered over that. “Well, I guess that’s fair enough. The same basic principles...in a way.” He looked up at me. “So, you mean you’ve never worked before? Never had a job in your life?”

“I used to work for my parents during the holidays,” I answered proudly. “I watched their shop and also helped them with book keeping. I was one of the best Accounting students in my class.”

He arched a brow. “Impressive.”

“I was also best in Mathematics, Chemistry, Physics and Geography,” I added, desperate to impress him even more, to erase whatever opinion he had of me as a local, village housewife.

“So, why on earth didn’t you go to university?” he asked, leaning forward in his bewilderment. “Your parents couldn’t afford it?”

All my defences immediately went up. “Something like that,” I answered, my tone and body language now stiff.

Catching on to the change in my demeanour, he thankfully changed the topic. “There really isn’t that much to do here. I’ve already hired an administrator who will be starting work in about a week or so. I guess you could start by helping me with some small data entry. Transferring information from these,” he patted the large pile of folders, “to that,” he added, pointing at his laptop. “You know how to type, so it shouldn’t be a big deal.”

I looked at the laptop like it was the devil, sick to my stomach about making a fool of myself. I wouldn’t even have known what to do with a typewriter if it was placed in front of me, talkless of the sleek and modern laptop device. Sensing my apprehension, Naeto popped it open, showed me how to launch Microsoft Excel and how to input the required data. As I

tried it for myself, I realised he hadn't been lying at all. The keyboard was very similar to the typewriters I'd been taught how to use in school, and within the hour, I was comfortably transferring the information from the files to the machine.

As I worked, he proceeded to continue organising the place, which included unpacking books from a box, deliberating additional modification with some workmen who came at different intervals, and several discussions on his phone. He was clearly determined to get the hospital off the ground, and I couldn't help but admire his gumption.

"Wow! You did all that?" he exclaimed, looking at the large number of files I had successfully converted. "And you say you've never used a computer before?"

"It's just like using a typewriter," I beamed, so happy I hadn't let myself down.

"Well, for this purpose. But we're going to have to get you learn how to really use one. I'll have to take out time to show you the other nifty things a computer can do. But very well done!" he looked at his wristwatch. "It's getting late. Do you want me to call you a taxi?"

I looked at the time. It was only a little past 4 pm, and I was in no hurry to head back home. "I can still do another hour."

"You're sure?"

I smiled and returned my attention to the laptop. He took his seat on the other side of the table and rummaged through an old diary. From how worn it looked, it probably belonged to his late father, and I was touched by how desperately he wanted to not just fill the old man's shoes, but even exceed every expectation.

“So, when is she coming?” I asked. He looked at me confused, confirming my inner suspicion. “Your wife,” I added for clarity.

“Oh. Soon,” was his vague answer, returning his attention to the folder.

“I remember your wedding. It was so beautiful. Your wife, Fuchi is her name, right? I couldn’t help but admire what a beautiful bride she was. You didn’t look too bad yourself,” I said, trying to make conversation.

“Hmmm,” he mumbled, not even looking up from the folder.

“Her dress! I’m sure it cost a fortune. All that lace and all those pearls and stones! She looked like an angel. So lean and tall! Is she still that way?”

This time, he didn’t answer, and it made me insistent to press on.

“Naeto, you aren’t wearing a wedding ring, and there is no imprint on your finger to show that you’ve worn one in the recent past. There are no pictures on your desk or anywhere, and I’ve been here over five hours, but there has been no phone call, neither to nor from anyone that sounds like a wife, or even a child for that matter,” I said, looking at him closely. “And I’m sure it’s not as a result of time difference.”

He looked up from the folder, the emotions on his face ranging from shock to anger to amusement. “Impressive,” he conceded. “You’re correct. Fuchi and I are no longer together. We’ve been divorced about ten years.”

“So, why the lies?”

He shrugged. “It’s just easier for the town folk to understand this way. There’s no need going around telling people how my wife of less than three years left because of ‘irreconcilable differences’. It’s less complicated for them to think I have a wife and brood of kids back in America.”

“What happened?” I asked, saddened that the couple that had looked so much in love hadn’t been able to achieve forever in the end.

He looked at me, as if wondering how much he should disclose to a complete stranger. “We grew apart, I guess. Her ambition was one of the things that made me fall in love with her, and it was the same thing that tore us apart in the end. We realised we wanted totally different things; I wanted more of her, but she wanted more of the world. We separated a few days shy of our third anniversary.”

“I’m so sorry to hear that,” I said, genuinely meaning it. They had been such a beautiful couple. “That’s a long time to have been alone. How come you never remarried?”

He shrugged. “I decided to follow her cue and chase a career as well. I specialised first of all in Family Medicine, and then Endocrinology. Before coming to Nigeria, I was an attending physician in one of the biggest hospitals in Houston.”

“So, why give that up to come back here? To this dead village?”

He smiled, obviously having answered this question a lot of times. “Apart from it being my father’s wish, I had this urge to give back. I was making so much money, but for what really? A group of Nigerian doctors came together and decided it was time for us to do something about the state of healthcare back home. We could no longer bear to hear all the horror stories coming from home and knew we just had to do something. I volunteered, mainly because I already had the infrastructure, and the others have also agreed to come periodically to contribute their own quota. The hospital will be run from money we all pooled together, and if we’re lucky, we might be able to get a hospital or two over there to support us.”

“What about Fuchi? Do you hear from her?” I asked, unable to contain my curiosity. “Did she ever regret leaving you?”

“Regret is such a strong word,” he answered. “Yes, she did want us to give it another shot, and we actually tried briefly. But it just wasn’t the same. The damage had been done, and I just couldn’t love her the way I once had. In the end, she accepted a job offer in Germany and, apart from the odd birthday email now and then, we’re not really in touch.”

I shook my head. “That’s so sad. You two were the perfect couple. Watching your first dance was like seeing love itself. You don’t know how much I envied your love.”

“Well, these things happen,” he shrugged, returning to the folder.

“I remember it was a Stevie Wonder song,” I continued reminiscing. “I don’t know the title, but I will never forget the melody. I hummed it for days afterwards.”

He nodded absentmindedly, but I wasn’t prepared to be ignored.

“Well? What was the song?” I prodded. “And don’t pretend you can’t remember, because I’m sure you do. You were both singing the lyrics to each other, and I’m sure it meant something to both of you.”

He chuckled. “No wonder your husband was eager to dump you here. Is this how troublesome you are?”

The smile on my face waned. If only he knew I was the complete opposite of that.

“The song was Overjoyed, and yes, it was, and still is, my favourite Stevie Wonder song,” he answered. “But no, we both weren’t singing the song to each other. I was singing it to her, but she wasn’t singing it to me. The song wasn’t exactly her cup of tea,” he shut his folder. “Madam Adanna, it is

almost 5pm. Let me call you a taxi before your husband wonders what I've done with you."

"Just play the song for me, and I'll get out of your hair. I promise," I pleaded, my hands clasped in supplication.

He looked at me for several seconds, before turning the laptop to face him. After a few clicks, Stevie Wonder's sonorous voice filled the room. I closed my eyes in bliss, the song having the same effect it had on me thirteen years before.

Years before, I'd fallen in love with the melody, but sitting there and listening to the lyrics, hearing the words for the very first time melted my heart.

"I haven't listened to that song in years," Naeto said, a sad smile on his face. "I guess too many painful memories."

"It's beautiful," was all I could manage to say.

"I could send it to you, if you like it so much," he offered. "Give me your phone number and I'll send it."

"I don't have a phone," I answered, ashamed for the very first time of that admission.

He was visibly surprised but chose not to say anymore.

I rose to my feet, feeling suddenly lightheaded. "Thanks so much for the job. I'll be back again tomorrow."

"Won't you wait for me to at least call you a taxi?" he asked, also standing up. "I would have dropped you, but I'm expecting someone here in a few minutes."

"It's fine. I want to walk anyway. The ranch isn't too far from here."

“And we haven’t even discussed your salary,” Naeto said, a cheeky smile playing on his lips. “Let me know if our small funds can accommodate your demand.”

“Getting out of the house is payment enough,” I answered. “Thank you so much. See you tomorrow.”

I walked out of the room before he could protest further, and as I walked back to the ranch, it felt like I was gliding on air, the song replaying not only in my head...but in my heart. I ignored the cat-calls from some young men smoking under a tree and waved cheerily at other people who greeted me along the way. Getting back to the ranch, I was all smiles and declined the offer of dinner. How could I eat when my heart was full to overflowing?

Lying in bed that night, I hummed the parts of the song I could still remember. And I shut my eyes, basking in the realisation that I was hopelessly in love with Doctor Naeto Nwabuwa.

Chapter Twenty

The Seductress

I woke up the next morning with a song on my lips and joy in my heart. From the moment I got out of bed, it felt like I was being carried by butterflies; my heart, body, mind, and soul were floating, basking in the euphoria of my newfound feelings for the young doctor. Not even for Chizutere nor Anayo had I felt this kind of overwhelming, all-consuming love.

I couldn't help but replay every single detail of the day before, remembering every feature of his handsome face down to the small birthmark on his left earlobe, the smooth baritone that enveloped his impeccable diction, and his smell that was a potpourri of mint, lemon, and musk. Everything about him was intoxicating, and I was ready to do anything it would take to be with him. Anything.

As I dressed up that morning, I took very special care to look my very best. I stuck to the nude and brown makeup palette I knew complimented my face best and wore a knee-length jersey dress that accentuated my figure in all the right places. My hair was released from its typical bun and, instead, left to flow freely down my back. Taking a step back, I stood before my full-length mirror and was satisfied with what I saw. There was no way he would be able to resist me.

“Wow! All for this your work. I should have gotten you a job a long time ago, if that would have made you dress up like the Adanna that scattered my head twenty years ago,” Chief remarked as I walked downstairs. “You look beautiful, my wife.”

“Thank you,” I mumbled, unwilling to make eye contact. The last thing I wanted was to rouse his suspicion. “I wanted to wear something more casual today, just in case I have to do any heavy lifting.”

Chief nodded and smiled. “Of course.”

I noticed the butler carrying bags to the car. “Are you travelling?” I asked.

“Oh, sorry. I forgot to tell you. I have a few meetings in Benin and Port Harcourt, after which I have to sort out some things in London,” he answered casually. “So, I might be gone for a while. I hope you won’t miss me too much.”

“Haba di’m. How can you say that? Of course, I will,” I added, trying not to smile as broadly as my heart wanted to. How fortuitous was it for him to be going away at the very time I wanted more time with my newfound love!

“Here is some money for you, even though you are now a salary earner,” he chuckled, pressing a fat envelope into my hand. “By the way, how much did you and the doctor agree on?”

“We didn’t agree on anything,” I answered truthfully. “Maybe today.”

“And when did he say his family is arriving again?”

“Erm, before the end of the year,” was my brazen lie. It was in everyone’s best interest for Chief to remain under the impression that Naeto was still happily married.

“Ngwanu, take care of yourself,” Chief said, patting me on the shoulder. “The driver can take you to the clinic every day, but if I were you I would walk. The exercise will do you good.”

I nodded, wishing he would just leave already.

“And you can see that it’s already working. I was told you didn’t sleepwalk last night,” he remarked, taking plenty of pride in his role in that small victory.

And it was true. For the first time in a long while, I hadn’t ventured out of my room the night before, thus confirming my suspicion that happiness, true happiness, was the only antidote to my sleepwalking.

I stood at the door, waving until the car disappeared down the driveway, before I too started making my way out. I was already later than I wanted to be.

“Adanna! Where are you going this early morning? I gaghị eri nri ụtụtụ?” Uzochi called out.

“I’m not hungry. I need to go now. I got a job at Doctor Nwabuwa’s clinic,” I answered, trying to mask my impatience. “His son has returned to manage it.”

“You got a job?” she exclaimed as if I’d spoken a foreign language. “And Chief is aware of it?”

“Very aware. It was even his idea,” was my confident answer.

“You don’t mean it,” she gave me a cautious look. “And is that what you’re wearing to go? Isn’t it too tight? And you want to leave your hair flying all over the place? Won’t it disturb?”

“I have to go now. I’m already late,” I said, waving at her as I continued walking, not wanting to give her any further room to postulate.

Walking to the clinic, I found myself wishing I’d asked one of the drivers to drop me there. The sandals I wore, though cute and dainty, did nothing to protect my feet from dust, so I arrived at the clinic looking like I’d been trekking through the Sahara. Thankfully, the door was open, so I made a detour to the toilet and painstakingly cleaned my feet with toilet paper, not wanting all my work to beautify myself undone by dust, of all things.

When I was sure I looked perfect, I made my way to his office, where he was typing away on his laptop.

“Good morning, Naeto,” I said, my voice a seductive purr.

“Good morning, Adanna,” he answered, not even looking up from his device. “You’re quite late. It’s almost 11am.”

Trying not to be dissuaded by the fact that he hadn’t even cared to look at me, I walked closer to him, my heady fragrance of honey and vanilla following me like an entourage. “I’m so sorry. Chief travelled this morning, so I had to attend to him.”

“No problem. You can sit at the front desk for now,” he said, still not taking his eyes off his machine. “Quite a lot of people have come here asking questions, so it will be a good idea for a familiar face to give them the answers they want.”

“You...you don’t want me to finish with the folders?”

He finally looked up. “Oh, I finished them last night. They weren’t even as many as I’d initially thought.”

I don’t know what irked me more. The fact that he had decided to finish the task he’d given me, or the fact that he looked away without even

acknowledging how beautiful I looked.

“So...you want me to sit at the front desk?” I echoed, still in disbelief.

He looked up again and smiled. “If that won’t be too much trouble. I actually think it would be a perfect fit for you for now. That way, you’re not out of your comfort zone too much.”

Walking to the front desk, I was so enraged I could have killed someone. Not out of my comfort zone? I had been top of my class and would probably have ended up either a doctor like him or a NASA astronaut if I’d only been able to make it to the university. Comfort zone indeed!

I took a seat behind the large oak desk, seething as I stared at the mint and lavender walls. Who was I even kidding? I was nothing but a local village woman to him. I might have considered myself beautiful, but I was clearly nothing close to the other beauties he had seen in his lifetime, a classic example being his former wife. Compared to her, I was nothing but a local champion.

“I hope you’re not too bored,” he said, walking out of his office after what had to have been the longest two hours of my life. “I heard you speaking with one or two people.”

It took everything in me not to let out a long hiss, demanding if he had really engaged me to be answering such banal questions as “Kedu ihe unu na-eme ebe a?”, “Mee ndị ọcha nwere ebe a?”, “Ebe a ka bụ ụlọ ọgwụ?”. I’d been tempted to retort: “What do we do here? We sell cars, that’s what!”; “Are the owners of this place white people? No, they’re from the moon!”; “Is this place still a hospital? No, it’s actually a shrine. Walk right in, so we can use you as a sacrifice!”

But instead, I’d shrugged. “Just people asking basic questions.”

“I’m off to Asaba to interview a doctor I desperately want to hire,” he said as he made his way to the door. “If I’m not back by the time you have to leave, please help me lock the door and put the key behind the flower pot. Thanks again for coming.”

And just like that, he was gone. All my makeup, all my grand plans of seduction for the day washed down the drain. He didn’t come back before I left that evening, but as I walked home that day, I was more than determined to win him at all costs.

“Nwanyi oma!” came catcalls from the same group of young men drinking under a tree nearby. “Who is allowing this beautiful woman walk under the hot sun like this?”

Even though I ignored them and continued my trek to the ranch, I couldn’t help but feel emboldened. I might not have been educated or exposed much, but I knew I could stand my own with whatever high standard Naeto was used to. I hadn’t been dreaming when I’d seen the look of desire in his eyes, the day he came by the house, or even the previous day when he’d been telling me about his past. He wanted me just as much as I wanted him.

I tried to silence the little voice in my head, reminding me of what happened the last time I’d nursed this type of desire. It had led to the death of an innocent boy and his family. If anything happened between Naeto and I, and Chief found out about it, there was no telling what the evil man would do to him. But I quickly shook it off, convincing myself it would be different this time.

We wouldn’t make the same mistakes Chizutere and I had made. We would run away quicker this time, maybe he would even take me to America. He would sell his father’s hospital, and we would live happily ever after, far away from Chief’s evil clutches.

Yes, that was what was going to happen.

But the next day when I got to the hospital, not only were there two additional people there, Naeto looked even less interested than he had the day before. After a brisk introduction, he left again for Asaba. Thankfully, the two new hires, Ebele, the administrator, and Helen, an auxiliary nurse, were people I knew from town, so it hadn't been too awkward. I couldn't help but mourn the loss of our privacy, though. How were Naeto and I supposed to fall in love under this kind of circumstance, in full view of an audience?

As the days rolled into weeks, our 'audience' grew in number, adding two more auxiliary nurses, three qualified nurses, a matron, two doctors, three cleaners, and a janitor. By the start of the fourth week, not only was the place fully staffed, we had opened our doors to the patients. I remained at the front desk and had to put up a brave smile to all the surprised looks from people, shocked to see Chief Nsofor's wife sitting behind a desk.

The real tragedy was how much further from my reach Naeto got with every passing day and every new hire. But the even bigger tragedy was how invisible I now was to him. It was almost like I'd imagined the whole thing; our mutual attraction and the wonderful time we'd had together, sitting in his office that first day, listening to Stevie Wonder. It seemed like it had happened in another lifetime...and not this one, where he was my boss, and I was nothing but the minion hired to man the front desk.

But I didn't give up and, instead, showed up looking my best every single day. Whilst it only got me more catcalls from street boys, and a few lustful stares from the younger of the two doctors, Naeto was as oblivious to my charms as if he'd pulled cloth over his eyes.

And then I came up with an idea. I finally figured out what would be the perfect tool to grab his attention.

“Do you have a moment?” I asked late one evening, when the last of the patients had left the building.

“Adanna, you’re still here?” he exclaimed. “It’s almost 8pm!”

“It’s okay, I was studying, and I lost track of time.”

“Studying?”

I nodded, happy he was catching the bait. “I’ve been thinking about what you said...about me furthering my education. So, I’ve decided to try my hands at the next GCSE.”

A broad smile broke on his face. “That’s fantastic, Adanna. I’m very glad to hear that,” his smile waned a bit. “But it won’t be easy, especially considering how long ago you were in school. What books are you reading?”

My mind raced for a suitable answer, considering I had been doing nothing of the sort. “Erm, just an old textbook I found at home. It has past questions.”

“Tell you what, I’ll try to get my hands on a few when next I’m in Asaba, and maybe see if I can find a tutor who can come here to help you for an hour a day. How does that sound?”

Like a downright drag, was what I thought. I had not the slightest desire to put myself through the humiliation of returning to school, but as it was the most reaction I’d gotten from him in weeks, I decided to run with it.

“It sounds perfect!” I lied, with a megawatt smile of my own.

“And if that’s not enough, I’ll be glad to also lend a helping hand,” he added.

Now that was more like it.

“Thank you, Naeto. I’d really appreciate it,” I said, loving him all the more for his selfless generosity. He was everything I had dreamt about in a man. Everything.

True to his words, the next day, he presented me with a box full of books; new ones he’d picked from Asaba and a few ones he had used himself.

“I know my books will be even more dated than anything you have, but I just figured they would be of a little help,” he said modestly. Looking through the marked-up yellowed pages of the old books, with their accompanying perfectly answered past questions, I knew they would be of more than a ‘little help’. If only I were interested.

“Thank you,” I smiled at him and was glad when I saw a flicker in his own eyes. He wasn’t as immune to me as he made out to be.

“I wasn’t able to find a suitable tutor,” he said, quickly looking away. “I’ll keep looking though, but in the meantime, just see what you can do on your own, and let me know if you need any help.”

Oh, I most definitely would.

The next day was a Friday, and from the moment I left the house that morning, I was determined that would be the day I would make him mine. I left several buttons of the fitted shirt I wore undone, and paired it with a long, tight skirt with a slit that went thigh high. I wove my hair into a single plait, making my slick hair slicker still with heaps of hair gel. There was no way, absolutely no way, he would be able to resist me.

Upon getting to the hospital and seeing the long line of patients waiting, I quickly buttoned up my blouse properly. There was no point having my cleavage on display for half the village to see. I decided it was best to save the nudity for later.

By evening, after the last of the patients had left and the last of the nurses had clocked out, I knew there was no better time. Popping open the buttons again, I grabbed a random book from the pile and knocked on the door.

“Sorry to disturb you, but I seem to have a problem with...” I cast a cursory look at the book I’d grabbed and was appalled to see it was a literature book, “...this book.”

He arched a brow. “Harvest of Corruption. I got it because I was told it’s one of the books in this year’s syllabus, even though I wasn’t sure if Literature is one of the subjects you’re interested in. I haven’t read it though, so I might not be of much help.”

I walked to his desk, leaning forward such that my breasts were almost bursting out of my blouse. “I’m not that good with literature, so maybe you could read it to me?”

He was momentarily flustered, looking away quickly. But not before I’d seen the look of raw desire in his eyes. He wanted me, no doubt about it.

“Why don’t you start with the other subjects you were good at before? You could try to freshen up on your Chemistry, Physics, and even Math. When we get you a tutor, he can help you with the rest,” he said, small beads of sweat forming around his brow.

“It’s okay, I’ll just read this here,” I said, sitting down opposite him, determined not to leave without winning him over.

He continued to type, but his tension was obvious. He seemed to be doing everything in his power not to look at me. After several minutes of struggling, he shut his laptop. "I think I need to call it a day. It's been a long week."

As he rose to his feet, I rose to mine as well. I stood there as he packed up his things and got a lot of satisfaction in seeing the slight tremble of his hands.

"Do you want me to give you a ride home?" he asked.

By now, even though he was standing about a foot away from me, it was the closest we had been since that first day in his clinic. And I knew I just had to grab the moment.

So, I kissed him.

In a single stride, I closed the gap between us, wrapped my arms around his neck, and kissed him. At first I felt him tense in surprise, and then soften as his own hands seemed to rest on my side, but then suddenly he pushed me away.

"What was that, Adanna?!" he exclaimed in horror. "What did you do that for?"

I looked at him, shocked by his reaction. "This is what we both want, Naeto. Tell me you haven't wanted this from the very first day we met?"

"Wanted what? Christ!" he exclaimed. "You're a married woman, Adanna. What is this rubbish?"

By now, I was beyond mortified. "Naeto..."

"Please leave!" he shouted. "Just go, I beg you."

Tears pooled in my eyes, my heart broken by his rejection. If I'd been asked to imagine a million different ways that would have played out, him rejecting me would never have been one of them. I was crushed... devastated...shattered. Every single dream I'd had of being with him had been ripped apart to pieces.

I staggered out of the building, blinded by my tears. All of a sudden, it was 2004 all over again. How could I have thought Naeto would want a dirty and broken woman like me? I was no good for anyone, and the same way I had been rejected when I'd tried returning home to Onitsha, the same way my would-have-been suitor David had eventually rejected me, was the same way Naeto had just rejected me. I was good for nothing. Good for nobody.

"Ewo! Nwanyi oma, who is making you cry?" came one of the voices I'd grown accustomed to from under the tree. "What's the matter?"

I found myself slowing down and, for the first time, turned to look where the voice was coming from. There were only three men sitting there that evening, a far cry from their usual number of about a dozen. The one who had spoken walked up to me, concern etched all over his face.

"Nne, who did this to you? Gwa'm, let me go and finish the person. Is it the doctor inside that hospital?" he asked, his false anger making him gyrate like a bad Nollywood actor. "Tell me, so I can go inside and scatter that place!"

I shook my head. "It's nothing. I just have a bit of a headache."

"So, why are you walking?" he asked. "Let me drop you at home. It's the least I can do for a beautiful lady like yourself."

He pointed in the direction of a small 1998 Honda Accord parked across the road, and I realised he was the famous Abaeze, popularly known as 'Baz', I

had heard so much of. A young man who had made money from spending questionable hours on his computer daily, he was a legend amongst the younger folks. On several occasions, I'd overheard Daluchi and some of the young maids talk about him with much excitement. He was one of the most popular young men in the village, and yet, here he was, lusting after me.

"Okay," I said, surprising both of us.

"Today has got to be Christmas, New Year, and my birthday all rolled into one," he exclaimed, as he drove. "For me to have you, Adanna, the most beautiful woman in the world, sitting in my car? This has got to be a dream!"

I smiled in spite of myself, flattered beyond measure. Maybe I wasn't that bad after all.

It was a short ride to the ranch, and when we got there, Baz leaned towards me. "I don't know what you are doing with that old man. Let me show you things only a young man like myself can show you!"

"Thank you for the ride," I said, ignoring him and making to open the door.

"Nne, why are you rushing? The night is still young," he said, putting his hand over mine. "Let me take you out. Let's go to the club in Asaba this evening. There we can...you know...get to know each other better."

I looked at him and was suddenly overcome by the need, the inexplicable need, to prove to myself that I was still desirable.

"Okay," I said, surprising us both again. "But I have to change."

He licked his lips. "Nsogbu adighi. There's no problem. I'll wait for you."

"Park by the pure water factory," I said, getting out of the car. "At the back." There was no way I would get into a stranger's car in the dead of

night, right in front of my husband's gate.

Getting into the house, I went looking for Daluchi. Uzochi's daughter was now in her late twenties and was her mother's carbon copy. She had managed to get into university and struggled through it for years. Clearly not academically inclined, she'd eventually dropped out and was still trying to figure out what to do with her life.

"I'm going to the club," I said, the minute she walked into my room. "I need something to wear."

She stared at me, mouth agape. "Club kwa? Who is taking you to club?"

"I'll tell you when I get back. Just bring me one of your outfits," I insisted. As desperate as I was to do anything to take my mind off the crushing rejection I'd faced that evening, I was well aware that there was nothing in my wardrobe that was trendy enough for nightlife.

She shook her head vehemently. "Not until you tell me who is taking you. I need to know, in case of any emergency."

"Baz," I answered, throwing all caution to the wind.

Her eyes widened in amazement and awe. She shut the door behind her, pulling me to the bed. "Baz is taking you to a club? Are you serious?"

She couldn't have looked more excited if I'd said I was going out with her idol, Jim Iyke. After subjecting me to telling her all about how he had offered me a ride home and then thrown in the invitation to go clubbing, she'd finally gone to get me several clothing options to choose from.

"Aunty Ada, please go and enjoy your life!" she squealed, entering my room with her arms laden with what looked to be her entire wardrobe. "Fine woman like you, I don't know why you've just been here suffering all these years. Go and enjoy yourself, biko."

I said nothing as I tried option after option, before finally settling on a halter neck blouse, which moulded every contour of my breasts, while at the same time leaving my back exposed, pairing it with a pair of equally skin tight jeans. At least a size smaller than me, Daluchi's clothes were bound to be tight. I sat as she applied makeup on me in the heavy-handed manner she favoured. I was present there only physically, my heart still in shards on Naeto's office floor. But I was determined to move on from that. I was determined to reaffirm my desirability, if not to anyone, to myself.

When I was dressed, Daluchi and I tiptoed barefoot out of the house.

"Not a word to anyone," I whispered hoarsely.

She mimicked pulling a zip across her lips. "My lips are sealed. Aunty, please go and enjoy yourself. And make sure you come back with plenty gist!" She pressed a phone into my hand. "This is mine. When you come back, dial my mom's number. I'll have it with me and will answer so I can come open the door for you."

I nodded, before walking towards the direction of the back gate. I hadn't been there in the twelve years it had been since Chizutere's death, and walking down that dark path brought back memories so raw and vivid, they could have been yesterday. But absolutely nothing had changed. The padlock was still damaged, and the gate still rusty. The only difference was that the large expanse of land at the back was no longer under dispute and had been developed into an industrial estate. After putting on my shoes, keeping my head bowed, I walked to the end of the road where the pure water factory was, and, just as instructed, Baz's car was parked right there.

"Wow!" he exclaimed upon sighting me. "Wow!"

His eyes were almost bulging out of their sockets as he looked at me...like I was a piece of raw meat. I reveled in his adulation, the look of

unadulterated lust in his eyes. I might not have been Naeto's cup of tea, but I was clearly more than a cup to many others. In fact, I was the whole teapot.

He led me into his car, his arm naughtily grazing my bottom. I smiled at his brazenness, determined to do everything I needed to make me forget my heartbreak and my insecurities.

It was a short drive to the nightclub in Asaba, an impressive two-storey structure which, rumour had it, was owned by a young politician desperate to launder his loot. The place was filled to the rafters, with people dancing and merry-making under the flashing lights, and music so loud, I could feel the reverberations through my body.

Maybe it was the heavy makeup, maybe it was because it was the last place anyone would expect to see me, but for some reason nobody looked at me like I was out of place. I was just one of the people who had come to have their fun. And I liked it...the invincibility and anonymity of it.

Baz pulled me to him as Mr. Eazi's Skin Tight pulsed through the speakers, and we danced...a little closer than I had ever danced with anyone. Looking around, I saw that kind of dancing was the norm and submitted myself to even more flirtatious, suggestive dancing. As I wound my waist, I noticed several of the other men around were staring at me, desire in their eyes, and it empowered me all the more. So, I continued to dance, rolling my hips the way I saw the other women do, smiling as I made eye contact with each and everyone of the men looking at me, showing them what they desired...but would never have.

"You're a real naughty one, aren't you?" Baz said, grabbing my buttocks and pulling me close enough to feel his erection.

That was the wakeup call I needed.

I wriggled out of his grasp, but he wasn't prepared to let go. His hands were roving around my whole body, and when he reached for my breasts, I slapped him hard across the face.

"Are you crazy?" I yelled.

He put his hands up. "My bad. Forgive me. I guess I got too excited."

Almost as if doused by a bucket of cold water, I looked around, at the gyrating people around me, and I suddenly wondered what on earth I was doing there.

"Take me home," I said. "I want to go home. Take me home now!"

Baz smiled coyly. "Sure. Let's go."

I was surprised he hadn't protested but glad that I would at least be taken far away from that place. We rode in silence back to Ojiji, the only sound coming from Tekno's Pana as it played on the radio. It was almost 1am, and everywhere was deserted.

"Thank you," I said, making to open the door.

"Not so fast," Baz said, reaching for me. "Wasn't that why you wanted us to leave? So, we could have fun more...privately?"

My eyes widened in terror at the realization of what he wanted to do. I struggled with the door handle, but he was on top of me in a flash, pressing his lips on mine as his hand went up my blouse. With all the strength I could muster, I kneed him in the groin, making him yell in agony. Taking advantage, I pushed him off, kicked my door open and scampered out, running as fast as my legs could carry me. When I was sure he wasn't following me, I frantically dialed Daluchi on her mother's number.

"Mepee ızo! Open the door!"

Thankfully, even though I didn't need her to open the rusty gate, she was there before I got to it.

"What happened?" she asked, her eyes wide in panic.

I ran into her embrace, weeping, emotionally exhausted from all the awful experiences of the night. How could I have put myself in such a position, one where I'd almost been raped?

What had I turned into?

She led me to my bedroom and stayed with me till the following morning.

"That boy is a fool!" she retorted a number of times. "So, he wanted to sleep with you, in his car of all places? He is an animal. He's not even happy that a beautiful woman like you agreed to follow him out. Enwe! Monkey!"

I said nothing and was relieved when she finally left, leaving me to lick my wounds alone. I behaved stupidly and had almost paid the ultimate price for it. All I could do was be thankful nothing worse had happened. I simply had to find a way to move on with my life, broken heart and all.

I pretty much slept through Sunday, only waking up to eat dinner. By Monday morning, lying in bed, I pondered not showing up at the clinic ever again. I couldn't bear to face Naeto, not after the catastrophe of Friday evening. But I knew I owed it, not only to him but, to myself to make amends for my horrible behavior. He had been nothing but nice to me and didn't deserve the embarrassment of me throwing myself at him. I had to find a way to quickly make amends for my poor behaviour.

Walking down the dusty road, in a shapeless floral gown and a scarf tied securely on my head, I looked the drabest I had ever done. There was no use wasting any more time on my looks as it had gotten me nowhere.

Getting to the hospital, I noticed an elderly couple walking inside, the woman wiping tears from her face. I also saw a few familiar faces milling around, some of which included the guys who normally sat under the tree. As I made eye contact with first one, then two, then more of them, I couldn't quite make out what I saw in their eyes. It looked almost like... anger.

"What's going on?" I asked Helen, as she brushed past me.

"They brought someone in yesterday," she answered, unable to make eye contact with me. "Badly beaten almost to the point of death. If they had brought him here a few minutes later, he would have died."

"Onye? Who?" I asked, grabbing her by the arm, but she pulled away and rushed off.

I just stood there, as people rushed to and from the lobby. I didn't have to be a genius to know who it was. Or what had happened.

Almost thirty minutes after I'd been there standing like a statue, Naeto walked out with the elderly couple I'd seen entering. When he saw me, his own face hardened. I watched him as he spoke gently to them, explaining some things to them in Igbo, before putting them in a waiting taxi.

"Naeto, please what happened? What is going on?" I asked.

"What happened? A man is lying here fighting for his life because of you, that's what happened!" he exploded, indignation blazing from his eyes.

"You almost got a man killed, and I'm told this isn't even the first time!"

"Me? What did I do?" I bleated in protest, even though deep in my heart, I knew. I totally knew.

"You lured the innocent man away from his friends on Friday night. There are several witnesses who can attest to that. And then on Saturday evening,

he was attacked in his house, beaten to a pulp and left for dead. When I was called in yesterday morning and saw the extent of his injuries, even I didn't know if he would be able to survive them. I still don't know if he will ever be able to make a full recovery."

I gasped, covering my mouth with my face. "Baz?"

Naeto's nostrils flared. "Abaeze, yes," he glared at me, his disgust seeping out of every pore. "I don't listen to gossip, but I've been told the last guy you cavorted with didn't come out quite as lucky."

I flinched at his reference to Chizutere, desperately wanting to do everything I could to take it back, to take it all back.

"Please leave, Adanna," Naeto said. "Leave, and don't come back. Apart from the fact that your presence could upset the boy's friends and family, I really think it's better for you to just go. Just go, please."

And with that, he walked away from the lobby.

I looked around and noticed a few people watching, some of the nurses and a few waiting patients. In their eyes was the same anger I had seen in the eyes of the people that surrounded Chizutere's father all those years ago.

I stumbled out of the hospital, feeling like the scum of the earth, wanting nothing but for the ground to open up and just swallow me whole. I didn't deserve to live.

Chapter Twenty-One

The Escape

There they were again, the averted gazes.

Walking back from the hospital, and even upon getting to the ranch, where there weren't scornful looks, there were averted gazes. Just like I had been twelve years before, I was the reason another young man was now fighting for his life.

“Adanna, kedu ihe i na-eche? What were you thinking?” Uzochi lamented later that morning. She'd come to my bedroom where I was still sitting like an effigy, over an hour after my return home. I hadn't even taken off my sandals. “Abaeze of all people? Someone even Daluchi is older than! And you allowed him to be rubbing your body in the full glare of everyone in that God-forsaken place? Do you know how many people saw you? Do you know how many people are dishing first-hand news like hot akara? Eeeeoh! Nwaanyị a egbuwo'm!”

A lone tear rolled down my face as I looked at the distraught Uzochi, and I didn't have to be a genie to know why she was so distressed. She still bore the injuries from Akanna's attack when she tried to defend me 12 years before. With news of my indiscretion all over the village, there was no telling what the repercussion would be this time.

But as frightening as the thought was, the real thing that broke my heart was losing Naeto. I mourned not only the loss of the possibility of a future with him, but even more so his friendship. I found myself wishing I'd just been satisfied with the little time we had together, even if it was only platonic. As it was, being banished from the hospital meant being banished from his life. And it broke my heart.

“Listen, just lie low,” Uzochi finally said. “Stay out of sight for now. Akanna hasn’t been to Ojiji in a few weeks, and with any luck, the news won’t reach him. Chief is still away, so let’s just pray that by the time he returns, everything would have died down.”

I nodded in agreement. I had no intention of going to the village anyway. But I had no intention of hanging around either. I’d deceived myself for two decades that beautiful clothes, jewellery and the comfort of an easy life at the ranch were enough reasons to remain in Ojiji as a glorified prisoner. But the truth was any life was better than this. I had to leave. I didn’t even care where.

“Aunty Ada,” came Daluchi’s voice, as she peered into my room later in the day. “Can I come in?”

I shrugged, not caring for any company, but not wanting to shun her either.

“I feel so responsible for what happened,” she said, sitting on the bed beside me. “That night, a part of me wanted to discourage you from going...but a bigger part of me was just so happy to see you wanting to have fun for a change. And I thought there wouldn’t be many people from the village at the club. You know how stingy the boys here can be.”

I said nothing in response.

“When I heard what happened to Baz, it just reminded me of...” her voice trailed off, and I knew she was talking about the time she had escorted me to Chizutere’s family house after the fire. “Thank God he’s still alive.”

“So, everyone knows?” I asked, even though I already knew the answer.

She sighed deeply and hissed. “The way the news has spread, even I don’t understand! Too many people claiming to be witnesses; from his useless friends who say you were the one who forced yourself on him, to those at the club that claim you were trying to seduce every man there. I spent almost all morning fighting with people, telling them that, contrary to their stories, you didn’t sleep outside the house, but it was like using a spoon of water to put out a fire.”

I nodded, taking in the information and, at the same time, hating myself for making such a stupid mistake. I had gained nothing from that unfortunate night out, but because of it, I had lost everything.

“Aunty Adanna, I think you need to leave this place,” Daluchi said, her tone low and conspiratory. “It’s not safe for you.”

I looked at her, shocked that she was echoing my inner sentiment. In her eyes was the same fear I’d seen in her mother’s, the clear reminder of how I, too, had almost paid with my life the last time something similar had happened.

“I’m going away tomorrow,” she continued. “If you leave the house with me, nobody will suspect anything. There are many spies in this ranch, and nobody even knows who is who anymore. It’s better for you to leave quietly, before things erupt.”

“Take me with you,” I said, holding her hand. “Take me with you wherever you’re going.”

She suddenly looked uneasy. “I can’t. I’m going to see...someone.”

I nodded in understanding. “Your boyfriend?”

She smiled and nodded. “Yes. He has asked me to meet him in Lagos for a few days,” her smile dimmed. “He’s married, so we don’t get to spend a lot of time together.”

“Married? But why?” I exclaimed. “You’re so young. Why waste your time with a married man when you can have any man you want?”

She shrugged, and I immediately had my answer. I knew too well that the heart wanted what it wanted. Who was I to judge her for loving a married man when I had spent a lifetime loving men who were no good for me?

“My mom doesn’t know, so I intend to leave quietly,” she continued. “Maybe under the guise of going to the market or something. So, you can’t go with any of your things, not right now anyway. But don’t worry, you can pack them and leave them in the store downstairs, and I’ll find a way to send them to you when I come back.”

“Your mom doesn’t know you’re going?” I remarked, caring more about that detail than ironing out the details for my own escape. “Won’t she worry?”

“Don’t worry about that. She’s used to me by now,” Daluchi brushed it off.

That was when I remembered how frequently in recent times Daluchi had disappeared for days on end. I’d never thought anything of it before, but it was now crystal clear to me.

“You’ve been seeing him for a while?” I asked.

She blushed, and I could see in her face the look of a woman hopelessly in love, a look I not only recognised but could identify with.

“He’s leaving his wife soon, and then he’ll marry me,” Daluchi declared, her eyes dreamy. “And then there’ll be no more need for us to hide.”

I smiled at her naiveté. Poor girl. She was going to learn the hard way that these things were not as simple as that.

As early as 6am the next morning, she was at my door. “Let me have your bags, so I can hide them in the store. When I get back next week, I’ll send them to you in Onitsha.”

It had been the conclusion that I would return to Onitsha for the time being, from where I would later leave for Port Harcourt. Daluchi claimed to have friends who would be willing to accommodate me there, but needed time to make the arrangements. With Chief not due back for another few weeks, I had enough time.

I handed her two suitcases, with only my dearest possessions packed. I was more than happy to leave behind most of my clothes and the other adornments Chief had used as shackles to tie me down. If I was given the opportunity to start a new life, then I was willing to start over.

“You look better today,” Uzochi remarked as I struggled with breakfast. “Make sure you finish your food and get plenty of rest. In time, everything will blow over, and things will be back to normal.”

I offered a strained smile in response, while looking out for Daluchi. We had agreed to leave the house by 10am, and it was already a few minutes past. Thankfully, just as I was beginning to think she’d left without me, she appeared at the door.

“Aunty, you said I should let you know the next time I go to see Ogochukwu,” she said, trying to sound casual. “I’m on my way there now.”

I immediately pushed my plate and rose to my feet, my heart galloping at a million miles per hour. “I’ll go with you.”

“Ị na-aga ebe? You’re going where?” Uzochi exclaimed. “Have you forgotten what we said about lying low? What is the sudden interest in seeing the tailor?”

“I won’t be long, I promise,” I said, picking up my purse and rushing out before the older woman had the chance to say more.

“Daluchi, bia ọsọsọ!” Uzochi called out to her daughter as the two of us walked out of the house. “You two shouldn’t stay out late. You both know why.”

She didn’t even acknowledge her mother’s words and instead continued walking, her pace steady. With a small handbag slung over her shoulders, there was nothing to indicate she was going to be away for longer than a few hours.

“Don’t walk too fast. Try to act as normal as possible,” she muttered, as we approached the gate. “We don’t want them to suspect anything.”

Even though I was a ball of nerves inside, on the outside I tried to take her advice and act normal. We waved a greeting at the guards and walked out of the compound. Once out, all I wanted was to break into a run, but I kept up the slow pace Daluchi insisted on.

“Shouldn’t we walk fast, so we don’t miss the bus?” I whispered in a panic.

“There are buses to Asaba every few minutes, relax,” was her cavalier answer. “Once we get to Asaba, you can board the next bus to Onitsha.”

I was about to express my worry over being recognized in Asaba, when we heard Chiasoka’s doleful voice. In recent days, her position had been inching closer and closer to the ranch, where she would often be seen,

sitting on the ground; crying, singing, or both. This time, she was singing a children's lullaby, holding her wrapper bundled in a ball, like an infant.

“Onye mere nwa nebe akwa. Egbe mere nwa nebe akwa. Weta uziza weta ose. Weta ngaji nkuru ofe. Umu nnunu aracha ya. Eh! Eh! amaghim onye owu.”

“Na wa o,” Daluchi remarked, as we slowed down beside her. “That’s how this woman ran mad true true!”

As it always did anytime I saw her, my heart broke for Chiasoka. Daluchi was too young to remember the details of what had happened twelve years before. But for me, it was all too vivid, seeing the woman all hale and hearty and cavorting with Chief one day, and then her roaming the streets devoid of her faculties the next. If there was one thing we had in common, it was the fact that fate had dealt both of us a very poor hand indeed.

“Let’s hurry, please,” I said, grabbing Daluchi’s hand. The last thing I wanted was to tarry where I didn’t need to.

Thankfully, she also quickened her pace, and we got to the bus stop right on time.

“Wait o! Wait o!” Daluchi called out, dragging me into the bus about to depart, where we squeezed into the last two seats at the back.

It was filled to capacity, which wasn’t unusual for the time of day. It wasn’t unusual for there to be a steady flow of traffic to and from the state capital. A beefy woman next to me gave me a look from the side of her eye, and I immediately regretted not bringing a scarf to cover my face. I looked around at the other occupants, but nobody else seemed to be looking my way. My prayer was just to get to, and leave, Asaba unnoticed.

“I’ll get your mother’s number from my mom,” Daluchi whispered in my ear. “By the time I get back to Ojiji, I would have concluded plans with Princess, my friend in Port Harcourt. So, maybe in about a month or so, you should be able to –”

Her words were cut short as the bus suddenly screeched to a halt.

The protests from the passengers were cut short as four burly men emerged from the van that had cut the bus off. Big-armed and big-chested, they didn’t even need the clubs and knives they wielded.

“Si n’ugbo a gbadaa! Get down from this car!” they shouted, hitting the side of the bus before pulling the conductor off from where he sat.

The passengers needed no further prompting and rushed out in a crazy stampede, toppling over themselves as they did. Daluchi grabbed my hand, and I scraped my leg on the jagged edge of a broken seat as I also tried to make my way out, fearing we were being attacked by robbers. Even though it was broad daylight, we were still a few kilometres from the expressway, flanked by dense woodland. Anything could still happen there.

But the moment I got out of the bus, one of the men grabbed me. “Lee ya ebe a! I’ve found her.”

My eyes widened in terror at the realization that this was not some random attack. No. They had come for me. Daluchi’s eyes also reflected the same realization, and she was momentarily frozen to the spot. But as her senses kicked in, she turned around and ran away, following the other passengers as they disappeared into the thick bush. I didn’t even scream or struggle as the men threw me into their van, or as the van made a beeline back to Ojiji.

My escape had failed.

As expected, the van turned into the ranch and drove down the long driveway I had grown accustomed to for years. But it wasn't the fact that my getaway had been thwarted that made my stomach drop. No, it was worse than that.

Standing in front of the mansion, his face like thunder, was Akanna.

Chapter Twenty-Two

The Retribution

Looking at him, he was like the devil himself.

As the men dragged me out of the van, his scowl slowly morphed into a sardonic smile.

“Hey, be careful with her. She’s very important cargo,” he said, his voice dripping with sarcasm. “You guys can go. I’ll see you later today.”

I stood with my head bowed, as the thugs got back into their van and drove off.

“Adanna. Adanna, the party girl,” Akanna remarked, his smile now a full-on grin. “You can’t imagine my surprise when they told me that my Adanna, my own Adanna, was seen gyrating in a nightclub. I told them, ‘No! Not my Adanna!’” He whipped out his phone. “It wasn’t until they sent me these that I realised they were actually telling the truth.”

I couldn’t help but look as he scrolled past picture after picture, each one worse than the one preceding it. I felt my cheeks flush with shame at the images of me in the vulgar attire, displaying the outline of every arch and curvature of my breasts and buttocks, positioned so close to Baz that not even air would have found thoroughfare between us. All I wanted was to wish the entire unfortunate evening away...but there it was, immortalised on Akanna’s phone, and Lord knew how many more.

“Amazing, isn’t it?” Akanna remarked, still scrolling through. “Who taught you how to twerk like that? Who has been teaching you bad things? What kind of bad company have you been keeping? This can’t be my Adanna. My innocent and pure Adanna. The Adanna whose virginity I took -”

“The Adanna that is your father’s wife!” came Uzochi’s sharp voice from the doorway.

We both looked in her direction, he enraged, and I mortified, both of us wondering what could have possibly possessed her to brazenly challenge him like that.

“Uzochi, Uzochi,” he chuckled, shaking his head. “Uzochi. Your wings are clearly overgrown and need clipping. My father has let you run amok for far too long.”

“Leave her alone. She is your father’s business, not yours,” Uzochi maintained, her voice firm and confident.

“Is that right?” Akanna laughed. “She’s my father’s business, and yours as well, from the look of things. Is that why you asked your daughter to help her run away?”

Uzochi couldn’t mask her surprise, and Akanna, astute as he was, cued into it.

“Oh, you didn’t know? You didn’t know that your daughter and ‘my father’s wife’ were on their way to Asaba? Do you even know where your daughter is right now? On her way to see her lover, from what I hear. If it hadn’t been for my boys at the park who notified me, they both would have been in God-knows-where by now.”

“Ada, bata n’ime,” Uzochi said, ignoring him as she walked towards me, reaching for my hand. “Come inside.”

Even I, who had been anticipating some kind of reaction from Akanna, didn't see it coming. His backhand struck Uzochi on the face, with such force, she fell to the ground. As he made to grab her, I held his arm.

"Please, leave her alone. I'll do whatever you want. Please!"

That was enough placation for him. He glared at her before stepping back and turning to me. "Come," was all he said as he turned to enter the house.

"Ada -" Uzochi called out, her voice high-pitched with fear.

But I ignored her. The last thing I wanted was to drag her further into my mess. As we all could attest, Akanna was a dangerous animal, and I didn't want her to be harmed on my account.

Walking behind him, I was relieved when he headed for the stairs, taking them two at a time, obviously going to my bedroom. If sex was all he wanted, then it was something I could endure. If having him hump and heave on top of me would be my penance, then I could bear it.

Once in the room, he began to kiss me like a rabid animal, tearing off my clothes in the process, pulling and biting so hard, I could taste blood in my mouth. I shut my eyes as he pushed me to the bed, wincing as he pinned me down. Tears rolled down my face as he thrust away furiously, having his way with me not once, but several times. Never before had he been so insatiable and excited. Just when I thought it was over, he would start all over again. By the time he was spent, I was sore all over, stinging from all the cuts and bruises he'd inflicted...but consoled that it was over.

Except it wasn't.

He rolled off and lay motionless beside me. I didn't know whether to remain still or move. But my terror made the decision for me and kept me

immobile, fearing that the slightest motion from me would trigger him into continuing his assault.

“So, you didn’t learn your lesson after the last time,” he said eventually, his voice even. “You still went ahead to throw your legs open for another village boy.”

I knew it was futile telling him I didn’t sleep with Baz, so instead just remained quiet.

“Not only did you fuck him, you decided to behave like a prostitute at the nightclub,” he continued, his voice still steady, but the increased pace of his breathing the only indication of his rising anger. “Apart from those pictures, I also saw a video of you flirting with almost all the men there, enticing them to come fuck you as well.”

I tensed, not knowing how to answer, but knowing him well enough to recognise that we were in the calm before the almighty storm.

And I was correct.

He was suddenly on top of me, his hands around my neck. “As if it’s not bad enough that I have to share you with my father! Now, you’re giving what should only be mine to the entire village!”

I struggled as his grip around my neck tightened, trying in vain to pry open his fingers. My legs flailed as I gasped for breath, feeling life slowly ebb out of my body. And then I wondered what I was even struggling for. There was nothing about my life worth living.

And so I stopped.

Just as my hands fell off him, and I closed my eyes to submit to death, he grabbed my bedside lamp and hit me on the face with it repeatedly, until it broke to pieces. Disarmed of his weapon, he grabbed my head and hit it on

the headboard. I cried out in pain as he did this over and over again, with increasing intensity. It felt like my face was caving in, like every bone in it had been shattered.

Letting go of me suddenly, he rose to his feet and slowly got into his clothes. I lay face down, the sheets now crimson red from my blood. My head was pounding, my vision was blurred, and I felt myself slowly losing consciousness. I closed my eyes, wanting to just slip away permanently, to allow death release me from the hell that was my life.

But I was suddenly jolted by a large gush of water emptied over me. I had the habit of always leaving a full bucket of water in my tub and hadn't even heard him go to the bathroom to grab it.

“Get up!” he shouted. “Get out of that bed!”

I sat up, panting from the shock and cold, my hair dripping wet and sticking to my face. Seeing I was making no move to obey his order, he pulled me off the bed and slapped me across the face, the crack of skin contacting skin echoing off the walls. Grabbing me by the arm, he dragged me towards the door, and when I realised what it was he wanted to do, to expose my nakedness to the entire household for a second time, I decided to do everything I could to fight.

I grabbed my closet door, holding on to it for dear life. This only served to enrage him further, as he turned around and kneed me in the stomach several times. The pain shot through my body like a fireball, crippling me to the extent I couldn't even make a sound. I let go of the door and allowed him push me out into the hallway, stark naked.

“Go downstairs!” he barked, his eyes blazing fire.

“Akanna, please,” I pleaded, lifting my hands imploringly. “Please, just beat me here. Don’t send me down like this.”

In response, he pushed me again, making me stumble forward. Without any other word, I made my way downstairs. One of the housemaids, Ndidi, was coming out of the kitchen and gasped when she saw me. She made to run back inside.

“Come back here!” Akanna shouted. “As a matter of fact, call everyone from the kitchen and the servants’ quarters. Let them all see this.”

Our eyes held, Ndidi’s and mine, and there were tears in hers as she stood there, shaking, not knowing whether to leave or stay.

“Outside!” Akanna ordered me, holding open the front door.

My heart crashed. The last time he had done this, at least my shame had been contained within the walls of the house. Now, he was magnifying it in leaps and bounds. But I knew arguing would be pointless. So, with my head bowed, I walked out of the house.

“Stand right there,” Akanna said, pointing to centre of the courtyard, by the water fountain. “Let them all see what it is you have been peddling to village boys for free.”

As I made my way there, I saw several of the domestic staff emerge from the house. The others at the gate and aviary had also noticed what was happening. I stood there, at the very center of the compound, my hands doing little to cover my shame. The last person who had suffered a similar humiliation had been Isioma, but at least she had died shortly after. How would I ever be able to live down this humiliation after this? How?

Most of the staff had their heads bowed, unable to look at me. The ones that did had tears in their eyes. I knew they pitied me, and it wasn’t only

because I was standing before them without the honour of being clothed. There were streaks of blood streaming down from my badly injured head, and one of my eyes was swollen shut. I could have passed for a disgraced thief after a lynching, except my attacker hadn't been an angry mob but a lone, crazed animal. Suddenly, it felt like I was spinning, like we were all spinning.

And everything went black.

Somewhere in my subconscious, I knew I was falling, falling to the ground. I heard screams from people running to me, the loudest of which was Uzochi's. I felt myself being draped with someone's wrapper and lifted from the ground. I heard Uzochi screaming at the extent of my injuries, especially the deep one on my head, as I was carried back into the house. I heard all it...but I honestly wished I didn't. I wished I was dead.

"She is losing too much blood," Uzochi was crying now, holding a piece of cloth over the wound on my head that was fast soaking. "We have to take her to the hospital."

"Get her dressed," came the voice I dreaded the most. "I'll take her myself."

I forced my eyes open and saw that, indeed, my predator was still there, lurking over me like an evil spirit. I wanted to protest, to vehemently refuse having him any more involved than he'd already been. He had done more than enough. But I was too weak to even form the words, too weak to even speak.

Considering the extent of my injuries, they didn't bother taking me back to my room but instead brought from there a fresh set of clothes. After being hastily dressed in an ill-fitting gown I hardly ever wore, Uzochi helped me

to my feet. From the way she staggered, it was obvious my weight was too much for her.

“Why all this unnecessary fuss?” Akanna snapped. “She is more than able to walk by herself. Leave her alone.”

Uzochi hesitated before letting go of me, and as expected, I buckled.

“Leave her!” Akanna bellowed at the others who reached for me. “I won’t tolerate any of such theatrics from anyone. She is not an invalid.”

“Biko, jide akwa a n’isi,” Uzochi said, putting my hand over a fresh piece of cloth, while at the same time steadying me. “Hold this over your head. Please, don’t remove it. As soon as you get to the hospital, that’s the first thing you should show the doctor.”

The room was still swaying, and my feet were still unsteady, but taking small steps, I was finally able to make it outside, where Akanna’s driver was now waiting with his car.

“Get inside! I don’t have all day!” he snapped, making me stumble in my rush to increase my pace.

In the car, my eyes met the driver’s in the rear-view mirror, and the sadness I saw in them gave me an idea of just how bad I looked.

“You better sit up, and stop playing the part of an invalid,” Akanna snapped as the car made its way to the hospital. “You have been through worse, and we both know it.”

Except he was wrong. As badly as I’d been beaten in the past, I had never felt this shattered. By now, even the cloth Uzochi had placed over my wound was soaked, and blood was now trickling down my arm. This was worse than anything I’d suffered before.

Way worse.

The car pulled up in front of the hospital, and Akanna got out of it. But much as I tried, I couldn't summon the strength to do the same. He walked over to my door, yanked it open, and dragged me out.

"Behave yourself!" he whispered hoarsely in my ear, grabbing me by the arm. "You better not draw any undue attention to yourself. We will have your wound treated and leave, do you understand?"

Unfortunately it was too late for that, as my swollen and bleeding face had already drawn plenty of attention from people standing around.

And then like a ray of light, Naeto emerged from the building. His brows furrowed as he watched us approach, and the moment recognition set in, he gasped.

"Adanna!"

"Naeto! Welcome back home. It's good to see you again," Akanna greeted, trying to sound casual, keeping a firm hand around my arm to keep me steady. "I see you've met my father's wife."

"What happened to her?" he demanded, walking up to us. "Helen, bring the wheelchair."

"Wheelchair? There's no need for that," Akanna chuckled. "She just had a small fall at home, that's all. A fall in her bathroom, I'm told."

Naeto looked at me, at the blood-soaked cloth over my head, at my swollen and bleeding face, and there was sadness in his eyes...sadness and anger.

He made to take me from Akanna, but the latter held on. "Not so fast, small doctor. I'm more than capable to guide her in. As long as her husband, my father, is away, she is my cardinal responsibility."

“She’s your cardinal responsibility, and this happened to her?” Naeto exploded, unable to mask his rage. “This isn’t the result of any fall, but a vicious attack!”

“Naetochukwu Nwabuwa, it’s like you’ve forgotten we’re not age mates. You better watch how you talk to me,” Akanna snarled. “I wonder if you get this angry over all your patients or if there is anything special here. If there is, that would be a very, very bad idea.”

Naeto squared up before him. “Your empty threats don’t scare me.”

“Empty?” Akanna chuckled. “Lying in your hospital bed is living proof that I don’t make empty threats. He’s lucky that it wasn’t my father that got his hands on him, otherwise he would have been in the morgue by now. We don’t make empty threats.”

“Keep talking, and I’ll have the police over,” Naeto answered, his fists clenched. “I’m sure they’ll be very interested to hear about the empty threats you don’t make.”

As they argued, I found myself feeling weaker and weaker. And then with no warning, I lurched forward and vomited. Except it wasn’t just vomit. It was blood.

Akanna let go of my arm and stepped back. As Naeto rushed to my aid, I heaved again and threw up some more blood, this time all over him. Undaunted, he lifted me in his arms, and just as I slipped into unconsciousness, I saw Akanna scamper into his car, which then sped off like a bat out of hell. And then everything went black.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The Recovery

I didn't regain consciousness for several days. I had suffered a subarachnoid haemorrhage from my head injury which, left untreated, could have led to paralysis or death. Thankfully, Naeto and his team were able to control and reduce the swelling, and there had been no damage to my brain. They were also able to tackle the internal bleeding from my abdominal trauma. I was lucky to have escaped with no permanent damage to not only my brain and internal organs, but also my face, save for some lacerations on my brow and lips.

Regardless, it was clear I had a long road to recovery.

Naeto took complete charge of my care, handling himself things even the nurses should have. It was he who changed the dressing on my wounds, inserted my IV lines, checked my vitals, and topped up my medication, all in addition to closely monitoring my injuries. In the early days, when I was still heavily sedated, as I slipped in and out of consciousness, he was the one constant, the person I was always sure to see standing over me or sitting in the chair beside me. He guarded me like a hawk, not allowing me any visitors, not even Uzochi. He even limited access to my room to a small handful of his own medical team. It was clear he didn't want to run any risk of exposing me to anyone who might have been complicit in Akanna's attack.

But I was grateful for the solitude, the time it accorded not only my body to heal, but also my mind...my spirit. It gave me the opportunity to reflect on the last twenty years of my life and realise things couldn't continue the way they had. Another beating like the one that had landed me there, and I wouldn't survive it.

"Chief's housekeeper was here again," Naeto remarked one evening, referring to Uzochi. "She keeps coming every day, undeterred, armed with a basket of food each time."

I couldn't help but smile, my heart warmed by my longtime friend's concern. "Please, let her in next time. She's been like a mother to me."

Naeto nodded. "Are you sure you don't want me to contact your family?" he asked the same question every day.

I shook my head, the same response I gave him. The last thing I needed was the complication of getting my mother and brother involved. The time would come when they would have to be, but that time wasn't now.

"Why did you do it, Adanna?" Naeto asked, late one evening when the hospital had emptied, and we were pretty much the only ones on the premises. "Why did you throw your life away to marry Chief?"

Something in his tone irked me. It was almost like he was implying it was something I had wilfully done.

"What do you think?" I threw back at him. "If you were asked, what would be your guess?"

He shrugged. "Chief saw a beautiful young girl and expressed his desire to marry her. The girl and her parents saw a wealthy suitor and decided accepting his proposal would be better for her than continuing her education."

I shook my head and smiled sadly at the insinuation that my father, my dearly departed father, would have mortgaged my education for anything at all. If he had lived, he would have fought tooth and nail for my siblings and I to have had only the very best in life. “Is that what you really think?”

He was quiet for a while, looking at me as if trying to read me. “If I’m to be perfectly honest, there have been times the notion hasn’t added up for me. Your humility, your kindness, your willingness to go out of your way for other people...not quite the hallmarks of a -”

“A gold-digger?”

He smiled. “I was going to say hypergamist. You know, hypergamy, meaning -”

“Marrying up. Yes, I know the meaning.”

“I hope I haven’t offended you.”

I shrugged. “Why be offended when it is what most people think, and with good reason too. What other possible reason could there be for a sixteen-year-old girl to marry a man forty years her senior?”

“The true reason, it sounds like.”

“My father would have cut off his right arm before doing anything to stop my education. He would have done everything in his power just to see me actualise all the lofty dreams I had as a young girl,” I smiled, memories of him encouraging me vivid in my head. “Back then, I was so sure I would end up in NASA as an engineer, and he never laughed at me. Not even once.”

“NASA? Now that would have been impressive,” Naeto teased. “The first girl from Ojiji in NASA.”

My smile waned. “I don’t come from here.”

“So, what happened? How did you go from dreaming of NASA to ending up as Chief Nsofor’s wife?”

“A business deal gone bad killed my father. My parents were suppliers to Chief’s bakery, and in anticipation of a big deal, my father went ahead to borrow a large sum of money from a loan shark,” I shrugged. “Long story short, the bakery cancelled the order, and he died of a stroke at the age of forty-four. I’m sure you can guess what happened afterwards.”

“The loan shark came after your family?”

I nodded and laughed sardonically. “Four hundred thousand, can you imagine? It was four hundred thousand naira that seemed like millions to us back then. So out of reach. And as if that wasn’t enough, my younger sister’s kidneys failed, and we were told the only cure for her was a transplant. We were pretty much pushed to the wall. And then Chief showed up, offering to help us.”

“In exchange for your hand in marriage.”

I looked him in the eye. “Exactly.”

We were silent for a while before he sighed deeply. “That must have been a very tough decision for your mother to make. Do you have any other siblings?”

“A brother, and he wasn’t crazy about the idea either. But we had no choice.”

“How is your sister now? Did she have the transplant in the end?”

“She did, but she died a few years after,” I answered, wiping tears away from my eyes. “It was a cruel joke. Everything I gave up, all the dreams I

had to kill, were all for nothing in the end.”

“So, why on earth didn’t you leave, Adanna?” he asked in astonishment.

“Why did you stay here?”

“I did. After her funeral, I didn’t return. I tried to build a new life back home in Onitsha. I tried to get a job, but nobody would hire me. My reputation was in shreds.”

“Why?”

I looked at him and realised that he honestly had no idea of my notoriety, the notoriety Chief...and Akanna...had given me.

“Because I was sleeping with my husband’s son,” I answered, looking away. “I came to Ojiji a virgin but didn’t make it to my husband’s bed one. Akanna raped me very shortly after I got here.”

Naeto’s face reddened, but I couldn’t stop talking, not if I ever wanted to tell him what I’d had to endure for decades.

“Not even when his father found out about it did it stop. After a while, I just stopped fighting and gave in to it. They rotated me like I was a toy, until Chief eventually tired of me in favour of his village courtesans. In the end, I just learnt to live with it. By the time Akanna got married and moved away, his attacks were not as frequent, and I found solace in gardening,” I laughed, attempting to lighten the tense conversation. “I’ve probably grown the best flowers in all of Ojiji!”

But he didn’t crack a smile.

“Was he the one who did this to you?” Naeto asked, his face now beetroot, and his jaw muscles clenched. “Akanna?”

I nodded. “My punishment for Baz. He did the same after Chizu,” I looked at him. “The other boy you referred to the day you fired me.”

“Is it true what the villagers are saying? That you also had an affair with him?”

“‘Affair’ is such an ugly word. Chizu and I didn’t have an ‘affair’. We were in love,” I answered. “It was such a beautiful, pure love. He didn’t even touch me. We were going to run away to Jos.”

“The villagers say Chief had him killed.”

“And they’re correct,” I answered. “He told me so himself. But Baz’s attack was Akanna. It was brutal and sloppy, just like Akanna,” I chuckled sadly. “Funny thing is nothing even happened between Baz and I. That night, I wasn’t even thinking. I don’t know what came over me.”

“Why hasn’t anyone stopped them all these years?” Naeto asked. “Why have the people around you allowed this abuse to go on for so long? Why hasn’t anyone reported them to the police? Why did you never tell your family?”

For the very first time, I realised I had no answer. How could I explain the deep and intense fear Akanna elicited from anyone who came near him? How could I explain the fear I had of Chief doing to my family what he had done to Chizutere’s? How could I explain believing that enduring it was much easier than running away from it?

Naeto shut his eyes and rubbed his temples vigorously, clearly agitated. “I have to go,” he finally said, rising to his feet. “Call me if you need anything.”

And with that, he left the room.

I stared at the shut door, crestfallen. Even though I knew he was only doors away in his office, his unceremonious departure signalled to me his repulsion by my story, confirmation that I was indeed damaged. And even though it was a realisation I had lived with for years, this time it hurt. It truly hurt.

The next day, after weeks of trying, Uzochi was finally given access to me.

“Adanna, o!” she exclaimed, rushing to embrace me. “Thank God! I was almost beginning to think you were dead.”

I held on to my dear friend, heart-warmed to see a familiar face. For the first time since my admission in the hospital, I’d been attended to that morning by a nurse, and not Naeto. I hadn’t even had the courage to ask her about his whereabouts and simply accepted that this was the way it would be from now on.

“You look so well!” Uzochi exclaimed, touching my face. “You don’t know how worried I have been. The nurses told me you were fine, but I didn’t believe them, abeg. Not after the way I saw you last.”

We were both quiet after her statement, both of us teleported back in time to the awful incident that had brought me there.

“Has he been coming to the house?” I asked, both of us knowing who ‘he’ was.

She shook her head. “Not at all. He hasn’t been to the house since that day. In fact, he didn’t even come home after taking you to the hospital. That’s going on six weeks now,” she leaned in, her voice dropping to a whisper. “We hear that they are having police wahala. That’s why even Chief has still not come back home. It’s been close to three months since he went

away, and he has never been gone for this long. Even the money he left for housekeeping has long been exhausted. It's been very tough at the house."

My heart went out to her. "I still have most of the money he left for me. It's in my bedside drawer –"

She smiled and rubbed my hand. "No need for that, my daughter. We are managing. I'm sure he'll come home soon."

"What about Daluchi?" I asked after a while. "Is she back home now?"

Uzochi shrugged. "Ọ na-abia, ọ na-aga. She comes, and she goes. That girl is up to no good, but she's an adult, so there's nothing I can do about it." She looked at me imploringly. "Did she tell you anything about where it is she goes to all the time?"

Not wanting to break the young woman's confidence, I simply shrugged. "Lagos, I think?"

Uzochi nodded, fully understanding my inability to say more. All we could both do was pray Daluchi was staying safe.

I proceeded to feast on the bowl of native rice and smoked fish she'd brought me, as we engaged in small chitchat and gossip. After visiting for about an hour, she eventually left with the promise to return the next day. Sated by the food, I closed my eyes and fell asleep.

It was the scent of flowers that awakened me.

I opened my eyes to find two large vases on the table, with bouquets of the most exotic flowers I had ever seen. However, it wasn't the sight of the flowers that gladdened my heart, but of Naeto sitting on the chair by my side.

“I was beginning to wonder if we’d given you a sleeping pill by mistake,” he smiled. “I’m told you’ve been asleep for hours.”

“Blame Uzochi and her good cooking,” I managed to giggle in response, even though I was so lightheaded with relief, I could barely breathe. “Why the flowers?”

“Because you said something about flowers making you happy, and I found a nice florist in Asaba,” he answered. “And also to apologise for the way I left last night. I just couldn’t listen to it any longer. All I wanted to do, and still want to if I’m being honest, was to go punch Akanna in the face.”

The smile wiped off my face, and I grabbed his hand in fear. “Akanna is a very dangerous man. Please, don’t even entertain that kind of thought.”

He sat on my bed and covered my hand with his other hand, tenderness in his eyes. “Don’t worry, Adanna. I won’t do something quite so rash. But that doesn’t mean I’m not going to do anything at all. He is going to get his comeuppance if it’s the last thing I do.”

I guess I just had to be satisfied with that.

“While we’re apologising,” I said, finally ready to address the elephant in the room. “I’m really sorry for the way I jumped you the other evening. I took advantage of your care and concern for me, and I regret that.”

He said nothing in response, and we sat in congenial silence for a while. “I remember the very first day I saw you,” he said, smiling. “I was home for the holidays from med school and was at church with my folks. And then I saw this...this vision. You were the most beautiful human being I had ever seen in my life. I remember my older brother shoving me to close my mouth, which was hanging wide open. That was how stupefied I was by

you. All I kept thinking that day, and every time I saw you after that, was what on earth is a girl like that doing with Chief Nsofor?”

I looked at him, stunned by what he was saying. He had never given me any reason to think he'd even as much as noticed me before his return to Ojiji.

“Another fun fact,” he continued, chuckling now. “I don't remember much about my wedding. There were so many people there, guests from both families, that I can hardly remember who was or wasn't there. But I do remember you.” He turned to look at me. “You wore a yellow chiffon dress, and you looked just like sunshine. And even then, on my wedding day, I still wondered what on earth a woman like you was doing with a man like Chief!”

“And when you came back home after so many years, did you still think I looked like sunshine?” I asked, hoping to sound tongue-in-cheek, but really wanting to know. “Or was I a shadow of what you remembered?”

“Adanna,” he answered. “You are even more beautiful now than you were all those years ago. Seeing you the day I came to visit Chief, I was 20 years old all over again.”

Our eyes held, and it suddenly felt like all the air had been sucked out of the room.

“So, why did you reject me? Why did you turn me away?” I asked.

“It didn't feel right. It didn't feel like the right thing to do,” he answered, his face so close to mine I could feel his breath on my skin. “You might have been the one making the move, but it felt like I was the one taking advantage of you.”

“And now?” was my breathless question, my heart racing so fast, it felt like it would jump right out of my chest. “Does it still feel wrong now?”

In response, he leaned even closer and grazed his lips with mine. I shut my eyes, savouring the featherlight touch of his lips and the feel of his nose brushing over mine.

“I could lose my license for this,” he chuckled. “What are you doing to me, Adanna?”

And before I could protest, he pulled away.

“Naeto –”

“I think it’s better for me to leave,” he said. “Good night, Adanna.”

I stared after the door, angry with him for teasing me, and with myself for getting my hopes up a second time. But I couldn’t even stay angry for long. Remembering his words brought a smile to my face. Even if nothing ever came out of it, just knowing he thought me beautiful was truly enough to make my heart smile.

The next day, he didn’t come to my room at all, and I was attended by the nurses on duty the whole day. I mourned his absence and found myself wishing we’d never had the conversations we’d had in the last few days in the first place, conversations which had obviously driven him away. I would much rather have had him there, even only as my doctor, than not having him at all.

That evening, after dinner, I lay on the bed, idly watching Africa Magic on the wall-mounted television, and wondering how much longer I could be accommodated in the clinic. I clearly couldn’t stay there forever, and it was high time for me to start making some sort of exit plan, especially with Chief and Akanna being M.I.A. My injuries had long healed, and I knew I was strong enough to leave, so it was probably in everyone’s better interest if I did.

I had drifted off to sleep when I felt a light tap on my arm. I opened my eyes, and there he was, Naeto, impeccably dressed in a white Oxford shirt and black dress pants. I glanced at the wall clock and saw that it was almost midnight, way too late for him to look as perfect as he did.

“Come with me,” he said, stretching out his arm, a smile on his face.

I sat up, confused, wondering what he was up to. Taking his arm, I got out of bed and allowed him lead me out of the room and down the corridor, thankful I was clothed in one of my better nightgowns. Once out of the building, he opened the gate that led to the old doctors’ quarters his father had called home in the latter years of his life after his beloved wife had died, and all his children had moved away from home. The old structure had been demolished, and there were plans to eventually convert it to an extension of the hospital, but in the meantime, it just remained there fallow.

But there was nothing fallow about the sight that I beheld that night.

There must have been at least a hundred tealight candles scattered all over the grounds, in the middle of which was spread a small blanket, with a small basket next to it.

“Forgive me, but I could only manage a small picnic. I wanted it to be a candlelit dinner, but the only tables I could find inside were massive. Who knew we didn’t have any portable tables?” he chuckled.

“What’s all this?” I asked, confused.

He took my hands in his. “Out here, Adanna, I’m not your doctor, and you are not my patient,” he said. “I’m just a guy trying to impress a woman he loves.”

I felt suddenly lightheaded, almost like I was being lifted off the ground by helium balloons. Not waiting for me to say a word, he led me to the blanket

where I sat as he unpacked some strange looking snacks.

“These look a mess, right?” he asked, holding up a dodgy cupcake. “It was all I could come up with at such short notice.”

I could only laugh, not believing this was any more than a beautiful dream. It had to be. I would wake up in the morning to realise that my heart had made the whole thing up.

“Before I forget,” he said, connecting his phone to a pair of small speakers.

When Overjoyed came on, I shut my eyes and smiled. Yes, it was definitely a dream. This kind of thing didn’t happen to me. This kind of inexplicable joy was not what people like me got or deserved.

“So...where were we?” he said, leaning in.

The kiss was everything I had ever imagined it would be...and so much more. It was soft and tender, but also yearning. I knew that I would never be able to get enough of him.

Except Chief got to him first.

In a panic, I tried to pull away. “We can’t do this, Naeto. He’ll hurt you-”

But he held me closer. “Nobody is going to hurt me, and more importantly, nobody is going to hurt you,” he said. “All that is over, Ada. That part of your life is over. You’re not going back to that place.”

I looked at him, every ounce of my being wanting nothing but to believe him.

“We’re going to get you out of this town,” he continued. “I haven’t thought through it yet, but that’s what has to happen.”

“And what then?” I asked, wanting to hear from his lips that he had plans not only for me to leave, but for us to be together...forever.

He reclaimed my lips in an even deeper kiss, answering me without words. With Overjoyed playing on repeat, we lay there, surrounded by candles and, underneath the moonlit sky, kissing and talking into the night. We talked about everything imaginable; his childhood, my childhood, his relationship with his much older siblings, my precarious one with the only one I still had, his marriage, my love affairs with Chizutere and even Anayo...and our dreams for the future.

Before we knew it, dawn soon started to break. We didn't need any further prompting to know it was time to end our rendezvous. The very last thing we needed was for anyone to find us out there. He helped me up, and we giggled like children as we put out the tealight candles, one by one. In all my life, I had never been so happy, so over-loved, so overjoyed. I was living out the lyrics of our love song.

"We'll talk some more tomorrow," Naeto said when we were back in my room. "Or rather, later today. Can you believe it's almost 6am?" He kissed me on the bridge of my nose. "We'll figure all of this out, don't you worry."

I was all smiles long after he'd left, my heart, body, and soul singing. I lay on the bed, but I knew there would be no sleep for me. How could I sleep and run the risk of waking up to find out that none of it had happened? That it had all been a dream?

But as morning properly broke, I eventually did drift off to sleep, and even in my dream, I was deliriously happy. My captivity was over. I was finally free.

Until I wasn't.

I was awoken by a light tap on my foot. I had a smile as I opened my eyes, convinced it was Naeto. But it wasn't.

It was Helen.

“Ada, good news,” she declared, her eyes dancing. “Your husband is back. He has come to pick you up.”

The smile on my face took flight, and my heart lurched. Chief was back.

Chapter Twenty-Four

The Curse

Walking behind Helen, my legs were like lead. As we approached Naeto's office, the sound of Chief's gruff voice and hearty laughter made goosebumps break all over my skin. This was no nightmare but stark reality. Chief was indeed back.

"Ah, there she is!" he exclaimed, as I walked into the office. "See how fresh and healthy you look. I was expecting to see an invalid."

"She's had good time to recuperate," Naeto answered, his voice even. "She was in very bad shape when she was brought here."

I threw an alarmed look at him, wondering why he was going into that level of detail with Chief, especially as it would lead to questions about why I had been so badly beaten in the first place.

"Biko hapu akuko ahụ. Leave that story. We all know that it is laziness that has made her stay here this long," Chief retorted. "Almost two months in hospital, what kind of sickness is that? My friend, get your things let's start going home."

I looked at Naeto, wanting him to dissuade Chief from taking me away, so that we would at least have more time to plan my escape from town, but he responded with a small shake of his head, sending me the message that he had things under control.

“No problem, Sir. I’ll have the nurses help her with her things,” he said, rising to his feet.

“Adanna, Adanna!” Chief said, holding my hand. “My beautiful wife. I really missed you, o. When we get home, you’re going to give me one of those your wonderful massages. I’m an old man, and these long trips always take their toll on me.”

“Let me give you some privacy,” Naeto said, walking out of his office, but not before I saw the firm set of his jaw. It was clearly harder for him to watch Chief paw me than it was for me.

When we were alone, Chief dropped my hand, and I saw, for the first time, anger in his eyes. That was when I realised that he knew exactly what had led me to the hospital...and I knew I was in deep, deep trouble.

In less than thirty minutes, my bags were packed, and the hospital staff bade me a fond farewell.

“Please send me the bill,” Chief said to Naeto. “I can only imagine how much the lazy girl has incurred after being here for so long.”

Naeto smiled curtly. “It’s fine, Sir. We hadn’t paid her for the work she did for us before the incident, so that has taken care of her treatment.”

Chief raised his brows in amazement. “Really? You must have planned to pay her a pretty heavy salary then. Well, I guess that is better for my pocket.”

“I will stop by later in the week to check on her,” Naeto said, glancing at me. “She is really not as strong as she looks and still has a long recovery ahead of her.”

Chief smiled. “You don’t have to worry about that, Doctor. There are more than enough people at the ranch to take care of her. What I do need, though,

is some medication for my blood pressure and back ache.”

“Why don’t we go back to my office, so I can check it and your blood sugar as well?”

“No time, my son. No time,” Chief answered. “I’m just getting into town, and I am in desperate need of my bed. I need to rest. Maybe you can come to the house later? Will it be too much trouble?”

“No trouble at all, Sir,” Naeto answered. “I can be there tomorrow.”

“Mba, mba, mba. Not tomorrow, please. Come next week. Let me have enough time to rest first.” Then turning to me, he winked. “Ngwanu, nwanyi oma, let’s be going.”

The minute we got into the car, he dropped the act.

“So, I hear you have gone back to your promiscuous ways,” Chief said, as the car made its way down the dusty road. “You mean, you have such a short memory that you forgot what happened the last time you tried to misbehave?”

By now, I was quivering like a leaf. “D’im, it was all a misunderstanding. All I did was go dancing, nothing happened with anyone. I swear it.”

“Will you keep quiet there!” he shouted, hitting me across the face with the back of his hand, his large insignia piercing my skin. “You are nothing but a harlot. I saw all the videos of you shaking your body like a prostitute, and I heard you allowed that small boy have sex with you in his car of all places. You are a disgrace!” And with that, he spat on me, a huge ball of saliva hitting me on my cheek, adding to my humiliation. “You should count yourself lucky that it was Akanna who dealt with the boy, and not me.”

I held on to my bleeding face, whimpering. “Then send me away, Chief. Just let me go. I have disgraced you and your household, so why are you

still keeping me? Let me go!”

“Oh, is that your plan? Is that what you thought would prompt me to send you back to join your mother in prostitution?” he laughed, a loud humourless sound. “The problem is that I have given you way too much freedom. Trust me, all that is going to change.”

The car turned into the ranch, but Chief asked the driver to stop at the gate.

“Bia, Nwoke!” he called out at Ukawuiké. “Under no reason whatsoever should my wife be let out of the compound. If she as much as puts a toe outside of this gate, you and your men will pay with your lives. Inụgo?”

“Yes, Sir,” Ukawuiké answered, while at the same time, casting a concerned look my way. All I could do in response was weep, still holding my face. If I thought I was a prisoner before, I was about to be shown real incarceration.

The car made its way to the house, where Uzochi and some of the other domestic staff were eagerly awaiting our arrival.

“Adanna is not to leave the compound under any circumstance,” Chief bellowed as he got out of the car, ignoring their greetings. “Since she has shown that she is an animal that has to be kept on a leash, I will be more than happy to give her what she wants.”

“Sir?” Uzochi exclaimed, looking from her boss to me in her confusion.

“You’re there saying ‘Sir’! I trusted you to keep an eye on her, but under your watch, she ran completely amok!” he yelled at his longtime housekeeper. “You should count yourself lucky that I’m in a good mood today, otherwise you would have also tasted some of my anger.”

“Sorry, Sir,” Uzochi said, her head bowed.

By now, my silent whimpering had become loud wailing, the realization of what life would now be, dawning on me. There was no way I could survive being kept hostage in the ranch. I had to leave. I had to.

And so, I tore away from Chief and started running as fast as my legs could carry me, all the way to the gate.

“Ada! Adanna!” Uzochi cried out, panic in her voice.

“Can you see it? Can you see?” I heard Chief’s voice. “When I told you she is a wild animal, you were looking at me like a wicked man. Can you see it yourself now?”

But I kept running. I ran like my feet were on fire...because they were. For every extra second I stood on those grounds, my feet burned. The place had become hell for me, and the sooner I found my way out, the better. I ran the long distance from the house, but as I approached the gate, I saw with dismay the guards rush to close it.

“Adanna, please go back,” Ukawuiké pleaded, looking towards the house anxiously. “You will get into trouble.”

But I had past that stage of caring.

“Help me! Help me!” I screamed, using the large padlock to hit the gate.

“They want to kill me in here. Help me!”

But the passersby only cast curious looks my way, none of them making any attempt to even inquire further.

“Nne Basil, Nne Basil!” I called out, recognizing one of the people passing by as the woman who sold akamu in the market. “Please help me! Chief wants to kill me! Ọ chọrọ igbu m!”

I was relieved when she slowed down.

“Ada, will you go back inside! Go inside right now, and stop shouting like a mad woman!” she scolded, looking anything but helpful. “Unu ebutela ise okwu n’èzí! Don’t bring your quarrel outside! Go back inside, and stop disgracing your husband!”

I stood there in shock, watching as she walked away without even looking back. I watched as other pedestrians filed past the house, and I realised that it was all futile. The respect, or fear, or both, they had for Chief would not make any of them tarry any longer than they needed to. I could have stripped myself naked, with a spear protruding from my chest, and it wouldn’t have been enough to garner help nor even empathy from any of them. To them, it was obviously just a domestic dispute.

I was trapped.

Wordlessly, I started walking back to the house. I felt the sympathetic looks from Ukawuike and his men, and upon reaching the house, the rest of the domestic staff. But none of them was brave enough to approach me, not even Uzochi. I walked wordlessly up the stairs and to my room, my resolve to leave growing with every step. Even if as a corpse, I was going to find a way out of the ranch if it was the very last thing I did.

I lay in bed as day eventually turned to night, falling into a deep depression, wondering how to get myself out of the mess life had made for me. But just as I was sinking to the bottom of the abyss, I remembered Naeto’s promise to me.

‘Nobody is going to hurt me, and more importantly nobody is going to hurt you. All that is over, Ada. That part of your life is over. You’re not going back to that place.’

And I was comforted.

For some inexplicable reason, I trusted his promise to get me out of, not only the ranch but Ojiji. He wasn't going to allow me waste away, not after seeing, first hand, how Akanna had almost sent me to my maker. He was going to rescue me.

This was the comfort I had as I drifted off to a deep and restful sleep, and the next morning, I was relieved to awake on my bed. I hadn't sleepwalked in all the time I'd been in the hospital and had feared being back in the ranch would trigger a relapse. But it hadn't. Instead, I'd awoken with a peaceful smile on my face, confident that, even as I slept, Naeto was working towards getting me out of there.

It was this confidence that saw me through the next few days, allowing me go about my normal business without the cloud of my captivity hanging over me. In anticipation of my imminent departure, I started putting a few of my important items aside, things I didn't want to leave behind in the ranch. I was pleasant and friendly to everyone, even Ukawuike, whose new mandate was to keep me enslaved in the compound. Even though I knew it wasn't his making, I also didn't want to part acrimoniously with any of the people I had known as family in the 20 years of my stay in Ojiji. Come what may, people like Uzochi, Ukawuike, Fidelia, Okeke, and the rest of the staff at the ranch, would always hold a special place in my heart, no matter where I went.

"I'm happy to see you happy," Uzochi remarked, as I busied myself in my garden, which had been neglected while I was away and was now overgrown with weeds. "I was afraid this...this new development would break you."

I smiled. If it hadn't been for the hope I was holding on to, it very well almost would have. "It's no problem. Where do I go to anyway?"

Uzochi hesitated, and I wondered if maybe she had heard something in my voice that had given my plans away. It wasn't that I didn't trust her, far from it. I just didn't want to say or do anything that would compromise our plans. After having previous escape plans already dashed, I was especially protective of this one. Nothing could happen to destroy it. Absolutely nothing.

That Sunday, as he would typically do when he was in town, Chief summoned me to accompany him to church. I took extra care with my looks that morning, wanting to look my best if we saw Naeto. It had been four days since I'd left the clinic, and his absence from my life was already leaving a crater-sized hole in my heart. I couldn't wait for the time when we would be together...forever.

As Mass went on, I was disappointed to see that Naeto hadn't made it to church. My disappointment soon gave way to worry. What if he had already forgotten about me? What if he had no plans to rescue me? What if he had decided it was best to leave me at the mercy of Chief Arinze Nsofor and his evil son? What if he had permanently left my life?

I was so deep in thought that I barely acknowledged pleasantries from the other parishioners, not even the overly boisterous one from the newly promoted Sergeant Ifedi. All I could think about, worry about, despair about, was that waiting for Naeto to rescue me could just as well be a pipe dream.

"Look at that wretch of a man," Chief chuckled, interrupting my thoughts. "So, he finally decided to return to Ojiji."

I looked in the direction of his gaze, and my heart did a somersault when I recognized Chizutere's father, Achike. Following the death of his family, the man had left Ojiji, moving from one neighbouring town to the other in

search of an alternative livelihood or, better still, an alternative life, as rumour had it. But looking at the old man, time had not been kind to him at all. He looked twenty years older than he should have, had lost a lot of weight, and walked with a stoop, metaphorically carrying the weight of the twelve years it had been since life took his beloved family away. Or rather, since Chief Nsofor did.

I tried to stall, so that we wouldn't have to walk past him, but Chief clearly had other plans.

"Nwoke!" he called out. "Wow, it's been an age! Where have you been all these years?"

Achike glared at us, and if looks could kill, Chief and I would have died several times over. I stood there like a statue, worried that he would charge over to attack us, but to his credit, the man continued walking.

But the devil was working overtime that day.

"Haba, Nwoke"m. I'm talking to you," Chief called out, his voice dripping with mockery and sarcasm. "Where are you rushing off to? Or rather, to whom? Abi, do you have a new wife warming your bed at home?"

As my husband laughed, I wished the ground would just open up and swallow me, his callousness making me more ashamed than I had ever been. I couldn't believe he could be so cruel to mock the man about what he had lost.

Achike slowed down and turned around. "I don't blame you. It is the society that has given you the effrontery to still be walking around proudly, instead of rotting in jail, that I blame."

"Jail? Mu?" Chief exclaimed, his eyes still twinkling with mischief. "For just greeting you?"

Achike shook his head and laughed, a dry humourless sound. “The God I serve will avenge me. You will die like a criminal! That is my promise to you.”

All humour and mischief departed from Chief, and he straightened. “Kpuchie ọnụ, there! You better shut that your poverty stricken mouth before it lands you in trouble!”

“I can see that the truth is bitter to digest!” Achike continued, noticing he had hit a sore spot with his aggressor. “You think you have caused me shame? Your death will be shameful and disgraceful! You call me a pauper? You will die even worse than one! Chineke ga-anụkwa ekpere’m! God will hear my prayer!”

Chief let out a loud hiss as he grabbed my hand. “God saved you that I’m just coming from church. You would have slept in the cell today for threatening me.”

But I could tell that he was shaken. He ranted and cursed all through the short ride home, complaining about having to mix with people who weren’t even ‘fit to clean his shoes’. As he fumed and raged, all I could think about was Naeto, praying that he hadn’t forgotten me as I now feared, because rather than spend my life with a man as evil as the one beside me, it would be better to just take my own life.

The next morning, I could barely eat my breakfast and just toyed around with the fried pieces of yam on my plate.

“You don’t feel like eating yam?” Uzochi asked. “You want me to make something else for you?”

Even though there were always at least 2 other cooks in the house, Uzochi still remained primarily responsible for Chief’s meals and, by extension,

mine. I smiled at her and shook my head. “I’m just not very hungry this morning.”

She looked around to make sure nobody was within earshot, before pulling up a chair. “I heard that Chief was exchanging words with Achike yesterday.”

I nodded, without offering anything more. The last thing I wanted to do was gossip. I half listened as she relayed the version of the story she had been told and didn’t even bother correcting her when the account implied both men had been close to exchanging blows. It was easier for me to allow her believe what she wanted to. When she noticed I was less than an eager participant in her gossip, she rose to her feet.

“This one that you’re so quiet, I hope you’re not falling sick again. What happened to you wasn’t a small thing. *O ka nwere ike dịrị gị n’ahụ.* It might still be in your body,” she remarked, genuine concern on her face. But before I could even think of anything to say in response, she caught sight of someone walking up to the house. “As if he heard us talking. Isn’t that the small doctor?”

My heart jumped straight into my mouth as I saw that it was, indeed, Naeto. It took everything in me not to race to the front door and hop straight into his arms. Instead, I had to restrain myself from showing any outward emotion. No, I couldn’t do that, not if we wanted to remain under the radar. But inwardly, I was dancing. He hadn’t forgotten me after all.

I remained in the dining room as Uzochi went to let him in, and I overheard her as she led him to the living room to wait for Chief. I was so happy, I could burst. It didn’t even matter that, dressed in one of my older ankara dresses, I wasn’t looking my best. Naeto had seen me at my worst and had

fallen in love with me anyway. I was too ecstatic about not only seeing him again, but being one step closer to being rescued from that place.

“It’s Doctor Naeto,” Uzochi said again, returning to the dining room. “He said he has an appointment with Chief. Biko, go and sit with him while I call your husband. Knowing how long it takes Chief to get ready these days, he might have to wait a while.”

I nodded, trying to act calm and composed. Rising to my feet regally, I made my way to the living room. “Good morning, Doctor.”

Naeto, who was looking at the wall portraits, turned around with a smile on his face. “Adanna!”

I blinked fiercely to prevent him from acting or saying anything too familiar. I had never been able to identify who the spies in the house were, and we couldn’t take any chances...not after coming so far.

He nodded in understanding. “Good morning, Mrs. Nsofor. How are you feeling today?”

I smiled in spite of myself, amused by his forced formality. “Very well, thank you. I can’t complain.”

“I hope everything has been fine since you left the hospital.”

I nodded, understanding what he was really asking. “Everything has been fine, Doctor.”

Naeto turned back to the life-size wall portraits. “These are very nice. Chief must have spent a fortune on them.”

I shrugged, now indifferent to the ostentatious paintings of every member of the family, from Chief Akachi and Lolo Oriaku Nsofor, Chief himself, his late wife, Akanna and his wife, Apunanwu, Ananyo, and more recently, me.

I had been both surprised and reluctant when Chief insisted on getting a painting of me done, to add to the collection. Probably because I knew it was all a charade and just a way for the old man to continue to keep up appearances, especially as he'd had to answer one too many questions from his associates who visited about why his current wife's picture was missing from the collection. I had eventually gone ahead with it, staring, unsmiling, at the camera for the pictures the painter would reproduce. But as unwilling as I had been, the pictures came out beautiful and regal.

"Permit me to say, Madam, but yours is the best one here," Naeto remarked.

I walked to stand by him. "Really?"

We both looked up at the image of the young woman dressed in a scarlet red, off-the-shoulder dress, her neck bedecked with a thick gold choker, adorned with diamonds and rubies, her long hair wrapped in a loose chignon atop her head, and her lips the same shade of scarlet as her dress. She stared back expressionless and, for the first time, I saw that her eyes were just as sad as the picture of her predecessor. Chief was clearly not in the habit of making happy women of his wives.

"It's spectacular," Naeto remarked, and I knew he was not putting up an act.

Our hands grazed as we stood there, side by side, looking up at the picture. Even though we couldn't do or say more, he wordlessly gave me the reassurance I needed that nothing had changed between us.

"I saw your garden as I walked in," he said. "It's just as beautiful as you said it is."

"It's nowhere near as lovely as it typically is. They didn't take care of it in my absence, so I'm still trying to revive it," I answered.

"I'll stop by it on my way out," he said, looking at me.

I looked at him and smiled, getting the hidden message. “That would be nice.”

At that point, Uzochi walked into the room. “Doctor, Chief will see you now.”

He nodded in acknowledgment, smiled politely at me before following Uzochi out of the room. The older woman cast a curious glance at me as they left, but I made sure not to make any eye contact with her.

When they had disappeared up the stairs, I made my way to my garden, dusted the small bench there and proceeded to wait for him. I was too nervous to tend to my flowers or do anything that would ordinarily have distracted me, so instead I sat there, waiting anxiously for the man I loved. And after exactly 57 minutes, he came.

“Hello, beautiful,” he said, sitting next to me on the bench. “I was worried you wouldn’t be here. I didn’t know it would take so long with Chief.”

“I would have waited the whole day if I had to,” I gushed.

He leaned forward and kissed me tenderly, making me so grateful for the hedges I’d planted around the circumference of the garden, giving us the privacy we needed. “I’ve missed you, Adanna.”

“You weren’t in church yesterday. I was looking forward to seeing you there.”

“There was an emergency at the clinic,” he answered, adding with a coy smile. “Trust me, you weren’t looking forward to it as much as I was.”

I rested my head on his shoulder. “I’m really desperate to leave this place. Do you know that Chief has banned me from leaving the compound unaccompanied?”

“I heard that,” he answered, to my surprise. “One of the nurses told me something about people seeing you screaming and banging your gate.” He was silent for a few moments. “Hearing that made me realize we have to fast track our plans.”

“What do you have in mind?” I asked, eager to hear what he was planning.

“I’m finalizing a few things and should have more clarity in a couple of days,” he answered, before reaching into his pocket for a small phone. “In the meantime, hold on to this. It has almost driven me crazy not being able to speak with you. At least this way, we can always talk.”

I quickly slipped the phone into one of the oversized pockets of my dress, not wanting to run the risk of what happened the last time I’d been given one by a lover.

“You can also listen to our song on it,” he said, smiling. “I programmed it in for you.”

I couldn’t help the squeal of delight that escaped my lips. If there was one thing that would perfectly fill the gap between now and when Naeto and I were permanently reunited, it was Overjoyed.

“I love it when you laugh,” he said, stroking my face with his finger.

“It’s a beautiful sound, isn’t it,” came the one voice I hated the most, the one guaranteed to send chills down my spine.

Akanna.

I glared at him as he stood at the entrance to the garden, a smirk playing on his lips.

“What a romantic sight! The doctor and his patient!” he remarked. “I just knew there was more to your indignation that day at the hospital. I knew

there was more to your anger than mere concern for your patient.”

Naeto rose to his feet. “Is this how you sneak up on people? That’s rather creepy, isn’t it?”

“Creepy? On my own property?” Akanna countered, still smiling. “But I must say, you’re incredibly brave to be romancing my father’s wife, right here in his compound. You clearly haven’t heard what happened to the last two people who tried that nonsense. Oh, wait a minute, didn’t you treat the last one? Didn’t you see that he was lucky to have escaped with his life?”

“You don’t scare me, Akanna. Not when I was a child, and certainly not now,” Naeto answered, his voice even.

“Oh, so you’re not denying it then,” Akanna countered. “I was hoping you would say it was just a friendly visit from a concerned doctor to his patient, and that you were brushing away a strand of hair from her face when I saw you. I like you, Naeto. You better take this exit I’m giving you.”

By this time, my heart was racing. I pinched Naeto, wanting him to say that it had indeed only been a friendly visit, and there was nothing to be read from us being together. The last thing I needed was for Akanna or, worse, Chief to believe anything was happening between us.

“No, Akanna. There will be no more lies,” Naeto answered, squaring up before his adversary. “I’m in love with Adanna, and I will not rest till I take her out of here.”

Akanna started chuckling, quietly at first, until it escalated into full-on laughter. He threw his head back as he laughed, apparently more amused than offended. “Take her out of this place, indeed. My guy, please leave. Leave while you can still breathe, walk, and talk.”

Thankfully, Naeto decided not to say any more to him. “We’ll talk later, my love,” he said to me, squeezing my hand before brushing past Akanna out of the garden.

“You don’t learn your lesson, Adanna,” he remarked, still laughing. “It’s like you’re a sucker for punishment.”

“Please, Doctor was just joking,” I said, in a desperate attempt at damage control. “He only came to check on me. He just said what he did to get a reaction out of you. If he was really my lover, would he have told you?”

Akanna muled over it. “You’re correct. It would have been rather reckless of him to say all that if he was indeed your lover. Not after hearing about, and seeing, what happened to the last two who made that mistake.”

I glared at him, furious how he boasted about the attacks on Chizutere and Baz, wearing them like a badge of honour. At that very moment, I could identify with Achike’s frustration the previous day and echoed in my head the same curses he had reined on Chief. For all that he had done and continued to do, Akanna would one day have to pay dearly.

“Can I go now?” I asked.

He gestured emphatically towards the exit. “By all means, my lady.”

As I walked past him, it was a struggle to maintain my composure. I knew that the clock had already started ticking for Naeto and I. Akanna might have bought my excuse, but he was going to definitely keep a keen eye on us. Whatever Naeto was planning had to happen very, very quickly.

Chapter Twenty-Five

The Prisoner

Getting back to my bedroom, all memories of the encounter with Akanna were discarded as I lay on my bed, listening to Overjoyed on my new phone. I shut my eyes, a content smile on my lips, happy that, not only had my love not forgotten me, everything was still on course for my escape.

I sang out loud, not caring who heard me, elated that my life, my miserable life, had finally become a love story, the kind that I had read about and longed for, the kind I never thought I would ever have. But there I was, finally living and breathing that love...except it was so much better than anything I could have ever imagined.

Not up to an hour later, the phone vibrated. The smile on my lips widened when I saw Your Love on the screen.

“Hello? Naeto?”

“Unless you have another love,” he teased in response, before getting serious. “I’ve been waiting for the right time to call. I didn’t want to call while anyone was still within earshot.”

We both knew whom he meant by anyone.

“I came up to my room shortly after you left,” I answered.

“I hope he didn’t harass you. I’m so sorry for being so reckless and saying those things. I shouldn’t have let him goad me.”

I smiled. “It’s okay. I was able to convince him that you were just joking. Because you couldn’t possibly be my lover and be telling him to his face, could you?”

“I’m really sorry for putting you in that position, Adanna. He could have hurt you,” he said, his voice now sombre. “You’re not safe there. I don’t for a minute believe that he bought your story. We need to get you out of there quicker than I’d originally planned. I won’t be able to handle it if he hurts you like he did the last time.”

What was left unsaid was that there was a high possibility that I wouldn’t even survive another violent attack.

Naeto was quiet for a while, before finally speaking. “Tomorrow night. We’ll leave tomorrow night. I have a few procedures at the General Hospital, and I’ll be in Asaba for most of the day. When I get back, we’ll find a way to get you out of there. I can arrange for you to be taken to Benin, and I’ll meet you there.”

“And then what?” I asked. “What happens after that? Am I going to remain there, where Chief can easily find me? Are you still going to stay here in Ojiji? I know you can’t leave your father’s hospital, so what’s going to happen to us?”

“Once step at a time, my love. I have an airtight plan. Trust me,” he answered. “Nothing will happen to you under my watch. That I can guarantee.”

“Hurry. I can’t wait to get out of here,” I moaned in my frustration.

“And I can’t wait to be with you.”

And just like that, all my worries and fears evaporated, and were instead replaced with hope, anticipation...and love. The kind of love that made your heart sing and lifted you off your feet.

“Did you find the song on the phone?” he asked.

“Find it? I’ve been listening to it since you left,” I answered, the smile now back on my lips.

“It’s funny, even though I’ve always loved that song, the lyrics didn’t resonate as much as they do now,” he said. “When I sing it, it could have been written for you and I, Adanna. Especially the last stanza of the song.”

I shut my eyes, remembering the words and hearing the song as audibly as if it were still playing on my phone.

“You are my soulmate, Adanna. You’re the one I’ve been waiting for all my life. I’m going to do everything, everything, to be with you.”

Those were the words of assurance that enveloped me that night, enveloped me like we were still lying in each other’s arms the way we had the night everything changed between us...and the night before everything did change.

I woke up the following day with more purpose than I’d had in all the years I’d been in Ojiji. I was finally leaving. I wasn’t running away blindly to Asaba, or leaving for a life of uncertainty in Jos. The man of my dreams, the true love of my life, was taking me far, far away from all my troubles, to start a whole new life. I still had no idea what he planned to do with the life he had started for himself in Ojiji, most especially as it concerned his father’s hospital, but I was confident that whatever he was planning was the very best option there could be for us. And that gave me all the confidence I needed.

Speaking with him early that morning, we decided it would be best for me to use the desolate back gate as my escape route that night, especially as I was now confined to the compound. Unlike in the past when I could have sauntered out of the premises under false pretences, this time it had to be a more tactical move. Using the back gate might not have been the best of options, but considering all we had, it was the best one. We'd also agreed that I didn't need to bring along any bags. The less attention I drew, the better for me.

I wasn't able to speak with Naeto later in the day, but I spent my time preparing. I opted to wear a pair of trousers in case there was any need to jump over the fence, in the event that the lock of the gate had been fixed. I also keyed in the phone numbers of my mother and brother into my new phone, from the old notebook I'd written them in years before, so I could contact them the minute I was safe somewhere. Looking around the room, I felt no remorse that it would be the last time I would sit there, in the place that had been my sanctuary for so many years. It was finally over. And I was soon going to be free.

At exactly 10 o'clock, I waited patiently for Naeto's call. That was the time we were supposed to meet at the back of the house. It was late enough for most of the ranch to be asleep, but still early enough for us to leave town. When no call came from him, I proceeded to dial his number. My stomach crashed to my feet when I heard the dreaded recorded message

The number you have dialed is switched off.

No. It had to be a bad joke.

I dialed and redialed his number several times; 5, 12, 23, 45 times. But each time, the unbecoming voice repeated the same message. Undeterred, I slung

my small handbag over my shoulder, and, with my phone in my hand in case he finally did call, left my room.

As I made my way downstairs, I tried to be as quiet as I could, but my nerves made my steps that much quicker than they ordinarily should have been. Getting to the gate, I was relieved to see the bad padlock still carelessly lobbed across the gate and gently opened it so as not to attract any attention. Upon getting outside, there was nobody there. By this time, it was almost 11pm.

I dialed his number again, and it was still switched off. This couldn't be happening.

Looking down the lonely path, I decided to walk down, just in case Naeto was parked at the end of the road, where Baz had waited for me months before. Upon getting there, apart from one or two pedestrians, the place was completely desolate with nary a car in sight.

Standing on the road, not even caring who saw me, I must have called him a further 20 times, but all with the same outcome. His phone was dead. In a panic, I realised I wasn't going to speak with him that night.

Unless I managed to find my way to the hospital and wait for him.

"Ada? Is that you?" came a voice from behind me, making me jump.

I looked back, and my heart crashed when I saw it was Ukawuike.

"Kedu ihe i na-eme ebe a? What are you doing out here at this time of night?" he asked, his eyes wide in what looked to be a mix of panic and concern. He caught sight of my bag. "Are you going somewhere?"

"I want to get to the hospital," I answered, after all it was the truth. "I wasn't feeling too well, so I thought I could just go this night. Doctor will be there."

Ukawuike's brows furrowed. "Hospital? At midnight?" he shook his head. "I have to take you back. You can go to the hospital tomorrow."

"But I have to go now," I shrieked. "What if I die tonight?"

Standing there in my jeans and little handbag, I knew the last thing I looked like I was doing was dying.

"Please, I have to take you back," he implored. "If Chief finds out that you left the compound, you heard what he said he would do to me and my colleagues."

As much as I wanted to call his bluff and run away, and even though it sounded like he was pleading with me, I knew I really had no choice in the matter. Ukawuike was a renowned marksman and former wrestler and wouldn't hesitate to bundle me back to the ranch if he had to. Yes, he had a soft spot for me, but his allegiance was still to his employer.

Dejectedly, I turned around and walked back to the ranch, with the guard a respectful distance behind. Once in the compound, as quietly as I'd left the house was as quietly as I returned. There was no point rousing everyone over a botched mission. Even though our plans for that evening had fallen through, I still continued to call Naeto, hoping he would finally answer his call.

But his line remained dead.

It was a little past midnight, after dialing him for the 106th time, that I was hit by a horrible premonition. What if something had happened to him? What if Akanna had attacked him the way he'd done Baz? I covered my mouth to keep from screaming, as goose bumps erupted all over my body. I picked up my phone to call somebody, the doctors in the hospital, the nurses, anybody...but I was hit by the stark reality that there were only

three phone numbers stored on my phone; Naeto's, my mother's and Jidenna's. I didn't even have Uzochi's number.

I was completely helpless.

I sat up in bed all night, frantically dialing his number, but to no avail. As soon as dawn broke, I wore my slippers and started making my way to the back gate, determined to jump the fence if I had to. Nothing and nobody was going to keep me from finding Naeto, from seeing with my own two eyes that he was fine.

As I approached the gate, the little phone finally rang. I almost fainted from relief when I saw Your Love flash on the screen.

"Naeto? What happened? I've been calling you all night!" I shrieked.

"My angel, I'm really sorry," he apologized. "You won't believe what happened. I got back from Asaba to find that some hoodlums had completely trashed the hospital."

I stopped dead in my tracks. "Trashed?"

"My dear, the place is a mess," he continued. "They destroyed everything; furniture, equipment, everything. All that was left for them to do was burn the place down. They even chased away the two patients we had on admission and also the nurse on duty."

I was no longer listening. I didn't need to. I could only hear one word, one name.

Akanna.

"It's a lot of damage, but nothing that can't be fixed," Naeto was still talking. "What makes me mad is that they also attacked Olisa. He was very badly beaten. I had to rush him to Asaba. It was while I was there that the

battery of my phone went out. Thankfully, we were able to stabilise him, and _”

I hung up, unable to listen to any more. Olisa was one of the young doctors Naeto had hired. Akanna’s boys had probably wrongly assumed he was their target. How soon would it be before they realised their mistake and planned something more sinister for Naeto, something sinister enough to take his life? I realised then and there that I couldn’t do it to him.

I was a danger to his life.

Letting out a loud scream, I threw the phone at a tree, and watched it splinter. As it shattered, so did all my hopes and dreams. Nothing was ever going to take me from the ranch. Nothing short of death.

My legs buckled as I wept, and I was soon on all fours, weeping on the wet, marshy ground, weeping for my lost love, weeping for my wasted life.

“Adanna!” came Uzochi’s voice, as she rushed to me. “Someone told me they saw you back here. Ewo! What happened?”

But I didn’t even look up, instead, my crying intensified. With a deep sigh, the older woman knelt beside me and took me in her arms as I continued to cry, rocking me back and forth. Even without any words, I could tell she understood. I was back to being a prisoner.

Chapter Twenty-Six

The Return

By afternoon, the story was everywhere. Everyone was talking about the vandalization of the young doctor's clinic and the destruction of the legacy of the older Dr. Nsofor. Sitting in the dining room having my lunch, I listened as the domestic staff talked about it, and it took everything in me not to yell out in anger and frustration. How could one family, one man, hold an entire village to ransom? But I couldn't react, more for Naeto's benefit than my own. I was all cried out from the morning anyway. My heart and spirit were broken.

And so I just sat there, like a statue, as they talked.

"Ada, you're not eating your food," Uzochi remarked, taking a seat next to me at the table.

I looked at her, surprised. Uzochi never sat at the table, not even when she was invited. But whatever she had to say to me apparently had enough gravitational pull for her to defy her own principles.

And I was right.

"Ufọdụ ndị obodo na-ekwu okwu. Some people in the village are talking," she whispered, leaning close. "They are saying that what happened to small doctor's hospital was because of you. One of his nurses has been gossiping about how the two of you were...were very close."

I was taken aback, surprised that Naeto and I had not been as discreet as we'd thought. But it didn't matter what they were saying, how many people were saying it, or how my natural instinct would ordinarily have been to confide in my older friend. I knew I had to protect the man I loved.

"Mba o! Me and the doctor? No o! Whatever gave them that idea?" I exclaimed, hoping I sounded convincing.

But from the way she looked at me, I apparently didn't.

"Just lay low, I beg you," she said, her eyes wide in her alarm. "You know what happened the last two times. For the next few days, just stay in your room and lock your door. Biko! There can't be a repeat of -"

"There can't be a repeat of what?" came the voice neither of us wanted to hear. Probably ever.

Akanna.

Uzochi's eyes grew even wider, all suggestions of me keeping a low profile dying on her lips. It was too late for that anyway. The Armageddon we were running away from was already upon us.

"Oh nothing, Sir," Uzochi said, shooting to her feet. "I was just telling Ada about...about something that happened to my sister."

Akanna smiled, a wry, knowing smile. "Is that so? Your sister?" was his sarcastic retort. "Well, you can continue your discussion later. I'm sure you have other things to do than to sit comfortably in your employer's dining room, gossiping."

"Sorry, Sir," she bleated as she scampered out of the room.

Alone with Akanna, I knew I should have felt fear, especially considering our very recent history. But, at that point, my anger was greater than any

fear. All I wanted to do was to stab him in the chest with the fork in my hand. All I wanted to do was damn the consequences and end the life of the man who had tormented me for twenty years.

“Adanna, did you hear about what happened to your friend’s clinic?” he exclaimed in exaggerated surprise. “After all the money I hear he pumped into the place? Gosh! That is such a shame, isn’t it? Who on earth could have done that to him?”

I focused my attention on my plate, knowing it was better for me to busy my fork with food than what I really wanted to do with it.

“Na wa o! This village is just not safe anymore,” he said, a broad smile on his face. “And did you hear that they beat up one of the doctors there? Beat him to a pulp, o! Left him almost unrecognisable.”

I turned to look at him, expressionless. “I heard.”

“You heard,” he echoed me, the smile on his face dimming. There was now anger in his eyes, and I held my fork tight, ready to stab him if he as much as blew air in my direction. “So, what did you do when ‘you heard’? Have you gone to give him comforting hugs and kisses?”

My gaze didn’t even waver. “At the appropriate time, my husband and I will go to express our sympathy and offer whatever assistance we can. Don’t forget that his father was a close family friend.”

Akanna and I remained in an eyelock for several moments, neither party willing to even blink. But eventually, he chuckled. “You have a very, very short memory, Adanna. You both should count yourselves very lucky indeed.”

As he walked out of the room, I didn’t even feel any relief. I was simply fed up of living that kind of life after so long. What crime had I even committed

to warrant me being held in oppression, no better than a prisoner? Women who had done far worse than me were at least given the option to leave their marriages. Even if I was being kept as payback for what Chief spent on Ahunna's medical treatment, surely, after twenty years, it should have been all paid up.

Those were my thoughts as I lay in bed later that afternoon, staring at the ceiling. I knew Naeto would be trying to get in touch with me, that he would be worried about why my phone was switched off and would naturally be fearing the worst. But as much as it broke my heart, it was better for me to leave him alone. Even if I managed to finally leave Ojiji, it was better to fear only for my own life, and not his in addition. Yes, he was the love of my life, yet it was because of this love that I was letting him go.

But I knew I would never love another man like that again.

A soft tap on my door interrupted my thoughts. I was surprised when Daluchi peeped into the room. I hadn't seen her since the day of my botched escape.

"Daluchi! Is this your face?"

"Aunty Ada, please don't be angry with me," she said, sitting on my bed. "I shouldn't have left you like that that day. I should have stayed back to help you. I was so distressed about what happened that I wept all the way to Asaba."

I smiled. "What kind of help would you have given me? Those touts would have just flung you to one side."

But she didn't even smile. "I heard about what Akanna did to you. I heard you almost died."

“Well, I didn’t die,” I answered with a flippant shrug. “What about you? What brings you back to Ojiji? Your bobo finally released you? Or has his wife chased you away?”

She laughed, not taking any offence. “Ọ nọ o. He’s there. He got me a small flat in Asaba, where he comes to visit me from time to time.”

“Asaba? I thought you said he lives in Lagos.”

“He moves around a lot,” she answered. “But he comes to Asaba often.”

She didn’t offer any more, and I didn’t ask. They probably had that arrangement so she would be as far away from his wife as he could manage. But as complex as their situation was, at least she had the luxury of freedom, the freedom to come and go as she pleased. I would have done anything to have that.

And then I had an idea.

“Do you have enough airtime on your phone? I need to make a call,” I asked her.

“Sure,” she answered, digging into her bag. “I have more than enough credit, so talk as long as you want. I’ll give you some privacy.”

True to her word, she left my room after handing me the phone. Upon her exit, I dug up my old notebook and dialled Jidenna’s number. As I punched the digits on the sleek smart phone, I couldn’t help but wish I’d written down Naeto’s phone number as well. Yes, I had decided to set him free, but I would have done anything to hear his voice again.

“Yes?” came my brother’s gruff voice.

“Jidenna, this is Ada,” I said. “Adanna.”

“Adanna! So, you actually remembered your wretched family today? To what do I owe this ‘honour’?”

“You know I don’t have a phone. I told you that the last time I saw you at Mom’s place.”

“So, you’re using a can of Coke to call me, abi?” he retorted.

“Please, Jidenna. I’m telling the truth. I had to borrow someone’s phone to make this call,” I cried. “I need to leave this place. Please, get me out of this dreadful place.”

He laughed. “You’re hilarious. You need to leave where? I thought you loved it there, with your flashy clothes and big cars. Isn’t that what you like?”

“Jidenna, I’m a prisoner here, I’ve been nothing but a prisoner in all the years I have been here,” I wailed. “It is too much for me. I can’t take it anymore.”

His laughter stopped, and I knew my tears had hit a nerve. “If you want to leave, then leave. Is anybody holding your legs? Why can’t you just walk to the bus stop and be on the next one home?”

“I wish it were that simple,” I answered, and then proceeded to tell him all that had happened in the twelve years it had been since we had last talked, really talked. I told him about all the threats, the continued abuse, the beatings, the humiliation...everything. He listened in silence, and when Daluchi’s supposedly infinite airtime ran out, he called back immediately. When I was done talking, he was quiet for so long, I thought he had hung up.

“Daddy will be rolling and crying in his grave now,” he finally said, sighing deeply. “I was surprised when you decided to go back to Ojiji after Ahunna

died. After that night we spoke, after you told me about all that old man and his son were doing to you, I thought you were going to stay in Onitsha and rebuild your life. We would have managed somehow. When you decided to go back to him, I was so upset with you, Adanna. Upset and disappointed.”

“I had to go back. I couldn’t get any work, and don’t forget you were still in school...”

“I would have sorted myself out, and you know it,” he cut in. “When you got back there and stayed, I thought things had changed for you. I thought you had found a way to make yourself happy with your husband’s wealth. I even resented you for it, for the way you would flaunt his money anytime you came to Onitsha to see Mommy, changing cars like you were changing your underwear. Why didn’t you tell me about this before? And you say the last time that fool beat you, you ended up in hospital?”

I nodded as if he could see me, all the pent up emotion over the years cascading down my face in the form of tears. “But he can’t continue to keep me here, not if my family comes to demand for my release. If the same people that gave me away come here to take me back, even tradition will not allow him hold me here like an animal.”

“You want mother and I to come and get you?”

“Yes! With Uncle Mathias and all the elders of Ogidi if possible. Let them all storm this place to take me back home.”

“Uncle Mathias that can barely walk from his bedroom to the bathroom? Is that who you think will be able to confront your mad dog of a husband? Forget about him, Adanna.” Jidenna retorted. “Don’t worry. I know what to do. Taking you away is not enough. We need to show them they didn’t pick you off the street. So, the man’s bastard son has not only been raping you,

he stripped you naked and beat you almost to the point of death? Twice? Mkpari! They must pay for this. They must all pay!”

“Jidenna, please,” I implored, suddenly fearing the tone of his voice. “I just want to leave here. I don’t want any trouble, biko.”

“Adanna, don’t you worry about the details. You will surely leave that place. Just go to bed and sleep well tonight. I know exactly what I’m going to do,” he answered. “I can reach you on this number, right?”

“If you can’t, just leave a message,” I answered. “The owner of the phone is a good friend, her name is Daluchi. She’ll find a way to get it across to me.”

“No problem. You will hear from me,” he answered.

And with that, the phone went dead.

I didn’t quite know what to make of the conversation. On the one hand, I was relieved to have told someone in my family about the horrors I had been exposed to for so long, but on the other hand, there was something in his voice that been ominous and worrisome. The last thing I wanted was for him to try anything stupid. He might fancy himself a hero, but he was absolutely no match for Akanna. None at all.

The knock on my door made me jump this time, and I was relieved to see it was only Daluchi back in my room and not Jidenna emerging like a spirit, mere moments after our talk.

“Thanks so much for the phone. Please don’t be angry, I finished your airtime,” I said, handing her handset back. “Don’t worry, I’ll give you money to replace it.”

She chuckled at the mere thought. “Aunty, you’re too funny. My boo will send me more, or I can even just buy some myself. He gives me a lot of money.”

“Please eh, my brother might call you later. He’s the one I just spoke to,” I cut in, not really interested in hearing any more about her love life. “If he calls, and you’re not nearby, please just take a message. Biko, it’s very important—”

Loud voices from outside caused the words to die on my lips. Daluchi and I exchanged a bewildered look before rushing to my window to see what was going on. All we could see were three of Chief’s cars parked in front of the house and a few of the older staff smiling and talking loudly.

Unable to contain my curiosity, I left the room and made my way downstairs. From the stairs, I could see almost all the staff crowded around someone. I noticed several bags and boxes, and then I saw her.

Apunanwu.

I couldn’t control the hiss that escaped my lips. So, all this noise and raucous had been for her? It made no sense. Not only had she visited only a few years before, I knew she wasn’t particularly anyone’s favourite person on the ranch. She looked up, and as we locked eyes, I could see the hatred was still very mutual.

But as I reached the stair landing, I realised the celebration hadn’t been for her. As our eyes met, my heart jumped straight into my throat, a mix of surprise...and fear. It had been two decades, but the shame I felt made it feel just like yesterday. Anayo had come back home.

Chapter Twenty-Seven

The Prodigal Children

Adanna!” Anayo called out, making everyone look in my direction.

I suddenly felt like a deer caught in the headlights.

“W...welcome,” I managed to stutter. “I...I hope you had a pleasant journey.”

“What does a village girl like you know about a ‘pleasant journey’? Have you even seen a plane before?” Apunanwu retorted.

Thankfully, the sound of Chief’s Mercedes driving in distracted everyone. Taking advantage of the distraction, I quietly made my way back upstairs. The last thing I wanted was to face Anayo, my first crush, especially not after living as not only his father’s ‘wife’ for the last two decades but, even worse, his brother’s concubine.

I was so different from the pure and innocent girl he knew, I wasn’t even the same person. But even greater than any shame I felt was an intense fear. The last time I had seen him, he had tried to rape me. He had tried to get what it was I was ‘giving his father and brother’.

No, I couldn’t run the risk of seeing him again. I was going to stay locked in my bedroom for as long as I had to, no matter how long he was in Ojiji for. God knew I had more than enough to deal with already.

Not having slept in over 24 hours, my eyes were heavy. But I couldn't risk sleepwalking, not especially with the two prodigal children back home. In addition to locking my door, I pushed my armoire in front of it, so that if my sleepwalking spirit returned that night, it would be that much harder to get out of the room. To finally seal the deal, I located some old sleeping pills in my bathroom cabinet and swallowed two of them, with the intention of knocking myself out too deeply to even consider wandering out into the night. I just couldn't afford to.

And it worked. In a matter of minutes, I fell into a deep, dreamless sleep, so deep that my eyes didn't even flicker when the sun rose the following morning. I slept so soundly and didn't wake up until there were persistent knocks on my door. Squinting to look at my watch, I was surprised to see that it was 3 o'clock in the afternoon, a record for me. The armoire was still firmly in front of the door, meaning I hadn't tried to move it out of the way in the middle of the night. If losing half of my day was the price to pay for not sleepwalking, then maybe old Doctor Nwabuwa had been right after all. Maybe the sleeping pills were what I needed to end my nocturnal habit.

The knocking continued, and I reluctantly rose to my feet and pushed the armoire out of the way.

"Ha! Auntie Adanna! I was just about to call for help to break your door open," Daluchi said, walking into my room. "I have been knocking for almost an hour. Are you okay? Don't tell me you're just waking up."

"Did my brother call?" was all I was interested to know.

"Yes! That's why I've been knocking! He's here. He's been outside by the bushes, waiting to see you," she answered enthusiastically.

My heart leapt with joy upon hearing that Jidenna had truly come, but then it crashed right back to earth when I remembered that I had been prohibited

from leaving the compound, legitimately at least. It was much too early in the day to attempt any escape through the back gate.

“Don’t worry, they have all gone out. Chief and his two children from London went out since morning and haven’t come back,” she said, probably noticing the look on my face. “And I’ve spoken to Uncle Ukawuike and co. at the gate, so they will allow you quickly go and come back. I told him your brother wants to see you, and he was very sympathetic when he heard.”

“What about Akanna?”

“He hasn’t returned since he left yesterday. My mom said he doesn’t like being around when his brother and sister are here,” she answered. “Aunty, you have to be fast so you can return before they get back.”

That reminder brought me right back to earth, and I immediately dashed to the bathroom to pour water on my face. Returning to my room, I threw on an old boubou over my nightwear and tied a scarf. This was no time for beautification. It was imperative for me to see my brother. It was imperative for me to hear what he had to say.

I half-walked, half-sprinted down the stairs, eager to see him as quickly as possible. It took everything in me to restrain myself from running down the driveway as we approached the gate. Left to me, I would have run as fast as my legs could carry me...and never return.

“Ada, biko buru osiso,” Ukawuike warned, opening the gate cautiously. “Please, be fast. I’ve sent someone down the road to alert me when Chief and the rest return, so you can return inside quickly. But let’s not allow it come to that, abeg.”

I nodded, looking around anxiously, wondering where my brother was.

“He’s over there,” Ukawuike pointed across the road. “But why is he hiding in the bush like an armed robber and not coming into the house. O bu nwanne gi now. He’s your brother!”

“I’m sure he’s in a hurry,” I answered curtly. “Thank you. I will soon be back.”

Once out of the gate, I caught sight of Jidenna standing several feet away. Glancing anxiously from left to right, I walked quickly to him, and we embraced. We held each other for a long time, not minding the curious glances from passersby. At that point, I didn’t even care what they thought. I was so happy to see my brother after well over a year.

“Is this where he hurt you?” Jidenna asked, tracing the thin line that ran along my left temple.

I nodded and lifted my scarf to show him the deeper one on the back of my head, running along where my hairline connected with my neck.

“These people don’t know who they have been messing with,” he chuckled cynically, shaking his head. “Ha abiaruwo ọdụ n’azu agwọ ahụ. They have stepped on the cobra’s tail, but they will see that we are not pushovers in our family.”

“Jidenna, please,” I pleaded, looking around, hoping nobody had heard him. “Achoghi m nsogbu o bula at all, at all. I don’t want any trouble. I just want to leave here. Leave all this talk and just come back with our people to take me away.” My eyes widened as an idea struck me. “Or I could follow you now...”

He frowned. “No way, Adanna. They came to ask for your hand in marriage. You came here with honour, and you will leave the same way. I’ll

return, and I won't return alone. I will come with some people who will help me 'talk some sense' into this barbaric family."

"Jidenna, I beg you. They are dangerous. Very, very dangerous!"

My brother laughed, and I noticed a hardness in his eyes I had never seen before. "Adanna, don't worry about it. They can only huff and puff around women. They are no match for me. Just get your bags packed, as my friends and I will come at any time."

"Why don't I just follow you now?" I implored. "The guards are not looking. If we run away quickly, we'll be able to make it to the road."

"God forbid bad thing! You are not leaving here like a common criminal!" Jidenna said, his voice raised several decibels higher than was ideal for a discrete conversation. "Adanna, please go inside. Go inside, and be patient. Before the end of the week, you'll be out of here."

And with that, he gave me a brisk hug and walked away. I stood on the road, watching his disappearing form, tempted to defy him and run away anyway. I looked back at Ukawuiké, who stood at the gate watching me keenly, as if anticipating my escape. That was when I realised there was no use creating a scene. If I ran, I would be chased after and swiftly caught, giving the villagers more fodder for their gossip. I just had to trust Jidenna. If he said he would return for me, then he would.

So, I turned around to make my way back to the ranch.

"Adanna! Adanna!" came a call from behind me.

Even without turning around, I knew who it was. I would know that voice even in my sleep. It was the voice of the man I loved more than life itself, the man whose love I'd had to sacrifice...for his own good.

I quickened my steps, not even looking back, but so did he, and very soon, he caught up with me.

“Adanna, why are you doing this?” Naeto exclaimed, holding my hand. “Why has your phone been switched off since yesterday morning? I’ve been dying with worry. I even got your maid’s phone number from Helen, but she has been unyielding.”

“Don’t you love your life?” I snapped, grabbing my hand from his. “Don’t you see that what happened to your hospital was because of me? Don’t you know that you were the one they targeted and not Olisa? Don’t you know you could have been killed?”

“Is that why you’ve stayed away? Because you’re scared for my safety?” he asked, his voice gentle. “My love, nothing is going to happen to me. I’m not afraid of Chief nor his brute of a son.”

I shook my head. “A man lost his life because of me. Another will never be the same again. I can’t take that gamble with you, Naeto. I love you too much.”

He grabbed my hand again. “Then don’t give up on us. You need to trust me, Adanna. I already had everything planned. I’d already arranged for the car to take us to Benin that night, and we would have left for Abuja the very next day. I’ve started speaking with a few people at the embassy there, and we will have your travel documents in no time. I’m going to take you far, far away from here.”

“So, you’ll just leave everything you came back to Ojiji for? Your father’s legacy and everything? Just for me?”

He laughed sadly. “They’ve already destroyed the clinic. Even before that, I’d already planned to take you with me back to the States. I’d planned to

put Olisa in charge, with myself and my other partners coming back in rotation. But all that is destroyed now. I had to even call Jide and Val to cancel their trip. They were meant to arrive next week, remember? To run the one-month oncology clinic?”

I nodded. Those were the first of his partners scheduled to come to Ojiji. But now, that would never be...and it was all because of me.

“Just turn on your phone, Adanna. Please,” he said, and my heart melted. In the seventy-two hours it had been since I’d last seen him, he had lost a considerable amount of weight. His eyes were red and hooded, and I could tell he hadn’t gotten much sleep. He was clearly distressed, and not just because of his hospital.

“I destroyed it,” I answered.

“Then take mine,” he said, pressing his phone into my hand. “I’ll get another one. We desperately need to talk. I’ll find a way to call you tonight.”

“I can’t take your phone, Naeto,” I protested, trying to return it to him. “What if one of your patient tries to...”

The words died on my lips. There were no more patients. The hospital was gone.

“It won’t be for too long, I promise you,” he said. “Before the end of the week, I would have found a way to get you out of here.”

“That’s the same thing my brother said.”

“Was he the one you were just talking to?” he asked.

I nodded. “He also has plans to rescue me,” I said, putting the phone in his pocket. “Keep your phone, Naeto. If my brother succeeds, and I’m indeed

out of here by the weekend, I'll call you from wherever I am. And then maybe we can talk. But for now, for your safety, please stay away."

"Adanna, please!" he called out as I walked away.

But this time, I didn't turn back. Tears rolled down my face, fast and furious, as I walked away, and I made no attempt to stop them. Seeing him again, even for only a few minutes, had reminded my heart just how much it yearned for him. If Jidenna was truly able to help me leave town, then I would reach out to him. But if he wasn't, well then so be it.

Approaching the gate, Ukawuiké looked the other way. Even a blind man would have realised there was nothing platonic about the exchange between Naeto and I. For a moment, I was worried that we had made yet another careless mistake, and I feared even more for the consequences, but another look at Ukawuiké showed I didn't have anything to worry about. There was sympathy and a quiet understanding on his face. He wasn't going to rat me out. I was certain of it.

Walking quickly into the ranch, I made a quick stop in the kitchen, where I filled a large bowl with rice and meat. Yes, I had no intention to leave my room, but it didn't mean I had to starve to death.

Getting back upstairs, I had a shower, changed into my nightwear, and ate the food as ravenously as someone who had been starved for days. Technically I had, as I hadn't eaten a proper meal since the day of our planned escape. After the meal, I lay on the bed, so sated that I didn't even hear my door open.

"I knocked, but you didn't answer," came Anayo's voice, as he stood at the doorway.

I sat up, bolt straight, all my defences up.

“I’m so sorry, I didn’t mean to scare you,” he apologised, and from his voice, I could tell he was sincere. “If you want me to leave, I’ll leave.”

I looked at him, no amount of fight left in me. “What do you want?”

“I just wanted to apologise to you, Adanna,” he said, still standing at the doorway. “The last time we saw, I said and did some very nasty things, things I have carried on my conscience ever since. I’m truly sorry and didn’t mean any of it.”

His earnestness brought tears to my eyes. “It’s okay, Anayo. I’ve never held it against you.”

“Can I come in?” he asked.

I wiped my eyes and nodded.

“I was just so broken, you know?” he said, sitting beside me on the bed. “One minute, I was writing several letters a day to this beautiful girl I’d fallen in love with, and the next, she was married to my dad. It destroyed me. And then when I heard you were also fooling around with my brother, I simply couldn’t take it.”

I smiled sadly and nodded in understanding. “You don’t have to explain, Anayo. Your reaction was normal.”

“It took me a lot of years of thinking about it over and over and over again to realise that something drastic must have happened to make you do it,” he continued. “I found out that your father died and also heard your sister had been ill. I realised that life must have been tough for you and your family, which is probably what led you to marry an old man like my dad.”

I nodded, more tears pooling in my eyes, touched that he had cared enough to weigh all my circumstances and realise that there had been more to my marrying his father than simply a love for the finer things of life.

“But I couldn’t figure out the part about my brother,” he continued. “The girl I fell in love with would never have done that, sleep with father and son. What happened? What made you do that?”

“Akanna raped me,” I answered, my voice quivering. “He raped me even before I had the chance to present myself to my husband. Even after your father found out, he didn’t do anything about it. So, Akanna simply just continued, and he’s been doing that to me for twenty years. The last time, he not only raped me, he beat me almost to the point of death.”

Anayo sucked his breath in, and I could tell it was hard for him to hear. “I’m so sorry you had to go through that, Adanna. But at the same time, I’m relieved to hear that you weren’t a willing participant. I’ve had several years of therapy just because of it. This whole thing messed me up completely. Why do you think I never did come home over the years? It was such a mindscrew for me, I knew there was no way I would survive seeing you with him.” He looked at me. “As for my dad, he has never been able to stand up to Akanna. From as far back as I can remember, my brother has always gotten his way with the old man. It doesn’t surprise me at all that he would have looked the other way, even knowing his own son was sleeping with his wife.”

We sat in silence for a while, neither of us knowing what to say.

“So...what do you do?” I asked, trying to ease the tension.

“I work in Advertising,” he answered. “After I found out about you and my dad, I had to drop out of medical school. My mind was so messed up that it affected my grades. I just couldn’t cope, so I had to take a few years off school. When I returned, I decided to change my major,” he shrugged. “I’m doing okay now, thankfully. I just made partner in my firm.”

“Well done. I always knew you would excel,” I said, smiling at him.

“And after pining for you for years, I finally was able to open my heart to someone else,” he said, a smile on his face. I recognised that smile. It was the smile of a man in love, and it made me even happier for him. “In fact, that’s the reason I came home, to meet her family. She couldn’t come because of work, but the plan is for my family to meet hers over the weekend, so we can get the ball rolling.”

“Congratulations, Anayo” I said, truly meaning it. “I hope she’s a nice girl.”

“She’s lovely,” he gushed, bringing out his phone to show me the picture of a pretty woman. “Her name is Amaka. My mom would have loved her. She’s a beautiful, gentle soul, and she was patient enough to wait for me to get over myself and realise she was the one.”

“Where is she from?”

“Umuahia,” he answered, chuckling. “So, that’s the destination this weekend. You better get yourself ready, my dear step-mother. I’m sure you’ll be coming with us for the introduction.”

I laughed, hoping deep down that Jidenna would have taken me away before that time.

His laughter faded, and he looked at me. “I wonder what would have happened if you hadn’t married my dad. We would have probably been together by now...maybe even with a couple of kids.”

I shook my head and smiled. “What we had was mere infatuation, Anayo. Eventually, you would have found someone else, and I would have been heartbroken. I would have eventually moved on and life would have continued as normal for us. Let’s not over romanticise the past. There is a high likelihood that we would not have ended up together.”

He contemplated my words for a while. “I disagree, but I’m not going to argue,” he put his arm around me. “We’ve wasted so much time being enemies, Adanna. I look forward to being your friend. Now that I’m getting married, I’ll very likely be coming back home often, and it would be great for there to be a friendly face. Akanna and I aren’t particularly close, and you know Apunanwu can be a bit cuckoo!”

I laughed, placing my head on his shoulder and enjoying the friendly banter. “Don’t let her hear you.”

And speaking of the devil.

“Eeeehn? I knew it! I just knew it!” came her shrill voice. “So, you have added Anayo to your list of conquests! You have completed the trifecta, sleeping with father and sons!”

Anayo and I shot to our feet as we beheld an agitated Apunanwu standing at the open doorway.

“It’s not what you think,” Anayo said.

But she was too far-gone to see reason. “Everybody come and see, o! Come and see what I am seeing, o! Anayo has joined the rest to warm this prostitute’s bed!”

“Will you keep your voice down!” Anayo exclaimed walking towards the door, his own agitation rising.

But it was too late for caution, as we soon heard footsteps coming both from the stairs below and above. Apunanwu used her hands to block the doorway, to prevent us from leaving the room, hell bent on preserving her evidence.

“I heard shouting,” Uzochi said, out of breath as she ran to the room. “Is everything okay?”

“What is all this noise about?” bellowed their father, walking up from the other side of the hallway, tying the ropes of his dressing gown after obviously throwing it on in a hurry.

“I caught them red-handed! Red-handed!” Apunanwu shouted, pointing into the room. “Anayo was in Adanna’s bed. I caught them.”

“Chineke!” Uzochi mumbled, casting a look into the room. Our eyes met, and I saw in hers disappointment.

“That’s not true. Adanna and I were having a perfectly innocent conversation,” Anayo protested. “The door was wide open, for crying out loud!”

“Wide open, but you two were all over each other. Don’t lie. I saw you. I saw you!”

I just stood there, saying nothing. The hatred I felt for her at that very instant was enough for me to ram her head into the wall with enough viciousness to decapitate her.

“You’re a disgrace!” Chief snarled, his eyes on nobody but me. “Just when I think you can’t get any worse!”

And with that, he turned around and stormed upstairs.

Anayo shoved Apunanwu out of his way. “You’re sick in the head!” Then turning to me, he shook his head. “I’m really sorry, Adanna.”

I smiled. “It’s okay.” And it truly was. I was past the stage of caring what Chief or anyone in that house thought about me. God on my side, I only had days remaining before bidding them all a permanent farewell.

“Abeg, get lost!” Apunanwu shouted at her brother as he walked away. Then turning to me, she eyed me from head to toe. “Dirty dog! You will

never change!”

She left, leaving just Uzochi and I standing there.

“Adanna, why?” the older woman cried.

“Nothing happened. The door was open, and we were fully clothed!” I exclaimed.

“What was he doing here in the first place? Why were you entertaining him here at this time of night?”

“Biko, biko,” I muttered, shutting my door firmly in her face. Much as I hated to shun her that way, I’d had enough of blame and berating to last me a lifetime. I didn’t need to add this incident to my long laundry list of things I hadn’t done but carried the blame for.

Back in bed, I mulled over what Anayo and I had discussed and realised I felt so much lighter. I hadn’t realised I had been carrying that guilt with me all this time. Now that we had finally cleared the air, I felt so much better. I was truly happy for him for finally finding happiness and prayed that someday I, too, would bask in the afterglow of true love. It made me all the more determined to reconnect with Naeto after leaving the ranch. I regretted not taking the phone he’d offered, as hearing his voice that night would have been the perfect salve, the best way to end a very short but eventful day. All I could do was count down till Jidenna made good on his promise.

That night, I slept like a baby. I wasn’t sure if it was the relief that came from reconciling with Anayo or if it was still the effect of the sleeping pills I’d taken the night before, but whatever it was helped me sleep well for the second time in a row.

Until I heard raised voices.

Looking at my watch, I saw that it was 10 am, meaning I had again slept longer than was normal for me. The voices were getting louder, and my curiosity made me throw on the first dress my hands could reach, before rushing out of the room to find out what was going on.

Running downstairs, the sound of smashing glass made me realise a fight was going on. And I was right. At the base of the stairs, I gasped at the sight that met me, Akanna and Anayo on the floor in a vicious scuffle, surrounded by shards of glass from the flower vases that had toppled over during the fracas. Anayo soon overpowered his brother and was on top of him, punching away angrily.

As Akanna struggled, for the very first time, I realised he wasn't as invincible as I'd always thought he was. He was a 50-year-old man, and age was beginning to tell. I just stood there, frozen to the spot, unable to do or say anything. The rest of the household continued to scream and shout, but nobody made any attempt to separate them.

Nobody even dared.

Akanna was finally able to push his brother off, and he staggered to his feet, wiping blood from his mouth. Anayo stood, his face also bloodied, and his expensive shirt torn. It was heartbreaking and disgraceful to behold.

"Look at her! I hope you're happy now," Apunanwu taunted from where she stood, the moment she sighted me. "Two grown men fighting over you. This is what you want, isn't it?"

As realisation hit me, my heart crashed to my feet. Over me? Their fight had been over me?

"You better be warned! The next time I hear you've gone near her, it's your dead body that they will carry back to London," Akanna snarled at his

brother.

“I’d suggest you heed your own advice!” Anayo snapped back. “If you touch her, if you ever touch her again, I will break every single bone in your body!”

“What is this? What is all this?” Chief shouted as he descended the stairs, walking into chaos for the second time in less than twelve hours. “Look at this mess! Look at yourselves! Two grown men fighting like schoolboys in the playground. Over what?”

“Over Adanna, o!” Apunanwu chirped. “They’re fighting over Adanna.”

Chief’s face clouded. “You are fighting over my wife? Nwunye’m? My own wife?”

Akanna shook his head and laughed. “Which wife? Look, there’s no pretence here. We’re not your friends and business associates you put up a show for. Don’t stand there acting all self-righteous, as if you have a proper marriage.”

Chief turned to his older son, surprised by his outburst. “What is this one saying? Are you out of your mind? You stand there and talk back at me? Is it because I have said nothing as you’ve ravaged my woman almost from the moment she arrived in this house? Is that what has given you the effrontery to speak to me that way?”

Akanna chuckled again. “Your woman indeed!”

Chief’s nostrils flared in his rising rage. “Lee ya anya. Look at him. Big for nothing! At your age, your father is still paying your bills and fending for you. Useless waste of space! It took years to undo all the damage you did to the business when you were handling it from Lagos. At my age, I’m still actively involved because the one I’m supposed to hand over to is nothing

but a buffoon. All you know how to do is sleep with my wife and beat up small boys. You're a disgrace!"

The room went so silent, a pin drop would have sounded like an explosive. But it didn't last for long. Without warning, Akanna charged at his father, grabbing the man by the neck and pinning him to the wall, prompting screams from everyone standing around.

"You think I'm Anayo that you can talk to anyhow? You've forgotten what happened the last time you tried this with me?" he shouted, tightening his grip around the man's neck. "Adanna was mine! I told you about her, and you were supposed to get her for me! But you went ahead to get her for yourself!"

Anayo, Ukawuike, and Okeke rushed to Chief's aid, wrestling Akanna off him. When they succeeded in pulling him off, Chief fell to the floor, coughing and trying to catch his breath. Uzochi ran to him with a cup of water while the rest of the domestic staff just looked on, stupefied.

"If it wasn't for me, you would be in jail by now. If it weren't for my contacts, you would have long been arrested. Who do you think got the police off your tail? Who was it that cleared the coast, enabling you to return home after being on the run for months? Yet, you call me useless?" Akanna seethed. "You are the useless one! An old man with an exaggerated opinion of himself, carrying small girls all over the place in a desperate bid to feel young. Well, news flash, sleeping with teenagers will not add to your life. Your days are numbered, and you'll be of more use to us dead! Old fool!" he spat as he stormed out of the house.

I ran to Chief to try to offer assistance, but was brushed off by Apunanwu, who had beat me to it. "Please get away from here! Haven't you done enough?"

Before I could open my mouth to respond, we were distracted by more loud noise coming from outside. I remained by Chief's side as everyone else ran out to see what was happening, Apunanwu included.

"What is going on?" Chief asked, his voice still raspy.

"It's Chiasoka, o!" Uzochi exclaimed, running back into the house. "They caught her jumping into the compound!"

"What?" Chief exclaimed, scrambling to his feet. "What kind of demon has descended on this household today?"

Joining everyone else outside, I was saddened to see that it was indeed Chiasoka, the mentally ill Chiasoka, pinned to the ground by the guards.

"Haven't I been telling you people to fix that fence?" Chief shouted, his voice still hoarse. "Now, look. A mad woman was able to find her way inside. Don't you all feel ashamed?"

Before he could even finish speaking, she pushed the men holding her down, with more strength than I would have ever given her credit for, and sprinted back to the damaged part of the fence, from where she'd gained entry. In a flash, she was out of the compound.

"Look at them! Fools!" Chief yelled, the veins in his head pulsating. "Go after her!"

The guards in their confusion ran in different directions; some jumped out of the fence to chase after her, and others ran to the gate. In all the 20 years I had lived in the ranch, I had never seen anything like it. It was utter confusion.

"Uzochi, arrange to have that fence fixed immediately!" Chief barked.

“I will do that, Chief. You have my word,” she said, reaching to hold him. “Please, let me take you upstairs. You need to rest. I should even call Dr. Naeto to come and have a look at you.”

“No need for that,” he answered. “I’ll just go to my room to catch my breath for a little while. I feel completely drained.”

I watched as Chief, flanked by Uzochi and Apunanwu, made his way upstairs, and just stood there like a casual bystander. This was the same man outraged that people were coveting his ‘wife’, but who still treated this same wife worse than a common stranger.

“You okay?” Anayo asked. “Is this how exciting things get here?”

“I’m fine,” I answered, looking at him. “But you need to take care of that lip.”

Returning to my room, I retrieved the bag I’d initially packed when Naeto and I had made our grand plans. After the events of the morning, I was more than ready to leave the dysfunctional environment. When Jidenna and his friends showed up, I wanted to be ready.

I remained in my bedroom for the better part of the day, peeping out of the window on occasion. The raucous had long died down, and everything was pretty much back to normal. I realised I hadn’t seen Daluchi in all the excitement and deduced she’d probably been at her flat in Asaba. I smiled and shook my head at the irony.

Daluchi had a flat in Asaba, while her parents were squatting in the cramped basement apartment they had been allocated. I could bet everything I owned that her mother didn’t even have any idea about the flat. Well, she was old enough to do as she wanted. I only wished she was

around to help me send a message to Jidenna, a message imploring him to speed up his plans.

By evening, hunger pangs had set in, and I decided to damn the consequences, leave my room, and go hunting for food in the kitchen. But walking down the corridor of my floor, I heard soft crying from the abandoned family lounge. As mine was the only bedroom in that wing, the recreational lounge there was hardly ever used, so it was enough for me to wonder who had found their way there.

“Those are just crocodile tears,” I heard Chief’s voice. “How can you be asking me for money to start another business, Apunanwu? How many of your failed businesses have I had to pay for?”

I pressed forward to try to hear her answer but could only hear a muffled voice.

“Why is it that always your excuse? ‘They scammed me! They scammed me!’ Why is it only you people scam?” Chief retorted. “Over 40 years old and nothing to show for it. Husband, mba. Children, for where. Job, no way. Business, whossai. You are good for nothing, and you should be ashamed of yourself!”

At this point, I couldn’t take it anymore. Almost involuntarily, my hand reached for the door knob, and I walked into the room. Both Chief and his daughter looked up, surprised.

“What do you want here?” Apunanwu exclaimed through her tears.

“Do you have no heart at all?” I said, addressing her father. “Do you feel proud of yourself, reducing your daughter to tears? Does it bring you joy when everyone around you is unhappy?”

“Look at this wretched girl!” he laughed mockingly. “So, because everyone has had a go at me today, you think you too deserve a turn?”

I shook my head, disgusted. “A man with everything, but yet nothing. Apunanwu is the only one on your side, and look how you are treating her?”

“When I am talking to my children, never you deceive yourself into thinking it will ever concern you. It will never concern a wretch like you. Wretched girl from a poverty-stricken family!” Chief retorted.

“You are a sorry excuse for a man,” I said to him, the first time I was brave enough to stand up to him. “You are the worst decision my mother and I made. If only I could go back in time, so much would be different.”

“The worst decision you and your mother made indeed. You are just a joker. You and your harlot of a mother who is still looking for whom to sleep with in exchange for money!” he mocked, laughing. “Did I tell you I saw her, this last time I was away? I ran into her at Onitsha market, looking like a beggar. The old hag had the audacity to insult me, throwing empty threats at me, telling me I destroyed her family. A family that would have imploded without my money,” he shook his head and chuckled. “I don’t blame you people. I blame myself for stooping so low as to come join your ilk in the pig sty.”

His words stabbed me in the heart, and I felt sadness and regret, for my mother’s sake, for mine, and for my family’s.

“Imagine you telling me I’m a sorry excuse for a man! Adanna, I’ve been very lenient with you, don’t let me show you my other eye,” he said, the sardonic smile still on his lips. “It was out of pity for you that I left your doctor boyfriend alone and just decided to teach him a small lesson by destroying his hospital. Left to me, you know he wouldn’t even be

breathing by now. But my respect for his late father made me go easy on him.”

Goosebumps erupted all over my body. “You were responsible for what happened to the hospital?”

“From the very moment the boy came here that first time to tell us he was in town, I saw how you two were exchanging puppy looks. When I left you in his care before I travelled, I wanted to see if you would fall into my trap...and you both did; hook, line, and sinker. It amazes me how much of a fool you take me for, Adanna.”

Apunanwu’s tears had by now dried, and she watched her father and I with rapt attention.

“You are an evil man,” I said, after standing silent for a while. “If I hadn’t married you, I would have made something of my life. You will live to regret ruining my life.”

“Adanna, please leave. My father and I were having a conversation before you rudely interrupted,” Apunanwu interjected, but I saw what looked like concern in her eyes. She wasn’t dismissing me for her benefit...but mine.

“No, let her stay!” Chief countered. “Let her stay and listen to me wash her down! Imagine the wretch I picked from the gutter having the effrontery to stand there and talk back –”

I stepped out of the room, closing the door shut, all desire for food gone.

As I returned to my room, I had no idea it would be the last time I saw Chief Arinze Nsofor alive.

Chapter Twenty-Eight

The Morning After

I am drifting in and out of listening to the conversation Sergeant Ifedi is having with Akanna and Anayo. Apunanwu is still sitting listlessly on the floor, and the crowd of domestic staff loitering by the door has been dispersed. I look again at my husband's body, sprawled on the floor, soiled with blood, vomit, and if the smell in the room is anything to go by, feaces. What a sad, shameful, and ungraceful way to go!

"But, you had already left," I say, finally finding my voice. "You left in the morning, under very unpleasant circumstances. How come you were around to have wine with him late at night? I saw him with Apunanwu at about 8pm, and you weren't with them."

All eyes turn to me, bewildered, until Akanna points at his chest, "Are you talking to me?"

"What unpleasant circumstances?" Sergeant Ifedi asks.

"Nothing. It was just a small family misunderstanding," Apunanwu answers, throwing me a dirty look.

"That's why I came back. To make peace with him," Akanna answers. "I wasn't happy with what happened between myself and the old man, and also," he pats Anayo on the shoulder, "my brother here. So, I came back to make peace. Dad was happy to see me and invited us up to his room to have a few drinks. Isn't that right, Anayo?"

Anayo nods. "It's true."

Sergeant Ifedi nods and scribbles. "So, you two left him here hale and hearty?"

"Well, I did," Akanna says. "I left him with Anayo, so Lord knows what happened afterwards."

"After the heated argument you had with Dad, you mean," Anayo retorts. "Since we're going into specifics, we might as well drill down to the small details."

"My father and I were still passionate about what happened earlier in the day, and I guess the wine made us more loose-lipped than we ordinarily would have been," Akanna answers. "We said things we shouldn't have said, it got heated, and I left."

"But you remained here in the ranch?" Sergeant Ifedi probes.

"It was well past midnight. A bit late to drive back to Asaba, don't you think?"

The sound of a van driving in breaks the flow of questions.

"It's the ambulance," Anayo says, and I can hear in his voice the weight of the looming responsibility of having to take his father to the morgue.

"My brother and I have to do the needful, Sergeant," Akanna says. "Any longer, and the body will start to decompose. You can see that his widow and daughter are already traumatised as it is."

"No problem, Sir. My apologies, Sir," Sergeant Ifedi answers, and I am dismayed to hear the reverence in his voice. If he too is afraid of Akanna, where on earth can this investigation go? "We can continue later. One of my men will escort you to the mortuary, while the rest of us remain here to talk

to the staff.” He turns to Ukawuike. “Bia, Nwoke, onweghi onye batara na onweghi onye na-apụ apụ. Nobody comes into the compound, and nobody goes out, you understand?”

The distraught guard nods obediently, clearly wishing the whole nightmare away.

It feels like an out-of-body experience, especially when Chief’s body is loaded on a stretcher and taken out of the room, closely followed by Akanna and Anayo. Apunanwu surprisingly makes no move to go with them. I leave her in the room as I walk behind my stepsons, who, in turn, walk behind the body. Uzochi is no longer crying on the staircase, and I overhear someone say she has been sedated to sleep. The death of her benefactor has hit her hard, and understandably so.

“No, you don’t need to come with us, Ada,” Anayo says, as I make to follow them outside. “Akanna and I will handle this,” he beckons one of the maids. “Please, see to it that she has a shower and some food, okay?”

But I have no intention to do either.

“Just get my housecoat,” I say to her, once the ambulance has driven off. There is no way I’m going to retreat to my room, pulling myself away from the rest, not with a killer on the loose.

“Mrs. Nsofor, once again, I’m very sorry for your loss,” Sergeant Ifedi says, walking up behind me. “Is there anywhere we can talk?”

The maid returns with my housecoat at that point, and I shrug into it. “Sure. Come this way.”

I lead him to the living room, past the dour-faced domestic staff. It is not manufactured grief that they feel. He might not have been the kindest man in the world, but Chief treated his staff well and was loved by them. His

death is a real blow to the people who have worked for him for years, many of whom for decades.

“You said you retired early?” Sergeant Ifedi asks, once we are seated.

I nod. “I actually retired to my room much earlier in the day. I guess it’s no secret that there was...an incident in the house that day. I left for my room shortly after, and only came out to look for something to eat at about eight in the evening.”

“And you saw Chief then?”

“He was talking with his daughter in the lounge near my bedroom,” I answer.

“And then you went to bed immediately after?”

“Yes,” I say, not bothering to tell him how the exchange had been so bad, I hadn’t even bothered with food after all.

Apunanwu walks into the room to join us, still looking like someone in a trance. Sergeant Ifedi looks up and nods to acknowledge her presence.

“I was just telling him that I saw you and your father talking last night, before I went to bed,” I say to her.

Is it my imagination, or is there a flicker in her eyes?

“Yes. Yes, she did,” she confirms, sitting beside me.

“And she went straight to bed afterwards?” Sergeant Ifedi asks her, and I find it offensive that my word is not good enough for him.

“I didn’t see her again, so I reckon so,” Apunanwu answers.

“But then at night, you...erm...you came downstairs?” Sergeant Ifedi asks me.

“I have had a sleepwalking problem for years,” I answer, trying to keep my voice steady. “Everybody knows this. Not just here in the ranch, but probably the entire village.”

“So sorry, Ma. I didn’t mean to offend,” Sergeant apologises profusely. “I was just trying to ascertain your whereabouts, that’s all.”

Just then, one of the other policemen drags in one of the cooks, Inyene. “Sir, we just found out the cook is a relative of Chief’s former wife.”

Apunanwu’s head shoots up in surprise. “Nkoyo?”

I stare at Inyene in surprise. Very quiet and mild-mannered, he was hired a few months before, when one of the cooks left for a job in an Asaba hotel. “Is that true?”

Inyene’s head remains bowed, his sobs racking his entire body.

“Take him away from here,” Sergeant Ifedi orders, before turning to look at Apunanwu and me. “Let me go and talk to the staff. Biko, jisike. Take heart. Today is a very sad day indeed.”

He gets up and walks out of the room, just as I see, from the window, his men bundling Inyene into their van. Even though it is an outrage that Nkoyo’s relative has infiltrated our household, I find it difficult to believe that the timid cook is the culprit. After our last encounter 20 years ago, we never heard from Nkoyo again. I don’t know if she and Chief ever reached a private financial arrangement, but what I do know is that she never set foot in the ranch again.

“Nkoyo’s relative has been here, cooking my father’s food? Unbelievable!” Apunanwu exclaims.

“Uzochi is the only one who cooks...” I am dismayed to realise that it is now past tense. “...cooked for your father. Inyene and Pat cook for

everyone else. To be honest, I'm not sure why his association with Nkoyo should make him guilty."

Apunanwu shrugs. "You never know. Why would he leave his place and come all the way to Ojiji, to the same house that sent his family member away in disgrace, to find work? He couldn't get a job elsewhere?"

I say nothing in response, and we just sit in silence for a few minutes.

"Look, Adanna, I'm sorry for shouting at you earlier. I'm really sorry for all the awful things I said..."

"You mean accusing me and my 'lovers' of murdering your father?" I retort, angered afresh.

"I wasn't thinking straight. Waking up to find my father dead, a man I spoke with just last night, really hit me hard. I'm so sorry," she says, before moving closer to me. "And thank you for standing up for me last night. It means a lot."

I look at her, unable to mask my suspicion, wondering where this friendliness is coming from after so many years of enmity.

"Adanna, did you see those wounds on Akanna's hands? All those bruises?" she asks, her voice a conspiratory whisper. "I think he went back to Dad's room after Anayo left last night. I think he's the one who killed him. You heard all the horrible things he said to him in the morning, how he's more useful dead than alive. You heard, didn't you?"

I nod slowly, not quite knowing what to say nor how to react. Yes, I too have noticed Akanna's hand wounds, but I am reluctant to admit it to his sister, who could just be baiting me for all I know.

"I'm going to give him time to own up, but if he doesn't, I'll have no choice but to alert the police," she continues saying.

At this point, I have had enough.

“Please excuse me, I need to go and clean up,” I say, rising to my feet. “I think you should do the same. It’s going to be a very long day.”

And I am right. Even though nobody is allowed into or out of the premises, the police remain, interviewing...no...interrogating every single person on the ranch. After a quick shower, I manage to nibble on some biscuits as I sit in the living room with the door open, watching as the police talk to the staff in the dining room, one after the other. When Anayo and Akanna return, Sergeant Ifedi asks to meet with all four of us again.

“I’ve already sent a request to Asaba, for them to make arrangements for an autopsy,” he says. “I believe that will help put everyone’s mind to rest.”

“Is it really necessary? Isn’t it obvious the way he died?” Akanna asks. “He was stabbed in the stomach and had a chair broken over his head. The evidence is there for all to see.”

“Yes, but we still have to conclude which of the two injuries killed him, Sir,” he answers. “We also spoke with all the staff. One of them has been arrested as a possible suspect.”

“The cook?” Akanna grunts and shakes his head. “Officer, your people can’t surely think that little man is your culprit. My father, even at his age, would have thrown him away with one hand.”

“It’s Sergeant, Sir,” Sergeant Ifedi answers, his voice firm. I can’t help a satisfied smile, happy that the man is not as intimidated by Akanna as I’d earlier suspected. “And we can’t rule anything out. We have to see every lead to its conclusion.”

“What would Nkoyo have to gain from killing our dad after so many years?” Anayo muses.

“It could be anything...revenge most likely, if their parting was as acrimonious as I have been made to believe,” Sergeant Ifedi answers.

“So, apart from arresting a poor, defenceless cook, what did you find out from talking to the staff, save from wasting everybody’s time?” Akanna asks, his voice dripping with sarcasm. “Have you and your men even looked outside these gates at all? Just yesterday, a lunatic broke into the compound, a lunatic who has a sordid history with our father. Have you even looked into that? What about the doctor whose hospital the old man destroyed? Have you gone to find out where he was at that time of night?”

I glare at him, furious over any inference that Naeto had anything to do with it.

“Yes, we were told about Chiasoka, God rest her soul,” Sergeant Ifedi answers. “She was found hanging from a tree yesterday evening, so it is unlikely that she came here to kill your father. Unless you reckon it was her ghost.”

If it weren’t for the severity of the situation, I would have burst out laughing.

“As for Doctor Naeto, is this a formal confession that your family was behind the vandalization of his hospital?” Sergeant Ifedi probes.

“No, oh, Sergeant. Please ignore him,” Apunanwu cuts in. “Why would my father vandalize anybody’s hospital? He was very close to Dr. Nwabuwa. Please strike that out. Maybe the alcohol from last night is still turning my brother’s brain.”

You can cut the tension in the room with a knife, as Apunanwu glares at Akanna, and Anayo looks around confused. We sit in silence for a few more minutes, before Sergeant Ifedi rises to his feet.

“We better leave you, it’s been a long day, and I’m sure you all need to mourn privately,” he says. “Please accept our condolences once again. Ojiji has lost a great man,” he turns to look at me. “Madam, please can you show me to the servants’ quarters? I want to ask a few more questions before we leave.”

I reluctantly stand and lead him out of the living room. Once outside, he holds me by the hand. “That was just an excuse to get you out of there,” he says. “I wanted to ask you a question, and I didn’t want to do it in their presence.”

I look at him, confused about what he could possibly want to ask me about.

“A few of the staff have told me that your brother was seen here the day before yesterday,” he says. “They say you two were talking outside by the bushes, something most of them found odd.”

My heart starts racing. “Odd in what sense? What’s odd about a woman talking to her brother?”

Sergeant Ifedi smiles, and I can read a million and one meanings into that smile. “Is he still in town?”

“Of course not!” is my retort. “He went back to Onitsha that same day and hasn’t been back since.”

Or at least, I don’t think he has. I have a sick feeling in my stomach as I realise there is a possibility Jidenna returned last night...and did what he said he was going to.

“I also hear that your mother and your late husband had a confrontation in Onitsha recently,” Sergeant Ifedi says. “Your family wasn’t on good terms with him?”

“My family has...my family had a perfect relationship with my husband,” I answer firmly. “I don’t know who is feeding you with all these lies.”

“Please don’t take offence, Ma,” he says. “I just had to run these by you but didn’t want to do it to the hearing of Chief’s children. There might be nothing to these suspicions, but from what I have observed today, they might read more meaning into them.”

I nod, grateful he, at least, had the wisdom not to bring any of these to their attention. The last thing I need is to explain to Akanna and Apunanwu, especially, why my brother refused to enter the house and had instead chosen to speak with me outside. There is no way it can be spun not to look suspicious.

Walking away, through the open door, I spot Uzochi sitting in the kitchen. She seems to have aged several years over the course of the day and looks drained of energy, drained of life. Our eyes meet, and she dissolves into tears again, something I suspect she has been doing the whole day. But I am not in the mood to mourn with her, nor anyone for that matter. I just want to be by myself.

“Adanna,” Anayo calls out. “I saw you talking to the policeman. What did he want?”

“He just wanted to get a few details about the number and distribution of our staff,” I answer, the lie heavy on my lips. “Nothing serious.”

“I heard you don’t have a phone,” he says. “You can use mine, in case you want to call your family to let them know what’s happened.”

I look around, wondering if he and the rest heard what Sergeant Ifedi told me, hence his sudden interest in my family. Is it even concern, or just a ploy to record any conversation I have with them?

“You can keep it with you for as long as you need it,” he continues. “It’s scandalous that you don’t have one. Keep it. I have another I can use while I’m here.”

I don’t argue nor protest. Instead, I thank him before making my way to my room. Once there, I fish out my notebook and dial Jidenna’s number. It is switched off, further adding to my agitation. I then proceed to call my mother.

“Good evening, Mommy,” I say, when the line connects. “It’s Adanna.”

“Ada! My daughter, it’s so good to hear your voice,” my mother exclaims. “You have been on my mind, and I’ve been meaning to send you a message through Uzochi, since I got to Abatete.”

“You’re in Abatete?” I exclaim. “Since when?”

“I came because of my leg, the thing has refused to heal,” she answers. “I told you about my leg the last time we spoke, or have you forgotten? The pain got so bad that I couldn’t even sleep at night. But it’s improved since I got here. At least pus has stopped coming out of it.”

“Chief is dead, Mommy. He was killed last night.”

The line is quiet for a while. “That’s a pity,” is her curt answer.

“Mommy, they’re suspecting you,” I blurt out, aggravated by her aloofness. “They say you got into a public quarrel with him in Onitsha.”

“Suspecting me, why? We exchanged words, that doesn’t mean I killed him,” she snaps. “I ran into him at the market some weeks back, and when he started taunting me and our family circumstance that led to this marriage of yours, I couldn’t take it. All the anger and resentment that has been building over the years just poured out of my mouth. My daughter, I know you like it there, but I’m glad the man is dead. Very wicked man. O bughị

ezigbo mmadu. Please, after your mourning period, just pack your things and come back home. It's just unfortunate because I was hoping we could use his connections to get Jidenna out of police custody, but my daughter, I'm glad he's permanently out of the way and no longer an obstacle in your path. Please, come home. Leave that place and come back home."

"Jidenna is in police custody?" I exclaim. "Where? Why? When?"

"Yesterday morning, he called to tell me he was going to Port Harcourt to see his former classmates," she answers. "I couldn't understand what kind of visit it was in the middle of the week and why he was so keen on seeing these so-called friends, people he hasn't seen in years. I tried to talk him out of it, but you know how stubborn your brother is. He went anyway," she sighs deeply. "And my fears were correct. Those people he went to see, ha bu onye oshi! Thieves and kidnappers! Not up to an hour after he got there, he was with them in a beer parlour when the place was raided by police. They carried all of them away, including your brother. I heard the news this morning, and I was praying your husband would be able to assist."

By now, I'm no longer listening. Jidenna reconnected with friends from his obviously murky past, all because of me. He had been in Port Harcourt to rally his troops to help me, but alas, things hadn't quite gone the way he'd anticipated.

"I wish I could be with you now, but my leg is still very bad," my mother says. "I also need to find a way to get your brother out of custody. But I promise to be there before you start your funeral rites. You need moral support. You need your family with you at this time. We need to show them that you still have people. But in the meantime, please be strong. Don't let anybody bully you. If they want to do anything, tell them I said they should wait for me to get there."

Getting off the phone, saddened as I am about the turn of events, at least my mother and brother both have rock solid alibis. What stronger alibi could there be than sleeping in police custody? I almost wish I could call Sergeant Ifedi to give him the news, but I decide to keep the information for the next time he tries to confront me about it.

There is a soft tap on my door.

“Hi Adanna,” Anayo says, looking into my room.

“Hi,” I answer. “You want your phone back?”

“No, I told you it’s yours for as long as you want it,” he answers. “I just wanted to give you some news. Sergeant Ifedi just called. He said someone has come forward to confess to the murder.”

I sit up, more than ready to find out whom it was that killed the man I called husband. “Who?”

“Some old man in town,” Anayo answers. “I’m not too sure, but I think he said his name is Achike.”

I let out an audible gasp. Chizutere’s father?

Chapter Twenty-Nine

The Murderer

That's not possible," I counter, not believing for a minute that the old man could have found his way to the ranch to kill Chief. "There has to be a mistake."

Anayo shrugs. "Sergeant Ifedi says the guy just came to the station to make the confession. They'll keep him overnight and tomorrow morning we'll go there to see what's happening for ourselves," he pauses, deliberating his next words. "You should come with us, Adanna. Don't let my sister, or anyone at all, relegate you to a corner. He was your husband."

I nod, completely agreeing with him. By staying on the sidelines and not being aware of every development in the unfolding case, I run the risk of being thrown under the bus. "I'll be there."

The next morning, I awaken on my bed, which is a relief to me as I was too tired the previous night to take any measures to avert the sleepwalking. As I get ready for the day's activities, I think of Naeto and kick myself again for not having the foresight to have saved his phone number when I had the chance. Now that I have a phone at my disposal, I can't even put it to good use.

I opt to wear a simple black dress with a black scarf, knowing fully well that once the dust settles, I will have to commence the traditional widowhood rites. I shudder when I remember what my mother had to go

through, and I am resentful that I will have to endure the same, but in my case for a man who was never even really a husband to me. But then I remind myself of the silver lining. Yes, I might have to cut my hair and be subject to all sorts of unnecessary torture...but none of that will change the fact that I am free. I am finally free.

“Do you really need to come?” Akanna asks, as I walk out of the house to join the car conveying him and his siblings to the police station.

“I’m his widow. If I shouldn’t be there, then who should?” is my curt answer as I walk to the front of the car, getting into the passenger seat, daring anyone to stop me.

Thankfully, none of them do. As I exchange greetings with Okeke and Anayo, and a strained one with Apunanwu, Akanna finally gets into the car, and we are soon on our way to see for ourselves Chief’s confessed killer. The police station is in the heart of town and a 30-minute drive from the house.

As we journey there, driving through the streets of Ojiji, I am struck by the fact that this is a place I have called home for the better part of my life. I remember arriving at the town as a young and innocent girl, struggling to make sense of this new environment. But over the years, I have grown accustomed to the deep red sand, the thick bushes that intersperse most houses, and the natives who never appear to be in any hurry and go about their business in a leisurely manner. A far cry from the mad, frenetic pace of life I was used to in Onitsha.

But my love for the town is not enough to make me stay. The nightmare of a life I have lived in the four corners of the ranch more than overshadows whatever affection I have for the quiet, sleepy town. The very moment I am able to, I will leave.

The police station is a small bungalow that has seen better days. I had imagined it to be brimming with activity, with criminals and their sympathisers filing in and out, but this is far from the case. Apart from a haggard man, whose age I can't even tell, sitting apathetically on a slab, the place is a ghost town.

"Ah, you have come. Welcome!" Sergeant Ifedi says as we walk in. He is talking to one of his junior officers behind the counter and looks like he hasn't slept all night.

"Where is the murderer?" Akanna demands, not even bothering with any pleasantries.

"Good morning, Sergeant," Anayo greets. "Did you keep him in the cell overnight?"

"Cell, ke? We don't have money to treat anybody or, worse, bury an old man." Sergeant Ifedi answers. "He stayed in my office. He's still there now."

"But he's a murderer!" Apunanwu shouts. "Why are you concerned with making comfortable a man who has confessed to killing my father?"

Sergeant grunts, obviously doing everything he can to keep his temper in check. "When you see him, you can make your inference. Come with me."

We follow him to his office, where Achike is sitting. He is eating a small loaf of bread and looking like a man without a care in the world.

"O na-eri bread?" Apunanwu exclaims, rushing to grab the loaf from the poor man, throwing it to the floor. "You killed my father, and you're here eating bread and shaking your dirty leg?"

"Apunanwu, was that really necessary?" Anayo exclaims, exasperated.

I also feel saddened by her behaviour, ashamed that we have deprived the old man of what could possibly be the first meal he has had in God knows how long. But he doesn't even look disturbed and remains seated on the chair, a cheeky smile on his face, very different from the bitter and angry man I remember.

"Please sit down," Sergeant Ifedi says, beckoning us to the other chairs in the office, unable to hide his irritation and making no attempt to make additional seating arrangements, as the two other chairs in his office will clearly not accommodate four people.

Akanna and Anayo remain standing, leaving the chairs to Apunanwu and I. I make sure to take the chair separating my stepdaughter from the suspected murderer, lest we have another murder on our hands.

"When I got back to the station last night, I met him here," Sergeant Ifedi says. "My officer on duty says he walked in a few hours before, confessed to the murder, and took a seat. Immediately I heard, I called to inform you, after which I proceeded to interrogate him," he shakes his head. "You people need to hear this for yourselves," then turning to Achike. "Ngwanu, tell them."

The old man turns to us and beats his chest. "Ọ bụ m gburu ya. I was the one who killed your wicked father. I killed him the same way he killed my family."

Four of us just stare at him, speechless for a while, nobody knowing what to say. What do you say to a statement as blunt and direct as that?

"You're the one who killed him?" Anayo repeats, and I hear the doubt in his voice. "How did you manage it? How did you get into the house?"

“I didn’t have to go to his house to kill him,” he declares with unmistakable pride in his face. “All I had to do was talk to my God, and He did it. Chineke na-alurū m ọgụ! My God fights for me. I didn’t have to lift a finger. All I did was tell Him that I wanted the man dead, and gbua! Chukwu gburu ya! HE killed him for me! My God is a wonderful God!”

Akanna hisses and walks out of the office.

“Your God killed him for you?” Apunanwu repeats, before turning to Sergeant Ifedi. “Is the man crazy or something?”

“I’m not crazy! I’m of sound mind. My body might no longer be strong, but my mind is as sharp as a razor,” Achike answers, before pointing in my direction. “She knows I’m telling the truth. She heard me tell him God would avenge me. Or didn’t you hear? The day I saw you both in church, didn’t you hear me tell him?”

“Honestly, I only kept him overnight so he would still be here when you people arrived,” Sergeant Ifedi says, his voice tired, clearly fed up with the situation. “Left to me, I would have let him go since last night. I blame that imbecile out there who didn’t bother to interrogate him before calling to give me false news.”

“No, no, no!” Achike protests. “Mba! I killed the man. I got vengeance for what he did to me. Now, you need to handcuff me and put me in your cell.”

“Nna, go home. Go home and sleep. Leave us to do our job without distraction,” Sergeant Ifedi says, handing the man a hundred naira note. “Were onwe gị nweta ihe ị ga-eri. Get yourself something to eat, abeg. Leave this place biko.”

When Achike continues to protest, Sergeant Ifedi summons one of the officers who proceeds to escort the old man out of the premises. Akanna

walks back in, looking anything but pleased.

“I think this case is beyond you, Officer,” he says with disdain. “We have wasted one half of the day on an old man who thinks God is his hitman, when you should be out there pursuing other leads. For one thing, you should be in Onitsha, interrogating her brother, who I’m told was seen hovering near the house only days ago, whispering and looking suspicious with her,” he ends by pointing at me.

“Her brother? Adanna and her brother?” Apunanwu exclaims, looking at me in astonishment. “You and your brother were seen plotting to kill my dad? You killed him? After everything he did for you?”

“Calm down, guys,” Anayo interjects. “Let’s not jump to conclusions –”

“My father who brought you out of abject poverty and elevated you to human status? You killed him?” Apunanwu continues, refusing to back down.

“Enough, please! Enough!” I shout, well and truly fed up. “Enough from you! You’ve been there pointing the finger at everyone, whispering in everyone’s ears like a rat. Have you pointed the finger at yourself? You have just as much reason as anyone to have killed the man. You forget I heard all the insults he threw at you that night. You have everything to gain with him dead, so as you’re suspecting others, you better add yourself to that list. Because God knows, you are top of mine!”

Apunanwu is at first taken aback, before she dissolves into tears, much to everyone’s surprise. “How can you think I killed my father? The man was everything to me.”

“Everything, including his bank account,” Akanna chortles. “It honestly wouldn’t surprise me. His money is your only means of survival, after all.”

“And what about you?” Apunanwu demands tearfully. “You still have not given a believable reason for why you came back to the house so late at night. And those injuries on your hands, how did you get them? You threatened him to the hearing of everyone in the house. I’m surprised Sergeant hasn’t put you behind bars yet!”

“Do you have amnesia or something?” Akanna retorts. “You’ve forgotten that your younger brother fought me earlier in the day over this harlot over here. You think that left me with heart prints on my hands?”

“But can anyone confirm your whereabouts in the early hours of the morning when he was killed?” Anayo asked. “I was with him till well past midnight. Is there anyone who can verify that you were asleep all night, as you say?”

“I’m a married man, little brother. The only person able to verify my whereabouts at that time of night is my wife, and we all know I wasn’t with her. I was asleep in my old room, alone! So no, I have nobody who can ‘verify my whereabouts’!” Akanna retorts in response. “What about you? You were the last one with him. Why isn’t anyone considering the possibility that you killed him? After all, he married the girl you wanted, and we all know that you have held on to that pain ever since. Or maybe you’re just as eager to get a hold of his money as your sister.”

“I have no need for the man’s money, and you know it!” Anayo retorts. “And the reason I came back home is because I am in love with another woman whom I am getting married to. Whatever I had with Adanna is history!”

“In your best interest, you all should stop talking,” Sergeant Ifedi interjects. “It’s like you’ve forgotten where you are, throwing accusations at each other right here in the police station. In my very presence! Onweghi ihe

mmadu na-agaghị ahụ. There is nothing I won't see in this line of work.” Then turning to Akanna, “As for your concerns about your step-mother's brother, we have confirmed that the young man is in police custody for an unrelated offence. And as for all your accusations and counter accusations, trust me when I say we are leaving absolutely no stone unturned to get to the bottom of this matter,” he gestures to the door. “You may leave now.”

The ride back home is a tense one, everyone lost in their thoughts. I am not convinced by Apunanwu's tears, and she still remains the person I suspect the most. Akanna has too much to lose with the old man dead, and my heart doesn't believe Anayo would have done anything so sinister. To me, Apunanwu is the obvious culprit.

As we drive up to the ranch, there are dozens of people at the gate, weeping. News of Chief's death has reached the village and, as expected, their grief is palpable. The movement restriction is still on, with nobody allowed into or out of the premises. Getting to the house, I am surprised that the number of policemen there seems to have doubled. I'd thought that with Sergeant Ifedi in the station, there would be none of them at the ranch, but there they still are, pretty much everywhere you turn.

I ask for my lunch to be delivered to my room, and I am asleep very shortly after eating it, mentally and physically exhausted. With the mystery of Chief's murder still rife, whether we like it or not, we are all prisoners in the house, even the prospective groom. I feel saddened that the reason for Anayo's trip back home has been botched. With all that is happening, it is very unlikely that any introduction ceremony will be able to take place anytime soon.

The next morning, the movement restriction is lifted, and I am forced to remain in the living room all day, receiving visitors. I sit there, clad in dark

coloured clothes, forcing myself to wear the sullen and melancholy look of a widow. Thankfully, all I have to do is nod in acknowledgement to their greetings and expressions of sympathy. As a widow, I do not have to say anything. I have Akanna and Anayo for that.

I know it is only a matter of time before the traditionalists will descend on the house, telling me what to do; to sit on the floor, to not sit on the floor, to bathe or not bathe, eat or not eat. I don't even remember the specifics. I only remember that my mother was bound by so many rules when my father died. I don't know if it is a coincidence or just bad luck that my mother and I were widowed at almost the same age.

As the police walk about the house, dragging different people into questioning, I am forced to wonder if they even know what they are doing. It seems to me like plenty of motion but with no movement. With all the bombshells dropped at the police station the previous day, not one of us, not Apunanwu, Anayo, Akanna, nor myself have been questioned any further. On the contrary, we have all been allowed to roam freely, Akanna especially.

He has been coming and going as he pleases. If he is indeed the killer, he could have made a run for it a long time ago. It occurs to me that, at this rate, we might never find Chief's killer. Either that or we transfer the case to another police jurisdiction, Asaba maybe.

I go through the motions that day and the next, and all I can do is wonder why Naeto hasn't come to visit yet. Surely, by now he would have heard about what happened. I start to fear that he has taken on board my admonition to forget about me, realising he is better off not being associated with me.

With Uzochi still walking around the house like a ghost, Anayo has been the closest to a friend I have had in the house since this unfortunate incident. Apunanwu has been withdrawn and uncharacteristically quiet, and Akanna...well Akanna has been Akanna. I would do anything to see Naeto again.

I am asleep the next time I hear his voice. I am drained after receiving a large contingent from the church, and I'm lying on the couch, catching a short nap. As I hear the comforting timbre of his voice, I almost don't want to wake up from the dream. I want to reach out for him, and never, ever let go.

But it isn't a dream.

My eyes open, and I see Naeto and Anayo talking with a lot of familiarity, almost like they know each other or are, worse, friends.

"It was a real shock, my brother," Anayo is saying. "One minute, we were making plans for how we would go to see our prospective in-laws, and the next minute," he gestures around, "we wake up to this."

"Accept my condolences. It's never easy to lose a parent," Naeto answers. "And your dad was in such great health the last time I saw him."

"That's what makes it more painful," Anayo answers. He catches sight of me sitting up and smiles. "Adanna, you're awake."

"Adanna," Naeto says, before he can catch himself. "How are you? I've been worried."

"I'm fine," is all I can answer, even though I really want to add 'Better now you're here'.

Anayo looks from Naeto to me, and a smile of understanding forms on his lips. "Let me go grab a bite from the kitchen," he says. "Naeto, we'll catch

up later.”

“You’re friends with Anayo?” I ask, as Naeto sits beside me.

“We all grew up together. It’s a small town,” he answers. “I’m so sorry about what happened to Chief. So, you guys just woke up and found him dead?”

I nod. “It’s a mystery.”

He moves closer. “Adanna, being without you is killing me. I can’t even function. I miss you so much.”

I look around cautiously. “Not here, Naeto. Anyone can come in.”

True to my words, we hear voices in the hallway, and Apunanwu soon leads another crowd of sympathisers into the living room. She and Naeto exchange pleasantries, as he rises to make room on the sofa for the ‘important dignitaries’. I watch helplessly as he takes a seat on the other end of the living room and wish I could order everyone there out, so we can finally have some time alone. But instead, I sit and nod through yet another visit, while Apunanwu answers the myriad of questions our sympathisers always have about the circumstances surrounding his death.

I am further dismayed when, just as they rise to leave, another group arrives, and then another. It is an endless flow of visitors, but Naeto sits through it all, waiting patiently for time alone with me. Eventually, the last of the sympathisers leave, and Naeto takes advantage of Apunanwu and Anayo seeing off the visitors to move closer to me.

This time, we do embrace. I hold him, comforted by the feel of his arms and his signature mint and sandalwood smell.

“I’ve missed you so much, Adanna. But I’m glad. I’m glad that we can finally plan for our future. As soon as your mourning period is over, I’m

going to take you away from here,” he says, kissing me on my forehead.

I nod, happy that our hearts are still in sync and that we are thinking the very same thing. If it weren't for the 20 years I have spent as Chief's wife, I wouldn't even bother hanging around after the funeral. But out of respect for him, I will observe my widowhood rites, after which I will walk out of the gate with my head held high.

Naeto and I pull apart, and his brows are furrowed.

“Are you okay, my love? You seem tense. Your fists have been clenched since I got here. I noticed it while I was sitting on the other side.”

“Clenched?” I look at my hands and see that, truly, they are clenched. I release them, but they involuntarily form balls again. “I didn't even notice. It's been a stressful time, so maybe my body is just reacting.”

He takes my hands in his, and I am surprised by how painful this feels. The look of concern on his face shows that he can also feel it.

The deep wound on my right palm.

“Adanna, what happened?” Naeto asks, his voice a whisper. “How did you get this?”

I look at it, the wound, bewildered. I, too, have noticed the deep cut, but as my sleepwalking over time has led me to more than a few injuries, I haven't thought much of it.

“I don't know. I must have injured myself the night I...you know...” I answered, ashamed to say what is now a curse word to me. “Can't you remember the time I almost drowned? I usually end up with all sorts of injuries after most episodes.”

He looks at the wound again and rubs his hand across the other small angry red lines that criss-cross the rest of that palm, with even a few on the other.

“Naeto, thanks so much for coming,” comes Apunanwu’s voice from the door, making him quickly drop my hands. “And also for staying this long. I can’t wait for us to quickly bury the man so we can have some peace in this house.”

“Erm, how...how soon is the burial?” Naeto asks, but I can see that he is distracted.

Apunanwu launches into a long diatribe about how the police has to give approval before funeral planning can start and how difficult their relatives are being, but I can see that he is barely listening. Anayo walks into the room, and he takes the opportunity to announce his departure.

“Let me leave you guys to rest,” he says, before looking at me. “I’ll see you tomorrow. Make sure you get enough sleep.”

He walks away, and Apunanwu turns to me. “Is it my imagination, or did you both seem very familiar?”

“I didn’t want to say anything, but I also noticed some kind of energy between you two,” Anayo chimes in, a mischievous glint in his eye.

I am tempted to lie to them, to tell them that he is just my doctor and that we grew close when I was admitted in the hospital for so long. But, instead, I decide to damn the consequences and say the truth.

“Naeto and I are seeing each other,” I announce. “As soon as my mourning is over, I’m leaving to be with him.”

Apunanwu’s mouth drops open, but Anayo steps forward to embrace me.

“I’m happy to hear that, Adanna. I’m happy to hear you’re happy. It’ll make me less worried about you when I leave,” he says. “Naeto is a great guy. You couldn’t have picked a better man.”

His acceptance brings tears to my eyes, and just as I am about to respond, we are all startled by noise from outside. We rush out only to realise that the commotion is coming from my garden. The police and domestic staff have crowded the area, and we have to push our way through to see what is going on. But the sight that greets me sends my heart crashing to the floor.

Naeto is standing there, holding a bloodied knife.

I gasp, covering my mouth with my hands.

“I saw him with my own two eyes!” one of the policemen is recounting. “I saw him walk out of the house, and instead of heading to the gate, he turned left and started walking to where the flowers are. So, I followed him,” he pauses and shakes his head for emphasis. “Only for me to see him bend down and pick up a knife. A knife with blood!”

There is a collective gasp, with various exclamations of ‘Ewo!’, ‘Eziokuwu!’, ‘Odiegwu!’, ‘Asusu!’

By now, my whole body is shaking, and my tongue is tied. I look from the man I love to what is obviously the murder weapon in his hand, not understanding what I am seeing, not able to connect the dots. When our eyes connect, he gives an almost undecipherable shake of the head.

And then I know.

“Naeto? Naeto that was just talking to us inside?” Anayo exclaims. “How is that even possible?”

Naeto puts up no resistance as the police bundle him into their van, and there are more shouts of disbelief as the car drives off. Nobody can believe

that the mild-mannered doctor is the one who has committed such a horrible crime, the vicious killer on the loose.

“I said it, but you all thought I was crazy,” comes Akanna’s voice, as he emerges from the crowd. “I said it was that doctor, but nobody wanted to listen. Did I not say it? He hid the knife where he and his girlfriend have their secret meetings and was obviously trying to dispose of it.”

“It’s not true! That doctor can not hurt a fly!” Uzochi shouts, the first time anyone has heard her voice all week. “The person that kept it there knows himself. Somebody is trying to set the man up!”

“If he didn’t keep it, how did he know it was there?” came another voice.

As they are all arguing, I can feel Apunanwu’s eyes on me, but she says nothing. Wordlessly, I walk away, my feet heavy as I approach the house. As I ascend the stairs, I am hit by flashbacks, vivid flashbacks of a struggle, of someone holding me by the wrists, of the object I have in my hands piercing deep into my palm, of me wrestling my hands free...and of me striking back. The last one makes me stop dead in my tracks.

Of me striking back with the knife in my hand.

I remember a cry of anguish, I remember another voice shouting, I remember running. And then nothing. I remember nothing after that.

But what I have remembered is enough for me. I killed Chief. And now, Naeto is going to take the fall for me.

I get to my room and undress right there at the door. I walk to the bathroom and get into the tub, turning on the tap. I am nothing but an evil wind, taking down innocent men in my path. I have been responsible for the death of two men now, and destroyed the lives of another two.

As the tub fills, I sink in further, submerging myself inside it. I don't deserve to live.

Chapter Thirty

The Confession

I don't fight as my mouth and nostrils fill with water. Instead, I close my eyes and pray that the end will be quick. I push myself further down, trying to hurry the process. I hear water splashing from the tub to the floor and push myself even further still. It is better for me to leave this world than to continue to hurt the people around me.

The water has started to overwhelm my body and my breathing has started to falter when I hear what sounds like screaming. I struggle as I am abruptly pulled out of the water, fighting off the hands holding me, wanting desperately to return to my watery grave. But the person who has botched my mission will have none of it.

"Help! Help! Somebody help!" Apunanwu shouts, wrestling with me. She soon overpowers me and is able to lift me out of the bath.

Seated on the floor, I am now coughing and spluttering, water seeping out of every orifice. As we hear footsteps approach, Apunanwu throws a towel over my body to protect my decency.

"What happened?" Anayo demands, panicked when he sees me on the floor.

"Apunanwu, what on earth happened here?"

She doesn't answer, but wraps both arms around me from behind and squeezes tight, making me cough and splutter all the more. She snaps her fingers at the person who ran in with Anayo. "Bia, gini bu afa gi?"

“Daluchi,” the person answers tearfully.

“Stop standing there crying foolishly and go and get me steaming hot water!” Apunanwu orders. “Now!”

Daluchi scampers away like a startled mouse, and when she is gone, Apunanwu shakes me angrily. “What is wrong with you? Adanna, what is wrong with you? Why would you want to do something so stupid?”

By now, I am shivering violently, and Anayo reaches for another towel to wrap around my shoulders. He lifts me off the floor and carries me to my bed. Daluchi returns with Nneoma, both of whom are holding vessels of hot water; Daluchi, a small pot, and Nneoma, a kettle.

Anayo leaves the room to give us privacy, and the women proceed to soak towels in hot water, massaging me down from head to toe. Seeing that none of my clothing will be suitable enough, Apunanwu brings a pair of fleece pyjamas from her room. The last thing I remember is a hot water bottle being placed on my chest, as I fall into a deep but fitful sleep.

I have nightmares of sinking deep into the sea, of struggling with an underwater beast while my late father tries to fight it off. Of Naeto being tied to a stake before being killed by a firing squad, and of me standing all alone in the desert, my mourning clothes flying in the sandy wind...nothing but rags. In between these dreams, I wake up with a start, sweating profusely. Apart from the trauma of the nightmares, my body temperature has long adjusted, and the fleece nightwear is too much for my moderately cool room. But someone always sponges me down, this time with a cool cloth, wiping the sweat off my face. I am too agitated to notice who that someone is, but by morning when I do, it is the last person I expect it to be.

Apunanwu.

She is lying crouched on the small sofa, and I know only too well that it isn't the most comfortable sleeping option available to her.

"Why didn't you just let me die?" I croak.

She looks in my direction and sits up. "You're still sounding hoarse. We might need to take you to the hospital this morning."

"Apunanwu, why didn't you just allow me go? If you hadn't come, I would be gone by now!"

"Gone to where?" she retorts. "When you walked away last night, I just knew you were going to do something stupid. And when it took you so long to return, I knew I was right. Why would you want to kill yourself, Adanna? Is it because we found out that your boyfriend was behind the murder? Is that why you want to die? You think he would do the same if the reverse was the case?"

"Naeto didn't kill Chief," I say, looking her square in the eye. "I did."

She snorts. "Adanna, please sleep. Sleep and stop saying nonsense."

I suddenly realise she isn't even the one I should be speaking to, so I throw off my sheets and sit up, trying to shake off the horrible headache that hits me when I do.

"And where do you think you're going?" she demands.

"To confess to Sergeant Ifedi," I say, rising to my feet. "I have proof that I'm their culprit. Naeto only surrendered to the police to protect me. I have to make sure an innocent man does not suffer for my crime."

"Adanna, if you're going anywhere today, it's the hospital and not to confess to anybody!" Apunanwu shouts, rushing in front of me. "I thought you were stupid before, but by God, this takes the cake! You want to throw

away your life because of a man? Adanna, leave him to pay for his crime. He was caught red-handed, holding what has been confirmed to be the weapon that killed my father. Leave him, and let justice take its course.”

There is a timid knock on the door, and Daluchi peeps inside.

“About time!” Apunanwu retorts. “Come and stay with her, abeg. I need to shower and get ready for the day. Stay here, and don’t allow her go anywhere.”

She walks out of the room, leaving me standing before the younger woman.

“Aunty Ada, you really frightened me,” she says, her eyes still shiny with tears. “Did you really try to drown yourself?”

I sigh deeply. She is too young to understand. “I need to leave here, Daluchi. I need you to help me get to the police station.”

“Have a bath first, Aunty,” she answers, locking the door firmly and putting the key in her pocket, before walking to the bathroom. “Let me run you a nice, warm bath, and we can talk about how to get you anywhere you want to.”

I hesitate, contemplating forcing my way out of the room, or maybe even escaping through the window. But both options would only serve to cause more trouble, and God knows I have caused more than enough already. Besides, I have confidence in Daluchi’s ability to help me get across to Sergeant Ifedi one way or another. The few minutes it will take to shower and change are a small sacrifice to make.

Keeping away from the bathtub, I step into the shower cubicle instead, and I’m not surprised when Daluchi enters it as well. After what happened the previous night, it’s not unexpected that they don’t want to take any chances

with me. I stand and allow her lather my body, relishing but hating every rub of the sponge, as it cleanses and hurts me at the same time.

“Where have you been?” I ask, trying to make conversation. “It’s been several days since Chief died. I thought I would see you around a lot earlier than this.”

“I’ve been around, Aunty,” she answers. “I came as soon as I heard the news, and I’ve been taking care of my mom. She took the news very badly.”

I nod in agreement. If there is one person who Chief’s death has devastated, it is Uzochi. And understandably so. With her benefactor dead and with none of us knowing what lies ahead for the ranch, her days here might be numbered.

“Have you been coming from your place?” I ask. “Your place in Asaba?”

She shakes her head, holding the shower head over me, allowing the burst of water wash away the soap suds. “I had to leave there.”

She doesn’t offer any more, and I turn around to look at her. Her eyes are downcast, and I suspect that her lover’s wife might have found out about her and their love nest. Her heartbreak is evident, and I can’t help but feel sorry for her. Her first real taste of heartbreak.

We don’t say any more, as she helps me into a change of clothes, including a light cardigan Apunanwu brought for me. As I am still coughing, I reluctantly wear it.

Getting downstairs, I am happy that Akanna is also having breakfast with his siblings. If Apunanwu will not allow me report myself to the police, I know the fastest way for that to happen.

“Ah, the girlfriend of the murderer!” Akanna remarks. “Were you aware of the plans your lover had? Or did you scheme the whole thing together?”

“How are you feeling?” Anayo asks, ignoring his brother. “Are you sure you should be up and about? Apunanwu says you don’t want to go to the hospital.”

“Thank you, but there is no need for the hospital. I’m fine,” I answer, smiling at Anayo, grateful for his concern. “I’m happy you’re all here, as there is something I have to tell you,” I say, turning to the other occupants of the room. “Naeto didn’t kill your father. I did. This is the wound I got in the process.” I show them my injured palm. “Naeto saw the wound last night, and he figured it out. Knowing where I would likely have hidden the knife, he went to my garden and found it there. He is taking the fall to protect me, but I’m not going to allow it. I shall be confessing this to the police today, so I’ll be grateful if you could notify Sergeant Ifedi and ask him to come right away. If you don’t, I’ll just repeat this confession to any of the policemen hanging around.”

“Adanna, wait! Slow down!” Anayo exclaims, raising his hand. “This makes no sense at all. I don’t care about whatever injury you have, but I know you didn’t kill Dad. Don’t throw yourself under the bus just to save Naeto. I know you love him, but this is your life you want to destroy.”

“So, the truth finally comes out!” Akanna chuckles, reaching for his phone. “Let me call Ifedi to let him know the culprit has finally owned up. Somehow, this doesn’t surprise me at all.”

“Nobody is calling anyone!” Anayo yells, glaring at his brother. “Drop that phone, Akanna. Let’s discuss this as a family first. Adanna is clearly in distress and not thinking straight.”

Akanna ignores him and dials anyway. “Good morning, Officer...” he says when the line connects, before rolling his eyes. “My bad, Sergeant. There’s been a new development here that requires your immediate attention... Oh,

you're in Asaba? Well, I think you might want to leave immediately and head back here now... Why? Well, the real murderer has confessed." A broad smile breaks on his face. "I knew that would interest you. We'll be expecting you," he disconnects the phone and smiles at the rest of us. "He's on his way."

"Adanna, don't do this," Apunanwu implores, and I am surprised by the concern in her eyes. I would have thought she would be the first person crucifying me by now. "You didn't kill him."

"Is there some kind of serum people are drinking that's making everyone want to own up to this?" Anayo exclaims in exasperation. "First it was that old man, then Naeto, and now Adanna. Meanwhile, the real person we're looking for is probably walking the streets, free as a bird." He glares at Akanna. "Or sitting at a table, having breakfast."

By this time, I have had enough.

"I'll be in my room. Let me know when Sergeant Ifedi gets here," I say, making to leave.

"Hold it right there, Adanna," Akanna calls out, rising to his feet. "You no longer have the luxury to come and go as you please. You killed my father, and you think you can go and lie on your bed leisurely? You will remain seated here until Sergeant Ifedi arrives."

"Akanna!" Anayo chides.

But I am glad to comply. Without argument, I take a seat, avoiding eye contact with Anayo and Apunanwu, and instead look ahead with my hands on my laps, patiently waiting for when I will be taken away, and Naeto released. I am surprised by the calm I feel, despite the fact that punishment for murder in the state could lead to my own death.

Nobody leaves the table, and their meals remain untouched. Akanna, I'm not surprised about, as I know he is determined to watch me like a hawk so I don't escape. I'm not surprised about Anayo either, as his fondness for me has made him distressed about the unfolding situation. But Apunanwu...I just can't figure out the sudden about-turn in her behavior towards me. It simply makes no sense at all.

A little under an hour later, Sergeant Ifedi walks into the room.

"Good morning, all," he greets. "Forgive me, but I had a meeting with the DPO at the Asaba station. May I?" he asks, beckoning at a seat and proceeds to sit when Akanna gives a dismissive wave of the hand. "So... you say you have found the killer?" There is no mistaking the cynicism in his voice.

"There she is," Akanna answers, pointing at me.

The Sergeant looks my way. "Chief's wife?"

"Surprising, we know," Akanna answers sarcastically. "She just confessed."

Sergeant Ifedi looks at me, his brows furrowed. "Is this true, Madam?"

I nod. "Yes. I killed him. I stabbed him and hid the knife in the garden. Dr. Naeto was unlucky enough to find it, and that was when your officer saw him. So, you need to release him...and take me instead."

"Adanna didn't kill him," Apunanwu says, her voice quiet. "I saw what happened. She didn't kill him."

Anayo gasps as all eyes in the room turn to her. My mouth parts in surprise. She saw what happened?

A small smile forms on the Sergeant's lips. "Can you please tell us what you saw?"

She is quiet for a while, her head bowed. "I heard him that night. He was moaning and cursing and sounded like he was in distress. When I got to his room, he was sweaty and clearly uncomfortable. I saw the three used glasses of wine and figured he was drunk. He's never really been able to handle alcohol. He was complaining of his stomach, and at the same time cursing Akanna and Anayo for sleeping with his wife, cursing me for being a disappointment, cursing his mother for killing his true love...he was saying a whole lot. Then he said he was thirsty and wanted to go downstairs for a drink of water. I offered to get it for him, but he brushed me aside. I followed him downstairs anyway and poured him a glass here in this dining room. While he was drinking, we heard footsteps coming down the stairs," she looks at me. "It was Adanna. I was surprised to see her up at that time of night as I wasn't aware of her sleepwalking."

"What time was this?" Sergeant Ifedi asks.

She shrugs. "About 2:30am. Maybe 3."

"Then what happened after that?" the Sergeants prods.

"Dad started calling her names. He insulted her family, called her a prostitute, a sleepwalking witch...so many horrible names. She tried to run away from him, but he chased her into the kitchen. Maybe it was the alcohol, I don't know, but it almost seemed like he wanted to have his way with her right there in the kitchen, not caring that I was standing barely a foot away, screaming and begging him to leave her alone," her voice falters, and she looks at me again. "Then Adanna grabbed a knife from the counter. There was a struggle, and when she got her hands free, she swung it across, and it hit him."

"She stabbed him?" Sergeant Ifedi asks.

“It wasn’t exactly a stab,” she answers. “It was just a surface wound. I screamed at the sight of blood on his white vest, and she ran away. But Dad wasn’t seriously hurt. He was just angry, furious that she’d had the audacity to strike him. He was yelling about how he was going to throw her in jail first thing in the morning, how she was going to rot in prison for daring to attack him with a weapon. I was panicked by his bleeding. I wanted to help him but he pushed me away and stormed off. He walked upstairs unaided. The knife injury wasn’t what killed him.”

“Why didn’t you say anything all this while?” I ask, my voice shaking. “You knew all this, and yet, you kept quiet?”

Her eyes fill with tears. “I didn’t want to admit being the last person to see him alive.”

Anayo sighs deeply, and Akanna shakes his head.

“So, what happened next?” Sergeant Ifedi asks.

“Nothing,” she answers. “I just returned to my bedroom. That’s where I was when he was discovered dead by Anayo.”

Sergeant Ifedi looks at him. “And what were you doing in his room so early in the morning?”

“I was just checking on him,” he answers, seeming a bit flustered. “He was piss drunk when I left him, and I wanted to be sure he was okay.”

“And you found him on the floor?” Sergeant Ifedi prods.

Anayo nods. “With the broken chair beside him.”

“There was no broken chair when I was with him,” Apunanwu interjects.

“That must have happened after he returned to his room.”

Sergeant Ifedi ponders on what has been said for a while, before sighing deeply. “You’re right about one thing. The knife wound didn’t kill Chief. In fact, that’s what I was discussing with them in Asaba this morning,” he shakes his head. “When the doctor’s confession was all about how he stabbed the man, we already knew the boy was just talking nonsense. He couldn’t even tell us the location of the stab wound. He first of all said ‘chest’, then said ‘rib cage’. It became evident very quickly that he wasn’t the culprit,” he looks at me. “And when Madam started her confession with ‘I stabbed him’, I ruled her out.”

“So, what are you saying? That it was the head wound from the chair that killed him?” Akanna asks.

The Sergeant shakes his head. “Not even that.” He looks around the room. “Chief Nsofor was poisoned.”

“Poisoned?” Anayo exclaims. “How is that possible? He was fine that night, and we even drank from the same bottle!”

“But you didn’t eat from the same pot,” I say, a sick realization dawning on me. “Only one person ever cooked for Chief.”

Uzochi.

Chapter Thirty-One

The Woman Scorned

“Where is Uzochi?” Akanna demands.

That soon becomes the question on everybody’s lips. Where is Uzochi?

“Amaghị m ebe ọ nọ,” Nneoma answers when she is summoned to the room. “I don’t know where she is. She hasn’t come upstairs today.”

That in itself is an ominous sign, as Uzochi has not for one day missed coming up from her basement apartment. Even when she hasn’t felt her best, she has at least ventured up to monitor the progress of work.

“Let’s not get too hasty,” I plead. “Anyone could have intercepted Chief’s meals. Let’s not jump to the conclusion that she did it.”

“I agree,” Anayo supports. “There’s no way Uzochi could have done such a thing. Have you seen the state of her since he died? She’s even taking it worse than the rest of us.”

“Nobody is suspecting her,” Sergeant Ifedi clarifies. “It’s just important that I ask her a few questions about who she believes might have had access to Chief’s food that day. That’s all.” He looks at the rattled housekeeper.

“Nneoma is your name, right? Can you take me down to where she stays?”

“Actually, I think we should all be there while you’re questioning her,” Akanna says, rising to his feet. “She’s not very educated and I wouldn’t want you to confuse her with your questions.”

I look at Akanna in surprise, wondering when Uzochi's welfare was any of his concern. But I also share his sentiment of not wanting her to be alone while being interrogated by the police. The last thing I want is for her to say or do anything to incriminate herself.

As we make our way down to her basement apartment, I am ashamed that it has been a few years since I have been down these stairs to pay her a visit. In the early days, eating with Uzochi, Daluchi, and the paraplegic Ibe gave me the semblance of being at home with my own family. It was during these visits that I bonded with her and formed a close friendship with Daluchi. Ibe remained reserved, so we were never close. I am filled with nostalgia as we approach the door leading to her apartment, reminded of happier times.

But the foul smell that assaults us when we open the door is anything but nostalgic. Lying on his bed, encased in his waste, is Ibe. The stench is so overwhelming, breathing is almost impossible.

"Ah! Unu abiawo!" he exclaims. "I've been expecting you."

"Nna, good morning o," Sergeant Ifedi manages to say. "The niile di gi mma? Are you okay this morning? Do you want someone to come and clean you up?"

"Where is Uzochi?" Apunanwu demands, clearly not interested in any pleasantries.

Ibe smiles broadly. "Apunanwu! See how much you have grown. The last time I set my eyes on you, you were just a child," he looks at her brothers. "Anayo, my friend. You were the only one who used to come down here to see me after my accident in the early days. You have grown into such a handsome man!"

I am not surprised that he has nothing to say to Akanna.

“Old man, where is your wife?” Akanna demands. It appears neither does he...

The smile remains on Ibe’s face. “She has gone, o! She left early this morning. I’m even surprised she stayed this long. I thought she would have left this place the morning after the man died.”

By this time, nobody even notices the rancid smell anymore.

“Nna, why do you say so?” Sergeant Ifedi asks. “Why would she have had cause to leave?”

“See the table behind you,” Ibe answers. “That was where she sat, crying and mixing otapiapia. If you look properly, I’m sure the bottle she used is still lying under the table.”

“Otapiapia?” Sergeant Ifedi repeats. “Inye onye? To give who?”

“That wretched man who has been sleeping with her almost from the very moment I married her and brought her to this place!” Ibe snaps, all humour gone from his face and voice.

My lips part, and my eyes widen in my shock. Looking around, I can see my reaction mirrored on everyone’s face, even Akanna’s.

“Chief?” Sergeant Ifedi exclaims.

“At first, they used to hide it,” Ibe continues. “She hadn’t been here up to a month when I started suspecting something was going on. Ifeyinwa was still nursing Apunanwu and was always upstairs with the baby. I later found out that Arinze was sleeping with my wife, right under his wife’s nose. My good friend, Emenike, the former butler, walked in on them in the study, with the bastard mounted on top of my wife right there on his desk.

Emenike told me...and he lost his job for it. I couldn't confront Arinze, because I didn't want to lose my own job, but when I confronted my wife, she denied it, swearing on her mother's grave that she had done no such thing and that the people here were just jealous of our marriage and trying to ruin it," he chuckles and shakes his head. "But after my accident, they didn't bother hiding anymore. For over 30 years, I had to endure watching him as he slept with my wife right here in this room, right here in my presence. As early as 4am most mornings, he would come and they would go at it like animals."

"In front of you?" Sergeant Ifedi exclaims.

"All I could do was lie here and watch them, completely helpless," Ibe answers, the pain still evident in his voice. "In the early days, I cried, I cursed, but nothing changed. After my accident made me completely dependent on her, my wife lost all respect for me. How can you respect a man whose buttocks you have to wipe clean? A man you have to feed, bathe, and take to toilet? How can you have any regard for such a person? Such a man is nothing but an inconvenience, and she always made sure to remind me that was what I was to her. So, it was really no surprise to me that she would disrespect me like that. Arinze would come, sleep with her, and they would even lie on the bed for sometime afterwards, talking as if there was no other human being in the room with them." He turns to look at me. "It was on that bed that they always discussed your matter. A lot of the things I heard her tell him were things I knew you had told her in confidence."

My legs are so weak that they can no longer support me. I sit on the only chair in the room, my mouth agape, shocked to my bones by this revelation.

“When Ifeyinwa died, she thought he would marry her,” Ibe continues, a sardonic smile on his face. “Everyone told her how much like Chioma she was, and she believed that Arinze would marry her because she reminded him so much of his first love. She would even taunt me with it, calling me a liability and how she couldn’t wait for when she would abandon me in a hospital somewhere when she became the ‘Madam’ of the house.” He shakes his head and chuckles. “It was a rude shock for her when Arinze not only didn’t marry her, he brought in another woman to the house. She wept bitterly that day, the day Nkoyo arrived. For a short while, he stopped coming down here, and I was even beginning to be happy that I had my wife back. But before I knew it, he was back in her bed...even though not as frequently as when Ifeyinwa was still alive. It was clear that he liked this one, his Calabar wife. He loved his wife but, for some reason, still felt the need to continue to sleep with mine. I think he enjoyed the power he had over the fact that he could bed her right before me, and I could do absolutely nothing about it. Before I had my accident, I was big, strong and intimidating. But there I now lay, in a crib, shriveled from my neck down, unable to do anything to stop him. I’m sure that must have made him feel even more of a man.”

“Jesus Christ!” Anayo exclaims, sitting on the table.

Even though Chief’s promiscuity was no secret to anyone, hearing so sordid a tale is too much for anyone of us to even comprehend.

“She and Nkoyo were mortal enemies. From what I overheard her and Arinze discuss, it seems the woman had her suspicion about the two of them. When they finally chased her away, Uzochi’s hopes were again raised. She was hopeful that this time Arinze would elevate her to wife

status. But that never happened,” he looks at me, and we all know what happened after that.

Chief married me instead.

“Poor girl, you don’t know how much I pitied you every time you came here, thinking she was your friend,” he said, still looking at me. “Almost from the moment you arrived, she did everything she could to get you out. I used to shake my head as she encouraged you to continue to receive that one,” he beckoned at Akanna with his chin, “in your bed, deceiving you that it was the only way to have some footing in the house, though she knew full well that the more accepting you were of his son, the more it angered Arinze and pushed you away from him. She thought he would have sent you away years ago and didn’t anticipate you staying for as long as you have.”

“But Chief had so many other women. Chiasoka, Isioma, Nwanne, Clementina...just to name a few,” I say, my head still spinning. “I was the least of her problems.”

“You were the one he called his wife. You were her only problem,” Ibe answered. “Until recently.”

“Where was your daughter in all of this?” Apunanwu asked, speaking for the first time. “When he used to come here to sleep with Uzochi, was it also in the presence of your daughter?”

“When Daluchi was about 8 or 9 years old, her mother stopped her from sleeping here with us, and moved her to the servants’ quarters upstairs,” he answered before turning to look at me again. “It was just about the time you arrived.”

I nodded, remembering when I had asked Uzochi why her young daughter didn't sleep in their quarters and only came there for her meals, and how her reply had been something about shielding her from seeing the full impact of her father's debilitating condition.

"But she knew. The girl knew," Ibe continues. "Before her mother moved her away, she saw enough to understand what was happening. And as she grew, she knew the man's early morning visits were not innocent."

"You said Chief's wife was her only problem until only recently," Sergeant Ifedi interjects. "What changed?"

Ibe smiles. "About two years ago, Arinze stopped coming here completely. I would overhear her calling him on the phone early in the morning, begging him to come back to her, but he never returned to her bed again. It became clear that someone else had replaced her, but she had no idea who that person was. Until recently," he starts to laugh, a malicious and vindictive laughter that shows he is glad to finally be exposing the woman who has hurt him for so long. "Where does a woman start when her competition is her own child?"

"Chineke!" Apunanwu exclaims, putting her hands on her head, just as Akanna starts laughing. Sergeant Ifedi brings out a handkerchief to clean his face, while Anayo looks at Ibe with his mouth agape.

But I am not surprised. I think on some subconscious level, I knew.

"She found out a few days before Arinze died. Every evening after that, she wept like a wounded animal. I couldn't even tell what hurt her the most; that Arinze was ravaging her daughter, or that she had been replaced by her." He paused, almost as if reliving what happened. "The night before he died, she didn't get any sleep. She was just sitting on that chair, crying, and mixing that poison. The next day, from the many trips she made upstairs,

she administered it to him more than once. At a point, she even came and poured it directly into a jug of water.”

I remember when she brought water to Chief after his altercation with Akanna, and my blood runs cold.

“She was on edge the whole day, waiting for the poison to consume him. But Arinze was a strong man, even at that age,” Ibe continued. “At about 3 AM , we heard noises coming from upstairs. We heard Arinze shouting at somebody, we heard a struggle, someone screaming, and then after a while...we heard nothing. At that point, she got up and left the room, only to return about thirty minutes later, trembling from head to toe. Her wrapper was disheveled, almost like she had been in some sort of fight. My guess is that she went upstairs to see what happened, probably went upstairs to check on Arinze, maybe to see if he was dead or alive, got into a fight with him, and then killed him.”

The room is pin drop silent for several minutes. Even Akanna is no longer laughing. We are all stomped by the realization, the confirmation that Uzochi, good natured and maternal Uzochi, is Chief’s murderer.

“Where is Daluchi now?” Sergeant Ifedi asks.

“She was in the house this morning,” Apunanwu says. “She even helped get Adanna ready for the day.”

“When she came back home after the murder, from the tearful discussions I saw the two of them having, I think her mother confessed what she had done,” he answers. “And when she came back here this morning after assisting Arinze’s wife, and realised her mother had run away, she grabbed her own bags and left.” He shakes his head, but this time, can’t use laughter to hide the pain he feels. “There were three people in this world who knew

that the girl was conceived several weeks after my accident. Three of us who knew she wasn't born months early, as her mother tried to make everyone believe. Three of us who knew the truth behind Daluchi's paternity; Arinze, Uzochi, and I."

There is pin drop silence in the room.

"He was sleeping with...with his own daughter?" Anayo bleats, breaking the silence.

"Chukwu biko saa m ntị!" Sergeant Ifedi exclaims, unable to maintain his composure. "Nna, I have heard enough. I just need to find your wife. If you can give me an idea how to locate her, it will be much appreciated."

"I don't know about Uzochi, but I have an idea where you can locate Daluchi," he answers.

"In Asaba?" I ask. "She told me she has an apartment there."

"If it's dad's hideout in Asaba, I locked up that place the day after he died," Akanna says. "He has always had a small flat there where he entertains his women. I went there to change the locks, so that none of those girls would get any funny ideas. I saw what I thought were a woman's belongings, but I threw them in the garbage without even thinking twice about it."

I nodded. It all made sense to me now.

"Daluchi isn't in Asaba. She's here in Ojiji," Ibe says. "Maybe she'll be able to tell you how to locate her mother."

He gives us an address in town, which I recognize as Uzochi's older sister's house, one I have accompanied her to several times.

"Nna, Daalụ. You have been really helpful," Sergeant Ifedi says, before looking around. "Isn't there someone here to assist you? Someone to

change you?” It was a polite way of referencing the very obvious smell of stale faeces in the room.

Ibe shakes his head. “My wife stopped my carer from coming a few years ago. She said it had become too expensive, but I know Arinze was still paying for it. Sometimes, she would clean me, and sometimes she wouldn’t. I am used to stewing in my waste. It is the insects on my back that cause me discomfort.”

Braving it, Sergeant Ifedi walks closer and flips the man over, and we all scream at the sight of maggots crawling on the old man’s skin. I see a dirty plate on the floor, and from the dried remains, it is clear he hasn’t been fed anytime recently. He has been left to literally waste away.

In less than an hour, Ibe has been cleaned and ferried off to a hospital in Asaba, while the rest of us prepare to go in search of Daluchi. Apunanwu opts not to follow us, drained from all the revelations of the day, and I can’t blame her. I always knew Chief’s life was messy, and sleeping with mother and daughter is not something he has not done before. But sleeping with a girl he fathered is on a whole new level of mess.

We ride with the Sergeant, this time, not in the police van but Akanna’s car. The last thing we want is to scare Daluchi off before we get to her, and the police van will most surely announce our arrival long before we are ready to. We are soon at the modest one-storey house, and I make sure I am walking in the lead. I want to be the first person she sees, not the police.

“Aunty Adanna,” comes her voice, even before I see her.

I look up, and there she is, cowering by the door. Her eyes widen in fright at the sight of the men with me, and I can’t tell who she looks more frightened of, the Sergeant or Akanna.

“Daluchi,” I answer, giving her a reassuring smile. “Why did you leave the house?”

“My father told you,” she states, not asks.

Realising she isn’t aware that her true father is the man whose bed she has been warming, I nod. Her eyes cloud with tears, and I turn back to look at the Sergeant. “Can I speak with her in private first?” When he hesitates, I add. “I promise, she’ll answer all your questions later. Just give me the chance to talk to her first...to get her more comfortable.”

That seems to do the trick, and he nods in agreement. I look at Akanna and Anayo, and neither one expresses any reservation.

Taking Daluchi’s hand, we enter the old house. “Are you the only one home?”

She nods, her body shaking like a leaf. “Aunty, I didn’t know she was going to do it. Please, don’t let them arrest me.”

“Nobody is going to arrest you,” I coax her.

She wipes her eyes. “I know you’re angry with me. Angry because of...”

“Because of Chief? Daluchi, you should know better. I wish you had trusted me enough to tell me. I thought we were friends,” I say, holding her hand.

“When did it start?”

“On and off, when I was still in school,” she answers. “There was a day I was on my way home and was waiting to board a bus from Asaba. He saw me on the road, picked me up, and offered to take me out for lunch. Apart from the fact that I was hungry and tired, it was a free ride home, so I couldn’t resist,” her eyes pool with tears again. “We went to a hotel for lunch, and he started telling me how beautiful I had grown, how attracted he was to me, and how he would take care of me if only I...” She wipes her

eyes again. “I wasn’t an angel then. I knew what he wanted, and it didn’t seem like a bad idea...to be taken care of by a wealthy man. So, he got us a room, and...well...that was how we started. We would usually meet in hotels in Asaba, and anytime he had to travel, he would take me with him.”

“Which is why you were with him in Lagos the time he was away for so long.”

“Lagos, Port Harcourt, Benin, Owerri, Abuja...I followed him everywhere, except out of the country,” she continues. “And when he came back home finally, he decided it was best to get me an apartment, instead of us always going to hotels.”

“Did you know about him and your mother?” I ask, not caring to sugar coat it.

She nods, and I can see her eyes harden. “I knew. He used to sleep with her in my father’s presence, right there in their room. I hated her for hurting him, and when the opportunity came for me to hurt her the same way, I took it.”

I sigh deeply, heartbroken for her, wondering how she will handle the news when she gets to know the truth.

“How did she find out?” I ask.

“She heard some whispers and, one day, came to lay in ambush for us at the flat. But she arrived just as his car was driving off, and she went crazy. It was a few days before Chief’s children arrived,” she shrugs. “She saw enough to confirm what she’d heard was true. And I didn’t deny it. I looked her in the eye and told her that I was going to be the next Mrs. Nsofor, since I knew you were leaving soon. I knew it was something she badly wanted, and as she wept, I asked her if she now knew how my father must have felt,

watching her sleep with another man for years.” She starts to cry anew. “She left the place cursing, but I had no idea she was going to kill him. When I came back to the house after I heard, and she told me what she had done, I could see in her eyes satisfaction. She was pretending to be shattered and regretful of her actions, but I could see that she was happy to have deprived me of what I wanted the most, what I had taken away from her.”

I cover my eyes and sigh deeply. It doesn’t even sound like the people I thought I knew for 20 years, the people I have called my friends, my family. I have been living with complete strangers.

“She has gone to Aba,” she says, preempting my next question. “I overheard her telling her cousin she would be coming. If you’re fast, you can find her before she leaves for Lagos.”

“Thank you,” I say, hugging her. “And take care of yourself, okay? Be strong. You have a very tough road ahead.”

I emerge from the house with the address, and Sergeant Ifedi calls for reinforcement from Asaba. We are on a mission to locate a fugitive...a murderer...and we need all the help we can get.

“Are you sure she didn’t give us a wrong address to just blow us off?” Anayo asks as we are on the highway, en route Aba.

I shake my head, confident that Daluchi wouldn’t want to cause any more trouble. She already knows she has caused enough already.

We don’t get to the address until about 6pm. It is a busy block of flats that looks to have nothing less than thirty small apartments. Locating Uzoamaka, Uzochi’s cousin, takes us almost half an hour. When we

eventually find her apartment, the elderly woman looks anything but pleased to see us.

“Ehn? Ndi Police?” she exclaims, when she opens the door. “Kedu ihe i choro? Wetin una want, o?”

“Mummy, we are here to see Uzochi,” Anayo says, trying to pacify her. “Is she here?”

“Ọ hapuru ugbo a. She don go park, o! She no dey hia, o!” Uzoamaka shouts, getting more and more agitated.

“Mama, calm down,” Sergeant Ifedi snaps, his patience already worn thin. “Calm down, and give us information we can use. Which park? Where is she going to?”

“Ebee ka ọ na-aga?” I repeat his question gently.

“Lagos,” she answers, calmed by my tone and making eye contact with only me. “Ọ na-aga Lagos. Ọ bu Festus kpogara ya motor park.”

“Festus took her to the motor park?” Anayo echoes. “Who’s Festus?”

“Onye bu Festus?” I ask her.

Festus turns out to be their taxi driver neighbour who, on interrogation, confirms he dropped Uzochi at the park of a popular bus service about an hour before. We leave for the park, and get there a little before 8pm. Luckily neither of the two night buses leaving for Lagos have departed.

I watch as Sergeant Ifedi and the rest of his men order everyone out of the buses, combing through the passengers, one by one, in search of the fugitive cook. The police have even accosted the vehicles of another bus service headed for Lagos from an adjacent park. There is confusion everywhere, and I stand there, wondering if they will find her in the mayhem.

Another bus is pulling out of the station, headed this time to Gboko. As the Lagos bound passengers are searched, harassed and interrogated, my eyes are drawn to the departing bus.

And then I see her.

A scarf is covering most of her face, but I would know those eyes anywhere. Our eyes meet...and hold. And rather than the anger, resentment, and betrayal I thought I would feel, all I can feel instead is sympathy.

And forgiveness.

So, I say nothing as the bus pulls away.

“She must have gone to another motor park,” one of the policemen muses.

“She must have outsmarted that Festus fellow and gone elsewhere to take a bus.”

“You’re correct,” Sergeant Ifedi agrees. “Let’s quickly get to Osinachi Motors before their night bus leaves.”

I say nothing and get into the car with the rest, ready to go on a wild goose chase...while Uzochi leaves, never to be seen again.

Chapter Thirty-Two

The Mourning

With the mystery of Chief's death solved, we are now able to focus on funeral arrangements. As expected, distant relatives descend on our home, eager for me to begin my widowhood rites. With my mother still a few days from arriving, I am frightened by the prospect of having to go through what she did so many years ago.

But my rescue comes from where I least expect.

Apunanwu defends me like a hawk, blatantly refusing their relatives' demands for me to be secluded until I am 'cleansed', or to begin and end my day with loud crying to show the 'depth of my grief', or to take an oath of my innocence by drinking water used to bathe Chief's corpse.

"She is not drinking anything!" she yelled at the person who made the suggestion. "O gburu ya? Did she kill him? Biko, anyi adighi eme nke obula n'ebe a. We're not doing any of that mess here. This is a Christian home. Besides, I don't remember any of you coming to ask your brother to drink any dirty water when my mother died!"

It isn't until my mother arrives that she convinces me to at least honour my late husband by shaving my hair.

"Mama, it's not necessary," Apunanwu complains. "She doesn't need to cut her hair. This is the 21st century, and those things are no longer important."

Besides, you know how poorly the man treated her. He doesn't deserve this sacrifice from her."

"My daughter, let her at least do this one," my mother implores. "She was married to him for 20 long years. She can't refuse to participate in all of the rites. It's not done. The hair will grow back, biko. Let her just do this one."

And so, for the first time in my 36 years of existence, my almost waist long hair is shaved off. But I don't even mind the loss of my hair. My liberation has finally come. It is so close, I can almost taste it. I am finally free.

Even though the immediate family would have preferred a small funeral, Chief's status, in the community and outside, has made that impossible. I watch as everyone throws themselves headlong into preparations, realising most are using it as a distraction, as a means to forget about the roller coaster the last week has been. The domestic staff in particular are still shaken, after finding out that their beloved Uzochi was the one who killed their benefactor. Even though quite a few of them admit to knowing about the affair, not one of them would ever have imagined the nurturing and affectionate woman capable of a crime so heinous. So, the funeral preparations have helped many of them forget this unfortunate reality.

But one thing I have not forgotten is the love of my life. Naeto.

The day after the manhunt for Uzochi, I heard he was released from police custody, and I regretted afresh not having the wisdom to have saved his phone number when I had the chance. With Uzochi, the only person who could have helped me with it, I was even more regretful of the loss of the person I had once considered my closest ally in the house. As the days rolled by, but with no word from him, I have had to accept that he had probably realised I just wasn't worth all that trouble. On my account alone, he lost his father's hospital and was almost imprisoned for a crime he didn't

commit. Nobody would blame him for walking away from someone so toxic.

But just when I have brought myself to accept that, this time, I have lost him forever, and that I will just have to make do with the beautiful memories of the brief time we had together...he shows up.

It is the morning of the wake, and I am looking out from the balcony at the preparations unfolding. Canopies have been erected in the compound, and the whole place is bustling with activity. Anayo's fiancée has flown in from the United Kingdom and has arrived at the ranch, with her family in tow. Apunanwu, on the other hand, is dishing out orders to staff and vendors alike. Just as I am thinking how I can't wait for all the madness to be over, I see him.

I stand straight as I recognise him walking up the driveway. As he approaches, he looks up, and a smile lights up his face when he sees me. I smile back at him, the first smile unencumbered by Chief's shadow. I make my way downstairs, just as he is walking into the house. My first inclination would have been to jump into his arms, to wrap my arms around him, and never, ever let go. But dressed in my widow's garb, even I know that would be the least appropriate and most disrespectful thing I could do. He must realise this as well, as he also makes no attempt to come any nearer than a few feet from me.

"Hi Adanna," he says, the smile still on his face. "It's so good to see you."

"Naeto, I've been so worried," I say, my own smile waning. "Where have you been?"

"I caught a bad chest infection while I was in custody," he answers. "I was even hospitalised for a couple of days. My older brother in Abuja got wind of it and came to take me back with him. He and his wife refused to hear

anything about me stepping out of the house till I got better, talkless of returning to Ojiji.”

I can’t help but giggle. “You’re just an aje butter.”

He takes a step closer to me. “I’m so happy all this is over. Now we can make our plans without worrying about anything.”

“Ada, why are you just standing there?” comes my mother’s voice from behind me. “Bia nọdu n’ime. Come and sit inside. I’m told the corpse is on its way.” She looks at Naeto, and I take the cue.

“This is my friend, mommy,” I say, smiling. “Doctor Naeto.”

“Good morning, Ma,” he says, with a courteous bow.

My mother smiles, and I can read in it understanding. “It’s nice to meet you, Doctor Naeto. Please forgive me, but I have to take her inside. Guests will soon arrive.”

“That’s fine, Ma,” he says, with another bow. “I’ll go join the others outside.”

The smile remains on her face as he walks away, and she interlinks her hands with mine. “Ada nwa’m! My heart is happy to see you happy. But now is not the time. Let us honour your late husband. After your mourning period, I will be only too happy to hear all about this handsome Doctor Naeto of a somebody!”

I laugh, and it isn’t lost on me how being so much at ease with my mother is an alien feeling. Not since my father died has our relationship been this fluid. Chief’s death has brought us back full circle. But it is going to take a lot to repair our fractured relationship. There has been so much ugliness, pain, and resentment over the last 20 years that it will take more than a few days of bonding for us to heal. But for now, I am just so happy to have her

by my side. Apunanwu has been fantastic, but nothing beats having one's mother there to fight off vultures.

True to her words, the hearse soon arrives with Chief's coffin. I go through all the motions as it is lifted out of the car and placed in a receiving area in the living room. As people file past to pay their respects, I have to act the part of the devastated widow, offering a sad smile in response to their expressions of sympathy. I cannot bring myself to look at the body of my tormentor, as it lies in the heavily decorated box. I do not want to add that visual to the long list of disturbing visuals I already have of him ingrained in my head, starting from when my teenage eyes were forced to behold his naked body, and culminating in seeing him lying on the floor, covered in blood, vomit, and faeces.

All through the day, and even at night when the service of songs begins, all I can think about is Naeto. My eyes follow him everywhere, as he sits first with Anayo and his fiancée, before proceeding to mingle with the other sympathisers. Once in a while, our eyes meet, and I am further reassured by his smile, reassured that he will still be there waiting for me when all this is over.

The following day, the day of the funeral, is even more chaotic than the preceding one. From the moment I awake, I am surrounded by people. Everywhere around me, there are strange faces, each person mourning a little louder than the next. It is total chaos while we are still in the house, and even as we leave for the church. Apunanwu and I ride in Chief's favourite Mercedes Benz, while Akanna and Anayo opt to go in another of his cars. My mother rides with Anayo's in-laws, and we drive to the church at snail speed, as several of the village people are dancing in front of the convoy, holding Chief's picture. Ideally, this is something usually done by

the children of the deceased, but it is clear that neither Apunanwu nor Anayo are in any such mood. Akanna doesn't even appear to care less.

In church, behind my large glasses, my eyes roam the place. I look at Akanna's wife in the pew beside ours, flanked by her teenage sons, and I feel overwhelming sympathy for her. She has aged so much over the years, and even beneath her expensive designer clothes looks weathered and haggard. She is painfully thin and her eyes are sunken and emotionless. We have lived with physically and emotionally abusive men for so many years, even sharing one of them. But while I can at least see the light at the end of my own tunnel...she is stuck in hers for life, or at least for as much time that Akanna has on this earth. If he is anywhere near as strong as his father was, he won't be going anywhere anytime soon.

As we file out of church behind the coffin, I see Naeto in one of the pews at the back. He gives me a slight wave, and I can only nod slightly in acknowledgement. We return to the ranch, where Chief is interred, ironically, right there in my garden. That was the site his children felt would make the most befitting resting place for him, and I find myself mourning the loss of the place I called my sanctuary for so many years, much more than I will ever mourn him.

I go through all the motions of listening to the priest pray over his casket, watching as it is lowered into the ground, and perfunctorily performing the rite of throwing dust into the grave. I brave another few hours of dealing with even more sympathisers, but by nighttime almost everyone is gone. I sit in the living room, watching Apunanwu see off the last of the guests and marvel at the unfamiliar sound of peace and quiet, with the only sound coming from the night birds and the staff chatting as they clear up the

premises. Everyone has returned to their lives, and it is now time for us to face reality.

“Daalụ Chukwu!” my mother exclaims, sitting on the chair beside me. She has been in her element the whole day, fraternising with our guests and enjoying the comfort of living in the mansion. “We thank God for a successful ceremony.”

“How did you feel when everyone left after Daddy died?” I ask, curious about how she would have handled the drastic change from being surrounded by people to being left all alone.

“I was too busy worrying about you children. I couldn’t have cared less how long those people stayed,” she answers. “Half the people here only came to eat. You know that, don’t you? They were only here to watch and see how you and Chief’s children are coping, to see for themselves if all the gossip they heard is true. Only very few of them were here out of love for Chief and concern for his widow and children. We live in a very wicked world.”

I nod in agreement, taking off my scarf. It still feels alien to feel the breeze on my bare head, and I know it will take some adjustment for me to resume life as normal. But I am willing to make any adjustment I need to.

“I thank God that you are fine. The people here love you and will take care of you,” she says. “It gives me confidence that you’ll be fine when I leave first thing tomorrow. My leg is still giving me trouble. I also need to go and follow up with the people trying to get your brother released. As much as I would have loved to keep you company, I have things to take care of,” she leans over to embrace me. “Six months will go by quickly, my daughter. Just be patient.”

Anayo walks into the living room just as she leaves, and I smile at him. If anyone had told me twenty years ago that my wild crush on him would be replaced by platonic affection, I wouldn't have believed it. He has been one of the positive forces that have made the last few weeks easier to handle.

"Crazy day, huh?" he sighs, sitting down. "Thank God I don't have any more parents to bury."

"Your fiancée's parents are still alive, or weren't they the people I saw with her?" I laugh. "So you better tie your belt tight, because you still have more of this ahead of you!"

He sighs and shakes his head, prompting more laughter from me.

"Seriously though, I'm so happy for you," I say. "Amaka is a lovely girl. It's such a shame the introduction couldn't happen as planned. Will you return later for it?"

"Much later. Maybe next Christmas or something," he answers. "In the meantime, we're going to get married when we get back to London. The traditional rites can happen later." A smile forms on his lips as he looks at me. "What about you and the doc?"

I smile and shrug. "I honestly don't know. We haven't spoken about it yet. I was kind of hoping he would be here now that things are quieter."

Anayo hesitates, before handing me an envelope. "He gave me this for you. I have to confess that I was tempted not to deliver it. Or to read it, at the very least," he shrugs. "I'm not going to lie, it still makes me feel some kind of way thinking about you with another man."

I take the envelope from him. "You have Amaka, Anayo. No other person should even matter."

He rises to his feet. “I guess. Let me give you some privacy. I need to get some rest anyway. It’s going to be a busy day tomorrow, especially with the lawyer coming to the house to read the will.”

“Will?” I exclaim, not having even contemplated Chief had left behind any such testament. “Why so soon?”

“I’ve been in Nigeria much longer than planned,” he answers. “If I still want to have a job by the time I return to London, I need to get back quickly. And I know Apunanwu wants to leave as well. The lawyer reached out, and we figured it would be best to get it done as quickly as we can.”

I mule over that piece of information as he leaves, before shrugging indifferently, convinced the activity will have nothing to do with me anyway. So, I turn my attention to the one that does.

My Love,

I couldn’t find any time to tell you that I leave for Houston tonight. I had to leave the ceremony earlier to catch a flight to Lagos. I will spend every single day looking forward to when we can finally be together.

I love you.

N.

Tears pool in my eyes as the contents of the note hit me like a slap in the face. Naeto has left me, and despite what he has written, there is a high chance that he might not return. My heart, soul and spirit are crushed. Without him, what is there to look forward to?

Early the next morning, my mother leaves for Onitsha. By noon, Chief’s lawyer has arrived. Barrister Eteri is Chief’s longtime associate, who was even part of the contingent that accompanied him to Onitsha when he came to marry me. A pleasant man who wears his age just as regally as his friend

did, he is one of Chief's cronies who never lusted after me once, and was always genuinely nice to me. But today, sitting before us in the living room, he isn't his usual humorous and playful self. He is here for serious business. He coughs before he starts to read.

I, Arinze Ambrose Chibuikem Nsofor, a legal adult, being of competent and sound mind, do hereby declare this to be my last will and testament and do hereby revoke any and all wills and codicils heretofore made jointly or severally by me. I further declare that this Last Will & Testament reflects my personal wishes without any undue influence whatsoever'.

The will reels off the full names of his three recognised children, and I can't help but feel pained for Daluchi, his illegitimate, incestuous daughter, who has gained nothing...but lost everything.

After payment of all of personal debts, expenses and liabilities, I request and direct that my property be bequeathed as follows...

I am half listening as the Barrister reads the names of beneficiaries. To his children, Chief leaves ₦20 million each, alongside shares in several blue chip companies, his jewellery and pieces of property; Akanna gets the bakery and the houses in Asaba and Lagos, Anayo gets one of the houses in London, while Apunanwu gets the other. To his longest serving employees, Okeke, Ukawuiké, and Uzochi, he leaves the sum of ₦5 million each. Whilst I am happy for the older men, my heart bleeds for Uzochi. The woman who gave him everything she had, only to be lumped with his other staff in the end, without any special mention. I make a mental note to ensure Daluchi gets the money, so that she can at least have some sort of head start in life.

Just when I think they are done, the Barrister looks in my direction.

‘And to Adanna, my wife, from whom I took so much more than I ever gave,’ he reads, ‘I leave to her ₦15 million, and also my most prized possession; my ranch.’

I gasp in surprise, shocked. From the stunned looks on the faces around me, I’m not the only one.

“He left her the ranch?” Akanna asks.

The Barrister nods, and continues to read the rest of the will, which details smaller amounts to be distributed to the rest of the staff, the church and several charities. I just sit there like a statue, dazed that he thought enough of me to bequeath so much.

When the reading is over, as Akanna engages the lawyer some more, Apunanwu reaches over to hug me. “You deserve it, Adanna. It is the least he could give you for taking the best years of your life.”

I am relieved by her acceptance and that nobody is causing any trouble. The lawyer leaves, and I can hear the wild jubilation of the staff who are beneficiaries. For a man as evil as he was, he did a lot of people good in the end.

The day ends uneventfully, and in the days that follow, Anayo and Apunanwu leave for London.

“I know you probably won’t be here when I come back next year,” Anayo says, embracing me. “You have my phone number. Make sure you stay in touch, okay?”

“Be strong, Ada,” Apunanwu says, as she takes her turn to hug me. “Go and make the most of your life.”

As they drive away, I realise that I am now completely alone.

As one day turns into another, I have more than enough time to think and ponder my next move. I have more money in the bank than I could ever have thought possible, and I realize that instead of sitting and sulking sulk over Naeto, I can make a difference not only in my life, but in the lives of others.

That is when I make the radical decision to sell the ranch.

I decide to sell it, and pay off all the staff handsomely. The place holds happy memories for nobody, and even if it is the one gift I give myself, just knowing that it no longer exists will go a long way in helping me heal.

A good number of the staff left after receiving their inheritance from the will, and the ones that remain jump at the opportunity of getting even more from me. One by one, they leave the ranch, until it is just Nneoma, Ukawuike, and I in the large compound. Even with his own newfound fortune, the old guard refuses to leave until I do, and so we all patiently count down to the last week in November, when my mourning period will officially be over.

Jidenna is released from police custody and is thankfully not charged along with his friends. Upon his return home, I am finally able to give him the money he needs to open his own vehicle workshop. As for my mother, she declines my offer to set up a business for her in Onitsha, indicating her preference to leave the town, and I can't blame her. The town holds too many bad memories for us, her especially. We decide that, as soon as the ranch is sold, we will buy a house in Port Harcourt or maybe even Abuja. Anywhere we can both make a totally fresh start.

Even though it takes longer than anticipated, the agent I appoint is finally able to get a buyer for the ranch. When he initially informed me of what the asking price for the property would be, I didn't believe anybody would be

willing to pay an almost nine digit amount for the place, so I am shocked when we find a buyer ready to pay that asking amount. I am overwhelmed by the dramatic way my life has turned. Only a few months before, I was no better than a prisoner here. Now, I not only own the place, I am on the verge of making a fortune from it.

On that November morning, I wake up feeling happy and grateful. My mourning has officially come to an end, and I am finally free. As I shower, as the water washes away the soap suds, I feel cleansed from inside out. Finally, I can put the horrors of the last twenty years behind me and move on with my life. I wear a simple grey dress, putting aside the white cotton and linen blouses and wrappers that made up my mourning clothes, my sole attire for the last six months. I comb my thick hair, which has regrown, and, for the first time in months, apply some makeup.

My plan is to be out of the ranch by noon at the very latest. Apunanwu will be back to pack up the furniture in a few weeks, after which the keys will be handed over to the new owner. I am only too happy to leave that task to her. The two suitcases that contain my belongings are all I need to leave this awful place.

And then my phone rings.

There is a sinking feeling you get in your stomach when something terrible is about to happen. That ominous feeling when your heart tells you bad news is lurking. But this time, as my phone rings, I feel the exact opposite. Even though I do not recognise the number calling me, even before I answer it, my heart has told me already.

“Hello?” I say, my heart pounding fast, eagerly anticipating to hear the voice it has been longing for, for months.

It isn't his voice I hear but Stevie Wonder's, as he belts out the song...our song. "Over time, I've been building my castle of love..."

By the time the song is done playing, tears are streaming down my face. Tears of pure, unabashed, unadulterated love.

"My sweetness," comes Naeto's voice, prompting even more tears from me. "I have dreamt of this day, counted down to this day. I have looked forward to the day when we could finally be together...properly."

"When are you coming back, Naeto?" I ask, tears still pouring down my face. "When are you coming back to Nigeria?"

I can hear the smile in his voice. "Look out of your window."

My eyes widen. No...it can't be. I take tentative steps there, not daring to hope, not daring to believe that the person I have longed for...is finally here.

But there he is, standing there beneath my window, holding a bouquet of the most beautiful red roses I have ever seen.

"It took me almost an hour trying to figure out which was your room," he calls out, a smile on his face. "This house is way too big!"

Not wasting any more time, I run out of my room, almost tripping over my legs on the way down. I race down the stairs, out of the house, and jump into his arms as he walks towards the front door. As we embrace, my tears start anew. I cry for all the time that has been wasted, for all the opportunities we lost, and for the chance we have to start all over again. His embrace is tight, and I can tell that he too is afraid to let go, lest something happens that takes me away from him all over again.

And then he kisses me.

At his lip's touch, I feel myself blossom like the flowers that have now been discarded on the floor. Our kiss binds not just our lips...but our hearts and our souls. Cupping his face with my hands, I want to remain in that position forever. I want him to whisk me off my feet, take me to my bedroom, and make passionate love to me. And from his heavy breathing, I can tell he wants that as well.

But then he pulls away and gives me a tender kiss on my forehead, bringing me also back to my senses. There will be plenty of time for us to explore each other...in every way possible. But not here. Not in this house.

We walk inside, hand in hand, and sitting in the living room, I tell him about all that has transpired in the months since we have seen; my shocking inheritance from Chief and the even more shocking amount the ranch is about to sell for. I tell him how grateful Daluchi was to receive her mother's inheritance, and how Ibe sadly passed away a few short weeks after Chief's funeral. In turn, Naeto tells me about his return to his job in Houston.

"But my partners and I haven't given up on Nigeria," he says. "We're going to put up an even bigger structure where my dad's hospital was. We're going to do it even better this time. Olisa is very eager to get things started, and he'll be in charge while the rest of rotate."

My heart crashes. "So, you're going back to America?"

He nods and smiles. "And you're coming with me, Adanna. The first thing we're going to do when we leave here is to see your mother. I want to meet her and your brother properly, and then we're going to start working on your papers. It might take a few months, but what matters is that we're going to be together."

"We haven't spent a lot of time together, Naeto," I say. "What if I don't live up to your expectations? How do you know all this won't fade when the

initial excitement wears off?”

He tilts my chin up. “Adanna, you are the woman my heart has longed for. You are the woman it has always been waiting for. That is all I need to know.”

The certainty in his eyes mirrors the certainty I have deep in my heart. Deep in my heart is a conviction that this man, this beautiful man I have been in love with even before I realised it, is the one. He is the one.

We talk and plan for hours, not noticing the time go by. I cancel my plans to leave for Onitsha that day, choosing instead to leave the following day with him. Our journey to forever has started, so a few hours won’t make much of a difference.

“I’ll pick you up first thing in the morning, my love,” he says, kissing the bridge of my nose. “Make sure you’re packed.”

“I’m already packed,” I giggle. “I’ve been packed for weeks.”

We kiss yet again, and as he turns around to leave, I call out. “Are you sure you don’t want to stay here with me tonight?”

“I have a meeting with the new developer, and I also need to sort out a few things at my parents’ old house,” he answers, before smiling slyly. “I also don’t trust myself alone with you. Not just yet.”

I blow him a kiss and watch him walk away, my heart soaring. So this is what it feels like to not just be in love, but be in love and happy. It is, without a doubt, the best feeling in the whole wide world.

Returning to the living room, it feels like I am walking on clouds. I shut my eyes, dreaming of what our life will be like, and soon fall asleep.

“Nne, I’m going, o,” Ukawuike says, rousing me from my nap. “I thought you were leaving today?”

“I was supposed to, but decided to move it by a day,” I answer, not giving him any details.

“Chai! I wish I could stay but I already informed my daughter I would be on the night bus to Lagos tonight. I have a doctor’s appointment tomorrow.”

I sit up. “Doctor? I hope all is well?”

He chuckles. “You know how you young people can worry. She thinks everyone that lives in the village is walking around with a terminal illness. It’s just a check up.”

I smile sadly. “I will miss you. You’ve been like a father to me.”

He nods, and I can see he is struggling with tears. “Jisi ike, Adanna. Please take care of yourself. I will come look for you in Onitsha when I come home in the New Year, to check on the tenants of my house.” He used his inheritance to buy a bungalow in the village, which he is renting to students of a nearby Polytechnic.

“We will talk on the phone,” I say to him, standing up to embrace him.

“Ebe Nneoma di?” he asks. “I hope you’re not alone.”

Nneoma left earlier in the day, but I know if I tell him this, he will refuse to leave. “Ọ nọ,” I lie. “I’m not alone. Ngwanu, go before you miss the bus.”

After Ukawuike reluctantly leaves, I pour myself a glass of wine and sit in the private living room, the one once used to entertain high profile guests. For the first time, I am all alone in the big ranch. I look up at the portraits staring down at me and remember looking at them for the first time, as a

young, frightened child bride. I look around at the lavishly furnished room, the place where I endured so much suffering and humiliation.

From the open door, I can see the spot in the hallway where I was paraded naked not once, but twice. I wince at the memory, hearing the whipping sound of the belt and feeling the painful strokes as if I am still living it. No, I most surely will not miss this place.

“That’s a nice hair style you have there. It seems strange seeing you without your head scarf,” comes a voice from the door. “I didn’t think I would find you here.”

Even though the worst is over, hearing that voice still sends shivers down my spine.

“Good evening,” I say to Akanna, as he walks into the room. “Something came up. I’ll be leaving tomorrow.”

“May I join you?” he asks, smiling at my glass of wine. I shrug, and he proceeds to pour himself a glass. “I hear you were able to sell the place for a tidy amount of money.”

I shrug again, not wanting to go into any details with him.

“I’ve also put up the bakery and the house in Asaba for sale,” he says. “My family and I are moving to Lagos. With Dad gone, there isn’t much for me here anymore.”

I don’t answer, and he sets his glass down. “Adanna, for what it’s worth, I’m really sorry for whatever role I played in making your time here uncomfortable.”

I look at him, surprised. An apology is the last thing I thought I would ever get from Akanna.

“The circumstances around Dad’s death really got me thinking, and I don’t want to end up like he did,” he continues. “I want to change, not only for myself but also my family.”

“You need to see a therapist, Akanna,” I finally respond. “You have serious issues and need professional help. You apologise for making me ‘uncomfortable’, but what you did to me was more than cause mere discomfort. You broke me...you and your father broke me. You broke an innocent young girl, whose only crime was sacrificing her own happiness for the sake of her family. You almost killed me several times, not to mention the men whose lives you destroyed. And when I see your wife, I see in her the same pain and suffering I endured. You have a serious problem, and my prayer is that you can get the right kind of help you need.”

He sits with a bowed head and in spite of myself, I start to feel sorry for him.

“I forgive you, Akanna,” I finally say. “I forgive you.”

He looks at me, and I can almost see the weight falling of his shoulders.

“Thank you, Adanna. You don’t know how much this means to me.”

And then, for the first time in two decades, we sit in the living room, drinking wine and chatting like old friends. We talk about Anayo’s traditional wedding slated for the following year. He expresses concern over the man Apunanwu has recently started dating, convinced he is only after her money, and he laments how expensive it is costing him to send his two older children abroad for their studies.

“I hear Naeto was around here today,” he says, a sly smirk on his face. “Is that why you moved your departure by a day?”

I can't help the smile on my face, even as my lips remain sealed. I am not seduced enough by our new friendship to give him information about my plans.

"I'm happy you're happy, Adanna," he says. "We might not have had the best relationship, but you will always be family. Please don't be a stranger. We'll look forward to seeing you at Anayo's wedding." He looks at his wristwatch and rises to his feet. "Let me be on my way. I actually came to be sure everywhere was locked up."

"Don't worry, Francis will be here tomorrow morning to assist with that." Francis is the estate agent.

He nods. "This isn't goodbye," he says as he embraces me. "More like a 'see you later.'"

Long after he has left, I am still stunned by his visit. But as surprising as it is, I am happy that we have put aside the past. Now, all of us can really and truly move on from everything.

Suddenly feeling tired, I manage to make it up to my room. I am unusually drowsy and fall into bed without even getting out of my clothes, and I'm asleep in mere seconds.

I toss and turn, uncomfortable but unable to open my eyes. I am eventually awoken by an intense and inexplicable heat. I am soaked in sweat and wonder if it is because I didn't have my usual night shower before going to bed.

"Hello, Adanna," comes Akanna's voice.

I sit up with a start and see that he is sitting on the sofa in my bedroom. "What are you doing here? I thought you left?" I demand, pulling the sheets close to my chest, an eerie feeling of déjà vu enveloping me.

“I didn’t expect you to wake up so soon,” he says, the evil smile I am more accustomed to on his lips. “You really should be careful with your drinks when you have company.”

The realization of his words hits me as I still struggle with drowsiness. It was all an act. His demonstration of remorse earlier on had been nothing but an act, an opportunity for him to tamper with my drink.

“From the very minute I saw you in your father’s shop, you’ve been all I wanted,” he continues talking. “I made the mistake of telling my father all about you and how I planned to return to Onitsha to marry you, only for him to see you and want you for himself. He cheated me of you,” he looks around at my room. “And he cheated me of this house. He always told me this place would be mine after he died. He shouldn’t have given it to you.”

I hop out of bed, not needing to hear anymore but desperate to leave the room as quickly as I can. I will not allow him rape me on my last night in the God forsaken place.

“Don’t bother, Adanna,” he calls out just as I run out of the room and into the corridor.

And I soon realise why.

I stop dead in my tracks. Looking left and right, all I can see are angry, orange flames.

The house is on fire!

“We’re dying together, my love,” he says, walking up behind me. “You and I...and this house. If we can’t be together in this life, by God, we will be together in the next.”

I turn to look at him, stunned silent. I turn around and see that the flames are getting angrier and angrier. And I realize there is no escaping it. Akanna

has won.

Chapter Thirty-Three

The Inferno

He takes advantage of my shock to pull me back in the room.

Iwant us to die in each other's arms," he says, his hands roaming my body as he lowers his face to mine. "Our naked bodies entwined in perfect union. That's the way they will find us, loving each other even unto death."

Before his lips can claim mine, I reach for the now empty jewellery box on my table and smash it on his head with all the strength I can muster.

He lets out an anguished yelp as he releases me, and I take the opportunity to run out of the room. To where, I have no idea. I run down the corridor towards the flames, hoping I can make my way downstairs somehow. But as I approach the stairs, the searing heat keeps me from attempting to go any further. The fire is raging furiously, obliterating the stairwell and, from what it appears, the entire lower floor. He must have started the fire downstairs.

I realise then that even I had underestimated the extent of his depravity.

I turn around and run from room to room, desperately looking for an escape route. The building smoke is making breathing difficult, and my head is still swimming from being so heavily sedated. But the entire left wing of the mansion is in flames, and there is no escape from any of the rooms, as most of them are already engulfed. Running into the last room, I struggle through

the thick smoke, but when I open the window, the angry flames from below greet me. Climbing out is not an option. I run out and contemplate running back to my room, to try to escape from my window as the fire on the right wing has not quite caught up in intensity. But looking in that direction, I can see Akanna struggling through the thick smoke on the floor, making his way to me. Without even thinking twice, I run up to the nearby stairs, headed to Chief's room, hoping that, as it is directly above mine, escape will still be possible, despite it being two stories above ground.

But he is too fast for me.

He grabs me from behind and lifts me off my feet. By now, the fire is thick on the corridor and he fights through flames and thick smoke as he makes his way back to my room. I am too weak to struggle, too weak to fight. Instead, I allow him carry me like a rag doll. If this is how it will end for me, then so be it.

Returning to my room, I am dismayed that it is not as unscathed as I thought it would be. The curtains that hang on my bathroom window are on fire, and the inferno is slowly consuming the small cubicle. It is only a matter of time before it reaches my bedroom.

He throws me on the bed and starts to unbutton his shirt. But then he stops when he hears a sound.

In the far distance, someone is shouting. "Fire! Fire!"

I sit up, hopeful. Akanna's face clouds over, and he rushes to lock the door and window, making the already smoky room smokier still.

"Akanna, please," I plead, my voice weak. "I will do anything you want. I will follow you back to Asaba or Lagos or wherever it is you want to go. I will marry you if you want. Just let us leave here, I beg you."

He silences me with a slap. “Do you think I’m a fool to fall for that? You think I don’t know that the minute we’re out of here, you’ll run straight into the arms of that Naeto of a boy?”

I panic when I see the agitation in his eyes. He is frantic and agitated and nowhere near rational. Trying to make him see reason will be a fruitless endeavour, as he is too far gone in his frenzied mission to end both our lives. For him, there is no going back.

The voices outside are multiplying, and I don’t know whether to be confident help is on the way or saddened that there will be more people with a front row seat to watch our demise.

“I will give you the house,” I whimper. “The ranch is yours. You can reclaim money from insurance, and I’m sure the buyer will still be interested in the property, even without the house.”

He is on me in a flash, claspings his hands around my neck. “Don’t get me angrier than I am, Adanna. The more you try to deceive me with your lies, the angrier you make me. And I don’t want to be angry with you.” His grip on my neck tightens. “I don’t want to be angry with you, Adanna.”

I have vivid memories of being choked by him several times, and I am determined that if I’m to die tonight, it will not be at his hands. And so I fight back. I grab his neck as well, digging my nails deep into his skin. He lets out a cry of pain but doesn’t let go of my neck, so I dig in further still, dragging my fingers down and widening the wounds they have caused.

He punches me hard across the face, with his other hand still on my neck. In turn, I continue to drag my nails this time all the way down to his chest, drawing blood as I do. He grabs both my hands, pins them to the bed and gives me a headbutt. The impact of the blow and the choking smoke makes

me almost lose consciousness, but I fight to keep my eyes open, determined not to allow the beast have his way. Not this time. Not ever again.

With all the strength I can muster, I knee him in the groin. He groans in agony, but doesn't let go of my hands. I repeat it again and again, but he still doesn't let go. He seems immune to the pain, and tightens his grip instead. He lowers his face to mine, and I clamp my teeth on his jaw, biting hard enough to draw blood. By now, visibility in the room is so poor, I can not make out his form anymore. My lungs are fast filling with smoke, and breathing is becoming intolerable.

Because I don't see it coming, I am unprepared when his hands let go of mine and return to my neck, this time with a grip so tight, mine can only flail around him helplessly. As my consciousness starts to slip, I see that my bathroom is now fully ablaze, and small flames have appeared on the carpet on that side of the room. I realize fighting Akanna is a lost cause. We are dead anyway.

The door is kicked open, and I hear, but don't see, people rush into the room. One set of hands pulls him off me, while the other grabs me from the bed.

"Ị bụ nwa ekwensu! Son of the devil!" I hear the angry voice of the person holding Akanna. It is Ukawuike. "Hapụ ebe a! Get her out of this place immediately!" he orders his companion through heavy coughing.

A heavy blanket is thrown over me, as the other person lifts me and dashes into the inferno outside. I can tell we are running towards the staircase leading upstairs, and from the footsteps coming from behind, so is Ukawuike, who is carrying a weakened Akanna, clearly determined not to leave him in the fire. I realize this route must have been how the men gained entry into the house to rescue us.

But then they stop in their tracks.

“Hei! Ụzọ egbochiwo!” Ukawuike exclaims, confirming my worst fear. In the brief time it took for them to enter the house, their entry route has been consumed by fire.

We are all trapped.

“We fit pass am! Make we just run quick quick. We fit make am,” the man with Ukawuike, who from his voice I can identify as Uzoma, one of the old ranch hands, counters, himself also coughing heavily.

But I know there is a fat chance of this. One foot into that inferno, and we will all be roasted alive.

And then I hear my name.

“Adanna! Adanna!”

I would know that voice anywhere.

It calls out from the only other room on my side of the hallway, a long abandoned room that served as an extension of Chief’s late wife’s closet, a room that has remained locked since her death.

Uzoma kicks the door down, and we run inside it, escaping the ravaging flames that are about to consume us. I throw off the blanket and see Naeto and another man standing by the open window. Their clothes look torched, evidence that they too have had direct contact with the fire. There is loud noise coming from downstairs, and I can tell that a crowd has gathered.

“The stairs collapsed as we ran behind you,” Naeto says to Ukawuike. “We had to quickly go back down the ladder and look for another unaffected area to enter from.”

He takes me from Uzoma, and I wrap my arms around him, relieved to be rescued from this madness.

“We need to get her out of here,” Ukawuike starts to say. “She has inhaled too much –”

His words are cut short as Akanna suddenly punches him in the stomach and hops out of his arms. The older man staggers and Akanna punches him again, sending him falling to the floor. Then he turns to face Naeto and I, and I can see in his eyes that he is ready to fight to the finish.

“Get her out of here!” Ukawuike shouts, struggling to get to his feet.

But it is too late, as Akanna grabs Naeto from behind as we approach the window, trying to pry his hands off me. Naeto doesn’t drop me but shields me instead, fighting off our attacker with his shoulders and elbows. Ukawuike finds his feet and pushes Akanna away, sending him sprawling to the ground.

“What are you doing?” I panic, as Naeto hands me over to Uzoma.

“Go, go, go!” he barks. “Get her out of here now!”

Without argument, Uzoma puts me on his back and climbs out of the window to a waiting ladder. My last sight of the room is of Naeto pinning Akanna to the wall and punching him furiously, releasing all the rage and anger that has been building for so long. I also see that some parts of the room are already on fire.

“Naeto!” I scream, as Uzoma makes the meticulous climb down the ladder.

Holding on to Uzoma for dear life, I hear calls of ‘Jide ya, jide ya!’ ‘Hol’ am well’, ‘Nwayọọ nwayọọ’ from the men standing at the foot of the ladder, keeping it steady as we make our descent. All the while, my eyes remain on

the window, anxious for when I will see Naeto and Ukawuike emerge. They don't have much time.

After what seems like eternity, we are finally on solid ground. I gasp in amazement as I take in the sad sight of the house, my house, completely up in flames. Very soon, there will not be any support for the ladder, as the room we have emerged from is the last one standing.

Across the courtyard is a large crowd of people, probably the entire village. I am equal parts amazed and relieved by how quickly news travels in this small town, even in the wee hours of the morning.

I fight off the hands that try to bustle me away to safety, as far away from the burning house as they can, determined not to go anywhere until I see Naeto. Akanna can burn to ashes for all I care.

As Uzoma is about to climb back up the ladder to see what is causing the delay, we see Naeto emerge from the window...only to be dragged back inside again. I scream as Akanna's head emerges...and as he pushes the ladder away, slamming the window shut, intent not to go down with the house alone. By the time Uzoma and the men on the ground reposition the ladder, almost every inch of the house is on fire. Uzoma wastes no time climbing back up, pushing open the window. I make to follow suit, but strong hands hold me, preventing me. I am crying like a banshee, watching as the fire continues raging furiously. I will never forgive myself if anything happens to Naeto.

Just when I am convinced all is lost, the window opens and Ukawuike comes out, followed by Uzoma and then Naeto. The three men descend the ladder, the top of which has already started to burn. From the way they descend, I can tell the rungs are scorching hot, and I hold my breath as I watch them come down, one by one.

Naeto's feet have barely hit the ground when I rush to him, throwing my arms around him for the third time in less than twenty-four hours, but this time even more desperately. I don't want to let go of him ever again, lest I lose him permanently this time.

As we all make our way away from the burning house, I half-listen as Ukawuike recounts seeing Akanna coming to the house earlier in the evening, just as he was leaving for Asaba. He says he immediately turned around, uncomfortable about leaving me alone with him. He prowled the house, waiting to hear any sign of distress from me, but relaxed upon sighting Akanna and I chatting and drinking wine together. Convinced all was well, he retired to the gatehouse for the night, only to be awakened by the heat emanating from the burning house. He immediately raised an alarm and called Naeto on the phone.

I notice that Naeto keeps on looking back at the burning house, and so I ask. "What happened to him?"

We all know whom I mean by 'him'.

"Nwoke ahụ bụ ihe ọzọ!" Uzoma exclaims. "The man is possessed. After we overpowered him, Uncle Uka still went to try to help him leave the place, but mba!"

"He refused?" chimes one of the men who were on ground.

"He no gree, o! The man just lock window, siddon for ground!" Uzoma continues to regale the growing crowd of listeners. "Ahụ adighi mma at all, at all!"

When we reach the courtyard, we are surrounded by everyone trying to help in some way or another. As I sit on the floor trying to stabilise my breathing, I listen to Uzoma tell the story of how he and Ukawuike defied

the fire to locate me, and from the firm set of the older man's face, he is clearly unhappy about leaving Akanna behind. The son of his beloved longtime employer, whom he watched grow from a boy to a man, his grief is understandable. Naeto also can't seem to keep his eyes off the burning house...and I get a sick feeling in my stomach.

"We can still get him out," Naeto says, looking at Ukawuike, the only person who shares his sentiment.

"I si gini?" Uzoma exclaims. "You and who? Can't you see that fire? Nobody can still be alive in that thing."

But Naeto has found a willing partner in Ukawuike, and the two men start running back to the burning house.

"Naeto!" I scream, trying to chase after him, but I am held back by a group of women, some of whom I recognize from town.

I watch as some of the men, Uzoma included, follow them and as they struggle to place the charred ladder by the burning window. I watch as Ukawuike tries to climb, but is unable to because of the heat. I watch as Naeto manages to climb all the way up, shatters the glass window and calls out to Akanna. When there is no answer, I watch as he climbs right back into the burning room. There is an anxious wait until both men emerge at the window, and just as Naeto is about to help a weakened Akanna out, Akanna pushes him.

My last conscious visual is of Naeto falling...of him falling through the sky, just as the ladder falls in the other direction and as the house finally goes down. Taking Akanna with it.

Chapter Thirty-Four

The End

Today

It's been three years, and I am still haunted. I am still haunted by the sight of Naeto falling through the sky to certain death. I can still feel the many hands that restrained me from running to him, and my scream still reverberates in my ear. It's been three years, and I don't think I will ever get over it.

Lying in bed, my eyes open and, as it always does, it takes me a minute to remember where I am. I hear my mother's voice from the other bedroom, my reminder that we are back to living under the same roof. As I listen, I realise her voice isn't coming from the other room, but actually from outside.

I hear the muffled voice of a neighbour and, again, recall bad memories of the last time we lived together under the watchful eyes of neighbours.

Except it is different this time.

"Good morning, sweetness," comes the voice of my beloved from behind me, kissing me on my shoulder.

A wide smile spreads across my face as it always does, my reminder that I have left behind my horrible past, and I'm living my dream life...with my dream man.

“Can your mom stay here forever? I love being able to hold you like this in the mornings,” Naeto says, holding me closer. “I could lie here forever.”

I smile, and when his hand moves to my swollen stomach, as it always does, a tear rolls down my face. How on earth did I get this lucky?

Back in November 2016, I felt anything but lucky. As Naeto fell 40 feet to the ground, all I could do was curse myself, curse myself for being the reason the man I loved the most was about to lose his life. When I tried to run, I wasn't trying to save him. I knew I couldn't. I was trying to run into the fire, so it could consume me as well. So that I would put an end to the sorry existence that was my life.

But the people around me restrained me, and Uzoma and some other gallant men were able to break Naeto's fall by catching him just in time. But it didn't come without a price, as all five men ended up with serious injuries. Naeto, a fractured vertebrae, and the men who caught him, varying degrees of arm and shoulder injuries.

But all that was inconsequential when I was finally allowed to run to him, and saw that he was alive.

And as we were quickly moved away from the inferno as the house collapsed, as he was put in a nearby car and rushed to the hospital in Asaba, I didn't leave his side. I made up my mind never, ever to take my eyes off him ever again. And in three years, I've been able to manage just that.

His recovery was slow, and he was bed-bound for close to a month. During this time, I finally met his older brother, Somto, who came to Asaba when he heard the news and immediately had him transferred to a hospital in Abuja, with me in tow. I ignored all Francis's pleas for me to be around to finalise the sale of what was left of the ranch to the new owner. At that point, I could have cared less about what we could or could not salvage

from the sale. I didn't care about whether or not the buyer was even still interested. Apart from not being willing to leave Naeto's side, I didn't want to have anything to do with the cursed property every again.

Francis was able to perfectly handle the situation with the buyer, who was still very keen on the property, despite the fire. The man apparently already had plans to demolish the structure, so it didn't matter much to him that it had been razed to the ground. In the end, we only lost a small amount, which was just as well as no money could be claimed from insurance, considering the fire was a result of arson.

But none of that was as important to me as helping Naeto recuperate, and in the one month we spent together before he returned to the U.S., we bonded in a way we never would have been able to otherwise. From sun up to sun down, we talked about any and everything. We laughed, we cried, we argued, and we made up, and by the time he left, he was no longer a fantasy but a real human being I had fallen in love with, warts and all.

I remained in Abuja, as Somto was mandated by his brother to work on my travel documents. While we organised my passport and documentation, I bought my mother her dream house in the Jabi area of the town, and before Easter, she had packed up and left Onitsha for good.

In May, I got my K-1 visa, Naeto returned to take me back with him, and less than three weeks after arriving in Houston, we were married in a small civil ceremony. We told everyone it was rushed because of the requirement to be married within the stipulated 90 days, but the truth was that we couldn't wait to be together...properly.

Every single day, I kept on waiting for the penny to drop. I kept on waiting for something to go wrong, for something to happen that would make me realise I wasn't that special after all, and that I was just living a façade.

I kept on waiting for the bed of roses I was lying on to become a cradle of thorns. But while I awoke every day, expecting it to be the beginning of the end, the day only ended up being even more beautiful, more perfect than the one preceding it.

Naeto showed me the true meaning of love. He loved me with a tenderness I never imagined possible, with a depth that was endless. With him, I was truly over-loved. Over-loved and overjoyed.

Our daughter, Chisimdi, was born in March 2018. We gave her that name because, despite all the odds, God had given life to our love. When she was placed in my arms for the first time, I wept like a baby. Never would I have ever believed that I would be blessed with the gift of motherhood, not after all the atrocities my body had gone through with Chief and Akanna.

But there I was, holding in my arms confirmation that second chances are not a myth...but reality.

Motherhood opened my heart in ways I never knew were possible. All of a sudden, I wanted to be the very best I could for her, my daughter. I wanted to be someone she would be proud of. So, one Sunday, when she was about six months old, on one of our frequent trips to the NASA Space Centre, I made a decision.

“I want to write the GED exam,” I said to Naeto.

His tearful smile was confirmation that this was something he too had been hoping for. As we embraced, I felt hopeful and anxious at the same time. There was no guarantee that I would go on to get a university degree, but at least it would be a step in the right direction.

In Christmas 2018, we went back to Nigeria...for Jidenna and Daluchi's wedding. What began with her being the conduit through which my brother

and I communicated, had apparently blossomed into a love story. I couldn't get over how happy my brother looked. Gone was the man who was always angry, the man with the permanent scowl on his face. This man's eyes twinkled like the sun, and he had regained the cheeky sense of humour that had been missing for so long. He looked so much healthier...so much happier. His life had completely turned around, with him not only marrying the love of his life, but enjoying plenty of success in his business.

As for Daluchi, it was initially awkward seeing her again, as she was clearly uncomfortable, considering I knew all about her past life with Chief. But I was quick to put her at ease, embracing her to give the reassurance that everything was in the past. Everything.

She looked even more like Uzochi than I remembered, and I had to fight the temptation to ask if she had heard from her mother in the years since the incident. Apart from it not being the right occasion, I realised I wasn't ready to know. One day, I probably would, but for the time being, I was ready to simply let things be.

Naeto's family took the opportunity of us being in the country to finally pay my bride price, so we journeyed from Abuja, where Jidenna and Daluchi married, to my hometown where my old uncles were ecstatic to receive a more appropriate husband for their daughter.

But nobody was more ecstatic than my mother. Her joy knew no bounds with her two children marrying within weeks of each other. As she danced and celebrated, it was a side of her I had never seen before. Or rather, it was a long-subdued side, one I had forgotten ever existed.

And then at the end of our trip, we made our way to Ojiji as Naeto wanted to visit the recently recommissioned hospital. I was initially reluctant, and

we both agreed Chisi and I would wait for him in a hotel in Asaba while he visited, but then I had a morbid curiosity to see the place again.

As we drove into the sleepy town, nothing at all had changed. The same people were strolling the dusty roads, the same road-side hawkers selling their wares, the same leprous beggar begging by the school gates. It was like someone had hit the pause button in the place, freezing everything in time. But one thing that wasn't frozen was the hospital.

Getting there, I was amazed by how much bigger and better the structure was than what had been there before. It was on a completely different scale, hands down bigger and better equipped than not only the old clinic it had replaced, but even the big hospital in Asaba.

I was full of so much pride for what my husband and his friends had been able to achieve and decided I wouldn't fight him anymore the next time he asked to return for the one-month rotation. Of all the doctors in the U.S., he was the only one who hadn't yet done it, which was ironic considering the hospital was his brain child, his father's legacy.

And then it was time to see the ranch.

"Are you sure you want to go there?" Naeto asked, as I directed the driver there.

I nodded. I had to see the place. The place where my innocence had died and lay buried. The place where my body, soul, and spirit had been crushed but, thankfully, not destroyed. I had to see it.

As we approached, I gasped. Standing where the ranch once stood was a multi-block hotel, with several buildings scattered all around the large compound. Gone was the vast expanse of grassland, the luscious array of trees. The ranch as I knew it was gone. Forever.

Yes, I felt a twinge of sadness...but I felt more of relief.

Returning to the States, I was surprised by how much lighter I felt. Even though I didn't know I needed it, I had gotten my closure. That chapter of my life was over forever...and I couldn't have been more relieved.

As we prepared for Chisi's first birthday, I found out I was pregnant again. This was not only a pleasant surprise, it was a very different experience, much more difficult than my first pregnancy. I was in and out of hospital so often, it was a unanimous decision to make arrangements for my mother to come over to help out.

She arrived two months ago, and even though I had my initial reservations, she has been nothing short of a lifesaver, taking care of Chisi, my household chores, and not to mention fussing over me non-stop.

And as I approach my third trimester, I am tempted to have her stay forever, not releasing her to Jidenna and Daluchi, who will need her when their own child is born later in the year.

Naeto's phone rings, and as he answers it, I rise to my feet and peer out of the window. Chisi is sitting in her stroller as Mom chats with the elderly gentleman who lives in the house next door.

She catches sight of me and waves, a broad smile on her face. I wave back, wondering if there is more to their discussion than friendship, and thinking it wouldn't be such a bad thing if that were the case.

Because, after all, everyone deserves a second chance.

The End

About The Author

Investment banker by day, romance writer by night, Adesuwa O'man Nwokedi began writing by accident and what started as a few scribbles for friends has led to 15 titles...and counting.

A self described hopeless romantic, when she's not creating new characters, she's a loving wife and mom of three.